

Experiences of War and Nationality in Denmark-Norway, 1807-1815

Rasmus Glenthøj and Morten Nordhagen Ottosen

War, Culture and Society, 1750-1850



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Rasmus Glenthøj

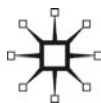
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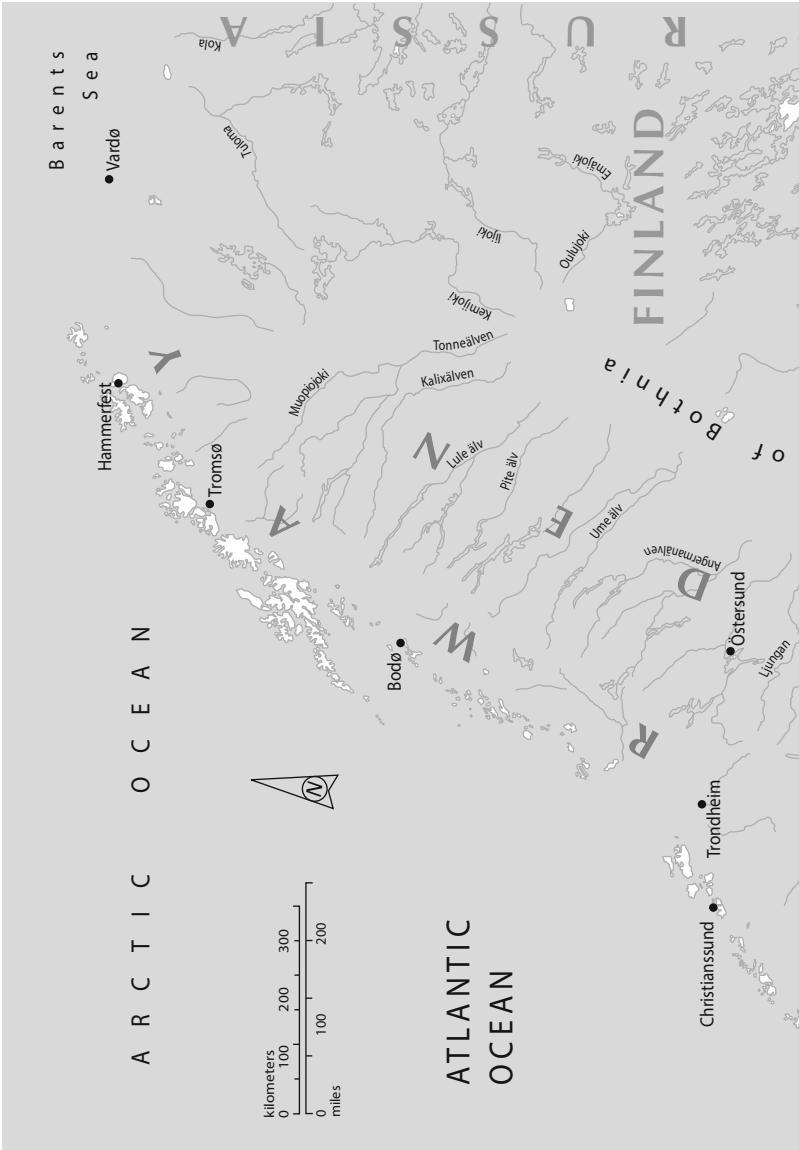
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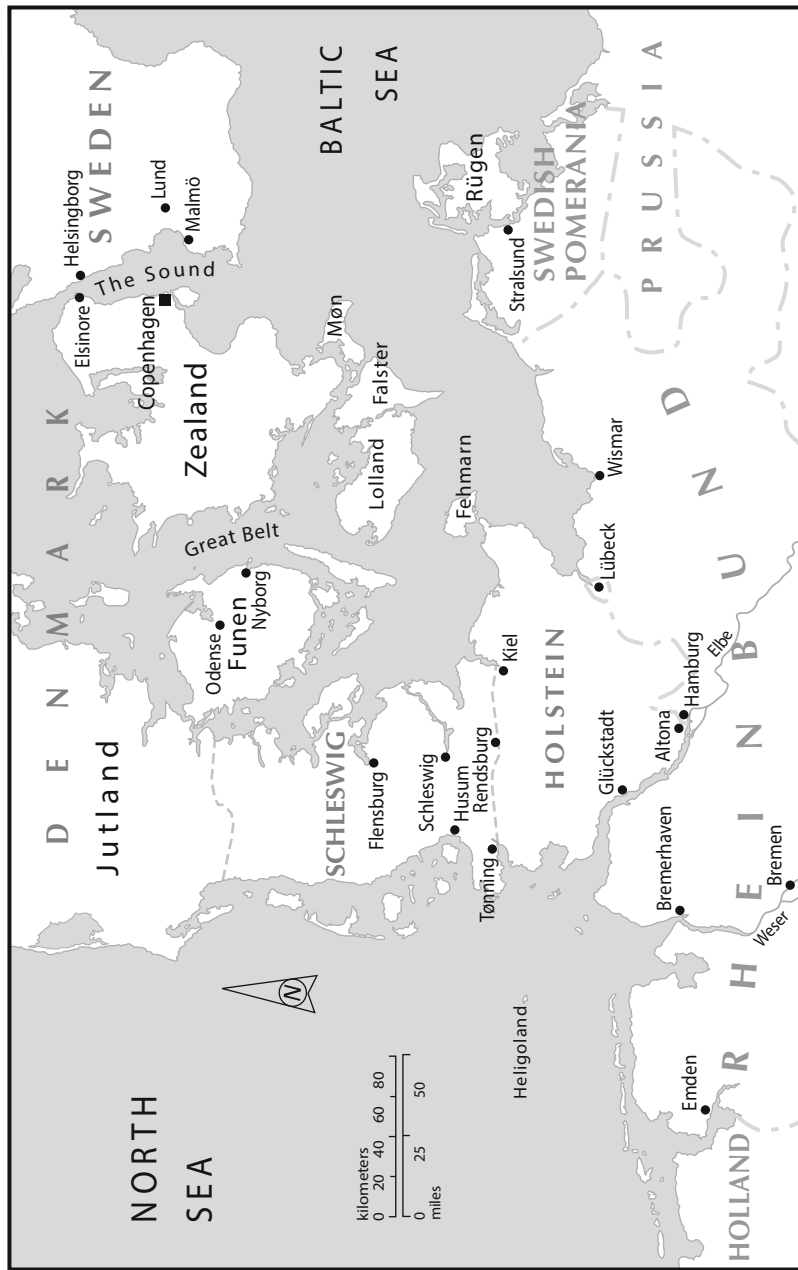
*Rasmus Glenthøj and Morten Nordhagen Ottosen
Copenhagen and Oslo, April 2013*

Historical Maps of Scandinavia





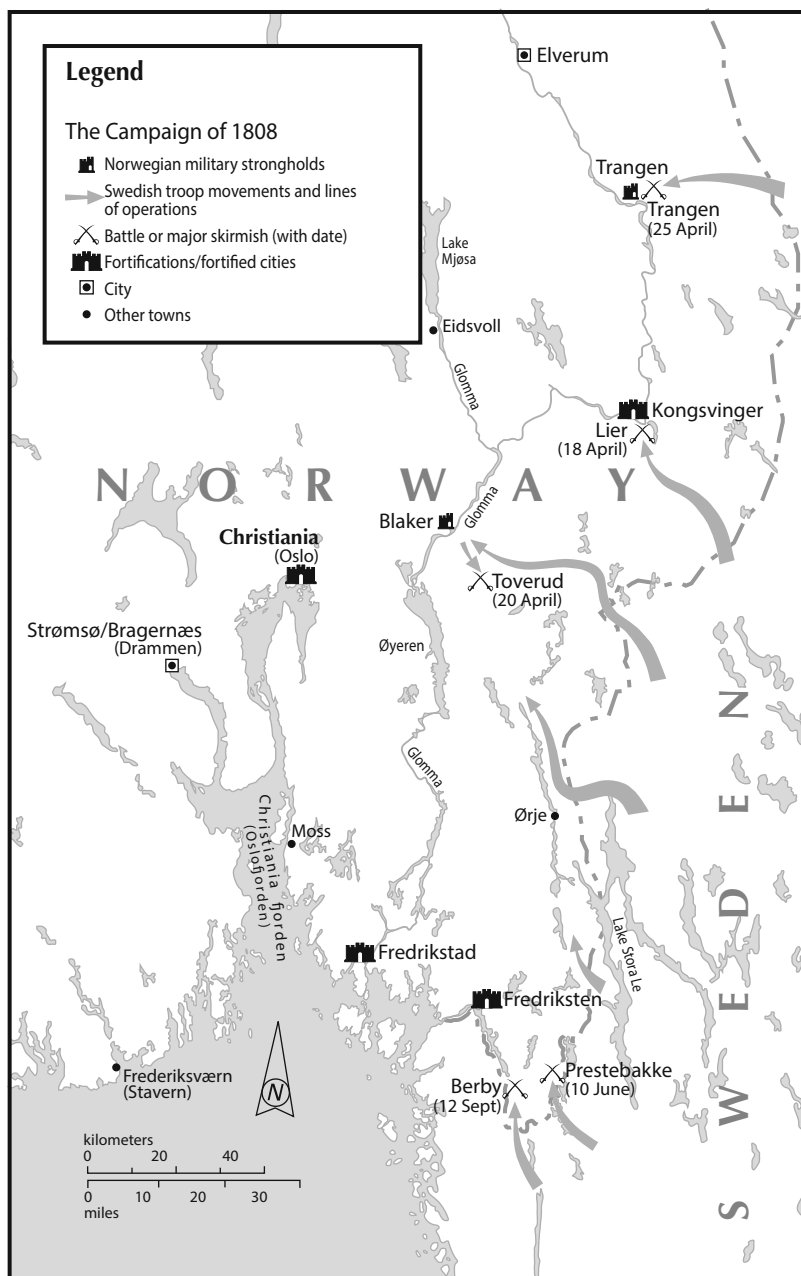
Map 1 Scandinavia and the Baltic area as of 1807



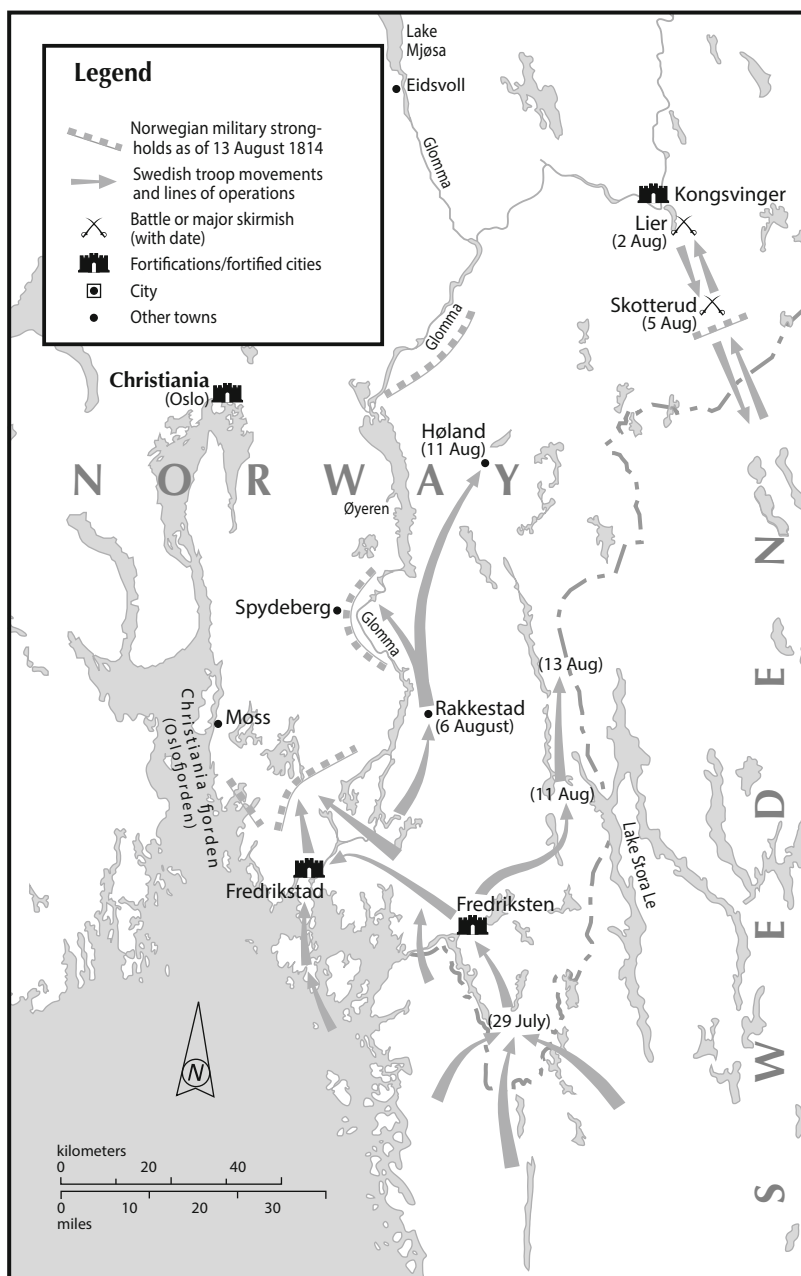
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1

Denmark-Norway and the Ideology of Patriotism

Between a Rock and a Hard Place

The winter of 1813–14 was unusually cold. Mountains of snow kept many roads in Denmark closed up to the end of March and even the major rivers had frozen over. To survive in these conditions, Danish troops had to fell wayside trees, tear down fences and even demolish houses in order to obtain vital fuel supplies. But combating sub-zero temperatures was not the only element in the soldiers' struggle for survival. They were also pawns in the battle for power between Denmark-Norway and Sweden that had been contested for centuries and was now nearing its conclusion; a battle for ascendancy in Scandinavia in general and control of Norway in particular.

At the very end of 1813, the duchies of Schleswig and Holstein, which were under Danish rule at the time, had been occupied by a Russian-Swedish army led by the Swedish crown prince, Charles John. The choice facing Frederick VI, king of Denmark and Norway, was either to throw the Danish army into a heroic – but in reality hopeless – fight to the death against the invaders, or to accede to Charles John's demands. In the name of his adoptive father, Charles XIII, the French-born prince laid claim to all of Norway – a kingdom stretching 1700 km. This was an attempt on the part of the lawyer's son and former revolutionary to realise the dream pursued by Swedish kings for centuries.

Charles John's dream was Frederick VI's nightmare. Denmark and Norway had been united since 1380, and, according to the state's absolutist constitution of 1665, the Danish-Norwegian monarch was duty-bound not to surrender any of his territories. Frederick VI felt a responsibility not only to his subjects but also to God, his forefathers in heaven and the successors to his throne to adhere to the 1665

constitution. Denmark-Norway, however, was isolated politically and militarily, and necessity dictated peace at any price if the remainder of the state were not to disappear into the maelstrom of the Napoleonic Wars. The Treaty of Kiel was accordingly signed on 14 January 1814. It involved surrendering an area of 385,252 km², and meant that the territorial losses of the Danish king were among the greatest during the Napoleonic Wars. The treaty dissolved the 434-year union between Denmark and Norway, a union that had bound the two countries together not only in their constitutional law and fiscal policy but also in their language, culture and family ties.

But how had this situation come about? Why had Denmark-Norway been dragged into the Napoleonic Wars? How had the wars influenced society and the inhabitants of the two countries? And what did the separation come to mean for them? Historians outside of Scandinavia have not found it easy to provide satisfactory answers to questions of this kind, as little has been written in English about Scandinavia during the period. The most recent general survey in English, covering the entire duration of the wars, dates back to 1986 and does not include insights gained from the extensive Scandinavian research conducted over the last 25 years. Nor have other major works in English provided much information, with the exception of a monograph on the bombardment of Copenhagen and one on the Anglo-Swedish alliance of 1805–10. For their part, Scandinavian historians in general have shown relatively little interest in recent international research on the Revolutionary period and its Napoleonic aftermath. It therefore comes as no surprise that Scandinavia has largely been ignored in the surge in international studies of the period, and some scholars have voiced their frustration over the lack of literature in English on Scandinavia.¹

The aim of this book is to help fill this lacuna in international research on Europe in the Napoleonic era. Its contribution is twofold. First, it provides a general overview of war, society and politics in Denmark and Norway in the years 1807–15, and is the first monograph to do so from a comparative perspective. Second, it provides an in-depth analysis of three central subjects in recent international historiography in the context of Scandinavia: the role of nationalism, patriotism and experiences of the Napoleonic Wars.

But in order to understand the turmoil created by the Napoleonic Wars in Denmark and Norway, it is necessary to begin with the conditions that prevailed at the time. This chapter introduces the reader to the Danish-Norwegian state: its structure, geography, economy and society, its domestic and foreign policy, its system of government, view

of foreign powers, ideological currents and collective identity on the eve of war.

The Danish-Norwegian State

Denmark-Norway was a *composite state* or even an empire, as some Danish and Norwegian historians have begun to call it. The term 'empire' should not be misunderstood as an instance of Danish megalomania but, quite the contrary, as a conscious attempt to settle with the methodical nationalism that has characterised the discipline and erroneously equated the Danish nation-state, which was created in 1864, with the polity of the more distant past. It is more appropriate to compare Denmark-Norway with the Habsburg Empire, which united several nations in a community based on loyalty to the same royal house, than with the British Empire. The kings of Oldenburg reigned over a state that stretched from the North Cape in the north to the gates of Hamburg in the south. It was a conglomerate that differed fundamentally from the Danish and Norwegian nation-states of the present.

In addition to the kingdoms of Denmark and Norway, the Danish-Norwegian state comprised the duchies of Schleswig and Holstein, the dependencies of Iceland, the Faroe Islands and Greenland, as well as the overseas colonies in the West Indies (today the US Virgin Islands), the East Indies (Trankebar, Serampore, the Nicobar Islands) and the Gold Coast (today part of Ghana). According to the census of 1801, 929,000 people lived in Denmark and 883,000 in Norway. The Danish duchy of Schleswig had 278,000 inhabitants, while Holstein, until 1806 part of the Holy Roman Empire, had 328,000. In total, 2.5 million people lived in the Danish-Norwegian state. This overextended coastal state with its many islands and overseas provinces was difficult to defend – especially in a naval war, and the navy, which was regarded as the pride of the two kingdoms, was therefore vital for the Danish-Norwegian union.

The capital, Copenhagen, with a population of more than 100,000, was the only city of any size by international standards. Yet it had far fewer inhabitants than the major European metropolises such as London (958,000), Paris (547,000) and Naples (430,000). It was more comparable to the populations of the larger German cities such as Berlin (170,000) and Hamburg (130,000) and greater than the population of the biggest city in the United States, New York (61,000), and Scandinavia's second capital, Stockholm (75,000). In spite of liberal reforms at the end of the eighteenth century, the state was still centralist. A contemporary observer noted that Copenhagen was like a giant's head on a dwarf's

body. The city was the kingdom's principal fortress where the court, the administration, the Academy of Fine Arts and the navy were based. Copenhagen was not only the political, military and intellectual capital, but also the financial heart and brain of the Danish-Norwegian state. The banks and the only university in Denmark-Norway were located here – though the duchies of Holstein and Schleswig were privileged in having their own banks and a university – and the capital had a de facto monopoly on colonial goods, which made the Danish provinces and Norway dependent on Copenhagen.

The other 'larger' Danish towns – Odense, Aalborg and Elsinore – had only 5000–6000 inhabitants and, in the words of Danish historian Edvard Holm, were little more than pantiled villages with a licence to distil spirits. Towns in the duchies such as Altona (23,000) and Flensburg (13,000) were far more populous, while the biggest town in Norway, Bergen, had 18,000 inhabitants. Trondheim had 8800, while Christiania (today Oslo) had slightly more, with approximately 9000 inhabitants. Even though the town was only half as big as Bergen, Christiania was the closest Norway could get to its own capital. In peacetime, there were limits to Norwegians' ability to determine their own affairs independently of the administration in Copenhagen. The duchies, on the other hand, had considerable influence on their own affairs thanks to their old landed aristocracy and a separate chancellery in Copenhagen.

The Norwegian towns were generally bigger than those in Denmark, but there were fewer of them. They held a total of about 20 per cent of Norwegians, while the rest of the population lived in the country. The figures for Denmark were roughly similar: 80 per cent lived in the country, 10 per cent lived in provincial towns and 10 per cent in Copenhagen, but the majority of the city's inhabitants were not born there. The number of Norwegians who lived in Copenhagen is not known, but it was considerable. About 20 per cent of the inhabitants were German speakers who chiefly had their roots in the duchies.

At the time, Denmark-Norway was simply called Denmark, the Danish state or, more poetically, the 'twin kingdoms'. The last name was later interpreted as a rhetorical instrument used by the state to create a false impression of equality between the two countries. There is no doubt that 'twin kingdoms' was part of the rhetoric of absolutism, but the fact that many Danish-Norwegian citizens really did view the two peoples as 'brothers' should not be underestimated. The ties between the two nations, which had never been stronger than just before the outbreak of war in 1807, led some Danish writers during the Napoleonic Wars

to suggest that either 'Dannora' or 'Dannorig' should be the common name for the Danish-Norwegian union, just as Great Britain was for England, Scotland and Wales, in order to emphasise the 'eternal' merging of the kingdoms. The suggestion was probably never representative of the views of the general public, but it did reflect a powerful sense of the Nordic identity that could be found in some academic circles.

After the war it was claimed that there had been a Danish plan to replace the name of Norway with North Denmark in order to obliterate it. While there is no proof of this improbable conspiracy theory, there were actually some sarcastic statements made by Norwegians during the period to the effect that they believed the Danes wanted to turn them into 'Northern Danes', which could reflect the fear of some individuals that there was a policy of 'Danicisation' in existence, based on what actually happened in the duchies at the time. What was known as the 'Danicisation process' in Schleswig and Holstein had begun even before the outbreak of war in a bid to modernise the state administration.²

Dissatisfaction and Identity in Denmark-Norway

In spite of the reform fervour at the end of the eighteenth century, Denmark-Norway was far from perfect either as a union or as a state, which meant that the patriotism of the period potentially became an oppositional phenomenon. The potential firebrands among Danes and Norwegians alike were young academics, and their base was Copenhagen. Danish national patriotism, materialising out of a challenge from the middle classes to the aristocracy and to pro-German sympathies, helped to strengthen Norwegian national patriotism. National patriotism can be understood as a form of patriotism that primarily involves a citizen's own nation within the framework of the state. Patriotism of this type can easily be confused with nineteenth-century nationalism but, as the Norwegian historian Odd Arvid Storsveen, for example, has pointed out, it existed side by side with ordinary state patriotism, which had its own political aims such as civic virtue, rationality and the common good throughout the state.³ Thus, working for and serving the cause of the Norwegian nation need not make a Norwegian national patriot an opponent of the union with Denmark and of the king in Copenhagen, as long as the union and the monarch served Norwegian interests.

Norwegian middle-class identity developed, with a brief delay, along the lines of the Danish process that had begun in the 1740s. From 1770 to 1773, when in principle there was full freedom of the press, many young Norwegians expressed their dissatisfaction with the state of affairs. Their

complaints were that Norway was not on an equal footing with Denmark, that the central administration had no knowledge of their country and treated it like a colony. They demanded the abolition of the Danish corn monopoly in Norway (which took place in 1788), more Norwegians in the central administration and separate Norwegian institutions. Merchants wanted a bank in Norway and a Norwegian department of commerce, while civil servants demanded a Norwegian university. These demands can be traced back to the seventeenth century, but they increased in vigour in the eighteenth century with the emergence of a self-recruited class of Norwegian civil servants, who were often descendants of Danish, German and British families. From the 1790s, the university cause became a 'national cause' for the Norwegian elite. This was rejected in Copenhagen on several occasions for fear that a Norwegian university would militate against the unity of the state and strengthen Norwegian separatism.

The state attempted to make allowances for Norwegian national patriotism without giving in to Norwegian wishes. The opposite held true for the Danish middle classes, who demanded the primacy of the Danish language, the sole right of citizens of the Danish-Norwegian state to occupy government posts and recognition of their social and cultural ambitions. During the last decades of the eighteenth century all Danish demands were acceded to, in direct contrast to the response to Norwegian demands. However, their demand for political influence was rejected out of hand. The policy of absolutism was a balancing act, where the necessary concessions were made in an attempt to tame, neutralise and control burgeoning national and political tendencies to the state's own advantage.⁴

The only Norwegian separatist idea we have any definite knowledge of before 1807 was discussed at a meeting close to the border at Eda in Sweden by four Norwegian merchants and a Swedish emissary in 1790. There is controversy about the significance of this particular meeting, but it is clear that the merchants were imbued with a separate Norwegian identity that was in opposition to the royal power and that their political aims were inspired by British parliamentarism and revolutionary France. The excitement felt in Norwegian (and Danish) circles at the beginning of the 1790s, however, turned to some extent into a conservative reaction during the second half of the decade. In spite of a certain amount of discontent, most Norwegians were generally satisfied with the state of affairs, largely due to the long period of peace the state had enjoyed, the rule of law, an economic upturn, traditional dynastic loyalty and the taxation of peasants, which was among the lowest in Europe. The

absolutist monarchy consciously combined a certain leniency with regard to the Norwegians with unyielding centralism. At the same time, it was evident that Norwegian national patriotism was limited to the middle-class elites. Contemporary peasant risings and religious movements targeted the local middle class, and their leaders viewed the king as an ally rather than as an opponent in their struggle against the elite.⁵

However, Norwegian identity was not solely political in nature but also cultural, and this came to expression in works dealing with Norwegian history and geography, which, together with poetry written in local dialects, gave the Norwegians material that they could use in subsequent nation-building processes. Their political demands and cultural identity strengthened the concept of being Norwegian, but they did not *necessarily* conflict with loyalty and state patriotism.

According to the Danish historian Ole Feldbæk, two elements that were decisive for the development of a Danish national identity were still lacking in the establishment of a Norwegian identity: their own language and a distinctive contrast in national character. The language of the people had not yet become a national 'border guard' and – according to Feldbæk – Danes were not objects of hatred. As the Norwegian civil servant class was self-recruiting, they had no need to create an object of hatred in order to secure their social position – as was the case with Danish civil servants. On the other hand the Norwegian historian Ståle Dyrvik has claimed that there is a parallel between Danish anti-German feeling and Norwegians' sense of being unfairly treated by the Danes. Given the closeness of Danish-Norwegian ties, this parallel is exaggerated, but there is no doubt that the Dane – and the Swede – was seen as a potential antithesis to the Norwegian.⁶

Norwegian civil servants were 'pseudo-Danes' linguistically, culturally and with regard to their education, and they had ties to Denmark through families and friends. The difference between Danish and Norwegian was fluid; a father might be Danish and his son Norwegian or vice versa, and many Norwegian civil servants were married to Danes. This meant that some Danes considered Norwegians as half Danish and Denmark and Norway as a common fatherland. For some Norwegians who did not regard themselves as pseudo-Danes, this acted as a provocation, which they would demonstrate by flaunting their 'Norwegianness' whenever possible. This often happened at the expense of Danes, who found it irritating. Norwegianness became associated with nature, history, allodial rights, and with a particular Norwegian character that comprised stamina, honesty, freedom and loyalty, while Danes were considered softer by Norwegians. According to the later Bishop of Bergen,

the difference between Norwegians and Danes was created by nature, but the two peoples were citizens of the same state and shared common privileges and duties, and for this reason, loyalty to the king extended over an area from Vardø in Northern Norway to Kiel in Holstein. As far as the bishop was concerned, the relationship between the two countries was characterised by an honourable competition between brothers as to who could best serve their father, the king.⁷

The Norwegian peasantry's ties with Denmark were naturally looser than those of the civil servant class, but this did not mean that they considered Denmark a foreign country. Peasants were aware of the basic principles of the Danish–Norwegian union and of the fact that Copenhagen was the centre of the state. Norwegian peasants were familiar with and diligently made use of their right to send petitions to the king in Copenhagen when they were dissatisfied with local or regional conditions and, in a few cases, peasants' sons could be found among the students at the University of Copenhagen. There can, therefore, be little doubt that the Danish–Norwegian union had deep roots in Norway. On the other hand, the Danish peasantry's relations with Norwegians were weaker. This was not only due to adscription, which remained in force until 1788, but also because Danish peasants had few dealings with Norwegians and therefore had little reason to take Norway into consideration, even after adscription was abolished.

The strength of the feeling of fellowship and the fluid borders between what was Danish and Norwegian is demonstrated by the fact that Danes and Norwegians could actually speak of a Danish–Norwegian people. In Norway even the most uneducated peasant might think of himself as a Norwegian, but as a Norwegian who lived in Denmark (e.g. the Danish state). The distinction, or the gradation, between Norwegian and Danish would often be connected with the idea of 'Norwegian' as the people and 'Danish' as the state. In the same way as England and English are sometimes used as synonyms for Britain and British, the concepts of Denmark, Danish and Danishness were used in some contexts by both Danes and Norwegians. In other countries, Norwegians were often referred to as Danes because they were citizens of the Danish state. Thus, many Norwegians had no problem referring to themselves as 'Danish citizens'.⁸

Patriotism and Fatherland

Patriotism had long been the point around which contemporary ideas about a community of citizens revolved. It was based on ideas

of natural law, according to which people had a number of inviolable rights. Society was a community of individuals who together ensured each other's freedom and independence. It not only protected citizens against external enemies, it also supported and formed the individual. All of which imposed a duty on citizens to be prepared to set aside their own needs for the benefit of the interests of society and the state. The idea being, in the final analysis, that by serving the common good patriots also served themselves.

In other words, patriotism was the dominant social morality that emphasised ideas about civic virtue, the common good and self-sacrifice, and focused on the active participation of the individual. The rational construction of patriotism, however, did not exclude a strong emotional commitment on the part of the citizen. On the contrary, the period was rich in bombastic pronouncements and decided sentimentality. Most people saw love of country as a natural urge that should be raised to the status of a virtue with the help of upbringing.⁹

The ideas of the Enlightenment had initially engendered a decidedly cosmopolitan form of patriotism in which the fatherland was defined as the place people lived and made themselves useful as citizens. However, there was also an alternative view of the fatherland as that country in which one was born. Europe in the eighteenth century was characterised by enmity between a rising middle class and the traditional aristocracy, which in Denmark became a national clash of interests. For centuries German language and culture had had an influence on the country, in part as a result of German immigration, which, as far as the aristocracy was concerned, was further boosted by Frederick III's *coup d'état* and the introduction of absolutism in 1660. This was a development that only peaked with Frederick V in the middle of the eighteenth century.

The growing middle class saw the aristocracy as its antithesis and as an obstacle to social advancement, because it was to them that the top jobs in the bureaucracy were reserved. They defined themselves, therefore, in contrast to the German-French culture and language of the aristocracy and identified themselves with Danish language, history and culture. In Denmark, the Norwegian-born historian and author Ludvig Holberg had helped to awaken the interest of younger academics for Danish language, literature and history and, from the 1740s, they demanded that Danish patriots should write in their native language. The Danish middle class considered the lack of German assimilation as a provocation and developed a stereotype of Germans as the antithesis of patriotic Danes, which came to expression in concepts such as

'Germanness' and 'Germanity'. Germanness meant being boastful, superior, condescending and lacking knowledge of Denmark, its institutions, customs and posts. Germanity referred to German statesmen and civil servants who overlooked Danes and Norwegians for the government posts they gave to members of their families. Frequently no distinction was made here between Holsteiners, who belonged under the state, and other Germans. A radical author actually cast doubt on the loyalty of the people of Holstein, describing them as subjects of the 'Holy Roman Empire', which was correct as far as constitutional law went, but politically polemical.¹⁰

The movement away from cosmopolitan patriotism began with the assumption of power by Christian VII in 1766. A year later a Norwegian civil servant published a text entitled *Letters about Love of the Fatherland*, in which the fatherland was defined on the basis of birthplace rather than the state. This development was stepped up by the Struensee intermezzo during the years 1770–72 (see below), which increased national patriotism and anti-German feeling. Danish became the language of command in the army, 'national' tragedies were commissioned, and Danish and history were given a more prominent place as grammar-school subjects. The climax came with the introduction of the act of citizenship (1776), which was a *constitutional right* that reserved all government offices for the state's own citizens. The government had hit the nail on the head with this measure, as was made clear by the delight that news of the law aroused throughout Denmark, while enthusiasm was more subdued in Norway and non-existent in the duchies. The right of citizenship is in several ways reminiscent of what had happened in England 75 years previously. Prompted by the Dutch advisers that William III had brought with him after the 'Glorious Revolution' of 1688, the English Parliament adopted *The Act of Settlement* in 1701, which deprived both foreign and naturalised citizens of the right to hold government office. Together with the Union with Scotland Act of 1707, the provision was extended to include Scots. This provision relating to British citizenship, whose status resembled that of a constitutional right, may have been the inspiration for the Act of Citizenship in Denmark-Norway.

From 1772, the government was led by Ove Høegh-Guldberg. His love of the Danish language and Danish history is indisputable, but the patriotism Guldberg promoted had an instrumental character as citizenship applied to Danes, Norwegians *and* Holsteiners. He wanted to create a feeling of state patriotism, which was clearly shown by the books that were commissioned for use in grammar schools. The fatherland was

not Denmark, but all of the king's countries and kingdoms. One of the authors of the books, a Dane married to a Norwegian, criticised Norway's position in the state in a draft, for which Guldberg reprimanded him with the words, 'There are no Norwegians. We are all citizens of the Danish state.'¹¹ His attitude reflected the absolutist desire to create order, uniformity and a feeling of fellowship in the state.

But state patriotism involved more than just loyalty to the king. It was also associated with common state institutions such as the navy and the capital, Copenhagen. This can also be seen in appeals by the state for people to do their best for 'King *and* Fatherland', even with regard to the peasantry. State patriotism was based on the government's policy of neutrality, which safeguarded shipping, trade and prosperity, and on a progressive domestic policy which, at the end of the eighteenth century, came to include freedom of the press, citizenship, tariff reforms, agrarian reforms and reforms in education and so forth. This calculated construction of a state identity can be compared to the creation of the British identity in which the various nations within the state's territory were theoretically equal and governed from a common centre. In the language of art, this was depicted by the fact that Holstein, which had previously been neglected, was now placed allegorically on an equal footing with Danes and Norwegians as a child of a common fatherland.¹²

This meant that there were now three related, overall identities in Denmark-Norway in the eighteenth century: a cosmopolitan identity, a state patriotic identity and a national patriotic identity, which were attached to three different views of the fatherland, and were in turn connected respectively with a universal concept, a civic concept and an ethnic concept. These were ideal types that did not necessarily exclude one another – *yet*. Norwegians in particular argued that in a natural sense, Norway was their fatherland (*patria naturae*), while in the civic context, both Denmark and Norway were their fatherland (*patria civitatis*); similarly, Norwegians and Holsteiners could, as mentioned, refer to themselves as Danes and call Danes their fellow countrymen. On the other hand, the fact that Norwegian dissatisfaction was lurking beneath the surface should not be underestimated but, fear of the state meant that it was rarely expressed publicly. One exception was the book *Outline of Sensible Norwegian Patriotism* (1787), in which it was stated that Norwegians had only one fatherland: Norway. The king was considered just as Norwegian as Danish. Norwegians should only consider the good of Norway, and the author made no attempt to conceal that there were Norwegians who were discussing whether

Norway could survive as an independent state. The danger for the Danish–Norwegian union was precisely that Danes and Norwegians could be seen as antitheses. The threat to the Danish state arose as soon as the concept of the fatherland became so narrow that the cosmopolitan and state patriotic identities became incompatible with the national patriotic identity.

Society, Absolutism and Foreign Powers

In theory, the state was governed autocratically by Christian VII who, according to the only absolutist European constitution (the *Lex Regia* of 1665), was king by the grace of God. But everyone familiar with the state of affairs was fully aware that the schizophrenic monarch did not govern the state. Denmark–Norway's real regent was his son, Crown Prince Frederick (VI), who had taken over the reins of power in 1784 in a bloodless palace revolution, which marked the beginning of a period of reform, especially in the Danish part of the state. Elder statesmen such as Foreign Minister Andreas Peter Bernstorff were the prime movers of the new reform policy, but they would never have been able to put it into effect without the acceptance of the crown prince.

The new government wanted to see a middle-class public that was prepared to engage in public debate since Bernstorff believed that freedom of expression led to tranquillity and prosperity. In the final analysis, any criticism of social conditions in an autocratic state would be a criticism of the system, but the government was prepared to accept criticism – as long as it was not direct criticism of the king, state institutions, of people of rank or public officials. The public could be used by the government as a source of inspiration and support for necessary reforms. Initially, the government's hope was fully realised. Public interest in the state and society flourished as never before or since, perhaps, and new pamphlets and periodicals containing animated debates about the common good, flooded the market.

A free, informed public, however, proved to be a two-edged sword. Citizens no longer believed in the idea of an absolute monarchy established by the grace of God. A Danish lawyer actually called the idea insane. In accordance with contemporary thinking derived from natural law, informed citizens believed that the state had arisen from man's natural social instinct and that it was based on a contract between a prince and a people. The exercise of power by the former was only legitimate because power had been entrusted to him by the people – as the citizens of Copenhagen had done on the introduction of absolutism

in 1660. But, as the people were the real sovereign power, problems would increasingly arise if their will did not find expression through the state. According to the Norwegian historian Jens Arup Seip, this led to the creation of what he called *the theory of opinion-guided absolutism* (1958), which came to expression in the 1780s and dominated the public debate during the 1790s.

The Danish professor of law Johan Frederick Wilhelm Schlegel, who taught generations of Danish-Norwegian civil servants, made it clear in his lectures that the monarch was there for the sake of the people and that society was made up of free men and not minors. Schlegel and others viewed society as a contract between citizens and the monarch, an arrangement that meant that the king was not only obliged to ensure civil liberty but also to reign in accordance with the will of the people. Failure to honour this contract would mean that the king would be accounted a despot. Based on the theory of absolutism governed by public opinion, there was in fact already a kind of popular sovereignty that was based either on the king's interpretation of an abstract and ideal view of the will of the people or on specific measures of public opinion. These ideas were central to Schlegel's theory of democratic autocracy based on the will of the people.¹³

The idea of absolutism governed by public opinion was not a peculiarly Danish-Norwegian phenomenon. Similar ideas could be found in Prussia but, just as in Denmark-Norway, the public authorities in Berlin had a negative reaction to this liberal development, and freedom of the press became press impudence in the eyes of the government. Revolutionary impulses simply made the situation worse, according to the public authorities of both states.¹⁴ Initially, the upheavals in France had otherwise been well received by the Danish-Norwegian public. The French government had been seen as reactionary, and the revolution was therefore greeted with delight. There was a widespread opinion that the French people had now simply gained the benefits that were already being enjoyed in Denmark-Norway.

Relations between Copenhagen and London had previously been marked by the scandalous marriage between George III's sister, Caroline Matilda, and the mentally ill Christian VII. The young, British-born queen had begun an affair with the king's physician-in-ordinary, Johann Friederich Struensee, who in fact governed the state in the king's name for 14 months. However, the German-born doctor was overthrown and condemned to be broken on the wheel following a palace revolution in 1772, while Caroline Matilda was exiled to her brother's estate in Hanover. The scandal marred relations between Denmark and Britain,

until Crown Prince Frederick, Caroline Matilda's son, assumed power in the name of his sick father after a palace revolution in 1784. That Denmark-Norway was now ruled by the British monarch's nephew, however, made no difference to the fact that the Danish-Norwegian policy of neutrality continued to constitute a problem for relations between the two states.

This also had a certain influence on the general public's view of Great Britain, but it did nothing to change the long-standing perception that this was a pioneering nation, marked out by freedom, progress and sound business acumen. This was particularly the case in Norway, which had closer ties with the British Isles, via its commercial relations, than Denmark had. Norwegian exports of timber to the British market had taken off in earnest after the Great Fire of London in 1666, at which 'the Norwegians warmed themselves well'. Several of the great families of the Norwegian trading elite had emigrated from Great Britain, and their sons were often sent across the North Sea to do their apprenticeships. All Norwegian merchants could speak English, and their homes were furnished in accordance with the latest English fashion. English furniture could be found even in the homes of some of the richest farmers in the eastern regions of Norway who, in the service of the merchants, earned huge sums from the timber trade with Great Britain. But the Norwegians were not only receptive to British luxury items. They also imported British ideas and standards. So, for example, the first Danish translation of Adam Smith's *The Wealth of Nations*, published in 1779, only three years after the original version, was financed by Norwegian merchants. It therefore came as no surprise that Norwegians were highly critical of the government's mercantile favouring of the capital of Copenhagen at their expense. A prominent Norwegian poet sarcastically summed up his countrymen's attitude to England, taunting them for believing 'that human beings can be found / only in England and here [in Norway]'.¹⁵

The role of the British during the American Revolution and the Revolutionary Wars in Europe, however, had a more negative influence on the attitude of progressive forces in Denmark. The most significant issues for relations between the two countries were Danish-Norwegian exploitation of neutrality and the dominance of the British navy and British trade on the high seas. These factors helped to nurture the idea of Great Britain as a greedy nation of shopkeepers.

The attitude to France also changed during the 1790s when it became clear that developments in revolutionary France and in the Danish-Norwegian state were by no means identical. Robespierre's reign of

terror and the execution of Louis XVI and his queen sent shockwaves through Danish-Norwegian society, where the royal family and the aristocracy in particular feared the establishment of a similar mob rule in Copenhagen. However, the introduction of the Directory in 1795 meant that many people became more sympathetic to France. In general, young people and academics had a positive attitude to the revolution, while older people and especially senior civil servants were appalled at the development. Most members of the public supported state reforms, the struggle against the influence of the aristocracy and the greatest possible freedom of the press, but they remained positive in their attitude to absolutism as a system. There was no stomach for major, drastic upheavals; what was wanted instead, as the periodical *Minerva* put it, was governance by regents and ministers who acted like philosophers, as in Plato's *Republic*.

The French Revolution prompted the crown prince to take an increasingly reactionary stance. Two incidents, the first in 1794 when a fire broke out at the royal residence at Christiansborg Palace, the second the Copenhagen Fire of 1795, were interpreted by Frederick as the start of revolution in Denmark. While he was mistaken on both counts, events on the continent radicalised many members of the middle class and some began to doubt the wisdom of the existing system. Criticism had grown during the 1780s when radical authors in particular lambasted the aristocracy and its privileges. But the contemporary critics of the system still regarded the absolute monarchy as being, as it were, on the same team. This changed during the 1790s, however, when radicals increasingly began to challenge the legitimacy of absolutism. As early as 1790, then, we can find proposals to introduce an Assembly of the States of the Realm.

As in Prussia, so in Denmark the authorities deemed it necessary to halt such radical development. The theory of absolutism governed by public opinion collided with stark political reality when the crown prince forcibly imposed an ordinance limiting freedom of the press in 1799. The background for this ordinance can be found in Frederick's opposition to the French Revolution, his irritation over 'the impertinence of the press' and external pressure from the state's Russian ally that nursed an exaggerated fear of radicalism in Copenhagen. A prohibition was introduced against writing critically about the absolutist constitution, the royal house, Lutheranism, matters of state and well-disposed foreign powers, and against attacking private individuals and, not least, civil servants in print. Punishments for violating the prohibition ranged from the death penalty and exile to imprisonment and fines. In order

to avoid loopholes, covert attacks in the form of allegories, satire, irony and woodcuts were also forbidden. A person once convicted of a violation was subject to lifelong censorship, while works of less than 384 pages were subject to de facto censorship in advance as they had to be forwarded to the chief constable prior to publication. A fledgling sector of Danish-Norwegian public opinion that was free, young and immature was thereby crushed before it could spread its wings. Its two most vociferously radical authors were exiled, both fleeing to France, where they made careers for themselves under Napoleon.

There was good reason for introducing such harsh measures against incautious statements about conditions in foreign parts. During the period up to 1807 the government had fought a hard battle to navigate through the Revolutionary and Napoleonic Wars. The diplomats of the great powers kept a vigilant eye on the public and, with the help of complaints and threats, attempted to exercise control over what was written about their respective states. In spite of widespread media self-censorship, the government found it necessary to tighten up legislation even further. The state decided who could publish newspapers and periodicals and, to an increasing extent, what these publications could contain. During the years 1799–1814, the Danish-Norwegian state was turned from what had been, by contemporary standards, a very open society into one that was muzzled.

Denmark-Norway and the Politics of ‘the Palmy Days’

The successive helmsmen of the Danish-Norwegian state had by and large successfully steered the ship of state around the shoals of war aided by a mixture of luck, skill and sheer opportunism. This was a rare thing in a Europe where war was the order of the day. The background for this favourable period in the history of Denmark-Norway can be found in contemporary continental politics. Europe in the eighteenth century was marked by a seemingly endless series of wars between the great powers, which reflected the dominant theory of the balance of power. What appeared to one country to be the right balance of power could appear in the eyes of other states to be a fundamental breach of the fragile status quo. The Danish statesman, Ove Høegh-Guldberg, correctly observed that the system resulted in a new European war every seven or eight years, one which lasted for a corresponding period. Peace treaties rarely led to any real *détente* and were more in the nature of armistices.

Since the end of the Great Northern War in 1720–21, the Danish-Norwegian state had maintained neutrality in all European conflicts.

Neutrality, in the words of Foreign Minister Andreas Peter Bernstorff, would ensure the state's safety and prosperity. The traditional interpretation of this in Danish-Norwegian historiography has been that Denmark-Norway had given up hope of territorial expansion and revenge on the Swedes who, throughout the seventeenth century, had overrun many Norwegian and Danish provinces. The general political goal was to defend the state in its existing form against any external threat, which in practice meant from Sweden, which still wished to take possession of Norway. However, it must be added that Denmark-Norway entered into a large number of alliances during the eighteenth century but fulfilled its obligations only to a limited extent, which hardly improved the diplomatic reputation of the state abroad. But in 1788, Denmark-Norway was forced to fulfil its obligations under its alliance with Russia. After the Swedish attack on Russia, Empress Catharine demanded that Denmark-Norway should take action against Sweden, which resulted in 10,000 Norwegian troops entering western Sweden – but doing so officially as 'Russians' because, unlike Crown Prince Frederick, Foreign Minister Andreas Peter Bernstorff was absolutely opposed to a war with Sweden. The 'war' of 1788 could hardly be called a Scandinavian war, or even a war in any real sense, even though it may have appeared as such.

Relations between Denmark-Norway and Sweden improved considerably after the murder of Gustav III in 1792. The autocratic Swedish king, who had been notoriously anti-Danish, was replaced by a regency representing the under-age Gustav IV. This paved the way for a rapprochement between the two Nordic arch-enemies who, at the end of the 1790s, developed closer ties both politically and culturally. The former found expression in a collaboration on neutrality in which Danish and Swedish warships jointly patrolled the North Sea to protect neutral shipping. This had the desired effect when the British revoked instructions to privateers to seize Scandinavian ships carrying corn, which they correctly assumed was bound for France. Political relations, however, became cooler when the Swedish navy failed to come to the relief of Copenhagen when it was attacked by the British in 1801. Both states had joined the Russian-led League of Armed Neutrality, and Sweden was therefore obliged to come to the aid of Denmark-Norway in the case of a British attack. Swedish good intentions were genuine enough, but unfavourable winds prevented the Swedish fleet from leaving Karlskrona. In such a critical situation, the failure of the fleet to arrive stirred up rumours in Copenhagen and led to growing antipathy to Sweden among the population and in the crown prince, who was sceptical about these Swedish excuses. On the other hand, the Swedish king

regarded the Danish armistice with Britain as treachery and even used it as moral support when he attempted to persuade France and Prussia to back a Swedish annexation of Norway in the summer of 1801. In the wake of the First Battle of Copenhagen, the old mistrust between the two hereditary enemies flared up once again at the political level.¹⁶

At the cultural level, however, things were quite the reverse. Engendered by what was known as the 'Nordic Renaissance' at the end of the eighteenth century, intellectuals in the two countries began working towards closer literary and cultural ties. This led to the 'rediscovery' of a common Old Norse history, which became part of Danish, Norwegian and Swedish cultural identity. The languages of the Nordic countries were very similar, there were clear cultural similarities, their histories were connected and they had common myths concerning their origins.

This proto-Scandinavianism bore a cosmopolitan stamp and, during the war of 1807–14, it was affected by dynastic thinking.¹⁷ The Danish professor Jens Schiønderup Sneedorff had launched the idea of 'the union of the three Nordic kingdoms' as early as 1792, while in France the exiled Danish geographer Conrad Malte-Brun published his pamphlet *Projet d'association coloniale de la nouvelle Scandinavie* (1804), in which he suggested that Napoleon should unite the Nordic countries under Danish leadership. Malte-Brun even organised a committee in Paris to further this aim, but it was suppressed by Napoleon, who did not consider the idea politically opportune. News of the project reached Copenhagen, however, where it was erroneously believed to enjoy French support. As will become evident, several attempts were made by Danes and Norwegians to realise a Scandinavian union during the war years of 1807–14, but each time French support, which would have been decisive, failed to materialise. This may appear paradoxical since in 1801 the French had shown interest in the idea of a united Scandinavia that could pose a threat to the influence of Great Britain in the Baltic.¹⁸

The Danish and Norwegian armies, which were separated for administrative reasons, each consisted of approximately 40,000 men, to which must be added the militia (established in 1801) and the navy, which comprised more than 20 ships of the line and a larger number of frigates and smaller ships. At the beginning of the eighteenth century, the 'twin kingdoms', together with Sweden and Prussia, had been the most militarised kingdoms in Europe. This was no longer the case on a continent where war and chaos had brought about a hitherto unseen mobilisation of power, resources and military might. However, the Danish and

the Norwegian armies were each of about the same size that the British army had been at the outbreak of war in 1793.

Growing prosperity masked the fact that Denmark-Norway had become weakened militarily in relation to the rest of Europe during the long period of peace. The integrity of the state was thereby only allowed to endure for as long as this was in the interests of the great powers. Russia played a decisive role here as, since entering into the 'eternal alliance' in 1773, the country had been the protector of a Denmark-Norway which had, in effect, become a Russian client state. The alliance was in opposition to Sweden, which nursed the desire to regain lost areas of Finland from Russia and, above all, to conquer Norway. It might not appear on the face of things that Sweden could have constituted a threat to mighty Russia, but during this period the Russian army was frequently engaged in wars with the Ottoman Empire or, after 1792, in wars with France on the continent. In this situation, the Russian capital was dangerously close to the border with Finland, which was part of the Swedish state. Sweden could launch a surprise attack on St Petersburg from Finland in order to regain its lost territories, something that Gustav III had unsuccessfully attempted to do in 1788. Therefore, the purpose of the Danish-Russian alliance was to keep Sweden in check with the threat of a war on two fronts. Russian interest in the integrity of Denmark-Norway, however, was conditional upon the danger of a Swedish attack on St Petersburg. If Russia were to conquer Finland, it would render the alliance superfluous and make the Swedish loss of the country a Danish-Norwegian nightmare.

In step with the growing 'civilising' effect of the Enlightenment, a number of European philosophers, among them Immanuel Kant, dreamt of a peaceful world where war did not exist. Even in military circles, attempts were made to find laws of mathematical strategy that would eliminate war once and for all. In Denmark-Norway such thoughts were seen in the light of the long period of peace, which prompted some authors to claim that the Danish-Norwegian state had actually moved to a more elevated stage than the rest of the world. This may appear exceptionally arrogant, but it must be viewed against the fact that Europe had been in the throes of wars and revolution since 1792, while Danes and Norwegians had been enjoying the fruits of peace for 80 years. The two peoples can hardly be blamed for viewing the state as a 'temple of peace' in a chaotic world. In prose, poetry and song Danes and Norwegians paid tribute to themselves, their king and their government for the twin kingdoms' wise and humane policy of neutrality. It appeared to some people that the perpetual peace Kant had

dreamt of a few years previously had descended on Denmark-Norway in an absolutist form.

This growing prosperity, however, had its foundations in the misfortunes of others. The good times that had literally cannoned into existence with the American War of Independence in 1775 and lasted up to the Bombardment of Copenhagen in 1807 have become known in Danish and Norwegian historiography as ‘the palmy days’. This was the golden epoch of big business, during which fortunes were made from overseas trade, from the exploitation of neutrality and from speculation. The economic boon was closely related to the wars and destruction created by the rivalry of the great European powers. These perpetual wars allowed Danish and Norwegian ships to win a market share on international routes. The years of peace in Europe, on the other hand, meant economic decline with ships laid up by the major business houses in Copenhagen, where fortunes had been amassed by exploiting the neutrality of the state to the *absolute* limit. But even though Danish-Norwegian market share always fell at the end of a war, it would stabilise at a higher level than before. In 1806, the year before Denmark-Norway became involved in the Napoleonic Wars, the Danish-Norwegian merchant fleet saw the number of its ships and their total tonnage reach its peak. A total of 3500 merchant ships sailed under the Dannebrog (the Danish flag) in 1806, making Denmark-Norway one of the world’s largest shipping nations relative to its population.¹⁹

The general expectation in the Danish-Norwegian state was that the good times would continue to roll. The author of a series of articles in a prominent Danish newspaper at the beginning of 1807 optimistically envisaged how, over the next 30 years, the appearance of Copenhagen would be enhanced with the addition of magnificent public buildings, among them a new palace that would house a national museum. As predictions go, this was not a bad one, since the museum was actually opened in the newly built palace in 1832, but the vision of an interim period of peace and happiness was, to put it mildly, misplaced. Before the end of the year, large areas of the capital had been turned into smouldering heaps of rubble.

The Exploitation of Neutrality

During the eighteenth century territories overseas took on increasing importance for the European economy which, during times of war, meant that many nations made use of neutral shipping to bring home their precious cargos. This was a *sine qua non* for ‘the palmy days’ in

Denmark-Norway. However, it also gave the warring parties a greater incentive to engage in economic war at sea, something that increasingly affected Danish and Norwegian ships in the form of privateering, searches and seizures.

The concept of neutrality essentially involves the idea of occupying a balanced mid-point without favouring any parties, even though it does not exclude the possibility of being neutral and allied at one and the same time. Reality, however, often looks quite different. Great Britain was indisputably the strongest naval power, and neutral trade therefore always benefited Britain's opponents. For this reason, the Danish government adapted its policy to the current balance of power at sea. During the American War of Independence, the Royal Navy was under extreme pressure and this allowed Denmark to exploit the situation to a greater degree than usual. The principles of the Danish-Norwegian standpoint can be summed up in five points: (1) There must be no restrictions to shipping in any port or along any coast. (2) A neutral ship has unrestricted cargo (except contraband). (3) There should be a narrow and equitable definition of what constitutes contraband. (4) A blockade need only be respected when it is enforced. (5) These rules had to be published and apply to all privateers and in all courts of law.

The demand was that neutral ships, like the Danish-Norwegian ships, should be able to sail the seas freely and without being searched to determine whether they had contraband of war on board, or whether their cargos really belonged to one of the warring parties. In reality neither Danes nor Norwegians wanted these principles to be universally enforced as it would have benefited their competitors. The Danish-Norwegian government was therefore anything but happy when the state was forced to join the League of Armed Neutrality in 1780 by its Russian ally, which officially demanded recognition of precisely the five Danish-Norwegian principles.

The *de facto* recognition of Danish and Norwegian activities by the British was at stake and this goal was achieved during the American War of Independence. There was also a victory in relation to the issue of contraband of war with the Danish-British convention of 1780. Contraband of war includes the materials used by a state to conduct war and it was generally accepted that a country was entitled to prevent its enemies from obtaining them. The question, however, was how the concept should be defined. A narrow interpretation included products that were of immediate use in a war, such as cannons. But a broad definition could include everything from iron and timber to agricultural produce and fish. First in practice and later also in principle, however,

the British accepted the narrow definition during their confrontation with the belligerent American colonists.

Neutrality was not only exploited by the Danes and Norwegians in the form of shipping supplies to the warring parties, but also by their ships sailing under a Danish flag of convenience. The prime mover in this connection was the Dutch-born merchant Frédéric de Coninck. When the Netherlands were forced into the war, de Coninck and other Danish merchants purchased a large number of Dutch ships on a pro forma basis. With the help of his political contacts, de Coninck managed matters so that many of these Dutch ships that were in foreign ports were sent Danish papers and could provide a regular carrying trade on the international routes without so much as even seeing the coasts of Denmark or Norway. Other ships were purchased in the Dutch colonies where goods were stockpiled and sailed to Copenhagen under the cover of the *Dannebrog*. This was a pattern that was repeated during the Revolutionary and Napoleonic Wars.

The state not only attempted to help private individuals by exploiting the boon. Members of the government also established quasi state-owned trading companies, all of which had six directors, who were government ministers, and merchant prince Niels Ryberg in common. The group of shareholders was dominated by the royal family and the power elite, which blurred the line between private advantage and the interests of the state. However, other traders were generally given concessions similar to those that members of the government reserved for their own speculations, or were allowed to take part-ownership of the companies through the issue of 'small-denomination shares'. The companies thereby functioned as the advance guard for the exploitation of neutrality.

The question, however, was whether this was a responsible policy as it increased the risk of a conflict with Great Britain. The gamble became more dangerous over time with ministers smuggling colonial produce from the Spanish colonies under the protection of the navy's men-of-war, whose captains had orders to prevent any British attempts to search them. The government had refused to give this protection to merchants as the use of warships involved the risk of a conflict that could probably not be controlled. The members of the government were hereby playing games of chance with the neutrality of the state for the sake of their own gain.

The economic downturn in the wake of the American War of Independence was replaced by a new boon as the Revolutionary Wars once again threw Europe into a state of conflict. These wars, however, were of a new character as they were fought not only to gain power, territory

and glory, but also in the name of ideology. There was thus tremendous pressure on the Danish-Norwegian state to join the war against revolutionary France. But the government stood firm on its policy of neutrality. After the execution of Louis XVI, while the state officially broke off diplomatic relations with France, it retained a secretary of legation in Paris and allowed a French emissary to live in Copenhagen.

The Danish-Norwegian government demanded only two things from its merchants during the Revolutionary and Napoleonic Wars: first that they respected an effective blockade and second that they did not ship contraband of war to the French, the latter being something that the Danish government was fully aware that the merchants were doing. Huge quantities of muskets, gunpowder and bullets were thus shipped to France under cover of the neutral Danish flag. But the greatest service the Danes performed for the French was to transport corn and other food to France. According to Denmark-Norway's understanding with the British, this should not have been a problem, but it was.

The British thus broke the convention with Denmark from 1780 as they had made it their official policy to starve the French into submission. Denmark was thereby from the very beginning of the Revolutionary Wars on a collision course with Great Britain. Danish and Norwegian ships were seized by the dozen and the strong Danish-Norwegian protests were rejected on the grounds that France had no legal government and in pursuing its policy had placed itself outside all existing international law. With the support of the other great powers, the British attempted to put the neutral states of Denmark-Norway and Sweden in their place – but without success. Denmark-Norway invoked the immutability of international law, but went so far as to refuse to admit French privateers to the state's ports.

The First Battle of Copenhagen, 1801

The Danish-Norwegian exploitation of neutrality often balanced on a knife-edge, but was usually weighed up according to the situation. At the end of the 1790s, however, Denmark-Norway made the fatal mistake of going from a 'defensive' to an 'offensive' policy of neutrality. Ailing Foreign Minister Andreas Peter Bernstorff wisely rejected the request for convoys from the merchants of Copenhagen as this could bring the state on a collision course with Great Britain. However, his son, Christian, who in fact, although initially not in name, took over the office of foreign minister on his father's death in 1797, did not possess the authority of his father. Crown Prince Frederick was a year older

than Christian Bernstorff and he now wished to reign 'autocratically'. Finance Minister Ernst Schimmelmann, who was deeply involved in a host of business speculations, wasted no time in appealing to the prince's overdeveloped code of honour. By citing the increasing problem of French privateers at the beginning of 1798, he succeeded in gaining permission for ships to sail in convoys from the East Indies through the English Channel in 'exceptional' cases. Once the barrier had been broken down, more and more convoys sailed during the following period until the exception became the rule and thereby set Denmark-Norway on a direct collision course with the world's most powerful navy. This was a signal error of judgement and rapidly turned into a number of minor episodes that led to acrimonious diplomatic exchanges.

The situation became acute in connection with what was called the Freya Affair, a brief naval battle in the English Channel between a Danish-Norwegian warship and three British men-of-war. The government in Copenhagen subsequently appealed to its Russian ally to establish a new League of Armed Neutrality, an idea that was received with enthusiasm in St Petersburg, where Tsar Paul wanted to establish a new, more aggressive policy in relation to Great Britain at precisely this point in time. The result was a new league between Russia, Denmark, Sweden and Prussia with the tsar high-handedly and ruthlessly determining the common course of the league. The policy that had been chosen led the league in general and Denmark-Norway in particular towards war with Great Britain as the League of Armed Neutrality denied the right of the great powers to inspect the cargos of neutral ships and made it clear that there would be no hesitation in backing up the principle of neutrality with arms.

The new Danish-Norwegian policy was based on an unrealistic assessment of the state's military power. The British seized all Danish and Norwegian ships in their ports, occupied the Danish-Norwegian colonies in the West Indies and sent a fleet to Copenhagen in March 1801 in order to convince Crown Prince Frederick that he should leave the league. This created a dilemma for the Danish-Norwegian government. Leaving the league would mean running the risk of reprisals from Russia, where the anti-British Tsar Paul I was making energetic overtures to France. The existence of the state was now under real threat as any concessions to Great Britain could be expected to result in a Swedish invasion of Norway while, under pressure from Russia, Prussia could occupy the Jutland peninsula.

This was the reason why Denmark-Norway decided to take up the First Battle of Copenhagen on 2 April 1801. As the Danish-Norwegian fleet was the guarantor of the lucrative maritime trade, there was no desire to

put it at risk, so a number of decommissioned defensive ships were sailed to the King's Deep outside Copenhagen Harbour. If the British gained control of these waters, they would be able to bombard the city and the fleet, and were well on their way to accomplishing this when, after a battle lasting almost five hours, Vice Admiral Horatio Nelson offered Denmark-Norway a truce. There was no reason to increase what were already considerable British losses in equipment and lives when it was simply a question of time before the battle was won. This offer should be seen in the light of the fact that the British fleet, according to plan, would subsequently have to be capable of challenging both the Russian and the Swedish fleets. This inconclusive outcome created the myth that Denmark and Norway had been closest to victory. There can be no doubt that the Danes and Norwegians who fought and died on the 'glorious' 2 April 1801, as the battle in Denmark-Norway was known at the time, did so with a courage that helped to ignite the strong sense of patriotism of the following period. But the First Battle of Copenhagen can only be regarded as a British victory. The negotiations after the battle were on the brink of breaking down when news came on 9 April that the tsar had been assassinated just over a week before the battle. His successor, Tsar Alexander I, was far less keen on a confrontation with Great Britain, and Denmark-Norway could therefore meet the British demands by suspending its membership of the League of Armed Neutrality. This made it possible to avoid a total military defeat, which would almost certainly have been the outcome if hostilities had continued.

The First Battle of Copenhagen was compared in contemporary poems to the battles of antiquity at Salamis and Marathon. Danes and Norwegians poetically presented themselves as Greeks who were defending the civilised principals of trade and international law against the British, who acted barbarically like modern-day Persians under the leadership of the new Xerxes, Lord Nelson. In spite of this blustering rhetoric, the First Battle of Copenhagen did not result in a general, lasting hatred of the British. According to the memoirs of a civil servant, relations with Great Britain at the time were relatively amicable. Trade took an upswing again and many people took a positive view of the British up to the Bombardment of Copenhagen in 1807.

The Last Years of Peace

Denmark-Norway returned to its less provocative policy of defensive neutrality after the Battle of Copenhagen, and relations with Great Britain remained good for the next few years. The danger at this period

came from another quarter. During the summer of 1801, Gustav IV Adolph considered attacking both Zealand and Norway, and during the winter of 1803, Swedish propaganda was spread in the Norwegian border areas in order to pave the way for pro-Swedish sympathisers. Even though Gustav IV Adolph had spent the years between 1803 and 1807 chiefly in Germany and had brought Sweden into the third coalition against Napoleon in 1805, several of his most influential political and military advisers had their eyes focused sharply on Norway. They felt that Sweden should rather make war on Crown Prince Frederick in Scandinavia than on Napoleon in Germany. Initially, Gustav IV Adolph paid no attention to this, but when the Swedish army was thrown out of Pomerania in September 1807 and Sweden, as the only remaining British ally, was threatened by Napoleon and Russia, the pressure on the Swedish king became even more intense.²⁰

The Treaty of Amiens in 1802 brought a temporary halt to the seemingly perpetual hostilities between France and Great Britain, but the respite was brief and the war broke out again in 1803. Many Danes saw Great Britain, which had declared war, as the villain. According to a prominent Danish philologist, seven of the eight members of the Danish general staff in 1804 were convinced 'Bonapartists'.²¹ In general, however, sympathies were more divided and attitudes to France and Britain were ambiguous.

It comes as no surprise that Napoleon Bonaparte was central to Danes' and Norwegians' views of France. His person and conduct divided opinions. After his *coup d'état* in November 1799, Napoleon reintroduced censorship in France, which presumably prompted many Danish radicals to renounce the new regime, while others continued to hold their democratic views in the guise of 'Bonapartism'. Many people thus saw Napoleon as the man who could further and realise the revolution's ideals. A prominent Danish periodical editor, who was critical of Napoleon, grudgingly acknowledged that the 'general view' of the First Consul of France was positive. However, this was not the crown prince's view. Frederick VI has often been accused of being an uncritical admirer of Napoleon, but this is due to a lack of knowledge of the later king's attitude. Crown Prince Frederick had become increasingly conservative over the years and his personal view of Napoleon was that while the man was a great general, he was also a dangerous usurper who was a threat to the stability of Europe.²²

Just as expected, the resumption of the war between France and Britain constituted major financial benefit for merchants in Denmark-Norway. When the British blocked the Elbe, many exports had to be

redirected to towns in west Schleswig such as Husum and Tønning. In 1804, the Danish monarchy imported what was technically 15 per cent of total British cotton production – which should not be taken to mean that Danish peasants stopped wearing woollen vests!²³ But during the years 1805–07, the political and military situation developed in a way that was to prove catastrophic for Denmark-Norway. The victory at Trafalgar in October 1805 definitively secured British naval superiority while Napoleon ruled the European continent to the same degree as the British dominated the seas. The victories at Austerlitz (1805) and at Jena/Auerstädt (1806) removed the Austrians and Prussians from the picture and it appeared to be only a matter of time before the Russians would also have to give in. The French troops were now immediately south of the state's border in Holstein and there were rumours of a French invasion of the two duchies.

While it was true that it was a loss of prestige for the British to see the coalition they had financed brushed aside, Napoleon's victories on land brought him no closer to a decisive victory over Great Britain. After the Battle of Trafalgar, an invasion of the British Isles was not realistic and it would hardly be possible to starve the British into submission. Attempts to do so might also lead to reversals on the home front as French farmers earned good money by exporting corn to the British. Napoleon hoped instead to undermine the British economy by striking at the country's huge export income from its industrial and colonial products by closing the continent to British shipping.

In the autumn of 1806, Napoleon attempted to realise his plan by introducing the 'Continental Blockade' with the intention of creating an economic and social crisis in the British Isles and preventing Britain using its wealth to finance its wars against France. London's counter-move in January 1807 was to forbid the ships of all other countries to enter those ports that British ships were debarred from entering. This was a bitter pill for neutral Denmark-Norway to swallow, but initially it was only possible to partly enforce the draconic French and British provisions. Where the Continental Blockade was concerned, while Napoleon already controlled large areas of Europe through his allies and vassal states, the system would only have the desired effect if the hostile states of Russia and Sweden and neutral states such as Denmark and Portugal joined in. In spite of the Danish-Norwegian government's genuine desire to maintain the state's neutrality, its time was running out and it would soon be necessary to choose between Great Britain and France, a choice that lay between the devil and the deep blue sea for the government in Copenhagen.

2

The Bombardment of Copenhagen in 1807

The Peace of Tilsit

The Peace of Tilsit between Russia and France on 9 July 1807 changed everything. The Russians entered into an alliance with Napoleon and joined the Continental Blockade, and the general assumption was that attempts would be made to force neutral countries to follow suit. This created a dilemma for the Danish government. Rejecting the expected Franco-Russian demand would lead to the occupation of the duchies and Jutland. Acceding to the demand would mean that the British navy would cut the connection to Norway, and the state would run the risk of losing it. The government could cling to neutrality as long as possible, but, as far as Great Britain and France were concerned, the war had now entered a phase in which neutrality was no longer an acceptable option.

The demand made by France and Russia of the neutral states was formulated in a secret supplementary clause to the Peace of Tilsit, but at the end of July the French began to reveal its contents to the neutral countries. On 30 July Portugal was instructed to join the Continental Blockade. Napoleon had also ordered his Foreign Minister to present Denmark-Norway with an ultimatum to choose to side either with France or with Great Britain, while Marshal Bernadotte in northern Germany received an order to prepare an attack on Denmark-Norway. But the French Foreign Minister Talleyrand, who did, in fact, resign a few days later in protest against the Peace of Tilsit, ignored the Emperor's order when he met the Danish emissary in Paris on 6 August. In a subsequent conversation Talleyrand, now resigned, allayed the fears of the Danish emissary by assuring him that the Danish-Norwegian government would be permitted to continue its existing foreign policy. The reason for Talleyrand's disobedience is still unknown, but it could

possibly be due to the fact that he knew that the British were preparing an attack and therefore expected that Denmark-Norway would end up in the French camp under any circumstances. In this case, a French ultimatum could be used as a justification for an action by the British.¹

The British government also knew nothing of the supplementary clause to the Peace of Tilsit but quite accurately guessed what it contained and decided to steal a march on the French by sending a fleet to Copenhagen. In an attempt to prevent the Danes and Norwegians from learning about the impending expedition, a total prohibition was imposed on sailing from British ports. This was only partially successful. Members of the Danish Ministry of Trade as well as merchants in the duchies were convinced that the British aims were hostile, but it was assumed at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs that the expedition was bound for the Swedish town of Stralsund in northern Germany, where British troops were already stationed. Joachim Bernstorff, the Foreign Minister's brother and permanent secretary, brushed aside a warning from the Danish consul in Portsmouth in a similar manner.

But why did the actions of Great Britain come as such a surprise to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the foreign minister and the crown prince? One explanation was that even though the Danish-Norwegian government was not exactly enthusiastic about Great Britain, it did not believe it had acted in such a way as to be considered hostile. But this was precisely what the British did feel. The British had long feared that the Danes would not be *capable* of preventing the French from taking possession of the Danish-Norwegian fleet, but now they had begun to doubt whether they were even *willing* so to do.

On the face of it, it could be asked whether Denmark-Norway and its fleet really could constitute a threat to the mighty Royal Navy, but the British fleet was stretched almost to the limit on the seven seas. In 1805 Denmark-Norway's fleet was the fifth largest in the world and was manned by skilled seamen. In addition, it would easily be able to collaborate with the state's traditional protector – and Napoleon's new ally – Russia, whose Baltic fleet was the fourth largest in the world. They were incapable of challenging British mastery of the seas either individually or collectively, but at home the Danes would be capable of cutting off British trade in the Baltic, which was vital for the British economy, for British corn imports and for the Royal Navy, whose supplies of naval stores came from the Baltic. In addition, if the Danish-Norwegian fleet fell into Napoleon's hands, the French could employ it in an attempt to challenge British naval dominance or to mount a landing in the British Isles to provide support for an Irish rebellion.²

In contrast to the situation in 1800–01, this was not a question of Denmark-Norway deliberately running a risk. Danish-Norwegian protests against violations of its neutrality had become more acrimonious and had grown in number as the British countermeasures had made life increasingly difficult for the neutral states, but they were hardly intended as provocations. They were simply necessary in order to be able to invoke the principles of neutrality at a later date. While the Danish-Norwegian government was not enthusiastic about the British, both Foreign Minister Christian Bernstorff and Crown Prince Frederick were clearly more critical of Napoleon. Bernstorff consistently referred to France as a tyrannical power that was keeping all of Europe in a state of dishonour and slavery.³

The size of the Danish army made it impossible to protect the state against a French attack on the duchies and Jutland as well as a British attack on Zealand and Copenhagen. What the Danish-Norwegian government chiefly feared and prepared for was an attack by the French, as was clearly shown by the fact that, since 1803, the Danish army had been guarding the border to the south, leaving the capital virtually unprotected. This policy had been reinforced in 1805 when the crown prince and the Foreign Minister took up permanent residence in Holstein. Fear of the French had only increased in 1806 when Napoleon clearly demonstrated his lack of respect for neutrality by occupying the free cities of Hamburg and Lübeck.

If the French ultimatum had been anticipated by the British, the chances were that the Danes and Norwegians would have thrown themselves into the arms of the British instead of Napoleon's. In December 1806 the Danish-Norwegian government had openly declared that, if the French demanded the closing of Danish ports to British ships, it would regard Great Britain as its 'natural ally', but the declaration appears to have gone unnoticed in Whitehall.⁴

What had caught the eye of the British was the rejection by Crown Prince Frederick of a Swedish proposal to set up a joint Scandinavian army in Holstein which, together with Britain, would act as a bulwark against further French expansion. This was only to be expected in the light of Denmark-Norway's declared policy of neutrality, but it provoked anger in the British government.⁵ This could possibly be because it coincided with the withdrawal of the Danish army from Holstein to Schleswig. This move took place firstly because the Danish army in Holstein had been surrounded by French troops on three sides. Second, there was a need to avoid a clash erupting between Danish and French troops, which was exactly what had happened before the withdrawal had begun.

On 6 November 1806 French troops crossed the Danish border in Holstein, hunting for fleeing Prussian soldiers. The Danes promptly took up arms to protect the neutrality of the state and forced the French units to withdraw. However, the battle did not appear to have harmed Danish–French relations. On the other hand, Danish support of the British mail route to the continent through the duchies was a thorn in the side of both states. Napoleon demanded it be closed, which the Danish–Norwegian government flatly refused.⁶

But neither the Danish–French engagement nor the rejection of Napoleon's demand made any impression on Downing Street. The growing British distrust of the Danish–Norwegian government was heightened in the summer of 1807 by some alarming information. The fleet in Copenhagen was a fleet in being, with the great majority of its ships lying stripped at anchor in the harbour. As long as this was the case, it constituted only a potential threat. If the fleet were to be fitted out, on the other hand, it would immediately be observed and interpreted as an expression of an offensive attitude to Great Britain. In May 1807 Lord Pembroke, who was the recently appointed British ambassador to Austria, was passing through Copenhagen on his way to his post when, so he said, he observed the entire Danish–Norwegian fleet being fitted out. What Lord Pembroke actually saw was and remains a mystery. The only ship that had been fitted out was a ship of the line being prepared to take a Russian princess to St Petersburg, and Foreign Secretary George Canning did not react immediately to Pembroke's letter. Matters changed, however, at the beginning of July with the Peace of Tilsit, which fundamentally altered the appearance of the threat. British fears were further exacerbated by intelligence from France that Napoleon was planning to use the Danish–Norwegian fleet to support an invasion of Ireland. The information later proved to be a deliberate fabrication but it was taken at face value by the British government and, together with Pembroke's letter and the erroneous assessment of sentiments in Denmark–Norway, it contributed to the decision to send a substantial British fleet to Danish waters to emphasise the gravity of the ultimatum that would be presented to Crown Prince Frederick. The actions of the British government may appear ruthless, but as far as the British were concerned the aim was to deprive Napoleon of the first fruits of the Peace of Tilsit.⁷

A determined expedition against Copenhagen could be used to show the British themselves and the world that the country had not been beaten 'and to stun Russia into her senses again'.⁸ While the attack on Denmark did not on the face of it influence Russian policy, it was significant for the choice made in Portugal, which was shortly afterwards

presented with both a French and a British ultimatum. Referring to the fate of Copenhagen, the king decided to evacuate his capital with the help of the Portuguese fleet and set up a government in exile in Brazil, leaving Napoleon's troops to occupy Portugal itself. A similar parallel would have been Crown Prince Frederick seeking refuge with the Danish-Norwegian fleet in Norway. But in the first place the British had not burned Lisbon as a terrible warning of things to come, and in the second it should be remembered that the British had offered the Portuguese better terms than the Danish-Norwegian government.⁹

The British Fleet in Danish Waters

An imposing armada set sail from Britain at the end of July. The fleet, comprising no fewer than 25 ships of the line with around 40 smaller warships and several hundred transports, reached the Kattegat during the first days of August. Traditionally, only Danes had been able to navigate ships in the Great Belt in the waters between Zealand and Funen as they were the only seamen who possessed the necessary charts, but on their way home from the First Battle of Copenhagen, the British had charted the straits. This meant that Rear Admiral Keats could be sent to the Great Belt to cut off Zealand and the capital from the rest of Denmark.

Britain's impressive military demonstration was designed to emphasise its intention to back up the demands it was making on the Danish-Norwegian government with force. A decision had been made at a cabinet meeting on 18 July demanding that Denmark-Norway either enter into an alliance with Great Britain – whereby the entire Danish-Norwegian fleet would come under British control – or surrender its fleet to Britain for the duration of the war as a pledge that it would maintain its neutrality. It was impossible for Crown Prince Frederick to agree to either of these demands. Cohesion between the various parts of the Danish-Norwegian state depended on the fleet, and the protection offered by the British would not make it possible to defend the Jutland peninsula. The question here is whether the British demands were really addressed to the Danish-Norwegian government or to the British opposition. An attack on a neutral Denmark would in all probability give rise to harsh criticism, but the ultimatum and the offer to the Danish-Norwegian government could be used in defence of the policy the British were pursuing.¹⁰

The British negotiator, Sir Francis Jackson, presented the British demands to the crown prince and the foreign minister in Kiel on 8 August.¹¹ The

situation was clear to Jackson: Denmark must choose between an alliance and war, but after a heated discussion with the foreign minister and then the crown prince, it became evident that they refused to make this choice. Foreign Minister Christian Bernstorff called the British offer the 'most infernal' ever conceived, as the pledge demanded for an alliance was the entire Danish-Norwegian fleet. In his eyes this was not a question of an alliance, but of Denmark-Norway's 'thralldom'.¹² Denmark-Norway stood firmly by its 80 years of neutrality. This meant that there were never negotiations proper in Kiel in August 1807.

Having learned what the British aims were, the crown prince rushed from Kiel to the capital to prepare its defence where he summoned the leading generals and chief civil servants. News of Frederick's arrival spread like wildfire through the city, where it created great delight. Frederick had originally intended to take the lead in defending the capital as he envisioned an attack along the lines of that in 1801. It rapidly became clear, however, that the size of the British force was of a completely different magnitude than it had been six years previously.¹³ He therefore decided to return to Holstein immediately as he did not want to be cut off from the army or from contact with his surroundings and, after giving the necessary orders, Frederick left Copenhagen with his mentally ill father, Christian VII.

There was tremendous disappointment over Frederick's 'flight' in the hour of danger, and this was not lessened by the fact that, after the siege had begun, other members of the royal family left the city carrying British passports and accompanied by many members of the royal household, as well as the crown jewels. Copenhageners felt they had been betrayed, and in order to dampen the ill feeling, attempts were made in newspaper articles and sermons to explain the necessity of the royal conduct.

Having arrived safely on shore, the crown prince continued his journey, first through Odense on Funen to Kolding in Jutland and then on to the army's headquarters in Kiel in Holstein. However active Frederick had been during his 24 hours in the capital, he had forgotten what was perhaps the most important matter: he had given no instructions as to what should be done with the fleet if the city was forced to surrender. He attempted to remedy this from Kiel with an order to General Peymann in Copenhagen. If it became necessary to surrender Copenhagen, the fleet must be burned. The courier, however, was captured by the British, and the order never reached the capital. According to Danish historiography, the courier destroyed the order, but British sources show that the enemy got its hands on Frederick's instructions.¹⁴

Landing and Occupation

The morning of 16 August saw the start of the landing of a large number of troops at Vedbæk, north of Copenhagen, and this was followed the next day by landings at Skodsborg, also north of Copenhagen, and in the northern part of Køge Bay, south of the city. The British army comprised about 30,000 men who could, if required, be supplemented by 5000 seamen from the fleet.¹⁵

The British army advanced rapidly and had already surrounded the capital and cut it off from the rest of the country by 17 August. A proclamation to the effect that the British had not come as enemies but as Denmark's friends was distributed among the local inhabitants throughout the occupied areas. According to the proclamation, the British were acting purely in self-defence and their sole mission was to defend the country against the continental tyrant, Napoleon. They wanted nothing more than to reach an understanding with the Danish-Norwegian government. Their fine words made very little impression on the Zealanders – not least because they were not in Danish but in English or German. And when the British had the text translated in Sweden, it turned out to be a hotchpotch of Danish and Swedish, which the Danes found highly entertaining. The only result of this English propaganda was to encourage the gallows humour of the Danes, who subsequently described the British attack on Copenhagen as 'the friendly English bombardment'.

In Denmark, and across the rest of the European continent, the ravages and depredations of the French army were notorious, and on Zealand people hardly expected the British troops to behave much better, as their reputation was marred by stories about their conduct in India. The presence of the British fleet in the Sound alone prompted people in many places to bury their silverware, and after the landing the mere sight of foreign soldiers scared the locals half to death. Some fled helter-skelter into the forests with their families and belongings, while others loaded their wagons with beds, furniture and families before fleeing with their livestock in tow. People were afraid of being plundered, assaulted and raped, but this fear evaporated for many of them as it gradually became clear that it was unfounded in *most* cases.¹⁶

Although military operations took place primarily in and around Copenhagen, British troops were spread over large areas of Zealand. Officers usually lived on farms, while ordinary soldiers lived in the forests or in barns and stables. In some cases, this led to damage, theft and assaults on civilians. At Frederiksberg, just north of Copenhagen,

the inhabitants and their property were treated roughly. On the other hand, there were examples, particularly at the beginning of the occupation, of good relations between the local inhabitants and British soldiers. The only people the British killed in this connection were four of their own soldiers, who were executed for looting and other assaults on civilians. The supreme commander, General Lord William Cathcart, had given strict orders in advance that the local inhabitants should not be molested and warned that brutality would not be tolerated.¹⁷

On 16 August, the date of the landings, Admiral Gambier and General Cathcart had already proclaimed that all foodstuffs consumed by the army would be paid for. However, it was made clear to public officials that if they refused to cooperate, the British would take what they needed by force. Bearing this in mind, the local authorities everywhere met the British demands in order to protect local inhabitants, who were busy with the harvest.

In the northern area of Copenhagen County, however, the British ran into what was later described as 'patriotic collaboration'. The chief administrative officer and the district revenue officer both lived in Copenhagen and had therefore been isolated when the occupation began. The British instead contacted the local priest, Bonne Falch Rønne, who, in order to avoid military excursions and troops being quartered on them, agreed to help the enemy to obtain supplies. Rønne was soon seconded by the wealthy merchant Frédéric de Coninck at the manor of Dronninggård and by Count Schulin at Frederiksdal. This self-constituted commission, which was appointed by Cathcart as a British field commissariat, had the count as a figurehead, the merchant as entrepreneur and the priest as an energetic motive force. The three regarded themselves as true patriots, but their 'policy of collaboration' aroused considerable antagonism among Copenhageners. Realising that they were in an embarrassing situation, they sent a letter to the commandant in the besieged Copenhagen, General Peymann, to persuade him to concede that they had de facto taken over the duties that rightly belonged to the king's civil servants. This is a partial parallel to what happened in the Rhineland, where both the local elites and civil servants found themselves between a rock and a hard place with their princes on one side and the French occupying forces on the other.¹⁸

The commission, however, did not receive the reply for which they had hoped. Paradoxically, Peymann refused to admit that the chief administrative officer and the district revenue officer, who were stuck in the besieged city, were unable to perform their duties outside the city. Instead he warned the commission that their activities were usurping

the civil servants' authority and that they were in danger of committing treason by entering into the service of the enemy. This did not trouble the patriotic collaborators, who continued working to protect their countrymen.

Fortress Copenhagen

On 16 August, the same day as the landing at Vedbæk, Crown Prince Frederick declared war on Great Britain. His hope was that he could relieve the beleaguered city with the help of the army from the duchies. The crown prince was counting on Copenhagen being able to hold out for about three months, and the inhabitants of the capital expected that the army would be able to see off the enemy as soon as the inland waterways froze over.

Nobody in the isolated capital knew what was happening outside its ramparts, but in accordance with his orders, General Peymann refused the British request to surrender. He wrote instead to the crown prince that he would defend to the end a city that could only fall into enemy hands if it were stormed. As a fortress, Copenhagen was not only inadequate and outdated but actually in a state of decay. The soldiers, too, were poorly equipped, and their cannon and gunpowder were of inferior quality to those of the British. The defences constructed in the seventeenth and the beginning of the eighteenth centuries and fronted with artificial lakes were, however, so extensive that the fortress in itself was robust enough to withstand shelling and difficult to storm. On the other hand, the artificial lakes made it difficult to conduct an active defence using sorties.¹⁹

The defensive works facing the sea, on the other hand, had been strengthened since the First Battle of Copenhagen in 1801, so it was now possible, using gunboats, to ward off British attempts to bombard Copenhagen from the Sound. There were almost 14,000 men available to defend the city. Of these, however, only slightly more than 5500 were regular soldiers. The rest were made up of citizen corps, students, militia and gamekeepers. To these could be added between 3500 and 4000 seamen and marines, who were responsible for the seaward defences. At the head of this force was the 72-year-old engineer general, Peymann, seconded by the similarly ageing generals Bielefeldt and Gedde. All three were conscientious patriots, but none of them had any real experience of war. The only person with any military competence among those with the task of defending Copenhagen was the commander of the seaward defence, Commodore Steen Bille.²⁰

Volunteers

The city had its own citizen corps and, in theory, every male civilian citizen between the ages of 20 and 50 had a duty to serve in them. These corps were not always popular, and civil servants in particular were exempted, but the First Battle of Copenhagen had aroused enthusiasm for them among students and younger citizens. The Crown Prince's Volunteer Lifeguard was founded in 1801 for these students, while more well-to-do citizens joined the King's Fusiliers. The student corps was voluntary in theory, but in reality serving in it was made obligatory by the university, by the general public and by social pressure. During the siege of Copenhagen in 1807, many members of the general public who were not officially citizens and were not, therefore, part of the citizen corps were promised a cash reward if they joined the colours. This brought in more than enough willing hands, but many of those who volunteered had to be turned down because they were either suffering from consumption, scabies or other diseases. The military spirit seemed pervasive, and during the years after 1807 Denmark was described as a great military camp filled with soldiers on exercises and citizen corps.²¹

The Militia and the Battle of the Clogs at Køge

The only faint ray of hope for the rapid relief of Copenhagen was pinned on the peasant militias that had been established in 1801. The underlying idea of the militias was that the common man would defend his home, province and fatherland against any invading enemy. Here the patriotic and national ideals of the middle classes met head on with the local and regional reality of the peasants. The peasant militias had been based on the idea of an armed people, an ideological notion that can be traced back to ancient Rome and the idea that the peasant who fought in defence of his home made the best, most patriotic soldier. This idea would be put to the test when the British landed on Zealand in 1807 and the peasant militias on Zealand and Lolland-Falster, the islands just south of Zealand, were mobilised.²²

During the six years that the peasant militias had been in existence, they had received virtually no military training. There was a fatal lack of officers, and those who were available were often 'old men, weak in body and addled in mind'. Nor was the situation any better with regard to equipment, as the militias had been given only a limited number of weapons from the military stores in Copenhagen in time. In order to solve the problem, the crown prince gave orders for people to collect

halberds, spears and swords in market towns and churches, weapons that their forefathers had used 'with honour against enemies and assailants'. Uniforms were also in short supply, so most peasants simply wore their everyday clothes and clogs.²³

The attempt to assemble the militia in Zealand succeeded to a surprising extent, not least thanks to the tremendous efforts made by patriotic civil servants. Every man capable of bearing arms – including beggars – were assembled, armed and equipped. The peasants of Zealand, however, summoned from their homes in the middle of the harvest, were not fired by the same spark that had ignited the middle classes. When the call to arms reached the village of Spjellerup, wives and children bewailed the fact that their fathers and sons were going off to 'a real war'.²⁴

Things were far worse on Lolland-Falster. The peasants there were fully aware that, according to the original decree on militias, they had the sole responsibility for defending their own province. For that reason they had no intention of abandoning 'their country', that is, Lolland-Falster, *not* Denmark, in the midst of the harvest. The attempt of a general of the militia to explain to the peasants that they belonged to the Zealand regimental district and that their 'province' also included the capital had just as little effect as his appeals to patriotism and his hurrahs for king and country. The mood was almost rebellious and the local peasants threatened several times to shoot the general or the few people who wanted to march off with him. But after a great deal of toil and trouble, he finally succeeded in transporting the Lolland-Falster militia to Zealand.

They joined the Zealand militia at Køge, just south of Copenhagen, where they collectively comprised a force of 7700 men. The British were fully aware of the Danish activities on Zealand, thanks to their efficient network of spies. The decision was made to send a corps of 6700 soldiers led by Sir Arthur Wellesley against Køge where, early in the morning of 29 August, they took the unprepared militia by surprise. The battle was brief and unequal. Some of the militiamen fought heroically against the superior force while others simply succumbed to 'cannon-fever' at the mere sight of the enemy. The militiamen threw away their muskets and equipment in their panicked flight, the better to make their escape in their peasants' clothing. The reports from the field hospitals at Køge and Roskilde showed that most of the militiamen had been shot in the back. A total of approximately 150 Danes fell in the battle, 200 were wounded and more than 1100 were taken prisoner. British losses were considerably lower with 29 dead, 122 wounded and 21 missing.²⁵

The engagement was dubbed 'The Battle of the Clogs' in Copenhagen, as many of the peasants had thrown away their clogs so that they could run faster. Contemporary patriotic discourse emphasised time and again that Danes were courageous and loved their fatherland by definition. Middle-class opinion was, therefore, that, in acting as they had, the peasant militia had betrayed the patriotic set of norms which, in their eyes, was common to all Danes, and the Lolland-Falster militia was mocked as cowardly. But the militia had not been given either the training, the equipment or the leadership to take on a professional army of hardened veterans, and, if criticism should have been levelled at anybody, its target should have been the crown prince for giving those peasant conscripts such a self-evidently unreasonable task.

Conditions in Denmark and Norway appeared to reflect tendencies similar to those described in more recent research into popular resistance in Europe during the Napoleonic Wars. Linda Colley has shown that in 1798 there was the same unwillingness in Britain to fight outside the local area and that patriotism was weakest in rural districts. The view that peasants lacked a sense of national identity is also supported by a new study of letters from Danish soldiers during the First Schleswig War (1848–51), where the peasants identified with their villages and their regions and fought in the name of the king. National categories were foreign to them. The same point can be made as regards Norway, where the local peasant defence force was precisely that – local. The motivating factor appears to have been the fear of depredation, violence and rape, while national and patriotic themes were of only subsidiary importance.²⁶

The fear of violence and looting on Zealand were, in fact, justified in the wake of the 'Battle of the Clogs' at Køge, when the generally strict discipline among the British broke down during the hunt for militiamen through the town of Køge. In this case, it was not only the British soldiers, but also their wives and sweethearts accompanying them, who saw the occasion as an opportunity to fill their pockets and spread fear among the town's inhabitants.²⁷

The Besieged City

Many people fled with their belongings into the city from the area around Copenhagen for protection against the invasion. In spite of the departure of the crown prince, a general enthusiasm reigned inside the ramparts. The buoyant mood was due not least to the fact that the country's 'victory' at the First Battle of Copenhagen lived on in memory.

People simply did not fear the enemy when they remembered the ‘licking’ the British had been given at the last encounter.

The crown prince had issued orders that all British property should be confiscated and all Britons gaoled. The latter presented the commandant with a problem of interpretation as it was not clear whether the order applied to the many Britons who had become naturalised citizens of Copenhagen. Peymann pragmatically refrained from arresting the latter, but the British-born inhabitants of Copenhagen found themselves in a difficult position, as Danes did not trust them to take part in the defence of the city. The siege also triggered an unfortunate combination of patriotic fervour and paranoia in some inhabitants, which resulted in harassment for anybody who appeared suspicious. American seamen in particular were liable to suspicion because of their language, but Russians, Swedes and even one drunk Norwegian were reported or dragged before the police by overzealous and suspicious patriots.²⁸

The experience of Copenhageners of the British bombs in 1801 led many to believe that a bombardment was not really dangerous. At the time a sport had even developed among students to try to extract the fuses from bombs before they exploded. The bombs that flew in over Copenhagen during the first days of the siege did little to change the impression of its inhabitants. Many of the missiles exploded in the air high above the city, while others landed without effect. It was only when a man was injured by one of these bombs on 24 August that people began to get an inkling of what was in store for them.

Writing in newspapers, periodicals and sermons, the learned and the clergy incited the public to fight and, if necessary, die for king and country. They often referred to the deeds of their forefathers, not only to the ‘glorious 2 April’ of 1801, but also to Copenhageners’ courage and prowess during the Swedish siege of the capital in 1658–59. According to contemporary observers, the memory of the Swedish Wars in the middle of the seventeenth century was still very much alive and only fuelled the disappointment that must have been felt when the crown prince returned to the army in Holstein instead of declaring that he was willing to ‘die in his nest’ like Frederick III in 1658. The message from the pulpit was mixed. The ungodliness of the British and the innocence of the Danish government were emphasised, but citizens were also berated for having taken peace for granted and for allowing themselves to be corrupted by materialism. God had permitted this attack on the law of nations in order to awake the people to renewed piety and ‘Danishness’. The war was thus used as a means of intimidating Danes

to return to the narrow path of virtue, but the sermons left no doubt that 'God is with us, God is for justice'.²⁹

Most people anticipated a long siege and therefore laid in plenty of stocks of food, but, although no supplies reached Copenhagen from outside, prices rose remarkably little. Normal trading in the city itself continued in many ways unaltered. On their own initiative, a number of citizens began to make collections as early as 16 August to help the 'defenders of the fatherland'. This was such a success that the people manning the ramparts and the batteries in the harbour received double rations of everything from aquavit to bread, cheese, soup and meat. The fact that there were many men on the ramparts, however, meant that many families in Copenhagen had been deprived of a breadwinner, so collections were also made for them. These private initiatives enjoyed widespread support and were followed up by similar public measures.

The British fleet was kept at a suitable distance from the city by Commodore Steen Bille's efficient gunboats, which inflicted considerable losses on the British to the noisy rapture of the many Copenhageners following the battles from the harbour. Yet optimism and solidarity became mixed with growing dissatisfaction with the military leadership. During the first days of the siege, the citizen artillery on the ramparts shot at anything and anybody outside the city. However, when the supreme command, in an attempt not to squander gunpowder and shot, forbade unnecessary shooting, the inhabitants saw this as an example of the generals' lack of fighting spirit, or perhaps even as a sign of treachery. A total of five sorties were made to clear the terrain around the capital of buildings and trees, which helped in some degree to restore good spirits. This applied in particular to the sortie of 31 August, which was supported by heavily armed gunboats that fired on the British from the coast. The 2200 men were led by the supreme commander of the fortress, General Peymann, who was seriously wounded during the incident. There was a widespread assumption at the time that the ageing general was deliberately seeking an honourable death on the battlefield in order to be relieved of the responsibility for a task that was doomed to failure.

The Bombardment

There was disagreement among the besiegers as to how to force the city to surrender. As in 1801, an attack from the sea was ruled out, as the Danish defensive works had been considerably strengthened to seaward. Recently built Danish gunboats and batteries defending the

island of Amager immediately to the south of Copenhagen also meant that to land and launch an attack from there was deemed too risky. General Cathcart was apprehensive about the consequences of a bombardment as the bombs could hit a girls' school. Arthur Wellesley was also said to be concerned about a bombardment. His alternative was more traditional but hardly more humane, namely a protracted siege to starve the city into submission. This would almost certainly have led to a far greater number of deaths from hunger or infectious diseases. During a year-long siege of Danzig in 1813, 17,000 people died of typhoid. However, the final decision to launch a bombardment has to be seen in the light of the pressure of time the leadership of the British army was under. Weather conditions meant that the Royal Navy could only remain in Danish waters for a limited period, and the arrival of winter was expected to enable the deployment of the Danish army from the duchies to Zealand, possibly accompanied by the French troops.

Bombs, grenades and incendiary rockets rained down on the city for three consecutive nights. The latter, the 'Congreve rockets', named for their inventor, William Congreve, who instructed the soldiers how to fire them, created the greatest consternation. Their screaming flight also contributed to their alarming effect. The rockets were new and unfamiliar and could, in Peymann's words, be considered as 'weapons that are not usually used by refined [i.e. civilised] nations'. Historian Arnold D. Harvey has calculated that this was one of the most intensive bombardments before 1914, and that three times as much gunpowder was used as at the Battle of Waterloo.³⁰

The bombardment began on 2 September 1807, at half-past eight in the evening. Those who experienced it at close quarters often found it difficult to describe their experiences and feelings with any precision. A Norwegian wrote to his family in Norway,

It is difficult to think of anything more frightful and terrible than this bombardment, and nobody who was not there can have any real idea of the horror of it. Imagine the air filled with rapidly moving [...] shooting stars [...] imagine them flying along with a piercing scream and crashing down into a house and smashing roofs, ceilings, beams and floors and several storeys to pieces with a shocking din and exploding with a fearful bang, then flames breaking out through windows, ceilings, doors etc. Etc. [*sic*], and this will give you a vague picture of the sight we have witnessed almost every second. To this must be added that with almost every bomb we saw people either killed or with injuries to arms and legs [...].³¹

The first night of the bombing seemed worse than the second as the Copenhageners had got over the initial shock of the fires and the bombs. But it was the third night that went down in history as the worst. With more than 3000 members drawn from among its citizens, Copenhagen had a fire brigade that was modern and well organised by contemporary standards and, to the great vexation of the British, was remarkably efficient in keeping the fires under control during the first two nights. But on the third night, the fire brigade had to succumb to the sustained pressure. The rain of bombs was concentrated in the area around the Church of Our Lady, where the more than 120-metre-high church spire made an excellent target for the enemy mortars.

Large numbers of the city's inhabitants began to flee from the inner city. According to the historian E.C. Werlauff, who experienced 1807 himself, about 30,000 citizens sought refuge on the islands of Christianshavn and Amager to the south where they felt they would be safe. This perfectly rational mass migration, which appears to have taken place without panic, made it easier for the fires to spread, as there were fewer people to fight them.

The third night of the bombardment broke the will of many Copenhageners to defend the city – including that of the generals in command. The spire of the Church of Our Lady collapsed to the raucous cheers of the British and created an inextinguishable conflagration. Petitions from the city's merchants and noblewomen and from many members of the city's corporation and the 32-man council (a council elected by citizens) arrived at the sickbed of the wounded General Peymann at Raus Hotel (today, paradoxically, Hotel d'Angleterre). All of the petitions argued for surrender. Subjected to this pressure, and after having consulted generals Gedde and Bielefeldt, Peymann asked the British for a truce.

The British, however, were only willing to agree to a truce on the condition that negotiations for the city's capitulation were begun. They also made it clear that they would not accept the destruction of the Danish fleet, which they had good reason to fear after having intercepted the crown prince's orders to Peymann. A council, comprising the city's leading military and civilian authorities, decided to begin negotiations for a capitulation on 6 September. Their hope was that the British would settle for the surrender of the fleet as a pledge of the kingdom's continued neutrality, but the rules of the game had changed. The British now demanded the fleet not only for the remainder of the war but as their permanent property. The Danes were shocked and furious but were unable to do anything. The only one among the leading men

who refused to sign the capitulation was the head of the naval defence, Steen Bille. He wanted a sortie against the British positions by all of the men in the city who were capable of bearing arms. Bille was fully aware that such a suicidal attack would only bring him and those who followed him 'an honourable death', but a sortie would make it possible to destroy the fleet in the meantime.

Bille's proposal did not find favour with the generals, and nor did citizens wish to sacrifice their lives on the altar of the fatherland for no conceivable purpose, so Copenhagen capitulated on 7 September. The mood changed later, and Bille now appeared as a true patriot while the rest of the advisory assembly were regarded as defeatists or traitors. This could be the real reason for Bille's proposal, as it enabled him to avoid being involved in the subsequent judicial purge.

When the surrender was made public in the city's squares, most people greeted it with relief and pleasure, and the occasional cheer and 'Long live the king!' made themselves heard. The demand to surrender the fleet, however, aroused widespread grief and anger, and it was considered necessary to have the cavalry patrol the streets to maintain order. This failed to deter the sailors and the carpenters from Holmen, whose livelihoods depended on the fleet. Armed with axes, they marched through the city to the military headquarters at the Raus Hotel where the 'traitor' General Peymann was staying. Fearing that the mob would storm the building, students from the King's Volunteer Corps were called in to break up the demonstration. This was a wise choice as the students – unlike the army – were highly respected by seamen, carpenters and citizens, and they succeeded in defusing the situation in a peaceful manner.

Death and Destruction

Calculated statistically, there were fewer burnt-out buildings after the bombardment of 1807 – a total of 305 houses – than after the two conflagrations that had ravaged the capital in 1728 and 1795. But several thousand houses in Copenhagen had been damaged to a greater or lesser extent. Naturally, there were many homeless people after the bombardment, and it has been calculated that about 7000 people were forced to leave their homes.³² The most impoverished of them often had to resort to desperate measures and make their homes in tents or covered passageways. Ruins and piles of bricks remained part of the street scene for many years. Rebuilding was slow as the economy had been left in tatters by the expenses of the war, the state bankruptcy

of 1813 and the crisis after the peace, and it took almost two decades to rebuild the city. The Church of Our Lady was only reconsecrated in 1829, while the main building of the university was unable to admit students until 1836.

Danish historiography has varied in its estimates of the number of deaths caused by the bombardment. In most accounts it has been set at 1600, while some have put it as high as 2000 to 3000. These figures, which can be found in English-language publications, can for the most part be traced back to a historical work from 1845. The problem with the information in this book is that it stems in all probability from a highly polemical, anti-British propaganda pamphlet from the autumn of 1807. It was not until 2007 that a Danish and a Norwegian historian scrutinised the figures. We now know with reasonable certainty that at least 186 civilians lost their lives during the bombardment, but missing registers and doubts about the causes of some deaths in the available records mean that the figure was probably slightly higher. The loss of 183 lives in the military during the siege and the bombardment must be added to the civilian losses. Where the number of wounded is concerned, the figure remains unknown, but according to the director-general of the Royal Surgical Academy, those maimed by grenades, bombs and collapsing buildings were chiefly women, children and the elderly. British casualties during the siege were 56 dead and 145 wounded.³³

Reactions in Denmark-Norway

The misery in the capital was not only due to the immediate destruction of property. Its formerly flourishing commercial life was also ruined. Many people sought consolation and an explanation for what had happened from the church. The message from the church was that this was the Lord's just castigation of his people. Danes had thought of nothing but 'worldly self-indulgence and worldly superfluity' and had neglected 'feelings of love towards God, of friendship to their fellows, of loyalty to and ardour for their homes and the country of their birth'. Want of faith, deceit and evil had been punished, and Danes could once again turn to God and serve their king and country with genuine Danishness.³⁴

The American sociologist Randall Collins has written of 'time-bubbles of nationalism',³⁵ when a terrible event triggers a period of massive national mobilisation, which then declines after three to six months. In some cases it is possible to maintain a sense of national solidarity, but its intensity does not last and attempts to maintain such mobilisation

often result in exhaustion. In the Danish-Norwegian state of 1807, this could be called a 'time-bubble of state patriotism'. The outbreak of war and the siege of Copenhagen created a feeling of anger and uncertainty in Norway, as nobody knew what had really happened in the capital, where many people had sons, daughters, brothers and friends. People's sympathies were unanimously for the 'gallant' Copenhageners. The British, on the other hand, were seen as robbers and firebrands by Norwegians. Like the Holsteiners, the Norwegians collected money to help victims of the fire and for the defence of the state.

According to a naval officer, the mood in Norway before the bombardment had been confident:

Nobody thought about the loss that a war with England would inflict on those whose only, or most important, trade was with that country. Everybody expressed indignation and the desire to fight this aggressor and, while they longed for news from Copenhagen, it was without any fear of such a course as that they would all too soon see the battle take. Everybody expected a repetition of the glory of 2 April [i.e. the Battle of Copenhagen 1801].³⁶

The news of the capital's fall and the loss of the fleet created a mood of grief, commiseration and anger in Norway, but the Norwegians also feared what the future might bring now that the state had been thrown into a war with their most important trading partner, which, with the help of the Royal Navy, could cut off Norway from the rest of the world. This fear only intensified as the war progressed. Developments in Norway appear to have followed Collin's 'time-bubble' theory. However, it was impossible to keep the Norwegians' anger towards the British on the boil for any length of time, and their solidarity with the Danes waned in step with their privations. The strong sense of state patriotism in the autumn of 1807 was increasingly replaced by a growing sense of national patriotism, which, for some people, began to approach true Norwegian nationalism, as we shall see in the following chapters.

There was a similar development in Holstein, but it did not go to the same extremes. Mobilisation was less widespread in 1807, but in reality separatist tendencies never made an appearance in either of the two duchies during the period up to the end of the Napoleonic Wars. Volunteer citizen and student corps had already been established, newspapers praised the government's policy of striving for peace, and the public gave its support to the collections in support of the people of Copenhagen. A mood of state patriotism prevailed in Holstein, but it was hardly as strong as in

Norway. There may be a number of reasons for this. Holstein had been annexed to the Danish state the year before, after the dissolution of the Holy Roman Empire, and the government was beginning to harmonise it with the rest of the state. These measures were a contributory factor in aggravating the antipathy that already existed in certain circles between Danes and Germans. There was also a distinct anti-French and pro-British attitude in large areas of the north German region.³⁷

Scapegoats

Inwardly, the population was hunting for scapegoats. Initially the military command, who had not only failed to do their duty but were considered cowardly and incompetent by the majority or were even accused of having colluded with the enemy, were in the line of fire. The surrender had barely been signed before such talk was spreading to every corner of the kingdoms. The population's view of the military was not improved by the wholesale desertions that took place during the period after the capitulation. It was first and foremost the enlisted marine corps, who were regarded by the population 'as a horde from foreign parts, especially Germany, a motley rabble', known for drunkenness, theft and brawling, who deserted en masse. All in all 89 per cent of the Marine Regiment changed sides after the surrender of the city. There were also desertions from other corps and regiments, although far fewer. Those who were caught attempting to desert were immediately brought before a court martial and either shot or hanged within a few hours. This was not solely a Danish problem, however, as many Britons also deserted.³⁸

The army was not the only organisation to be accused of shirking its responsibilities. The government and the crown prince were fully aware of the mood of indignation in the capital. After the capitulation, the crown prince had forbidden all communication between the besieged Zealand and other parts of the state, and all letters from Zealand were confiscated and sent to Kiel, where they underwent scrupulous examination by civil servants. This led a prominent civil servant to conclude that

The mood in Copenhagen is extremely unfavourable. People heap abuse on the government, on the crown prince and on the ministries. The great merchants are so English-minded that they wish nothing more than to be under English rule. The common man also likes English guineas and curses their bombs. The better half are in the minority and are obliged to hold their tongues, at least while the English are there.³⁹

The criticism was directed in particular at Foreign Minister Christian Bernstorff, Permanent Secretary Joachim Bernstorff and the rest of the diplomatic corps. The Bernstorff brothers were reproached for failing to react to the many warnings of a British attack.

The two brothers in the foreign ministry, however, were not the only ones to be criticised. A priest wrote in his diary that respect for the crown prince had declined and would be difficult to restore. Antipathy towards the crown prince arose because he had abandoned Copenhagen in its hour of need and, by stationing the Danish army in Holstein, had left the city defenceless against Britain. Due to the de facto censorship imposed by the state, there was scarcely a voice that dared to openly criticise the crown prince's dispositions.⁴⁰

After the separation of Denmark and Norway, the following statement could be found in a Norwegian newspaper:

In 1807 all patriotic pens were busy writing about the inappropriateness of the army sojourning in Holstein while the English cabinet were hatching their shameful plot to steal the Danish fleet, but nobody dared to express his thoughts about this in public for fear of a civil servant's indictment [...] and the Danish fleet was lost!⁴¹

One Copenhageners, however, dared to write an open letter to the crown prince asking for greater freedom of the press so that citizens could freely offer patriotic advice for the good of the country. Under other circumstances, a request of this kind would have been unthinkable, but the fact that it could be printed in one of the capital's most popular newspapers shows how much the royal house had been shaken by the Bombardment of Copenhagen.⁴²

Collections after the Bombardment of Copenhagen

Although the bombardment produced a mood of great anger and dissatisfaction, it did not undermine citizens' patriotism. News of the capital's fate led immediately to substantial collections of funds among private individuals throughout Denmark-Norway. This enabled the middle-class elites to affirm their patriotism to themselves and to their countrymen – without risking their lives. In itself, the phenomenon was neither new nor particularly Danish-Norwegian. Something similar had been seen to accompany the Christiansborg Palace fire in 1794 and the First Battle of Copenhagen in 1801, and similar collections had occurred in France to assist the building of an invasion fleet to cross the

English Channel during the years 1803–05 and in Germany during the ‘Wars of Liberation’ against Napoleon in 1813.⁴³

In principle, such donations can be divided into three categories. The first category was to support those whose houses and belongings had been burned. The second category was for the many people who had been injured and bereaved, while the third category was to assist the rebuilding of the lost fleet. After the capitulation several new commissions had been set up, but after 8 April 1808 they were all amalgamated in a common fund. The fund gradually came to benefit everybody who had been injured, wounded or taken prisoner during the war, and it was subsidised by the state, the commission for the wounded and fallen after the First Battle of Copenhagen in 1801 and by many private individuals. As early as November 1807, help had been given to more than 8000 people, especially the so-called more ‘socially useful groups of the population’. The most impoverished people were often referred to ordinary poor relief, which was a factor in overburdening what was already a hard-pressed system during the war.⁴⁴

There was a widespread spirit of self-sacrifice throughout the state, and both rich and poor played their part. Owners of estates and woodland all over Denmark donated huge quantities of oak for new ships; some citizens gave everything they owned. There was no shortage of inventiveness among the citizens, and the collections were not limited to subscriptions. Books, pamphlets, sermons, poems and memorial works were published, plays were put on, exhibitions were opened and ceremonies were held with profits going to one or more of the collections mentioned. Yet there were still those who did not feel that the nation’s collective patriotic contributions matched its collective wealth. An anonymous author, who had read through the many lists of donations in the newspapers, felt it was beneath the nation’s dignity that many wealthy people had given no more than what they might lose at gambling. If this did not change, the fiery patriot challenged the government to force wealthy men to pay part of the national debt. In its own way, the state did precisely this, by increasing taxes on an ongoing basis and introducing progressive income tax for the first time.⁴⁵

‘That damned thief the Englishman’

A storm of anger over Great Britain and its government spread throughout Denmark and Norway. A correspondent wrote in a Norwegian newspaper that although he would probably never experience the day when Saint Paul’s Cathedral and Portsmouth’s dockyards went up in

flames like 'our capital', the day would certainly come when the enemy, with 'Vengeance' written in blood on his forehead and back, would learn what it meant to do battle with the Danes and Norwegians whom the British had dared to mock. Danish reactions were similar to those of the Norwegians. A flood of pamphlets were published during the period after the Bombardment of Copenhagen, a recurring theme being that the preventive attack on Zealand had been an unprecedented breach of international law. This was a view that was, not surprisingly, shared by Britain's critics, from Tsar Alexander to US President Thomas Jefferson.⁴⁶

For Danes, the matter was made even graver by the fact that it involved two peoples and two royal families who were related by blood. Crown Prince Frederick was George III's nephew, while the British were descended from Angles, Vikings and Normans, so they were 'the sons of gallant Danes'. However, the contemporary view of Great Britain was complex and self-contradictory. Many writers attempted to make an explicit distinction between the British government and the people. The anger of the Danish nation should rather be directed towards the cabinet in Downing Street, even more so as the British opposition had vociferously criticised the attack on Copenhagen. A number of writers challenged the British and George III to dismiss a government that was an insult to the 'many outstanding, upright, honest men of all classes' in the English nation. The flattering words about the English in these pamphlets, a number of which were translated, even into English, were in glaring contrast to the judgement of the Ministry for Foreign Affairs, whose members were described as 'highwaymen' and firebrands and who were headed by the satanic foreign minister, George Canning.⁴⁷

In public at least, there was virtually no one who accepted the British claim that they had been forced to take the offensive after the Franco-Russian treaty in the summer of 1807. Most writers interpreted the attack on Zealand as a classic example of British imperialist and commercial policy. One of them accused the British of attempting to extend their 'bloody yoke' to the Baltic – just as they had previously subjugated India. Another felt that the mean British 'shop-keeping spirit' threatened to transform hell from an 'image to spread fear among the faint-hearted' into a reality on earth, while both a Norwegian and a Danish philosopher stated that British policy was a non sequitur given Great Britain's commercial national character.⁴⁸

Some Danes and Norwegians tried publicly to combat the tendency to direct anger towards the British as a whole, but in vain. One writer noted dryly that 'If patriotism comprises nothing more than heaping abuse on the English, there has never been a better occasion to be a

patriot than in our day.' A stereotypical view of the Englishman arose as the polar opposite of the Dane, and this image of the enemy was constantly supported with the help of selective references to specific English acts such as the Bombardment of Copenhagen, the seizure of the fleet, looting at Holmen and the blockade of Norway.⁴⁹

This overpitched response must be seen in the light of the fact that the Danish-Norwegian world picture had disintegrated. Denmark-Norway was no longer the home of peace but a state engaged in a fight for survival, so people did their utmost to mobilise each other in the struggle against foreign and domestic enemies. The British bombardment of the civilian population of Copenhagen was described as a 'war of destruction [...] against the unarmed, against the aged and women'. A British prisoner of war noted that the government's violently anti-British rhetoric was a major factor in influencing the Danish population. He had been captured after the frigate *HMS Crescent*, one of the Danish ships seized in 1807, was wrecked off the west coast of Jutland. The loss of the frigate and the capture of its British crew were naturally interpreted as God's punishment on the ungodly British. According to his own statement, the British prisoner was treated fairly well during his imprisonment and he had every opportunity to observe that the Danes believed the worst of the British nation, almost without reservation. The intense hatred of Great Britain abated during the course of the war as more and more people became aware of the extent to which their continuing war with the British and their alliance with the self-serving French Empire was eating away at the Danish-Norwegian state and threatening its very existence. Views such as these could be found among the business community in Copenhagen in particular and in famine-hit Norway.⁵⁰

Looting at Holmen and the Loss of the Fleet

British conduct at Holmen, Copenhagen's naval base, contributed to their image as a brutal and predatory people. The terms of the surrender entitled the British to seize not only the fleet but also whatever belonged to it. The British interpretation of the concept 'naval stores' was rather broader than the Danes had reckoned with. Under the leadership of British naval officer Home Popham, British confiscations at Holmen turned into outright looting. They took everything that could be used in any way or was of value. The doors, windows and locks of the buildings were broken open to enable the British to remove stoves, furniture, books and maps – and even pairs of office scissors. The Danes

protested vehemently but to no avail. The Citadel, which belonged to the army, was treated in a similar manner.⁵¹

Even more salt was rubbed in the wound when the British resorted to destroying anything they could not take with them, including three ships under construction. Attempts were also made to demolish ship-yards and docks. News of the British embarkation on 20 October spread like wildfire through Copenhagen. The immediate reaction was relief: 'Praise God! They have gone!' But gone, too, was the fleet that had been the pride of the two kingdoms for generations, their 'most splendid common property', the loss of which aroused indignation both north and south of the Skagerrak. However, the impressive British-Danish-Norwegian armada of more than 300 ships did not reach Great Britain unharmed. Violent autumn storms split up the fleet before it had left the Kattegat, and several of the British transports sank in the North Sea, drowning many hundreds. Not surprisingly, the Danes saw this as God's punishment, but it is quite likely that there would have been Danes and Norwegians among the many dead. The British had nowhere near sufficient crews to man the Danish-Norwegian fleet, so there had been a recruitment campaign to find seamen capable of sailing it to the British Isles.⁵²

Reactions in Great Britain

From a military point of view, the Bombardment of Copenhagen or, to use the more neutral terms used in British historiography, the Copenhagen Expedition or the Second Battle of Copenhagen, was a brilliant strategic success brought about by an unprovoked attack by a great power on a weaker, unprepared and neutral state. It was common knowledge, however, that George III had been opposed to the expedition, and at home in Great Britain it triggered a steady stream of criticism. The opposition accused the government of isolating Britain diplomatically by acting rashly and ruthlessly on the basis of unreliable rumours and, in so doing, of throwing a neutral, well-disposed state into the arms of Napoleon instead of helping and supporting Denmark-Norway. The result of the British government's actions had, in fact, made thousands of well-trained Danish and Norwegian seamen available to Napoleon and on the continent had created a public relations catastrophe of undreamt-of dimensions. This last point was emphasised by the Danish-Norwegian government doing everything in its power to inflame public opinion in Europe by publishing newspaper articles and pamphlets in German, French and English and by distributing a host

of prints illustrating the Bombardment of Copenhagen and the seizure of the fleet. In Britain, the opposition's attack was supported by radical and humanitarian critics in intellectual circles, who stated that the expedition had been an infringement of international law, while the bombardment of the city and the seizure of the Danish-Norwegian fleet would be a lasting stain on the honour of the British nation. It also gave rise to the contemporary expression, 'as shameful as Copenhagen'.⁵³

The Return of the Crown Prince

The crown prince returned to the capital on 6 November, and all who had led the defence of the city were placed under arrest (with the exception of Steen Bille). A legal review in the wake of the capitulation was to be expected. However, it soon became clear that the crown prince was hunting for scapegoats in order to pander to public opinion and divert criticism from himself, while demonstrating to Napoleon that the defeat had not been due to a general lack of political or military will and/or strength on the part of Denmark-Norway but must solely be ascribed to the faulty judgement of a few officers. A court martial sentenced generals Peymann and Bielefeldt to 'forfeit their honour and their lives' and to have their property confiscated, while General Gedde was graciously permitted to retain his honour, but was sentenced to death. Several of the other accused were given prison sentences. The view of contemporaries was that the proceedings and the sentences had no foundation in law, and Frederick VI came to his senses and pardoned the three generals once the case had served its political purpose, but they were not fully rehabilitated until 1815, that is, after the fall of Napoleon. The 'patriotic collaborators', Count Schulin, Frédéric de Coninck and Bonne Falch Rønne, were brought before a court of special jurisdiction and charged with high treason for having assumed the powers of the public authorities and for having been functioned by appointment to an enemy general. All three were acquitted, as their activities were considered to have protected the local population, but they were ordered to pay the costs of the proceedings and their reputations were tainted ever afterwards.⁵⁴

The Defence of the Fatherland and the Function of History

The British attack triggered a mental mobilisation in Denmark and Norway that found written and oral expression in newspapers, periodicals, pamphlets and sermons. According to contemporary views, the

‘sacred flame’ in the patriot’s breast would never burn brighter than when the fatherland was in danger, as was the case when the war with Great Britain broke out. For the true patriot, freedom and defence were indissolubly connected. Nothing was considered more noble than sacrificing one’s life on the altar of the fatherland. A professor expressed the spirit of the time when he wrote of the true patriot that ‘Life is of value to him as long as it is fruitful for the state. If the moment arrives when its salvation must be bought at the price of his death, he will face a thousand whining bullets with joy.’⁵⁵ In the wake of the outbreak of war this patriotic rhetoric was so overwhelming that a Norwegian lawyer was led to remark that it had loosened a screw in people’s heads. The outbreak of war had not only mobilised the nation’s soldiers, it had also mobilised its legendary heroes of the past. After the 1807 Bombardment of Copenhagen, civil society needed soldiers, as was illustrated by Major General Johann von Ewald’s work on war heroes through the ages. Ewald was among the first to write about what was known as the ‘little war’ or guerrilla war, which was based on the idea of a completely new type of motivated soldier who fought for a cause or for a fatherland. The major general’s work became a source of inspiration for Carl von Clausewitz, who frequently quoted Ewald.⁵⁶

Danish newspapers and literature in general were laden with references to Nordic gods, ancient kings and heroes, while privateers were named after legendary figures from the Viking age. Here as elsewhere the warriors of the past were not only an ideal but were depicted as almost symbiotically connected with contemporary heroes. Being a Danish soldier meant possessing a number of special qualities and an ‘inherited gallantry’ that had not been lost during the 80-year ‘sleep’ of peace. By no means everyone at the time, however, felt that the present lived up to the example set in the past. Nordic antiquity was regarded as a golden age characterised by virtues such as chivalry, generosity, moderation, self-sacrifice, stamina, loyalty – and, not least, patriotism. Moralistic writers believed that these qualities no longer existed. The nation did not have the strength of former times, but it could be reinvigorated. The belief was that war and adversity could ‘wake a nation from its slumber’, and show that the ‘Northman’s spirit had not been extinguished’. Those who refused to learn from the past or considered giving up the struggle were described by patriots as ‘degenerate children of brave forefathers’. The pattern in Norway was the same as in Denmark, where poets harked back to Nordic mythology and referred to Danes and Norwegians as the sons and daughters of Thor and Woden. They referred to forefathers in an abstract sense and to specific

historical figures, and they emphasised the deeds of the heroes who had either saved the fatherland or sacrificed their lives for it.⁵⁷

Others, such as Professor Laurits Engelstoft, did everything they could to teach young people to serve the nation, body and soul. He wrote his principal work, *Thoughts regarding National Upbringing as the Most Effective Means of Promoting Public-Spiritedness and Love of the Fatherland* (1808) during the Bombardment of Copenhagen. Like Fichte's speeches to the German nation, Engelstoft's work was a product of war, but, for all their similarities, his reasoning was, unlike Fichte's, still marked by eighteenth-century thinking and not least by the impressions that had left their mark on him during his stay in revolutionary France from 1798–99. The work was clearly influenced by French thinking about using school and national festivities as tools in a patriotic project. However, Engelstoft combined this thinking with a nationalistic cultivation of Danish language and history, which placed the book at the intersection between state patriotism, cultural nationalism and an unspoken political nationalism.

In general, as a closet liberal, Engelstoft wanted to use the education system to create free, equal and patriotic citizens and to form a unified national character by stimulating the minds of the young. At the intellectual level, this involved broadening their knowledge of the fatherland's geography, history and native language in order to give them a sense of a common national character. Geography should teach children that all of the benefits they associated with home should rather be associated with the fatherland as a whole. However, the most important factor for Engelstoft was language, since he claimed, along similar lines to Herder, that the spirit and culture of the entire nation was bound up with its language. The nation and its language stood and fell together, so a nation that lost its language would perish.

The idea of using education to create an *ostensible sense of community* can be found in other textbooks, and it characterises a shift in the concept of community from family to nation at this period. One of the elements in Engelstoft's model of *Bildung* was the physical element that would strengthen the nation's spirit, culture and character and, inspired by the civic virtues of antiquity and the idea of introducing general conscription, would make the citizen the defender of the fatherland. This can be seen as a parallel to 'Turnvater' Friedrich Ludwig Jahn's nationalistic gymnastics movement in Germany, but similar thinking in Denmark-Norway can be traced back to the military reforms of 1788. The idea of a national programme of *Bildung* did not triumph immediately in Denmark due to a lack of resources and a

government that espoused state patriotism but was wary of nationalism. Some elements of it could, however, be found in the Danish school reform of 1814, and teaching in schools gradually began to emphasise language, history, geography and attachment to the fatherland – first in Denmark and then in Norway.⁵⁸

History as a Battlefield

The past was also mobilised in more concrete terms. Danes and Norwegians used historical parallels and a selective reading of England's history to support the existing view of the nation. Used in this way, history appeared to confirm the image of England/Great Britain as a greedy empire, addicted to expansion and the economic exploitation of the rest of the world. Denmark-Norway, on the other hand, had learned from the past and had found its natural borders. At the same time, Denmark had defended free shipping and international law and justice since antiquity, while Great Britain had always made light of all maritime rules. Such selectivity in the use of history was underlined when other patriots suggested making incursions on the coast of Scotland and, as in the Viking age, demanding *Danegeld*. This means that Danes had an image of themselves, at one and the same time, as a peace-loving people and as bloodthirsty Vikings prepared to rape and pillage British civilians.⁵⁹

The contemporary academic elite were strongly influenced by their education in Latin schools, and their world of ideas was coloured by the history of antiquity. It was a matter of course for them to compare Great Britain with Carthage, the arch-enemy of Rome, a parallel frequently seen in contemporary French and German literature. From the Roman point of view, 'Punic faith', that is, bad faith, duplicity and unreliability, was a characteristic of the Punics, as they called the Carthaginians. This was due to the fact that they were a commercial nation and, broadly speaking, in all premodern civilisations merchants ranged far below the aristocracy, priests and farmers. So, with clear reference to the Punics, Great Britain was now called 'perfidious Albion', and learned Danes referred to Britain as the new Carthage, which would perish as a consequence of its own greed, just as its predecessor had done.⁶⁰

A Danish writer used this historical parallel in a more novel and creative manner when he wrote three articles based on Carthage. The parallel was: like peace-loving Carthage, Copenhagen had been destroyed by a cynical empire bent on military conquest. However, the defeat of Carthage meant that no historical account based on the Carthaginians'

premises has been handed down to posterity, which might be able to challenge the tendentious, but dominant, Roman version of events. The victors write history. The articles were intended to present the loser's view.⁶¹

Jesus, the Patriot

In Lutheran Denmark-Norway, the king was the head of the church, so there were close ties between state and church. This meant that priests were the primary disseminators of propaganda to the man in the street. The clergy performed this service with a zeal and spirit that showed that men of the cloth were often among the most bellicose citizens in the two kingdoms.

The war had barely broken out before Danish and Norwegian bishops were ordered to write prayers to be read out in the dioceses with the aim of promoting loyalty to king and country and to encourage patriotic acts and true love of the fatherland.⁶² Christianity's universal message of love was replaced by the fatherland's message of rightful war against an ungodly enemy whose wickedness would be obliterated by an all-powerful God. In the late summer of 1807, the Bishop of Funen explained to his parishioners that the piety of the Danish people meant that God would animate and inspire love of the country of their birth and loyalty to the king. In a similar manner, the old Bishop of Zealand demonstrated an almost maniacal energy that came to expression in his daily sermons on the ramparts of the besieged city and in proclamations to citizens.⁶³

Their contents could give comfort to the courageous defenders of the fatherland when they read that only 'the body and not the soul would fall' if they died in battle. Bishop Boisen's *Catechism of the Fatherland* (1811) also promised eternal salvation to those who sacrificed their lives on the altar of the fatherland. In his prayer, a thousand copies of which were distributed to soldiers, the Bishop of Trondheim actually wrote that 'the first hour of our bliss begins at the moment of death'. In this manner the clergy used Christianity to teach Danes and Norwegians about the value of 'the honourable death for the fatherland'.⁶⁴

Like its poets, the state's priests used the Danish and Norwegian heroes of the past as examples of self-sacrifice for the fatherland. The men of the cloth also increased the number of role models available to contemporary soldiers by adding the old biblical warriors. At Fanefjord Church on the island of Møen, local inhabitants were told in the New Year sermon what they could learn from Gideon, Barak, Samson,

Jephthah, David and Samuel, who all defended their posts in every battle with ready spirit and resolute courage. The most beautiful example of love of the fatherland and heroic courage, according to the priest, was Jesus himself. He had put his life at risk for his fellow man and for his fatherland so, as good Christians, Danes 'had a duty to risk their lives for our brothers', and the war was a better opportunity than ever before to walk in Jesus' footsteps, 'as his unhappy people's saviour and his fatherland's heroic friend'.⁶⁵

3

Scandinavian War, 1808–09

From Copenhagen to the River Kymme

The alliance of its arch enemy, Sweden, with Great Britain aroused the suspicion of the Danish-Norwegian government that the Swedes had in some way played a part in the attack on Copenhagen, or intended to exploit it to their own advantage. Therefore, almost as a knee-jerk reaction, it turned its attention towards Sweden and from the end of August kept close watch on the Swedish–Norwegian border, while every movement on the Swedish side of it was closely monitored. King Gustav IV Adolph's amicable reception of Cathcart and Gambier in Helsingborg when the British fleet left Zealand on 20 October – with the Danish-Norwegian fleet in tow – aroused vigilance and not least anger on the other side of the Sound.

There was arguably some justification for Danish-Norwegian suspicions, at least as long as Swedish participation in the occupation of Zealand had been under discussion. Gustav IV Adolph refused this, however. Few of his central political and military advisers had much faith in the British, not least since they had recently abandoned Sweden in Pomerania. The king himself was concerned that agreeing to the British offer would provoke Danish-Norwegian and Russian attacks. He was painfully aware that the Peace of Tilsit had left Sweden in a very precarious position and he had decided to keep a low profile for the time being. Gustav IV Adolph's policy in the autumn of 1807 was to maintain a neutral position without severing ties with Britain.¹

The Danish-Norwegian government suspected Gustav IV Adolph of nursing plans to exploit the seizure of the fleet and the alliance with Great Britain to wrest Norway from the Danes, all the more so as George Canning – in a bid to frighten Denmark-Norway into neutrality – let

it be understood that Sweden might occupy Zealand or take Norway. Canning's intimations led to a furious communication from the Danish-Norwegian government to Stockholm in December, followed by the mutual closing of vital mail routes. While this measure was mainly a source of irritation for Sweden, it was much more serious for the Danish-Norwegian government, which now found all communication between Denmark and Norway severed.²

For all the tensions in the autumn of 1807, neither of the two governments wanted a war in Scandinavia. The fact that a Scandinavian war would nevertheless become inevitable during the winter of 1807–08 was primarily due to a number of other circumstances. The Peace of Tilsit had in practice turned the Scandinavian countries into pawns in the game being played by the great powers. This became painfully obvious in Denmark-Norway after the Bombardment of Copenhagen had prompted the Danish-Norwegian government to enter into an alliance with Napoleon in Fontainebleau on 31 October.

The alliance originated in a personal appeal from Frederick to Napoleon shortly after the surrender of Copenhagen, written with the purpose of saving the Danish-Norwegian state from extinction. Without an ally and without defences it would be impossible for Denmark-Norway to resist the great powers. If the worst came to the worst Denmark-Norway could in fact find itself at war with them all. A British offer for an alliance was turned down by the furious king and would have been impossible for him to accept under any circumstances after what had passed. Thus, when Napoleon responded favourably to Frederick's almost desperate personal appeal by offering him an alliance, it was the best the king could hope for, even more so as Denmark-Norway was no longer a particularly attractive military ally, having little to offer Napoleon in terms of manpower and resources. By then the British had occupied the island of Heligoland off the Schleswig coast and following a formal declaration of war on 4 November the British proceeded to occupy the Danish-Norwegian colonies in the West Indies (Christmas day 1807) and the East Indies (12 February 1808). However, the British did not occupy the Danish-Norwegian possessions on the Gold Coast nor its North Atlantic dependencies. The exception was a brief occupation of Iceland in the wake of an attempt at a *coup d'état* by the Danish adventurer Jørgen Jürgensen in the company of a British merchant.³

The Fontainebleau alliance was not favourable to Denmark-Norway, but Crown Prince Frederick had no option but to agree to Napoleon's demands. While it is true that the treaty of alliance included promises of a French loan and of French help to recover the fleet from Great

Britain, it was first and foremost Napoleon who reaped the benefits of the treaty, as it had been carefully adapted to further the aims of the Continental Blockade. First, it enabled him to close a considerable gap in the Continental Blockade as the ports of Tønning and Husum in Schleswig would now be closed to the British. Second, the treaty of alliance contained a secret supplementary clause that obliged Denmark-Norway to assist France and Russia to force Sweden to break with Great Britain and join the Continental Blockade. To the anguish of the Danish-Norwegian government, this amounted to an obligation to go to war unless the Swedes bowed to the French and Russian demands.

Gustav IV Adolph, however, had no intention of doing anything of the sort. Joining the Continental Blockade would first and foremost be a financial catastrophe for Sweden and that weighed far more heavily in his assessment of the situation than any personal aversion to Napoleon he might have had at the time. When Russia declared war on Great Britain on 8 November – citing the Bombardment of Copenhagen as its moral justification – and then began to use sharper language with regard to Sweden, Gustav IV Adolph took the initiative to renew negotiations for a fresh alliance, the Swedish–British alliance of 1805 having expired the month before. Yet, for all his attempts to renew this alliance, Gustav IV Adolph still hoped that war with Russia could somehow be avoided altogether, and, if that were not possible, at least that its outbreak could be postponed until the spring when the British fleet would be at hand to aid Sweden. The king therefore chose to refrain from implementing any military measures on the Russian border in Finland in order to avoid provoking war, a decision later cited as evidence of Gustav IV Adolph's incompetence and utter failure to grasp the serious threat posed by the Russians after the Peace of Tilsit.⁴

As for Denmark-Norway, the Swedish government was blissfully unaware of the secret clause in the Fontainebleau alliance. Gustav IV Adolph was clearly aware that Denmark-Norway might pose a threat in the event of a war with Russia and France, but he was confident that the Danes and Norwegians could be held in check by British landings in Denmark or Norway. British military aid was therefore discussed by the Swedish and British governments as part of the negotiations for an alliance. Yet, despite the risks, Gustav IV Adolph refrained from implementing any extraordinary military measures in western and southern Sweden. As was the case with Finland, he had no desire to do anything that might provoke a military conflict on Sweden's borders.

Gustav IV Adolph's wish to avoid a Scandinavian war was shared in full by the Danish-Norwegian government. Even though relations with

Sweden were tense, the Danish-Norwegian government was desperately trying to avoid a conflict – even more so after signing the Fontainebleau Treaty. What the Danish-Norwegian government wished to avoid above all was assisting what would in effect be a Russian military conquest of Finland. A Russian conquest of Finland would render Denmark-Norway useless as Russia's future ally, as it would remove the threat from Sweden to the other side of the Baltic, and almost certainly further embolden Sweden to take steps to conquer Norway as compensation. Foreign Minister Christian Bernstorff viewed developments in the winter of 1807–08 as shaping a nightmare for the Danish-Norwegian state and saw Sweden's joining of the Continental Blockade as the only real release. In St Petersburg, the Danish-Norwegian ambassador, Otto von Blome, stayed in constant contact with his Swedish counterpart, Curt von Stedingk, to emphasise the potential gravity of the situation. Stedingk reported this to Stockholm, but yet he failed to convince Gustav IV Adolph that war with Russia was unavoidable, let alone that such a war was likely to be only a few weeks away. This convinced the Danish-Norwegian government that a Scandinavian war could hardly be avoided, especially given the Swedes' renewed negotiations for an alliance with Great Britain. Crown Prince Frederick consoled himself with the thought that, with the help of the French and Russians, a war with Sweden might allow him to regain some of the territories that had been lost in the seventeenth century. This, however, did absolutely nothing to allay the deep concerns felt by Bernstorff, who was powerless to do anything other than watch these events as they unfolded.⁵

In St Petersburg the Russian government quickly came to the conclusion that Sweden had no intention of joining the Continental Blockade, and in December the Russians began to plan and prepare for an attack on Finland. It was perfectly clear to the Russian military that an attack on Finland stood the best chance of success during the winter, so they agitated for rapid action and, at the same time, demanded a Danish-Norwegian attack on the western and southern regions of Sweden. Denmark-Norway was also encouraged to ask for French help in this. The outcome of the negotiations was an agreement to attack Sweden from the east, south and west; not only with Russian, Danish and Norwegian forces but with the addition of 35,000 Spanish, Dutch and French troops under the command of Marshal Jean Baptiste Bernadotte.⁶

The Russian army's crossing of the River Kymmene into Finland on 21 February was the signal that the time had come for the Danish-Norwegian government to declare war on Sweden. By the time the Danish-Norwegian declaration of war was announced in Stockholm on

14 March, Bernadotte's troops had arrived in Jutland, and an invasion of Scania across the Sound from Zealand was in the offing, while the Norwegian army had received orders to mobilise and undertake an invasion of western Sweden. The first major Scandinavian war in 90 years had now broken out, and a joint Danish-Norwegian-French-Russian invasion of Swedish territory on several fronts seemed imminent.

The Swedish Attack on Norway

During the winter months the British fleet kept clear of Danish and Norwegian waters to avoid the storms and freezing conditions. Therefore, the invasion of Sweden from Denmark and Norway had to be undertaken before the British ships returned to take control of these waters. Denmark-Norway, however, was far from prepared to invade Sweden when Russian troops entered Finland. The mobilisation order to the Norwegian army was not issued until 1 March, while Napoleon's orders to Bernadotte to leave north Germany for Denmark were not issued until two days later. By the time Danish-Norwegian military preparations were finally concluded, matters had become extremely urgent as the return of the British fleet was imminent.

The reaction in Sweden to the Russian attack on Finland was one of indignation and – perhaps rather paradoxically – of surprise, perhaps chiefly because it had been undertaken without a formal declaration of war. After the Russian invasion, the question for the Swedes was what Denmark-Norway would do. At the beginning of March Gustav IV Adolph had received reliable intelligence that Denmark-Norway seriously intended to attack Sweden, but this was only confirmed as late as on 7 March. On the previous day Gustav IV Adolph's general staff had issued their first orders for the defence of Scania and of the border with Norway. This had given Gustav IV Adolph and his advisers time to prepare before they were officially informed of the Danish-Norwegian declaration of war a week later.⁷

In the meantime Bernadotte's troops had reached Jutland and Funen in the expectation of being taken across the Great Belt to Zealand. The march from north Germany had been delayed due to logistical problems and, not least, because of a disagreement with Crown Prince Frederick as to who should have supreme command of the troops during the operations in Scania. Moreover, on 18 March Bernadotte received orders from Napoleon to redeploy his troops, which lost him more valuable time. By now, the first British ships had been sighted in Danish waters, and the crown prince, who was proclaimed King Frederick VI on 16 March

after this father's death two days before, had serious cause for concern. This only deepened when his only remaining ship of the line, *Prinds Christian Frederik*, was destroyed off Sjællands Odde on 22 March.⁸ The destruction of this ship and Bernadotte's delay marked the end of plans for an invasion of Scania. Towards the end of March Frederick thus had to acknowledge that there would be no invasion of Swedish territory.

On the evening of 14 March Gustav IV Adolph summoned his closest military and political advisers to a council of war at Stockholm Castle. According to his aide-de-camp, it was at this meeting that the king decided to attack Norway, a decision that would come to be regarded as sheer madness given the situation Sweden was in. Most Scandinavian historians have viewed the attack on Norway in 1808 as a spontaneous manifestation of Gustav IV Adolph's long-standing dream of conquering the country, which he had allegedly nurtured ever since he had ascended the throne in 1796. Viewed in this light, the decision to attack and conquer Norway in 1808 – while the Russian army was on the march through Finland – was irrational and proof that the king was not sane.⁹

Yet, this is a faulty and unjust evaluation of the Swedish king's decision. First, Gustav IV Adolph was certainly not so bent on conquering Norway as many historians would have it, and his decision to attack the country was not made in the face of stiff opposition from his collective body of advisers, although they claimed that it was after the king's fall. Second, few Swedish military officers thought it would be possible to defend Finland against a major Russian attack. General Gustav Mauritz Armfelt, for instance, urged that, in the event of a Russian attack, an attempt should be made to conquer Norway and Zealand to compensate for what would almost certainly be a loss of Finland. As if a testament to his influence on the king, Armfelt was put in command of most of the troops along Sweden's western border. Third, the decisive factor in Gustav IV Adolph's decision to attack Norway was in fact the prospect of British help. Assistance from the British made a war of aggression against Norway far from the kind of madcap venture it has often been portrayed as, even more so since it would prevent Norwegian troops from taking the war into Swedish territory. The latter was in fact a crucial concern to Gustav IV Adolph, who knew that the Danish-Norwegian government aimed to bring the war to Swedish soil. Moreover, during negotiations in previous months the British government had hinted that help in the form of expeditions against Zealand and Norway might be a possibility in the event of a Scandinavian conflict. Gustav IV Adolph therefore had more reason to expect help from the British than it might seem in retrospect.¹⁰

Mobilisation in Norway was so slow, and the supply shortages in the army were so great that it could well be argued that the Norwegians would not have been capable of invading Sweden even if Bernadotte and Frederick had crossed over to Scania. Supplying the Norwegian army for any length of time, one general concluded, was a 'physical impossibility'. Norway depended entirely on imports and the real problem was that, as supplies were consumed, the British blockade prevented their replenishment. The blockade also prevented supplies of military equipment from reaching Norway, because the Danish-Norwegian war industry was located chiefly on Zealand. Nor would living off the land in sparsely populated western Sweden where there was little food have been an alternative. When in early April the news arrived in Norway that there would be no invasion of Scania, reactions of regret were tinged with a measure of relief, perhaps even more so as most still thought it improbable that the Swedes would dare to make an attack as long as the Russian army was advancing in Finland. This view would soon change, however.¹¹

The Swedish–Norwegian Border War

In practice, the war with Great Britain had all but cut off communications between Denmark and Norway, and Norway had been isolated. Immediately after the British attack, therefore, Crown Prince Frederick decided to establish a body in Norway to enforce the government's power. The Government Commission, as this body was known, met for the first time on 2 September 1807 and was chaired by Prince Christian August of Augustenburg, who had been the general in command of southern Norway since 1804. This meant that, in practice, his position at the head of the Government Commission made him the supreme military and political leader of Norway. Christian August was sceptical of joining forces with Russia and, not least, of invading Sweden. He was also fully aware of the critical position Norway had landed in as a consequence of the war with Britain. The most important task of the Government Commission was thus to obtain enough corn for Norway before the British blockade was able to come fully into force once the winter was over.

The situation that arose when the British fleet returned at the end of March 1808 only served to further aggravate the Norwegian position. Now Norway not only found itself isolated and under blockade, but also under direct military threat from the sea and the land by both Great Britain and Sweden. At the same time, there were limits to

how long Norwegian food supplies would last. Harvests were for the most part meagre in 1807, and a number of organisational and practical problems had severely limited the much-needed corn supplies from Jutland during the winter. In addition, it soon became clear what the Swedes were up to. Having been informed by Frederick VI on 7 April that the planned invasion of Scania had been definitively cancelled, Prince Christian August was extremely concerned at the possibility that Gustav IV Adolph might be able to keep the Russians in check with the help of British naval power, which would allow him to deploy considerable forces against Norway. To top it all, Sweden might also receive help from British troops, in which case Norway would effectively be at the mercy of Sweden and Britain.¹²

In the Swedish camp, General Armfelt had been busy preparing the campaign against Norway since 14 March. But his preparations were beset by considerable challenges relating to supplies, logistics and communications between the various Swedish military divisions. In the end, these factors all combined to make it impossible either to carry out the invasion of Norway on the date or in the manner that Armfelt had planned, or to abide by his original intention of conquering the country by military means. When Armfelt finally advanced into Norway between 14 and 17 April, it was only with about 8000 of the total of about 15,000 men in what was known as the 'Western Army'. Moreover, a few days previously, the goal for the invasion, by agreement with the king, had been scaled down from conquest by military means to reconnoitring the Norwegian border areas until the remainder of the Western Army could catch up and the anticipated help from Britain could arrive. In other words, unlike some historians have asserted, the Swedish aim was not 'a rapid conquest of Norway'.¹³

Armfelt advanced into Norway on a broad front in the hope that this would confuse the Norwegians. The disadvantage of this strategy was that he also divided his own army, something that became a catastrophe for the Swedes when Christian August realised what Armfelt was up to. This resulted in a handful of relatively small-scale Norwegian military triumphs close to the border, some of which later gained mythical status in Norwegian national history. Matters were not improved for Armfelt when the remaining 6000 troops of his Western Army crossed southern areas of the Norwegian border at the end of April without his even being aware of it and were halted. At that, the Swedish military offensive came to a complete standstill.¹⁴

Armfelt therefore clung to the hope of British help. 'If the English will help us in accordance with my plan, the conquest of Norway will not

take long', he promised the king. Although the government in London had been deeply averse to helping Sweden with anything but cash subsidies, at the end of April the Swedish government succeeded in negotiating the support of a British corps of about 12,000 men who would be shipped to Sweden from Great Britain. But no agreement was reached as to precisely how these troops were to be deployed, which left this open to interpretation. Probably due to discussions during the negotiations in London about using them either against Denmark or Norway, the Swedes were of the opinion that this was the purpose of sending the troops to Sweden.¹⁵

The British contingent would have none of it, however. First, there could be no question of placing the auxiliaries under Swedish command and, second, Great Britain had, to put it mildly, little interest in risking its troops in offensive operations against Denmark or Norway. After a farcical quarrel between Gustav IV Adolph and the commander of the British corps, General John Moore, the British simply sailed away from Gothenburg on 3 July without even having set foot on Swedish soil.¹⁶ By now the last Swedish troops had been pulled out of Norwegian territory, after Armfelt had misinterpreted the king's order to take up a defensive position in Norwegian territory as an order to withdraw completely. In practice, the brief border war of the spring of 1808 was over, even though a state of war between Denmark-Norway and Sweden still existed and would do so for another year and a half.

Danish-Norwegian Reactions to the War with Sweden

The British bombardment and the seizure of the fleet had outraged public opinion both in Denmark and Norway and led to a resurgence of patriotism in both countries. But very few understood why it should be necessary for Denmark-Norway to go to war with Sweden, unfamiliar as they were with the secret provisions in the Fontainebleau treaty. It was, therefore, vital for the government in Copenhagen to prepare the public for the forthcoming war and justify it. With this in mind, it was decided in January 1808 to leak and publish diplomatic correspondence in Copenhagen that ostensibly proved the Swedes' evil intentions with regard to Denmark-Norway.¹⁷

In Norway, Prince Christian August was hoping that Gustav IV Adolph could be provoked into being the first to declare war, so that it could be clearly represented to Norwegians as a defensive war. There were several reasons why Christian August was particularly keen on this. First, an apparently unprovoked Danish-Norwegian declaration of war on

Sweden, at a time when Norway's position was already precarious, would place Frederick and his government in Copenhagen in a very unfavourable light. Furthermore, Christian August knew that Norwegians traditionally nursed a strong antipathy to wars of aggression. In the seventeenth century peasants conscripted into the Norwegian army had even flatly refused to cross the border into Sweden. Moreover, it was a mere 20 years since the extremely unpopular invasion of the Swedish province of Båhuslen, referred to by some people – alarmingly for the government in Copenhagen – as the war of the Danes. This made it important for Prince Christian August to present the war as a defensive action, particularly if there was to be a Norwegian invasion of western Sweden in collaboration with the Franco-Danish troops from Zealand.¹⁸

Not surprisingly, it came as a blow to Christian August and the Government Commission that Crown Prince Frederick was forced to be the first to declare war. Gustav IV Adolph had no intention whatsoever of making war on Denmark-Norway, but he knew very well how to use the Danish-Norwegian declaration of war as propaganda. A proclamation distributed in the Norwegian borderlands emphatically stressed that the 'Danish government has declared war on Sweden without reason'.¹⁹ This forced the Norwegian authorities to begin immediate damage control, followed by press statements and frantic attempts to prevent Frederick's declaration of war from being distributed in Norway. As the Government Commission wrote to the king, it would be 'more favourable if the common people could be convinced that the Swedish invasion of Norway was solely a situation of their own making and prompted by the direct order of the Swedish government'. It was too late, however, and it did not take long before the majority were aware how matters really stood. One observer later wrote in his memoirs that there had probably never been any event in Norway during the years from 1807–14 that had aroused more 'fear and discontent than this inopportune and ill-considered declaration of war'.²⁰

Yet, at least to begin with, the government and the authorities were in a sense saved by the Swedish invasion, which made the war appear to the Norwegians as being one of Swedish aggression, aims of conquest and amalgamation. There can be no doubt that the defensive war during the period from April to June led to a considerable upsurge of national patriotism in a large segment of the Norwegian population, but without this undermining loyalty to the state and to the government in Copenhagen. Indeed, when the Swedish army withdrew from Norwegian territory in June, it was not declared as a victory for Norway, but a 'victory for Dania'. Many Norwegians, however, still saw this as a

purely Norwegian victory and as proof that Norway could stand on its own two feet.²¹

The establishment of Norwegian news media after the outbreak of war in 1807 broke Copenhagen's monopoly on providing Norway with news. What was more, the war years marked a major difference in the conditions for freedom of expression in Denmark and Norway. Public debate was sharply curtailed by various government measures. Postal censorship was introduced from 1807, fettering public opinion, particularly in Denmark. A lawyer stated in 1808 that he never wrote anything that was contrary to his convictions, but that he kept quiet when his opinions conflicted with those of the government. A Norwegian priest, although not one to be cowed, remarked that he was divided between love of the fatherland, which required him to speak 'the truth', and his family, which was dependent on his remaining in office. Still, while the public in Copenhagen was bound hand and foot, control in Norway was relaxed, so there could be more open opposition in a political and national sense.²²

At the same time, the Government Commission in Norway exercised strict control over what was printed because it 'hoped to provide the inhabitants of Norway with the information that could be made available and which it believed would serve to calm and encourage ordinary people'. To this end one of the Government Commission's key members, Enevold de Falsen, established a newspaper called *Budstikken* (*The Baton*), which very much became the commission's mouthpiece. *Budstikken* was exploited to whip up the national patriotic mood in Norway during the spring and summer of 1808 and was a mixed bag of war reports, war poetry and patriotic proclamations that had a powerful influence on its readers. Patriotic song lyrics, penned by de Falsen and printed in the newspaper, were particularly popular and were seemingly on everybody's lips, much to the dismay of Swedish officers who lamented that the songs and other propaganda had an immense effect even on the populace.²³

But patriotism in Norway also had its limits. When the war continued even after the Swedish withdrawal in June, the mood cooled considerably. Some civil servants reported that the opinion of Norwegians peasants was that they had nothing against the Swedes and saw the war as meaningless and as primarily the work of the government in Copenhagen. This opinion could also be found in higher social spheres. In October 1808 the merchant prince Peder Anker wrote, 'I say it yet again – this war is not ours.' Sentiments such as these constituted a clear danger to the cohesion of the Danish-Norwegian state, albeit chiefly

in the longer term. During the spring of 1808 the war had appeared to strengthen Danish-Norwegian ties in the face of common foes, but these ties were becoming frayed.²⁴

Denmark was not as vulnerable in the war with Sweden as was Norway. This meant not only that the main burden of the war gradually came to rest on Norwegian shoulders, but also that Frederick's declaration of war was not as potentially explosive in the eyes of Danes as it was to the Norwegians. The Norwegian defensive war, however, aroused great enthusiasm and support among Danes, who sang cheerfully about how the 'Swedes were decisively defeated by the brave Norwegians'. Military reports printed in *Budstikken* were read with the greatest interest south of the Skagerrak and the inhabitants of Copenhagen took the initiative to organise collections for 'their stalwart Norwegian brothers'. By the summer a considerable amount of cash had been collected. In one respect this helped to bring Norway and Denmark closer together in the wake of the outbreak of war, but the mood of harmony would not last long and the Swedes did everything they could to undermine it.²⁵

Wooing and Winning the Norwegians

When General Armfelt realised he would not be able to conquer the country by military means, he pulled out another card, which the Swedes had previously played in the years 1801–03. In a word, this involved wooing and winning Norwegian hearts and minds by emphasising all the advantages Norwegians would gain from uniting with Sweden, and in this way encouraging them to voluntarily support such a union.²⁶ This strategy was based on three underlying perceptions on the part of the Swedes: first, that Norwegian dissatisfaction with Danish rule was already relatively widespread and could be used to advantage by Sweden; second, that many Norwegians felt that a union with Sweden would be in their own interests; and third, that Norwegians and Swedes were really one and the same people and, as such, so closely related that it would be no great problem to incorporate and integrate Norway into Sweden – which the incorporation of provinces conquered in the seventeenth century seemed to confirm.

Armfelt's goal – rather paradoxically perhaps – was to use the war and the occupation to create a pro-Swedish mood among Norwegians and turn them against the Danish government by showing them how a union with Sweden could benefit them in practice. His basic idea was not as inept nor his strategy as far-fetched as it might appear at first glance. The British blockade had already cut off corn supplies to Norway,

and this was bound to leave the country's economy in tatters, since it put a stranglehold on Norwegian exports. Furthermore, a war would in itself be a tremendous burden because it would involve the mobilisation of a large number of military personnel along the coast and in the areas bordering on Sweden. This in turn would make great demands on supplies and manpower and would further aggravate Norway's situation by making major inroads into their supplies and taking men away from agricultural work. As matters stood in the spring of 1808, the Swedish government could offer peace, corn and trade. However, the price the Norwegians would have to pay was to turn their backs on Denmark and voluntarily unite with Sweden. In the light of the critical situation the Norwegians were in, it was not unreasonable to expect that this was exactly what they would be inclined to do once Swedish troops appeared on the Norwegian side of the border.

Reports from Swedish spies in Norway written in February and March 1808 painted a picture of widespread shortages of food and other supplies as well as dissatisfaction that Denmark-Norway had been drawn into the Napoleonic Wars. The Norwegian army, so one of the spies reported, could only be fully mobilised for a very limited period before lack of supplies would force it to be disbanded and lead to a breakdown of morale. This was not an unrealistic assertion even though, during the course of 1808, it turned out that – to the great surprise of the Swedish and Norwegian army commanders – military stores in Norway were never completely exhausted.²⁷

A report from another spy at the end of March, signed by Armfelt's own aide-de-camp, became a kind of blueprint for the strategy the Swedes came to pursue in Norway in the spring of 1808. The report emphasised that the Norwegians in general were preparing for war with Sweden, but in Christiania, 'where trade interests always trump patriotism, they are no strangers to the idea of uniting with Sweden to revive trade relations and food imports'. In the eyes of the aide-de-camp, this was an opportunity not to be missed and he therefore suggested issuing a proclamation that 'promised that they could retain their own laws, property and trade relations' in order to 'separate Norwegian interests from Danish interests' – but, he warned, 'without duping them, because they have the greatest misgivings about the administrative talents of our government'. Armfelt eagerly endorsed this suggestion to print and issue a proclamation and passed it on to Gustav IV Adolph, who promptly repeated the promises – except for the retention of Norway's own laws – in a proclamation he issued for the troops to distribute in Norway.²⁸

In addition to the general goal of wooing and winning hearts and minds, Armfelt's strategy with regard to the Norwegians had two related basic goals. The first was to ensure he had as many collaborators as possible, the second to reduce Norwegian opposition to a minimum. The first goal required a certain degree of manipulation and involved giving the Norwegians sufficient incentives to ensure they would support a union with Sweden and cooperate in bringing it about, while the second goal required giving the Norwegians as few reasons to oppose the Swedish army as possible. In the proclamation and in the Swedish army's propaganda much emphasis was placed on peace, trade and food, while they also contained promises that Swedish soldiers would behave in an exemplary manner. This last point was further stressed by Armfelt's strict and repeated orders that the troops must treat the inhabitants well and not molest them in any way. Such promises should not be shrugged off as 'the timeless rhetoric of invading armies', as Armfelt was at pains to ensure that the promises were kept and ruthlessly punished anyone who acted contrary to them.²⁹

Armfelt had high hopes that the Norwegians could be convinced that their interests lay in a union with Sweden. After winning an important battle against the Norwegians near Kongsvinger on 18 April, and in doing so having secured control over a crucial area of the front stretching up to the Glomma, Norway's longest river, he wrote to the king, 'the people are now beginning to get used to us and gradually, with the help of kindness and a little generosity, I think they will appreciate what they have gained through the change'. Shortly afterwards, he opened the border between Sweden and the occupied areas for trade, so that the Norwegians could be given a taste of what they could expect if a union were to become a reality. Gustav IV Adolph attempted to make the bait even more enticing by arranging a free-trade agreement between Sweden and the other areas of Norway that had not been occupied, but this was flatly refused by the Norwegian authorities. Still, the Swedes met with no success in ingratiating themselves with the Norwegians.³⁰

Popular Resistance in Norway

One of the highpoints of Norwegian national historiography, the war of 1808 has been represented as a nationally motivated defensive war that united the entire population in the struggle against the Swedish arch-enemy. As such traditional historiography bears some semblance to that of Prussia's war of liberation in 1813. Officers, soldiers and civilians have been depicted as national heroes, whose memory has been

preserved in memorials, celebrations and myths. While the number of historians who believe in the more antiquated interpretations of the war of 1808 has dwindled, the view that it united the elite and the people in a national patriotic struggle is still relatively common among Norwegian historians and the public.³¹

There can be no doubt that there at least initially was a strong desire at all levels of Norwegian society to put up a solid defence against the Swedes. As was the case in Denmark in 1807, citizens and townspeople – who were exempt from regular military service – established several volunteer corps, made up chiefly of artisans, clerks and workers. Many of them marched to the front to the sound of drums beating, imbued with patriotic sentiments. ‘Nobody must shirk the duty he owes his fatherland, the king and you’, were the words written to Prince Christian August by one. While it is true that the majority of these untrained volunteers had often had their fill of campaigning after only a few weeks, their first reactions nevertheless bear witness to a genuine desire to march to the border to risk their lives for the fatherland. Still, some of them hardly saw reason to protect places that were not their own cities.³²

Among the peasantry motives were very complex. Some of the peasant lads who had been conscripted into the regular army were obliged to march far away from their native villages and lost any sense that their main purpose was to defend their homes. A number of the Norwegian soldiers who had gone to the Swedish border in southeastern Norway wrote proudly home that they had marched on the enemy to ‘defend the fatherland and we did this as brave soldiers’, ‘fought in God’s name for the King and the country’s best’ and ‘protected the fatherland’. Another soldier wrote with equal pride that ‘it was read out to us at the fortress that our King is well-pleased with what the Norwegian has done in struggling to defend his country’. In this way, the defensive war was explicitly connected with God, king, fatherland and a sense of being Norwegian. It could be objected that these were words that had been read out to the soldiers by their officers and had merely been paraphrased, but they were still meaningful enough for the soldiers to put them in context, write home about them and indeed to expect that what they wrote would resonate among recipients.³³

But what did this fatherland mean to the soldiers? Their letters plainly give the impression that they perceived Norway as a territorial entity, and there can be no doubt that they were fully aware that this territorial entity was part of the composite Danish state. They also knew that they were Norwegians by virtue of the fact that they were the king’s subjects, born and resident in his Norwegian territory. Yet they never

wrote of 'we Norwegians' but rather referred to 'the Norwegian' in the third person and, moreover, usually made clear distinctions between soldiers and civilians. This might suggest that they had some difficulty in perceiving themselves as part of a national social group based on mutual solidarity and a sense of community. While too much should obviously not be read into the relatively few letters containing such expressions, the ways in which Norwegian soldiers in 1808 referred to and used terms such as 'Norway' and 'Norwegian' bear a strong resemblance to the way in which Danish soldiers related to 'Denmark' and 'Danish' during the war of 1848–51. This has been studied in some detail by the Danish historian Søren Frost, who concludes that while the soldiers did have some sense of Denmark as their territorial fatherland, albeit not unambiguously so, they had much greater difficulty in conceiving of themselves as members of a national community.³⁴

Many Norwegian conscript soldiers also developed something of a military identity, which was related to the army as a whole and to the regiments they served in. Triumphs on the field of battle and heroic feats became associated with their identity as soldiers and with their regiments. Their sense of military identification was revealed by phrases such as 'we Bergenhusers', 'we the 4th Grenadier Division', and 'our 3rd division' – all in reference to military units. This was perhaps not so very different to the 'regimental worlds' of British soldiers, which, as John Cookson has argued – in opposition to Linda Colley – carried more weight than did British identities during the Napoleonic Wars. Yet, even here solidarity had its limits. When the troops from Bergenhus in western Norway arrived at the border in August 1808, one of their officers reported that they were given a chilly reception by the soldiers from the eastern part of southern Norway, against whom they had to be on their guard 'as though we had Swedes among us', and that many of them 'would just as much have liked to see us in Swedish captivity as Swedes in Norwegian [captivity]'.³⁵

Ultimately, the soldiers turned to God to find meaning, comfort and hope, especially as the war dragged on while conditions along the border deteriorated and death rates soared. The soldiers neither believed in nor were indoctrinated to believe in a cult of death for the fatherland, unlike the middle classes and their officers. The extent of any such a cult was limited even among officers trying to cope with the horrors of war. While it is true that a few fallen officers were buried during the summer of 1808 with a ceremonious display that powerfully symbolised their ultimate sacrifice on the altar of the fatherland, most others were buried without any ceremony at all. Any impression the ordinary rank and file

may have received of the patriotic ideals of the elite was not clear, then, still less particularly forceful, especially as dead soldiers were unceremoniously buried where they fell. There was not even any observance of religious rituals when soldiers were interred, much to the disgust and fury of the Bishop of Christiania. In other words, there was little in practice to give soldiers the impression that, by adopting the patriotic ideal of sacrificing their lives on the altar of the fatherland, they would be honoured in the name of the fatherland after their deaths. It was rather the case that the soldiers' letters and notes expressed both the absolute horror of what they witnessed and their increasing disillusionment with the war in general. One disillusioned soldier wrote that he had 'seen all this misery several times; to see a human being in a state like this is a terrible sight. Many of the wounded are dead, many will probably recover but will remain crippled as long as they live.' Another was even more desperate to find relief from his nightmare and simply concluded, 'God help us to get away from this place'.³⁶

In other words, there was a marked difference in the perceptions of ordinary people and of the educated burgher elites as regards the cult of death for the fatherland and the ideal of personal sacrifice for king and country. Those publicising the war, in particular the clergy, did what they could to instil in the masses a patriotic notion of death for the fatherland as being honourable and even desirable, but their efforts hardly had any practical effect on the battlefield. Instead military officers seem to have adopted a pragmatic stance to casualties of the war, and there is no evidence that military chaplains – of whom there were few anyway – did much to promulgate patriotic sermons and texts at the front.

In addition to approximately 30,000 regular conscripts, somewhere between 15,000 and 20,000 men were enrolled in various types of militia in the Norwegian border areas in the years 1808 and 1809. The biggest of these were the peasant militias. They resembled the militias in border areas elsewhere in Europe, in which peasants often had a relatively free rein to organise border defences as they wished, largely in the form of highly localised militias.³⁷ In Norway the organisation of these militias was usually left to bailiffs, who in turn generally allowed the peasants to choose their own leaders, which gave them an air of democracy, not unlike the French revolutionary armies. The authorities in Norway and the leaders themselves, however, soon discovered that this system was hardly the most reliable way of ensuring discipline among militiamen, so these leaders were usually replaced by retired officers.

The militiamen's war was a completely different one from that waged by the regular soldiers. As the peasant militias were based on the administrative

units of bailiwicks and parishes, they were local and regional in structure. The peasant militiamen were obliged to fend for themselves where supplies were concerned, and this meant that they were unable to travel far from their homes. Thus the militias remained chiefly local.

Peasants were usually willing enough when it came to defending their own homes and families against looting expeditions or against brigands and bandits, but they made it quite clear to the authorities that under no circumstances did they wish to fight regular Swedish troops. Probably for this reason, efforts to recruit men from the militias into the regular army were widely resisted. This does not mean that the idea of fighting for their fatherland itself was foreign to them, but very few had any intention of risking life and limb in fighting experienced soldiers, even to defend their own homes.³⁸

The fear of looting by small raiding parties, robbers and bandits, however, was well founded among the peasantry in those parts of Norway near the Swedish border during the spring and summer of 1808. A peasant who lived close to the border wrote that he dared not sleep at night for fear that he would be molested and robbed, while a local officer of the peace cried out, 'God let us not be assaulted by the dreadful and terrible Swedes and brigands, which is to say: there is fear of an assault everywhere here.'³⁹ Popular perceptions of traumatic events involving Swedish soldiers related to the brutality and depredations of the seventeenth and early eighteenth centuries. This was not surprising, because Norway had not been invaded by foreign troops since 1718, and the folklore dealing with wars was therefore virtually the only point of reference, and guidance, the peasants had to war.

There were many contemporary civil servants and military officers who were fully aware that the peasants were motivated much less by the threat to the fatherland and the nation than by the fear of being assaulted and plundered. Yet, this fear was convenient for the authorities' wish to protect the fatherland in that it could be exploited to mobilise as many people as possible for the war effort. The general in command of Trondheim, Georg Frederick von Krogh, had a blustering article published in the press – well aware that its message would reach all layers of society – in which he encouraged people to take part in a guerrilla war and to conduct a scorched-earth policy to deprive the enemy of the 'means to destroy you – to kill you and your families'. By describing the Swedes as 'plundering hordes', 'barbarians', 'robbers' and 'rogues' the authorities succeeded on many occasions in getting the peasants to take up arms and patrol their local areas.⁴⁰

This tactic could also backfire, however, by scaring the peasants out of their wits. When the Swedish army crossed the border in the middle of April, they found that several villages and farms were completely deserted after what, in some cases, had been mass flights before the arrival of its advance guard. General Armfelt was dismayed by the mass evacuation of the border areas and by the way 'we are portrayed in all publications, war songs etc. as nothing but grim Swedes who are ready to treat the Norwegian people in the most barbaric way'. This, he concluded, had instilled 'a senseless fear' into the Norwegians, Armfelt concluded, and 'surely only time can eradicate such deep-rooted impressions'. One of his brigade commanders was less pessimistic, however, and noted that 'all of the peasants have fled from their farms, at least for the time being, but will soon return once they learn how they will be treated in accordance with the orders of the Commanding General'.⁴¹

This particular officer was right, because it took the majority of the peasants little time to find out that the Swedes were not the monsters they had been depicted as. Most of them therefore went back to their homes. This also meant that it became increasingly difficult to get the peasants to join the militias, as they no longer felt that the threat to them and their nearest and dearest was so acute. As the conflict developed into a kind of 'phony war' in the late summer and autumn of 1808 after the Swedes had retreated across the border, there were rumblings of rebellion in some places during peasant militia exercises, because the peasants could no longer understand why weapons training should still be necessary.

The reasons why there was never really a question of irregular resistance to any significant extent, if at all, in Norway – unlike the resistance to the French in the Italian peninsula, in Switzerland and in Spain – are complex, but in general it could be said that it was because the Norwegians never had any reason to offer such desperate resistance. No attempt should be made to paint the Swedish occupation in rosy colours, but it was relatively mild and far from as hard on the population as it could have been. Requisitions were minimal, looting and assaults were rare, and the Swedish troops generally behaved very well. Even when they could have acted ruthlessly, they refrained from doing so. When armed peasants were arrested by Swedish troops, they were released after being given a warning instead of being executed as martial law permitted. This in turn helped to prevent violence from escalating through acts of retaliation, as it had done during the brutal guerrilla wars in Spain, Calabria and Vendée, for example.⁴²

As long as the peasants in Norway, just as in most other European countries, were primarily interested in protecting their own families, homes and provinces, their attitude could be categorised as one of localism and regionalism. We have to be cautious, however, of allowing this to provide a basis for concluding that every conception of fatherland, state patriotism and national patriotism was completely alien to the populace as a whole, as many historians have tended to do. Localism and regionalism were not ideologies that necessarily excluded other identities and loyalties. As one Norwegian historian has written, all adults in their right mind knew that they lived in Norway and that, as such, they were Norwegians. Norwegian soldiers – similarly to Finnish peasants, for instance – also demonstrated a remarkable ability to debate the international situation and international politics, which reveals that they were keenly aware of the world beyond their own backyard, not to mention beyond their own national borders. Yet, this awareness did not mean that patriotism, still less nationalism, were primary factors in motivating popular reactions and resistance. Awareness did not necessarily translate into activism.⁴³

The motives and actions of the peasants and the elites could appear to fall into line as long as the goal was to defend the country against what was seen as a common enemy. Differences between what certain people would defend and specifically whom they would defend themselves against were less important in this context. Precisely how the interests and motives of the elite and the peasantry could run parallel rather than being one and the same is mostly clearly visible in the comprehensive, voluntary contributions made to the Norwegian army during the war of 1808. Until the circumstances under which these contributions were made are examined more closely, they appear as patriotic acts across all levels of society. In reality, however, this was often a question either of a variety of motives meeting in one action or of elements of compunction. For example, in some cases contributions took on a more or less compulsory character, because priests read out lists of contributors' names in churches. Those who had not made contributions risked being treated as suspects, a common occurrence in France during the Revolutionary wars.⁴⁴

While the middle classes and civil servants were motivated by love of country and made their contributions to the army as a whole, peasants' contributions were usually earmarked for soldiers from their own families, villages and parishes. Even then the peasants were all too aware of how to exploit patriotic discourse themselves, such as for example to obtain free transport, applications for which were usually larded with patriotic rhetoric.⁴⁵

To Die for an Ideal

As was the case in 1807, the outbreak of war with Sweden in 1808 mobilised patriotic and nationalist energies in Denmark-Norway, at least in more educated layers of society. This mental mobilisation focused not only on encouraging the population to defend their country but also on investing meaning in the war and in their own lives and identity. But how should people react when their sons, brothers, husbands or sweethearts followed in the footsteps of their ancestors and of Christ and sacrificed their lives on the altar of the fatherland? There was no mistaking the ideal: dying for the fatherland was an honour and the ultimate sacrifice an individual could make. To Western eyes this reaction may now appear a world away, but only a few generations ago it was a widespread attitude and, at the beginning of the nineteenth century, was particularly common among the officer class. When a Norwegian colonel enrolled his son at the naval academy, he hoped that 'he would defend the honour of the Norwegian and union flag to the utmost of his ability. *An honourable death for the fatherland is far to be preferred to a long life.*'⁴⁶

For many Danes and Norwegians, the Norwegian defensive war became a living image of the very ideal of fighting and making sacrifices for the fatherland, even though the real motivation for resistance was more complex. Many publicists, however, held this complexity as less important than the ideals they believed in and sought to promote. To some, the most important thing was that the defence of Norway should give the impression of being a war for the dual Danish-Norwegian fatherland. It was not just a war to prevent Norway being conquered by Sweden but a war to defend the state as a whole. The contemporary image of Danish and Norwegian soldiers, however, was not to be constructed solely from the period's patriotic discourse but also from a perception of common historical destiny that could be expressed both as state patriotism and as national patriotism. The past could at one and the same time remind Danes and Norwegians of their true character and give them a model to live up to. It was common throughout Europe to view great men and legendary figures of the past as incarnations of the various national communities: William Tell in Switzerland, Jeanne d'Arc in France and Holger Danske in Denmark, to mention a few. Whether these old heroes had actually lived or were simply mythical figures was less important. The virtues of the great forefathers of the nation were the virtues of the nation, and in that way such heroes personified contemporary hopes of reawakening moral qualities and reviving the glorious past.⁴⁷

Danes and Norwegians did not, however, necessarily invoke the same forefathers. Although there are many examples of contemporary references to a common Nordic past or simply to a group of unidentified forefathers, Norwegians often referred explicitly to the ancient Norwegian warriors. Their national past made it possible for them to differentiate themselves from Danes and affirm their national identity. Nordic antiquity, the Viking age and the Middle Ages were seen in Denmark and Norway as ages characterised by the liberty of the people but, particularly in Norway, there was a tendency to see the Norwegians of the past as stronger, braver and freer than everybody else.⁴⁸ While Danes first and foremost also praised their own 'Danish' heroes, there are many examples of them setting up Norwegian heroes – including those from the days before the union of 1380 – as historical models. On the other hand, the Norwegian-born heroes from the time after the union, such as the naval hero Tordenskjold (literally, Thunder-shield), were to a certain extent 'Danicised' in patriotic Danish songs.

Sometimes contemporary equivalents of the heroes of the past could be found. After a peasant girl had saved a Norwegian soldier from a Swedish patrol on the border at Magnor in October 1808, an enthusiastic officer reported that her act had borne witness to 'the nation's ingenuity and presence of mind' and that she 'deserved a place next to Anne Colbjørnsdatter', a well-known heroine in Norway from the Great Northern War. Her heroic deed was quickly forgotten, however, and a crofter's wife from Prestebakke became posterity's central heroine, albeit anonymous, of the war in Norway in 1808, even though the story of her deeds lacks substantiated documentary evidence. This serves to show how random, but yet selective, posterity's construction – or reconstruction – of national heroes and heroines can be.⁴⁹

Heroes, great deeds and virtues of the past did not always match contemporary reactions or the ideals espoused by educated élites. In May 1808, Prince Christian August lamented that his 'consolation is the bold troops I command, absolutely unlike the inhabitants, whom I cannot trust, as now and then they are traitors, are dull, timid and do not show the Norwegian's spirit'. By the 'Norwegian's spirit' here he meant a special, warlike spirit. Norwegians were often described as a wall of iron-willed mountain dwellers and spirited naval heroes who instilled fear into the country's enemies. In practice, however, this ideal was not always borne out, which could arouse anger in those who took such supposedly inherent national attributes very literally.⁵⁰

Occupation, Recalcitrance and Collaboration

The war with Sweden in 1808 naturally involved more for Norwegians than simply defending their own homes against plundering raiding parties and brigands. It also potentially involved Swedish rule, and all Norwegians realised that the war implied the real danger of a Swedish conquest. Such attempts on the part of the Swedes were nothing new to Norwegians. In past centuries a series of prejudices about Swedes, or rather about Swedish rule, had grown up in Norway and resurfaced during the Napoleonic Wars.

In retrospect, Armfelt's hopes of winning Norwegian hearts by means of a military occupation may at best seem paradoxical, given the burdens military occupations usually involve in terms of quartering, supplies and requisitions, and the need for labour and transport services to be supplied by the occupied population. As Tim Blanning has shown, the French occupation of the Rhineland in the 1790s – however much it had initially been intended as one to bring liberty, equality and fraternity to the Rhinelanders – was hardly a good way to make friends.⁵¹ The Russian occupation of Finland in 1808, during which the Russians strove very hard to pacify the populace, also ultimately proved intolerable for the inhabitants and was a prime cause of the fierce guerrilla war that broke out in some parts of the country.⁵² Things never reached such a pass in Norway, but no matter how much General Armfelt strove to keep the burdens of military presence to an absolute minimum, he never succeeded in erasing the perception that the Norwegians were under military occupation.

The occupation was a logistical nightmare for the Swedish army. When the supply system practically broke down shortly after the invasion commenced, there was no way to avoid requisitioning food and transport services from the occupied population – even though Armfelt and his officers strove energetically to keep requisitions to a minimum and to make sure they were carried out in an orderly manner and generously paid for. Despite this, requisitions of supplies and manpower bred much resentment and recalcitrance. Cash payment was of little comfort to the inhabitants when there was little or no food to be bought and new horses could not be found to replace those requisitioned by the occupiers. Things became worse when the Swedish army ran out of cash and had to issue promissory notes instead. Armfelt's promises that they could be exchanged for cash later counted for little in the eyes of the peasants, as did his efforts to round them up for transport tasks and work on roads

and canals. It mattered little to them that the occupiers were doing this in order to maximise the efficiency of transporting supplies from Sweden to make requisitioning of food and transports in Norway unnecessary. The occupied population not only began to shirk work and transport assignments, they also spied on the occupiers and provided Norwegian troops with intelligence in the hope of hastening the end of the occupation. Women took a particularly prominent part in the gathering of military intelligence, in no small part because they could wander about behind Swedish lines without evoking much suspicion.⁵³

Popular resistance and recalcitrance in turn frustrated Swedish officers, who grew increasingly impatient and sometimes lost their tempers altogether. They saw such acts of resistance and recalcitrance as plain ingratitude because – as was stated in a proclamation towards the end of the occupation – ‘Since Swedish troops invaded the country, Norway’s inhabitants have all experienced the friendliest treatment and Swedish troops have stayed in the country more as friends than as enemies.’⁵⁴ Swedish officers genuinely believed this and they were shocked that, instead of responding with gratitude and embraces, the Norwegians dug their heels in and resisted.

Consequently the Swedish army began to apply somewhat harsher methods to force the inhabitants to comply with their demands. Not surprisingly, this went down even worse with the occupied population. When the Swedish army left Norway in June, relations with the inhabitants of the occupied areas had become strained, to say the least. ‘The inhabitants in this area are very exasperated with the Swedes’, one military officer wrote after the Swedish retreat, something he could not quite understand, as he also noted how the Swedish army had not engaged in looting and had paid generously for everything they had requisitioned.⁵⁵

Antagonism towards the Swedes among the occupied inhabitants was not due exclusively to reactions against the occupation itself. There were also serious antipathies towards and prejudices about Sweden. In 1808 Armfelt concluded that ‘Norway, if it were conquered, would be a hell for us’, and went on to complain that ‘we are hated by the Norwegians, that is to say they are afraid of our government, our customs and excises, our restrictive constitution’. He complained to the king about ‘the inhabitants’ patriotic and unceasing devotion to their authorities, which it is beyond all attempts [to end] even though they acknowledge that our military treats them better than their own’. Fear of being conscripted into the Swedish army could also prompt Norwegian peasants to react. This was a remnant of the Swedish rule over the county of Trondheim

in 1658–60, when about 2000 Norwegian peasants were conscripted into the Swedish army and sent to the Baltic, from where very few of them returned. In fact, when in 1808 Swedish troops set about systematically registering the inhabitants in some areas to keep track of them and prevent espionage, it did not take long before rumours began to circulate that this was a military draft, prompting many to flee.⁵⁶

In other words, there was little support for the Swedes among the Norwegian population and collaboration was also a relatively rare occurrence. The military and civilian authorities in Norway, however, were deeply suspicious of the people who lived in the border regions. Several hundred people were seized by military and civilian authorities during and shortly after the occupation in what amounted to a witch hunt. When tried, however, few of them turned out to have done anything wrong. Even the few – less than 50 – who were convicted for having collaborated with Swedish troops had generally done so less in support of the Swedish cause than with a view to personal gain of some kind. Most of them belonged to the lower orders of peasant society and were utterly impoverished.⁵⁷

The majority of the inhabitants in the Norwegian border areas found the prospect of Swedish rule repugnant. In peacetime, there had been extensive trading and social relations across the border, but this did not mean that the borderers would prefer Norway to be united with Sweden rather than with Denmark. Even though the peasantry were accustomed to trading across the border and were on good terms with their Swedish neighbours and relations, prejudice against the Swedish state and Swedish social conditions was deep-rooted, and the occupation of 1808 only made matters worse. Swedish politicians and military personnel could never really understand why the Norwegians refused to embrace Swedish rule when they had so many dealings with Sweden and would derive considerable financial and social benefits from a union. Nevertheless, the belief that the Norwegians could be tempted to turn their backs on the Danish government and willingly unite with Sweden remained firmly entrenched in Swedish political and military circles during subsequent years, as Denmark-Norway's war with Britain wore on and increased the misery and desperation of the situation in Norway.

An Amicable Occupation

Although the war between Denmark-Norway and Sweden during the years 1808–09 was primarily fought in Norway, its effects and the

hardships it brought with it also had significant impact on Denmark and the duchies. The Danish-Norwegian government had been apprehensive about French troops entering Danish territory ever since the British landings in Zealand, and Marshal Bernadotte's offer of French assistance was refused both in August and September. This was first and foremost because the government was afraid that French troops would enter Denmark for the sole purpose of exploiting Danish resources. This apprehension grew after the Fontainebleau Alliance and became acute when the Russian government broached the question of an invasion of Scania. It was therefore an extremely hesitant Danish-Norwegian government that began negotiations with Marshal Bernadotte towards the end of January. The consolation, or hope, was that the problems would disappear once the crossing to Scania – known as Sweden's breadbasket – had been effected. The cancellation of the Scanian landing two months later, however, turned Danish nightmares into brutal reality as some 35,000 troops under French command were left stranded in Jutland, Funen and Zealand and had to be fed and housed.

The initial reception of Marshall Bernadotte's troops, particularly in Schleswig and Holstein, had been anything but enthusiastic. In the city of Schleswig, some of Marshall Bernadotte's adjutants and senior officers found themselves surrounded by an angry mob of about 500 people, who hurled abuse as well as stones and bricks at them. Brawls, fights and even skirmishes between civilians and Bernadotte's troops became commonplace. Clearly, the overwhelmingly German-speaking population of the duchies had heard enough about how the French had recently acted elsewhere in northern Germany to be much inclined to welcome them to their own cities and villages, while unruly behaviour on the part of the French troops was also a source of much popular resentment. Bernadotte's troops were slightly better received in Denmark proper, however, although here, too, there were brawls with peasants and other civilians, usually due to military demands for supplies and quartering.⁵⁸

On the other hand, the Spanish troops in particular seem to have got on well with the civilian population. Both contemporary and later Danish accounts provide a generally favourable impression of the Spanish, which seems largely to have originated in a kind of well-disposed inquisitiveness about these exotic strangers. It was naturally to their advantage that the Spanish troops acted amicably towards the civil population, while the French gained a reputation for being inconsiderate, unsympathetic and arrogant. There was also a good deal of mythologising about the Spanish troops afterwards. People's

impressions became rosier in retrospect, as memories of quartering and requisitions faded while those of exotic sights, language, noises and food remained or were forged later in the collective memory and in stories. In fact, memories were usually so fond that claims of having Spanish ancestry became quite common as the nineteenth century progressed, although painstaking searches for firm evidence of this in parish registers and other public records have yet to yield any substantial results. Even when Spanish troops were blamed for the burning of Koldinghus Castle in Jutland on the night of 30 March, the news was received with indulgence, as the Spaniards were simply said to have been a bit too extravagant in their attempts to keep warm during a cold night in early spring.⁵⁹

In Norway, however, there was very little enthusiasm for the presence of any of the foreign troops in Denmark. 'Our *allies* are still in Jutland eating the provisions intended for us', wrote Prince Christian August sarcastically at the beginning of May,⁶⁰ and there was also great irritation about a whole fleet of ships being held in readiness to take troops from Denmark to Scania that could otherwise have been employed in taking corn to Norway. Norwegians would later come to feel that all the resources devoted to the planned invasion of Scania in 1808 illustrated the failure of the king to come to the relief of his Norwegian subjects.

However, Bernadotte's army did not stay long in Denmark after the invasion of Scania had been cancelled. In April the French and Dutch soldiers were marched south to Hamburg and the duchies, while the Spanish contingent remained in Denmark. But nor did they remain long. In spite of frantic attempts to limit and censor news from Spain, it took little time for the news of Napoleon's invasion of the country to create unrest among the Spanish troops under Bernadotte's command. The situation became even worse when Napoleon removed the Bourbons from the Spanish throne and put his brother Joseph there instead, and then ordered that the Spanish contingent of his army should swear an oath of loyalty to him. Many of the soldiers refused outright, and when they were assembled to swear the new oath, there was a near riot and shouts of 'death to Napoleon' and 'long live Ferdinand VII'.⁶¹

Dynastic loyalty appears to have played a significant role in the growing reluctance of the Spanish troops to remain under French command in Denmark, something that the British government knew how to exploit. Newspapers and propaganda left on Danish beaches kept the Spanish troops fully updated on what was happening in their native country, which left many with a burning desire to return to Spain. Their motives for going home were not necessarily the defence of their

country but a fear of what the war and the rebellion could mean for their families, homes and provinces. The upshot was that a handful of Spanish officers led by Pedro Caro, Marquis de la Romana, took the lead in a rebellion involving a large number of the Spanish troops, of whom 10,000 managed to make away on 21 August with the help of the Royal Navy. The remaining Spanish troops were immediately interned and later sent to France as prisoners of war. While Frederick VI was incensed about the rebellion and the subsequent flight of the Spaniards, he could see that the event had its silver lining. It signalled the end of the amicable occupation of Denmark and meant that there were fewer soldiers to quarter and fewer mouths to feed. Money is a resource far less easily renewed than food, however, and the brief sojourn of Marshall Bernadotte's army in Denmark had been an enormous strain on the Danish economy. The rebellion and flight of the Spanish troops had also shown how helpless Denmark-Norway would be in a war with Great Britain.

Crisis and Devastation

Crisis struck both Norway and Sweden in the autumn of 1808. The Swedes were frantically attempting to defend Finland, but the Russian army gradually pushed them northwards towards the border to Sweden proper. The British government began to regard Sweden as an obstacle to a British–Russian rapprochement and also made it clear that it would not come to the aid of Sweden. This left Gustav IV Adolph with none but his own forces to defend Finland. The problem was that considerable numbers of his troops would be bound up along the Norwegian border. In order to free up troops for the war in Finland, therefore, and probably also in an attempt to get Norway to secede from Denmark, the Swedes made a number of approaches to the Norwegians in the late summer of 1808 to arrange a separate truce, which were all rejected.

Yet, the Norwegians began to accept the need for a truce as the autumn progressed. The lack of food forced them to grant leave to as many soldiers as possible to conserve provisions. Not only was the army in the field making deep inroads into the provisions in the military stores, but the harvest had also been delayed because of the many peasants who had been conscripted. The harvest also failed in parts of southern Norway in 1808, and the blockade hindered the vital corn imports. All of these problems, and recognition of the fact that it would be impossible to make war during the winter under any circumstances, prompted Christian August to agree to the Swedish request for a truce in

October. Negotiations were begun and resulted in a cessation of hostilities between Sweden and southern and eastern Norway on 7 December.

The irregularity of communications between Norway and Denmark meant that Christian August had no idea whether or not he had negotiated with the approval of Frederick IV. In his letters to the king during the autumn of 1808, the increasingly desperate Christian August informed him of the critical situation in Norway and attempted by these means to justify the negotiations he had entered into without the king's orders. Frederick VI's weeks-old rejection reached Christiania only a few hours after the truce with Sweden had in fact been signed on 7 December. By then the separate Norwegian–Swedish truce had in any case become a *fait accompli*, one that was made easier for Frederick VI to accept by Russia's truce with Sweden signed at Olkijoki on 19 November.

The Norwegian–Swedish truce failed to solve the Norwegians' problems. As it could be rescinded at only 48 hours' notice, it meant that the Norwegian and Swedish armies both had to stay in their quarters along the border through the winter. This created extreme hardship on both sides of the border for soldiers and civilians alike, especially after epidemic diseases began to spread from the military camps and food supplies dwindled.

Although conditions were bad enough in western Sweden,⁶² they were undoubtedly worst in the eastern parts of Norway. These areas had not only been the scenes of war and occupation during the spring and summer of 1808, they had also suffered due to the presence of the Norwegian army. While the army attempted to steer clear of quartering and food requisitions, it was impossible to avoid imposing other burdens on the populace, such as transport and supplies of wood. Nor could anything be done about the steady depletion of food for civilians. Many of the inhabitants had to resort to mixing bark and Iceland moss with their flour during the autumn and winter of 1808–09, both in accordance with an old custom and on the encouragement of the authorities. Even though cash contributions from the populace and extraordinary loans from the government in Copenhagen were distributed among the most needy living on the Norwegian borderers, this gave them little comfort in the short term as they could buy nothing with the money – and prices for the little that could be bought skyrocketed.⁶³

Disease, famine and death in the winter of 1808–09 virtually turned some parts of the border regions in Norway into wastelands. There are countless accounts of misery from these areas, some describing how 'many families have been completely obliterated', others how there

were so many corpses in some areas that there was neither the time nor the space to bury them. The traumatised peasantry lapsed into religious fervour or superstition in many places. This appears to have been a relatively common reaction in many other European countries where the miseries of the Revolutionary and Napoleonic wars had strengthened the religious beliefs and affinities of the people and made them look to the past rather than to the future. It was only later, with the culture of memorials and remembrance that grew up in Europe, that sacrifice for the nation was used to give meaning to the suffering and traumas of the Revolutionary and Napoleonic wars.⁶⁴

The crisis in Norway during the period 1808–09 tested solidarity with and loyalty to the Danish-Norwegian state at various levels. First, it was a question of what people in Denmark could and would do to help the Norwegians, a question that has been hotly debated by Norwegian and Danish historians. Norwegian historians have often been of the opinion that Frederick VI and his government failed to do enough to help Norway during the war, while Danish historians have been more inclined to point out what was actually done in Denmark.⁶⁵

Both opinions also reflect contemporary views. There are sound arguments for both points of view, but an important fact has often been overlooked, namely that the rigorous British blockade in itself severely restricted what could be done on the part of the Danes. Very few Danish ships evaded the blockade from the spring to the late autumn of 1808, and when the British fleet left Danish-Norwegian waters in the winter of 1808–09, the Skagerrak froze so extensively that hardly any ships were able to make the crossing from January to March 1809. It must have appeared to the increasingly desperate Norwegians that this absence of ships from Denmark was due to incompetence and lack of interest – a view to which many influential Norwegians began to subscribe. But even though some of the king's measures were unsuccessful in their execution and in their results, there can be no doubt that both the government and the middle classes in Denmark empathised with the suffering of the Norwegians and tried to help to the best of their ability. However, such moral support provided scant consolation when there was little evidence of any practical effect, and a vicious circle arose in the Danish-Norwegian state with Norwegians accusing Danes of not doing enough, while these accusations increasingly aroused irritation in Denmark, where people believed that everything that was humanly possible was being done to come to the relief of Norway.

In Norway the crisis and the war also raised once again the issue of solidarity between the various parts of the country that together

constituted both the natural fatherland and the nation. In an ideal world of national patriotism, all of the country's inhabitants would be prepared to set aside their own needs for the best of the nation and the fatherland. This is seen in the rather romanticised hindsight of one contemporary observer who 'had never in his long life experienced a time at which love of the fatherland burned with a warmer, clearer and more generally widespread flame and in which private matters, troubles and suffering were more subordinated to participation in the condition of the state'.⁶⁶ There is much to suggest that he was right, such as, among other things, the voluntary contributions of corn and money from the urban middle class and civil servants for the long-suffering border provinces and the soldiers.

On the other hand, the crisis and the war also created friction between the various regions of the country and even among local populations as some profited, rather than suffered, from war and occupation. In spite of complaints about their 'foul and avaricious mercenary spirit', the wealthy farmers of Hedmarken, the area of Norway richest in corn and very rarely subject to harvest failures, promptly seized the opportunity offered by the war to profit shamelessly at the expense of those areas where there was a dearth of corn, and at the expense of the soldiers. For his part, Prince Christian August accused the people of Trøndelag of stockpiling corn that had been acquired in Arkhangelsk in Russia instead of sending it to the most needy parts of Norway. Therefore, solidarity and concord in Norway during the war years of 1808–09 should not be exaggerated, even though in the long term the war would little by little help to create a heightened sense of fellowship and independence among many Norwegians, at least in their opposition to Denmark.⁶⁷

The Fall of Gustav IV Adolph and an Opportunity for Scandinavia

For all practical purposes Sweden had lost Finland to Russia by the beginning of 1809, once the Swedish army had retreated to Sweden proper. Far from being out of danger, however, the Swedes found themselves in an even more desperate situation. Tsar Alexander of Russia had assured Frederick VI that he would take the war into Sweden and expected Denmark-Norway to assist him in doing so.⁶⁸ Consequently, Frederick VI began to make new plans to invade Scania – but now without the help of allied troops – while at the same time the Norwegian army received orders to make new preparations to invade western Sweden.

The new plan for invading Scania involved marching the entire Danish army across the frozen Sound when conditions would make it impossible for the British fleet to intervene. The Danish army accordingly assembled in Zealand at the turn of the year 1808–09 and made ready for offensive operations against Sweden. The preparations and plans were comprehensive: more than 30,000 men would march across the Sound as soon as the ice was sufficiently thick. There can be no doubt that, had this invasion been carried out, it would have led to considerable problems for the Swedes and might have helped to bring Gustav IV Adolph to his knees before matters had gone so far as to bring about a revolution in Sweden. It could be argued, on the other hand, that the Danish army would have found themselves in a precarious situation as soon as the ice in the Sound had broken up and the British fleet could gain access to it. The government in Copenhagen made this clear when the Danish emissary in Paris was told to explain to Napoleon that ‘even in the event of our being able to join forces to put an army corps ashore, what means would be at our disposal to provision it in a country divested of everything, while our enemy would be in undisputable command of the sea?’⁶⁹ It is therefore impossible to know what the outcome of a successful invasion of Scania would have been, since it was dependent on many more circumstances and factors than simply whether or not the Danish army could have crossed the Sound.

The reason why the invasion never took place was that, when it came to it, Frederick would not risk marching the Danish army across the Sound. The ice on the Sound was simply too unsafe and, after the march had been cancelled several times, it broke up during a thaw that set in on the night of 29 January and continued for the next few days. The invasion was therefore deferred until the temperature fell sufficiently for the ice to bear, and this did not happen during the winter of 1809. At the beginning of March, Frederick VI was once again obliged to acknowledge that it would be impossible to make the crossing to Scania as planned. However, this does not mean, as some historians have claimed, that he was not seriously considering an invasion of Scania. Not only had extensive preparations been made with regard both to planning the campaign and to moving troops; Frederick VI had also had proclamations flown by balloon over to Scania encouraging the population to submit to a ‘Nordic Frederick’. When the invasion failed to materialise, the entire enterprise appeared nothing other than farcical, and the proclamation had no other effect than to bring about a furious exchange of letters with Gustav IV Adolph.⁷⁰

A Norwegian invasion of Sweden in 1809 never came to anything either. The dearth of supplies in Norway was so critical that there could

be no serious question of military operations. The situation in Norway became so desperate in the late winter of 1809 that the Government Commission hinted to Frederick VI that a separate peace with Great Britain might be Norway's only salvation. The proposal was not well received in Copenhagen, where the king was painfully aware that such a peace would constitute a lethal threat to the composite state, since it would almost surely set Norway adrift. But the proposal nevertheless did show that war and deprivation had forced high-ranking Norwegian civil servants, including Prince Christian August, to consider solutions that had previously been beyond the realms of the thinkable.⁷¹

Influential civil servants in Sweden had also begun thinking along forbidden lines. Even when the Russian army advanced into northern Sweden, Gustav IV Adolph refused to accept the loss of Finland, to withdraw from the British alliance and to make peace with his neighbours. Instead, he levied new taxes and made preparations to continue the war. Fearing that the very existence of Sweden was under threat, a group of officers decided to dethrone the king and succeeded in doing so in a palace revolution in Stockholm on 13 March. To assist in the coup, troops in the county of Värmland marched on Stockholm under the command of the colonel and politician Georg Adlersparre, and, having informed the Norwegians of their intention, opened up the border to Norway in the process.

Frederick VI's standing order to the Norwegian army was to invade Sweden as soon as circumstances permitted. But the Norwegians failed to take the opportunity to invade Värmland. Some Scandinavian historians have wondered whether this was because Christian August had been informed that he was a likely candidate for the Swedish throne and therefore decided to disobey the king's order for personal, egoistical reasons. Others have discussed whether Christian August exceeded his authority by letting the Swedes know that they would be given ten or twelve days' notice if Frederick VI gave the Norwegians a direct order to attack – sufficient warning to eliminate any chance of the Norwegian army catching them by surprise. This discussion is essentially irrelevant because, even though the border was wide open, problems with supplies and epidemics in the Norwegian army made them incapable of crossing it in any case. The Swedes knew this and by the time an emissary was sent to Norway to inform of what was going on, Adlersparre and his army were already on their way. Therefore, the Swedish revolution of 1809 was not carried out through the good offices of Norway.

The fall of Gustav IV Adolph opened the door to new opportunities in Scandinavia – primarily the opportunity to unite the Scandinavian

kingdoms under one crown. Initially, these opportunities depended on who his successor would be. The idea of uniting Sweden, Denmark and Norway under Frederick VI's rule was not in itself anathema to revolutionary Swedish circles, but the problem – from the point of view of the Danish-Norwegian king – was that they wanted a constitutional monarchy and not an autocracy based on the Danish-Norwegian model. Frederick VI solved the issue of his own candidacy by brusquely dismissing a Swedish officer on a peace mission to Copenhagen at the end of March with the words that 'any negotiation is difficult with a nation that has to be regarded as nothing but insurgents'. After that, his candidacy understandably lost its appeal for most Swedes.⁷²

A group of influential Norwegian merchants and civil servants had hoped that the Swedish revolution would pave the way for a constitutional Scandinavian kingdom. Frederick VI's reaction was naturally a disappointment to this group, but at the same time they were left with the feeling that Frederick would be unsuitable as the head of a united kingdom and that his reactionary views and his personality were an obstacle to a unification of Scandinavia and consequently to a Scandinavian peace. They began instead to work on a project with the aim of uniting Norway with Sweden under Prince Christian August and in this they were supported by the revolutionaries in general and in particular by Adlersparre, by then their leading figure. The spring and summer months of 1809 saw intense conspiratorial activity to bring their project to fruition. The outcome was that the dethroned king's uncle, Count Charles of Södermanland, was elected king, while Christian August was elected as the successor to the Swedish throne in July.

This made Christian August's position extremely awkward. He had been unaware of the conspiracies that had been going on and was extremely reluctant to go behind his king's back. For his part, Frederick VI had realised that his prospects of gaining the Swedish throne had evaporated, and he initiated an aggressive policy with the aim of conquering Sweden. Frederick had no intention of uniting Sweden with Denmark-Norway but of subjugating the country, which was a completely unrealistic ambition. The kings of the Scandinavian union of Calmar in the fifteenth and early sixteenth centuries had never been able to govern the Swedes against their will – so nor would a king in Copenhagen have been able to do so in the nineteenth century. A union could only be sustained if it were established on a voluntary basis and in the form of a federation with a constitution. Yet the idea of having a constitutional monarchy in just part of his state – in the event of a union – held very little appeal for Frederick VI.

The war with Russia in northern Sweden continued because the new Swedish government, hoping that Napoleon would eventually turn against Russia, refused to break with Great Britain and join the Continental Blockade. In the meantime Frederick attempted to gain possession of Swedish territories at any cost, as he knew perfectly well that the Swedish–Russian war would not last long. The Russian foreign minister made it clear that the only Swedish territories that could fall to Denmark–Norway were those that it might be able to conquer itself, which was in line with what had been agreed between Napoleon and Alexander at Erfurt the previous autumn. Moreover, in the absence of the invasion of Sweden from the west and south that had been agreed in Fontainebleau, he did not conceal his dissatisfaction at what St Petersburg saw as a half-hearted Danish–Norwegian effort in the war with Sweden. This in turn made Frederick VI even more desperate to take the offensive from fear of evoking the fury of the tsar and Napoleon. As he was unable to invade Sweden from Denmark because of the British blockade, he ordered Christian August to mount an invasion. However, the Norwegian army was still completely incapable of taking offensive action, and, because Christian August was extremely unwilling to attack Sweden, he refused to obey the king's order. His election as the successor to the Swedish throne *may* have played a role in this, but, as his biographer Lee Sather has convincingly demonstrated, it was first and foremost the fear of a permanent Russian presence in Scandinavia and his genuine desire for peace in Scandinavia that prompted the prince to refuse to invade Sweden. By invading Sweden, he reasoned, he would only help the Russians gain a permanent foothold in Sweden proper, which he told the king would eventually 'turn your Majesty's faithful Norwegians into slaves of the Russians'.⁷³

Here Frederick VI had fewer scruples, however. He was furious with Christian August for what appeared to him to be a downright refusal to obey his orders. In his desperation to seize Swedish territories, he suggested to Tsar Alexander I that Denmark–Norway and Russia should divide Sweden between them along a line some 150 kilometres north of Stockholm. Alexander flatly refused and, at the beginning of August, Frederick VI was obliged to back down and sue for peace. He took steps to placate Britain by forbidding privateering, and he gave Christian August permission to accept the offer of succession as soon as peace with Sweden was formally concluded. He also agreed to negotiate a peace with the Swedes, after which negotiations proper began in the Swedish town of Jönköping in November. In the meantime, Sweden and Russia had signed a peace treaty in Frederikshavn on

17 September 1809, and in doing so had formally placed Finland under Russian rule.⁷⁴

The events of 1809 had a number of important consequences and implications. First, the election of Christian August as the successor to the Swedish throne opened new doors for Danish–Norwegian–Swedish relations. There was much speculation as to how he would fulfil his office as Swedish crown prince and considerable expectation both in the government in Copenhagen and in those Norwegian circles that still wanted to see the end of Frederick VI's autocratic rule. Second, the loss of Finland meant that Sweden began to look around for some form of compensation, while at the same time Denmark–Norway became worthless as Russia's ally, much as Danish–Norwegian foreign ministers had feared for almost a century. Both of these factors came into play when Russian diplomats negotiating with the Swedes in Frederikshavn discreetly pointed a finger at Norway. In so doing, they were turning Denmark–Norway's nightmare scenario into a reality, although Christian August's indisputable loyalty to Frederick VI meant that that reality was kept at bay for the time being. There were also other groups in Sweden and Norway that had begun working to bring about the Swedish–Norwegian solution as early as 1809.

Discontent and Conspiracies

On 22 August 1809, Count Herman Wedel Jarlsberg summoned a number of influential merchants and ironworks proprietors to a meeting at Bærum Ironworks immediately south of Christiania. Wedel Jarlsberg was the son of a diplomat and one of the few Norwegian nobles. Despite having been born in Montpellier and having spent much of his youth in continental Europe, he had a strong Norwegian identity. Having been private secretary to the minister of finance in Copenhagen, he became governor of the county of Buskerud in 1805 and two years later he married into the merchant elite in Norway, thereby joining the elite of wealth and influence in Norway despite its essentially 'middle-class' composition. After the outbreak of war with Great Britain, the young, energetic Wedel Jarlsberg became involved in the supply sector, knowing full well that the war would cause tremendous problems with regard to the procurement of corn. His efforts in this matter, however, only convinced him that the Danish government was not doing enough for Norway and, even worse, did not care. And that was not all. All the other unfortunate consequences that the wars with Great Britain and Sweden had for Norway also left him with a feeling that Danish and

Norwegian interests were outright incompatible, while he also became increasingly critical of the absolutist monarchy.⁷⁵

For the count, however, this realisation only dawned gradually.⁷⁶ Initially he thought along state and national patriotic lines, and his energy prompted him to place himself at the head of a volunteer corps upon the outbreak of hostilities with Sweden in 1808.⁷⁷ In no small part as a result of his patriotic efforts in the war, he was given a seat on the Government Commission in January 1809, which confirmed his position as one of the leading men in Norway.⁷⁸

Following the Swedish revolution in March 1809, Count Wedel Jarlsberg had wanted a constitutional Scandinavian union under Frederick VI, which he wished to use as a lever to end Frederick's autocratic rule in Denmark and Norway. As this could not be realised because of the king's intractable attitude to the constitutional issue, he turned instead to the idea of a constitutional union of Sweden and Norway, as he felt that this would give Norway far-reaching national autonomy and much better economic conditions than Denmark had to offer. This idea, which entered the count's mind in the spring of 1809, was the point at which Count Wedel Jarlsberg's national patriotism met constitutionalism and liberalism, which would soon turn his national patriotic sentiments in a more radical direction.

This was what underlay his activities in 1809 and was the reason why he convened the meeting at his ironworks at Bærum in late August. As a person who was actively involved in obtaining supplies for Norway and as a member of the Government Commission, Wedel Jarlsberg was fully aware of the critical position Norway was in. He therefore wanted peace with Sweden and Great Britain in order to save Norway. On Norway's behalf, he had taken a leading role in the efforts to make Christian August the successor to the Swedish throne in the spring and summer of 1809 through contacts and conspiracies with leading Swedish circles. His reason for this was that Frederick VI's reactions to the Swedish revolution had convinced him that the interests of Norway and Denmark were becoming increasingly incompatible, and that a united Scandinavia under the rule of Frederick VI was not a desirable option as it was unlikely to put absolutism to an end.⁷⁹ Wedel Jarlsberg's subsequent activities during the spring and summer of 1809 resembled nothing other than pure conspiracy aimed at removing Frederick VI from the Norwegian throne. He secretly exchanged letters and held meetings with Swedish revolutionaries, including the officers Adlersparre and Baltazar von Platen, with the chief objective of putting Christian August on the Swedish throne. Their intention was that the Norwegians

would unite behind the tremendously popular prince and join forces with Sweden, which would dissolve the union with Denmark and leave Norway with extensive autonomy in a constitutional union with Sweden.

After the election of Christian August as the Swedish successor in July, Wedel Jarlsberg felt he could begin his work of arranging a union between Norway and Sweden in earnest. However, during the meeting with the merchants at Bærum Ironworks he did not receive the support he had hoped for. Most felt that the count had gone too far, while others warned him that he would not find much support for his plans for a union with Sweden among the Norwegian peasantry. Having previously gone so far as to consider an uprising against Danish rule in Norway with the help of a peasant army, Wedel Jarlsberg backed down somewhat after the sobering experience at Bærum. But even though few people were prepared to give their total support to his plans, Wedel Jarlsberg's activism in 1809 was a clear indication that the war had created a mood among many Norwegians that went beyond dissatisfaction with certain aspects of Danish rule and indicated dissatisfaction with Danish rule in general to the point that a cession from the Danish Empire was considered by some.

There had already been certain signs of discontent in Norway in the spring of 1808, including increasing misgivings with Danish rule. Popular discontent should not be exaggerated, but reports from some places in eastern Norway leave little doubt that in some instances the peasants 'blamed the Danes for every mishap' and uttered 'angry words about Copenhagen and the government'.⁸⁰ It was therefore not without reason that the Norwegian authorities strongly suspected that Swedish proclamations found many eager readers among the peasants of eastern Norway while Wedel Jarlsberg took this as reason to believe that his ideas were capable of arousing much popular support.

For Wedel Jarlsberg, national patriotism moved towards a desire for political and national autonomy and marked in practice the dawning of modern Norwegian nationalism. For others, their national patriotism had undoubtedly been considerably strengthened during the war at the cost of their loyalty to the composite state, but there were still very few people who were willing to go so far as to conspire against Frederick VI to wrest Norway from the grasp of Denmark or to work for a union between Norway and Sweden. The war in 1808 and 1809 showed quite clearly that war with Sweden and Great Britain at the same time would be catastrophic for Norway in the long run – to a far greater degree than it was for Denmark. Set alongside a recognition of the fact that Norway

had got through the war almost unaided, this created favourable conditions for the growing desire among the elite in general for greater autonomy for the Norwegian nation, albeit generally within the framework of the union with Denmark. The economic crisis that the war had brought about in Norway was also a powerful driving force towards such union, as will be demonstrated in the next chapter.

4

Naval and Economic Warfare

A New Fleet

The loss of the fleet was nothing short of a catastrophe for Denmark-Norway. It crippled the state's defensive forces and swept away what remained of the government's ability to manoeuvre in international politics. Thanks to the fleet, Denmark-Norway had been able to act as a regional power to be reckoned with and, if they had not lost it in 1807, the state would still have been relatively attractive to the great powers as an ally. After all, the fleet's military potential in the hands of Napoleon was the main reason why Britain seized it. Furthermore, the fleet was the only means that Denmark-Norway had of defending its long coastline, of securing communications between the various parts of the state and, not least, of controlling the strategically and economically vital approach to the Baltic Sea.

That an alliance with Napoleon was concluded entirely on the Emperor's own terms was essentially the price the state paid for the loss of the fleet. In addition, Denmark-Norway's coasts and coastal waters were now to all intents and purposes wide open to the British navy, while connections between Denmark and Norway had been severed. It therefore comes as no surprise that the construction of a new fleet was an immediate priority, not only on the part of the government, but also on the part of the people. Their commitment to the re-establishment of the fleet can be explained by various factors and considerations, but they were channelled into the state-patriotic wave that spread throughout Denmark-Norway in the wake of the bombardment and the seizure of the fleet. The desire to be able to defend the state with military means against what was seen as a dangerous and, above all, ruthless enemy was a clear motive for Denmark-Norway's inhabitants. Perhaps equally

important, however, was the fleet's symbolic significance. As a symbol of the king and of the security, prosperity and pride of the state, there was more to the rebuilding of the fleet than sheer military necessity.

Initially, popular measures resulted in comprehensive collections and gifts. The admiralty in Copenhagen received huge sums of money and quantities of valuable silverware. The patriotic symbolism of these donations was emphasised when the silver was melted down and used to mint coins which, by a royal decree of December 1808, were embossed with the words 'voluntary donation for the fatherland' surrounded by an oak wreath to symbolise a sacrifice for civil society. The voluntary contributions came not only in the form of money and silverware, but also included timber and even ships. This was the case with the town of Tønning in Schleswig, for instance, which donated a ship as a 'Gift on the altar of the fatherland as a pledge of its loyalty'.¹

From a military standpoint it was absolutely decisive to build a fleet as quickly as possible. This excluded major ships of the line, which required more time and resources than the Danish-Norwegian government had at its disposal. The solution was to build smaller vessels, collectively known as gunboats, which had the advantage that they could be rapidly built, cost relatively little and – perhaps above all – were highly manoeuvrable and therefore suitable for use in skerries and shallow coastal waters. It says much about the extent of the voluntary collections made during the war years, of the low price of the gunboats and of their utility that voluntary contributions could finance the construction of 173 such vessels in Denmark and about 100 in Norway. By comparison, only four frigates and one ship of the line, appropriately named *Phoenix*, were built during the same period. A Swedish naval lieutenant who was a prisoner of war in Norway noticed the underlying patriotism that motivated the building of the gunboats and the patriotism it in turn created and said, when he was released in August 1808, that 'the mood of the people is good and even enthusiastic, which can be seen from the fact that donations to build their entire flotilla of gunboats have been received and they are now beginning to build them at the expense of the king'.² This was in sharp contrast to Swedish expectations that the war and the blockade would soon demoralise the Norwegians and prompt them to throw themselves into the arms of Sweden.

Although Denmark-Norway had in no sense been able to build up a new fleet of ships of the line that could measure up to the fleet that had been lost in Copenhagen in 1807, Danes and Norwegians still managed to launch a fleet that could put up good resistance under favourable

circumstances. Initially, this involved a number of smaller vessels, which were easy to build and cost little, for use in coastal waters. This meant that it was also possible to begin large-scale shipbuilding for civil purposes in Denmark-Norway during the war years, even more so as trade with Great Britain from the autumn of 1809 created a tremendous economic upswing that encouraged extensive maritime trade.

Naval War

On the one hand, the new fleet of gunboats was to defend strategically important points along the coast and harass British ships in Danish-Norwegian waters, while on the other a more offensive tactic for naval war would be organised in the form of a privateering offensive, whereby civilian ships could attack the enemy's merchant ships with the blessing of the government. The gunboats were active throughout the war, and became more so as their number increased. Although these vessels were, generally speaking, on the small side and not particularly awe-inspiring to look at, they could be very effective under the right circumstances. Their chief advantage, perhaps rather paradoxically, was their small size and their oars, which meant they could be flexibly and rapidly manoeuvred in narrow coastal waters and fjords, and could therefore choose suitable ambush points and hiding places. This ability was used to advantage to seize or sink several British brigs in Danish and Norwegian waters, particularly in the summer of 1808.³ On the other hand, the gunboats were extremely vulnerable if there was a strong wind that enabled the bigger ships to turn their guns on them.

From a military point of view, Great Britain chiefly had two measures it could use against Denmark-Norway. One was the blockade, which basically involved stationing a cordon of men-of-war along the Danish-Norwegian coasts that could intercept any vessels that attempted to sneak through the line. The other was to attack points along the Danish-Norwegian coastlines, primarily towns and fortified installations. The first of such attacks came as early as the late summer of 1807 along the south coast of Norway, and they continued sporadically throughout the war, resulting in the destruction of military installations, looting and the capture of prisoners. In Denmark, too, British ships could constantly be seen patrolling the belts and the Sound.

Neither gunboats, batteries nor militias could do anything to restrict the range of the British navy or their freedom to choose their points of attack. British raids on the Danish-Norwegian coasts occurred regularly, particularly on ports where there were merchant ships and stores of corn

and other goods. In 1809 and 1812, ship traffic between Arkhangelsk in Russia and Norway tempted British vessels to sail all the way to the northernmost parts of the Norwegian coast.

At the end of July 1809 even Hammerfest – a town of some 1000 inhabitants close to the North Cape – was attacked by British ships. After exchanging fire with about 50 local militiamen, the British occupied the town and proceeded to loot and partly destroy it. One of the town's inhabitants gave clear expression to the way he experienced the event and, not least, to what he thought of the British:

We were convinced that we were dealing with robbers, but as we had treated them in accordance with the rules of war, we expected them to do the same, but we were completely mistaken – no sooner had they treacherously disarmed these few men than they began to rob and plunder, which was the very opposite of what they had promised orally and in writing: that nobody would be molested if we stopped opposing them – nothing more could be done against such villains except to avoid personal injury. Everybody went on their way and left the robbers to their deceitful deeds.⁴

It was not unusual for British raids of this type to turn into pure looting expeditions to the dismay of the inhabitants along the Danish-Norwegian coasts, but their number and extent should not be exaggerated. In fact, they were relatively rare and seem to have been at their height during the years from 1807 to 1809. They appear to have been even rarer in Denmark and the duchies than in Norway, probably because British naval activity seems to have been most extensive in Norwegian waters because of the blockade.⁵

Even though it was not always successful, the defensive war along the coast helped to heighten the patriotic mood both in Denmark and Norway. There were a number of occasions when British troops who had gone ashore were driven off by the coastal militias, and such events were always duly reported in the Danish and Norwegian press and propaganda. The greatest propaganda scoops, however, were when gunboats succeeded in capturing larger British vessels. These events were not only presented as military triumphs in the Danish-Norwegian press, they were also expressions of revenge, of the ability of the state to defend itself and, not least symbolically, of patriotic efforts and sacrifices for the fatherland.⁶

Still, some 1400 Danish-Norwegian ships ended up in British hands during the war years, which is equivalent to about one ship every other

day for the duration of the war. Several of the few remaining and of the newly built Danish-Norwegian vessels were also destroyed, costing hundreds of Danish-Norwegian seamen their lives. Nor were other areas of the naval war particularly successful. Attempts in 1810 and 1811 to reconquer the strategically important island of Anholt, north of Zealand – which had been occupied by the British in 1809 – ended in fiasco and aroused suspicions that the islanders were perfectly content with the British presence. In a similar case, a number of Norwegians found themselves in the dock for having assisted a British frigate that had entered Bergen harbour in May 1808.⁷

Losses and defeats at sea were also viewed in a national patriotic light and were invested with significance as sacrifices on the altar of the fatherland. During the summer of 1813, the Danish actor H.C. Knudsen was on tour in Norway as he had been in Denmark, both in 1801 and 1807. Knudsen's productions had a strong element of state patriotism, and their aim was to boost patriotism among the Norwegians within the firm framework of the monarchy and the state. In doing so, however, Knudsen made deliberate use of national patriotic elements. The main attraction of the production was a block of stone decorated with sprigs of spruce and engraved with the names of the officers who had fallen in action on the Swedish border in 1808. There was also a broken ship's mast decorated with the royal flag and engraved with the names of the officers who had died when the frigate *Najaden* was sunk in a Norwegian port in July 1812. Girls dressed in white and children holding wreaths and garlands stood on each side of the stage, and the two groups met at an altar on which the public's money was placed. This merged national patriotism with state patriotism, as the altar symbolised sacrifice for the fatherland, both natural and civic. The chief impression made by Knudsen's productions in Norway, however, could also be of a national patriotic character. A Norwegian officer recalled how one production at Sandefjord was held as a harvest thanksgiving celebration that concluded with a dinner and dance. The officer explicitly associated this with the heightened sense of Norwegian independence that arose towards the end of the war years. Seen in this light, the kind of national patriotism that Knudsen played on could move in the direction of nationalism, according to the way in which his public interpreted the symbolism of his productions.⁸

Several monuments were erected in Denmark, at Sjællands Odde (1808) and at Store Magleby (1809), for example, in memory of those who had fallen in the war. The monuments honoured the dead and reminded contemporary and future generations of the sacrifice they

had made, with the implicit message not to let this sacrifice have been made in vain. The memorial at Sjøllands Odde was also erected with the help of private contributions without any mention of the king, and the monument itself was a column topped by an urn to symbolise the altar of the fatherland on which the dead from the ship of the line *Prinds Christian Frederik*, sunk there in March 1808, had sacrificed their lives. The fallen were honoured as sons of the common fatherland, as the names of both the Danish and Norwegian dead were listed side by side on a memorial plaque in the church at Sjøllands Odde.

Imprisoned Sailors

Although the fleet had been lost in Copenhagen in 1807, its seamen did not suffer the same fate, with the exception of the approximately 1000 men of the Marine Regiment who had volunteered for British service. For their part, the remaining Danish-Norwegian seamen were left wondering what to do as the British sailed away from Zealand with the Danish-Norwegian fleet in tow. Several of the officers were afraid that their military careers in Denmark-Norway were over and reported to the French minister in Copenhagen with a request to enter French service.⁹

When the alliance was signed, the French government had hinted that they would send two ships of the line and two frigates to Denmark on the condition that they were to be manned by Danish-Norwegian officers and seamen but would remain under French command. In April 1808 Danish-Norwegian crews were therefore sent to Napoleon's naval shipyard at the mouth of the River Scheldt to man two French ships of the line. This was where problems began to crop up. It soon became clear that the French ships of the line would stand no chance of passing through the English Channel, while countless disagreements about who would be in command of them, about manning and other practical matters, created an unpleasant atmosphere among the Danish-Norwegian crews. When a few French sailors were posted to the ships, this led to new conflicts.¹⁰

National conflicts, however, were nothing new in the Danish-Norwegian navy, which was a unified state institution with seamen from the various parts of the state serving side by side. Although the great majority of the seamen were Danes and Norwegians, it was no accident that, in the eighteenth century, seamen of the same nationality were forbidden to help each other in brawls, albeit Norwegian seamen were excepted from this rule in 1771. The fact of the matter was that conflicts could

arise between Danish and Norwegian seamen, and there had also been constant conflicts between seamen and the predominantly German recruits in the Marine Regiment before 1807. In other words, there can be no doubt that serving in the navy strengthened the ethnic identity and orientation of the seamen and perhaps especially that of the approximately 2000 Danish and Norwegian seamen who found themselves in the company of French sailors on the River Scheldt. Here, the scene was set for major conflicts, with Danish and Norwegian seamen joining forces against the French.¹¹

Dissatisfaction among the Danish-Norwegian seamen and officers serving with the Scheldt fleet was almost constant and, when Napoleon ordered the Danish-Norwegian contingent to Brest in January 1809, some of them were close to mutinying. Many of the seamen simply wanted to go home and were supported in this by their officers. This in turn led to complications between the Danish-Norwegian and French governments, which initially attempted to smooth things over by recalling their senior officers. However, the problems could not be solved and remained a running sore in relations between Napoleon and Frederick VI up to the late winter of 1813 when – on the pretext of an allied threat to Holstein – the king ordered his seamen and officers to return to Denmark. In the meantime, obligations to man foreign ships on the Scheldt had also created unrest in Norway. On 13 December 1810 a revolt erupted in the city of Christiansand when seamen were to be conscripted for service in the Scheldt fleet. The seamen had just as little desire to serve outside their country's borders as had the peasant soldiers in the army. The rebellion at Christiansand naturally caused concern in Copenhagen, and, in January 1811, Foreign Minister Niels Rosenkrantz warned the king that 'Conscripting seamen from Norway has made an unfavourable impression in that country.' This did not mean, on the face of it, that the resistance to the conscription of seamen in 1810 was politically motivated, but it was a strong indication of growing discontent among Norwegians with the war in general and in particular with the burdens it placed on their shoulders. The Swedes naturally followed developments in Norway closely, and the rebellion at Christiansand even appears to have triggered preparations for a new propaganda campaign directed at Norway in the winter of 1811.¹²

The Danish-Norwegian seamen and officers on the River Scheldt were not alone in having to spend the war years in exile. About 7000 seamen – of whom 5000 were Norwegian and 2000 were Danes – crews from warships and merchant ships – ended up as British prisoners after their ships had been captured, most being housed in decommissioned naval

vessels known as 'hulks'. Danes and Norwegians came to refer to seamen's captivity as 'prisonen', and it took on gruesome associations as conditions were often appalling on board the prison 'hulks'. One way out of captivity for the seamen was to sign up to serve on British ships, and the British conducted energetic campaigns among the prisoners, some of whom did not hesitate to enter British service. The fact that, in spite of the terrible conditions they lived under, many of them resisted such a tempting offer was naturally used for propaganda purposes in the Danish-Norwegian press, and it appears that some of the prisoners did refuse to enter British service on patriotic grounds. The officer of a privateer, for instance, wrote in his diary about a seaman who had entered British service that it was 'in my opinion a poor thing for a Norwegian to have done'. Some of the imprisoned seamen and officers even celebrated the king's birthday on 28 January in the approved patriotic manner; sometimes with processions, songs, dancing and symbolic acts.¹³

There was also a patriotic response in Denmark-Norway to accounts of prisoners' conditions. What were sometimes massive collections were made for the Danish-Norwegian captives, and some newspapers, such as *Budstikken* in Norway, even donated the profits from their sales to the seamen. Alongside the collections for rebuilding the fleet, collections in aid of Danes and Norwegians in British captivity were a relatively common type of patriotic enterprise during the war years and could be associated with both the civil and natural fatherland. For many of those who remained in British captivity throughout the war, these patriotic manifestations had a hollow ring. The licensed trade that was permitted from 1809 brought Danish and Norwegian ships and seamen to Britain for commercial purposes but did nothing to assist in gaining the release of most of the prisoners.

Privateering

Privateering was naturally nothing new to European or Scandinavian wars, and France had conducted what was sometimes an intensive privateering campaign against Britain ever since the 1790s. Denmark-Norway and Sweden also had experience of privateering, as both sides had at times engaged in what could be profitable privateering expeditions against hostile and neutral ships during the Great Northern War (1709–21). In practice, privateering was a kind of state-sanctioned piracy which, put simply, involved private individuals and companies obtaining the permission of the authorities to equip vessels and seize hostile merchant ships and neutral ships carrying contraband of war.

Crown Prince Frederick issued a privateering regulation as early as 14 September 1807, which, in a slightly revised form, was proclaimed in Norway by Prince Christian August on 29 December. The privateering regulation chiefly laid down guidelines for which ships it was permitted to seize and how these ships and their cargos – known as prizes – should be approved by prize courts, realised and the proceeds distributed between stakeholders, crews and the state.¹⁴

This was of course controversial, but the British bombardment of Copenhagen had lowered the moral threshold of many people. Initially, it was well-to-do people, broadly speaking, who invested in privateers, chiefly on patriotic grounds, but as rumours gradually spread of the potentially huge profits privateering could bring, even less prosperous citizens began to invest in such enterprises. Even Christian August, who was not enthusiastic about privateering, had shares in a privateer, although he managed his ownership with the greatest discretion. Yet, he also felt that privateering posed a serious problem in relation to Sweden, as he wished to avoid ‘provoking the common people in Sweden and thereby uniting the parties [there] to our detriment’. Furthermore, during the campaign in the spring of 1808 he had made it a point of his propaganda that, unlike the Swedes, Norwegians did not engage in looting. It scarcely fitted his bill, then, that Norwegian privateers were extremely active along the west coast of Sweden, sometimes engaging in outright looting focused on Swedish ports.¹⁵

Perhaps above all, the Danish-Norwegian privateering campaign showed how patriotic and economic interests could combine to encourage the participation of a large number of people, without there necessarily being a hard-and-fast distinction between patriotic and economic interests for the individuals involved. For example, the general in command of northern Norway, the arch-patriot Georg Frederick von Krogh, had shares in a privateer and, as his private letters show, he was just as interested in the economic advantages of privateering as he was in its patriotic aspect.¹⁶

On the other hand there were many who had little other than financial gain in mind and for whom patriotism at best served as a pretext – similar to some of the guerrilla bands in Spain and southern Italy at the time who were often engaging in banditry under the cloak of patriotism. In Norway, Christian August was infuriated by a wholesaler who, with a great deal of patriotic pathos, had equipped a privateer immediately after the outbreak of war with Sweden and sent it off to raid Sweden’s west coast. This, said Christian August, had been less a patriotic act than simply ‘going to a hostile place to molest defenceless

people and rob them of their property'. In a similar vein, Frederick VI compensated Swedish fishermen who had been attacked by Danish privateers to prevent the escalation of war and violence.¹⁷

A remarkably broad segment of the population was involved in privateering. In a sense, every privateer functioned as a limited company with one or more investors, and the crews of these vessels were entitled to a share of the spoils. This tempted many people to take on privateers, not only seamen from the fleet, but also peasants and labourers. The latter flocked to coastal towns to take part in privateering expeditions, to such an extent that merchants and factory owners had difficulty in obtaining sufficient workers. This in turn increased the demand for manpower, and those who remained in their jobs did not hesitate to demand higher wages. However, the crews of privateers were also at great risk of being sunk or captured by the British. It was little consolation that the possession of a letter of marque entitled them to be treated as prisoners of war, given the wretched conditions in the British 'hulks'.

The profit from privateering appears to have been greatest during the two years between the outbreak of war in 1807 up to the late summer of 1809. Some 100 million *rix-dollars*' worth of ships and cargos were seized over the course of the war, and that is only counting official statistics. Although it is tempting to conclude by saying that the profitability of privateering was limited in the long term due to losses of men and vessels, it must be remembered that the 100 million *rix-dollars* was still an enormous sum, in spite of the decline in monetary value and inflation. In 1810, for example, Denmark-Norway's exports amounted to 14 million *rix-dollars*, while imports totalled 36 million *rix-dollars*, and that at a time when the licensed trade with Great Britain had breathed new life into Danish-Norwegian commerce.¹⁸

But the costs and the risks were considerable, not least for the crews of the vessels. Still, many citizens, seamen and fishermen took full part in this 'patriotic' piracy, where fortunes were made and lost. In southern Norway, the privateering campaign created great private wealth, but it is important to emphasise that this in the end affected relatively few people. For most Norwegians the war led only to crisis and ruin, something that in turn created tension between the few new rich and the majority of the population. This may also help to explain why some people were so violently opposed to the fortunes made by privateer owners and the luxurious consumption that they encouraged. Criticism of privateering, both then and later, was extensive in Denmark and Norway.¹⁹

The middle class, patriots and ordinary people who suffered during the hard times naturally focused most on the dissolute lives led by many

privateers, and this left its mark on how both they and posterity have judged the privateers. This, however, overlooks three things. First, if the moral distaste some people may have for whoring, drinking and excessive luxury and for brutal, state-sponsored piracy are ignored, there is no doubt that the privateers' debauchery helped keep the wheels of society turning. Their consumption created jobs not only in alehouses, breweries and brothels – where much money made from privateering was spent – but also in the protected domestic industries whose goods the privateers bought, or in whose production they invested. Furthermore, customs duties had – in theory at least – to be paid on the luxury goods that were imported.

Second, a good portion of the money for the prizes seized went to the destitute Treasury through special taxes levied on prizes, and this helps to explain why the king and government ministers did their best to promote and support this 'patriotic' piracy. Unlike the memoirs of the middle class and civil servants, who tended to condemn piracy as something unfortunate and immoral, contemporary newspapers were generally filled with apologies for privateering as a necessary and patriotic institution. This view found some echo among the populace, who regarded successful privateer captains as folk heroes taking revenge for the Bombardment of Copenhagen and for the many miseries the British had inflicted on them through their attack in 1807 and the blockade.

Third, most of the money ended up in the pockets of the backers. The backers were generally fairly well-off merchants and traders who possessed the necessary capital and were willing to take the risk of investing in the purchase of larger or smaller privateers. Some of the privateer owners ended up owning regular fleets of up to 50 smaller ships. All in all, these Danish and Norwegian backers owned about 900 vessels (600 in Denmark and 300 in Norway). They invested their earnings chiefly in industry, property and manor houses, so they put their money to work. Like everybody else in the Danish-Norwegian state, many of them were hard hit, first by the national bankruptcy and later by the peace crisis, but several of these enterprising men from the middle class became pillars of society who had medals pinned on them and were given distinguished titles. The motives of these backers can hardly be said to be state patriotism or national patriotism, even though this could have been a contributory factor, but primarily necessity. The war had brought normal trade to a standstill, so it became necessary to look to any new opportunities that presented themselves.

The privateering campaign also brought political complications with it. First, the alliance between France and Denmark-Norway gave French

privateers access to Danish-Norwegian waters and ports. The problem here was not so much that this meant competition for the Danish and Norwegian privateers, but that the French privateers were not always very particular about which ships they seized. They presented an added risk for Danish and Norwegian merchant ships and corn ships attempting to evade the British blockade. Furthermore, the privateering campaign was a delicate matter even between hostile states. While it is true that attempts were made on the part of the Danes, Norwegians and Swedes to keep the military campaign under control, it was no accident that privateering was a central issue during the peace negotiations between the two countries from the late summer of 1809 and was given a good deal of space in the final peace treaty in December. Nor was it by chance that the privateering campaign was one of the first things that King Frederick VI toned down when he realised the need for peace with Sweden at the beginning of August of the same year, while also attempting to persuade the British to ease their Norwegian blockade. Viewed in this light, privateering was a political instrument that could be used in relation to Great Britain and Sweden, which also shows that it had had an effect. In some cases Danish and Norwegian privateers had operated as far away as along the coast of Scotland, to the irritation of British merchants who, it must be said, had no qualms about equipping privateers themselves and sending them to Danish-Norwegian waters.²⁰

Privateering presented both problems and irritation for neutral ships sailing in northern European waters, so their numbers decreased as they began to avoid these waters. It was symptomatic that in the summer of 1809 an American merchant offered to take grain and other supplies to Norway in return for a guarantee that his ships would not be seized by Danish and Norwegian privateers. Neutral mercantile trade with Denmark-Norway was one of the things Frederick VI attempted to encourage when he prohibited privateering. However, not all Danes and Norwegians were enthusiastic about the introduction of this prohibition as it meant the disappearance of a potential source of income, and because the prohibition in itself was no guarantee that the British blockade would be less strictly enforced.²¹

The fact that Frederick made no noise when he re-permitted privateering in March 1810 was also evidence that its importance had waned. This was due not least to the opening up of a far more lucrative – and far less risky – licensed trade with Great Britain. This trade was carried on without the knowledge of the French privateers, who continued to hunt for prey in the English Channel and the North Sea. As long as the licensed trade with Britain continued, Norwegian shipowners and merchants realised that it

would be madness to risk arousing the wrath of the British by maintaining privateering expeditions. Furthermore, British trading licences were often offered in return for letters of safe conduct from Frederick VI for British skippers, which enabled them to sail freely and sell their goods in ports that gave access to the continental European market.²²

King Frederick's attempts to encourage privateering in the late summer of 1813, when Sweden and Great Britain had yet again joined forces against Denmark-Norway, proved to be in vain. Even though licensed trade had been suspended by the British government, and the blockade reinstated, six years of war ensured that there were in practice neither the finances nor the men to conduct another extended privateering campaign. By the very end of 1813 there were simply no active Danish and Norwegian privateers left.²³

The Double Blockade

After Trafalgar and Napoleon's subsequent sweep across continental Europe, Great Britain and France were almost incapable of threatening each other by military means. Therefore, the two antagonists were obliged to find other ways of striking out at each other. It was against this background that Napoleon issued the Berlin Decree on 21 November 1806, which in practice blocked imports of British goods to European countries under French control. This decree, as well as a number of British orders-in-council issued in 1807, firmly placed finance at the centre of the war, turning economic warfare, in the words of Paul W. Schroeder, from 'a covert, secondary, unsystematic aspect of the war' into 'a primary, central, highly organized one'. This change of focus had an effect not least on Denmark-Norway both in 1807 and during the years that followed.²⁴

In addition to obtaining military assistance to force Sweden's hand, Napoleon's primary purpose in the Danish-Norwegian alliance signed at Fontainebleau in October 1807 was to make sure that Denmark-Norway joined the Continental Blockade. He had his way when Crown Prince Frederick the same month prohibited all trade and connections with Great Britain. While this may not have been a wholehearted acceptance of the Continental Blockade as such – not least because Danish-Norwegian trade with Sweden was still possible, which at least in theory implied a way in for British goods – the prohibition was good enough for Napoleon for the time being.

The outbreak of war with Sweden in March 1808 also meant that Denmark-Norway joined the Continental Blockade in full. On 14 March,

the same day that the declaration of war was announced in Stockholm, all trade and communications with Sweden were prohibited and in the same way as with Britain, although some minor trade limitations had in the meantime already been introduced to prevent exports of military necessities such as horses from Norway. Moreover, a royal decree of 14 October 1808 considerably extended the scope of Danish-Norwegian export prohibition and made it almost total as regards food products. In this way Denmark-Norway's foreign trade was limited even further.²⁵

It could be asked why the Danish-Norwegian government took the trouble to enforce the Continental Blockade, as the state had already been blockaded by Great Britain and was incapable of importing and exporting goods by sea anyway. The answer lies first and foremost in the British presence on the island of Heligoland, which had been occupied in 1807, and, although to a considerably lesser degree, in Norway's extended border with Sweden. To all intents and purposes, Heligoland had become a warehouse for British colonial goods during the years after 1807, because the distance from there to the coast of Schleswig and Holstein was short. Furthermore, as the British were in command of the sea, it was a simple matter to smuggle large quantities of goods to ports in Schleswig and Holstein under cover of darkness and transport them from there further into continental Europe. Indeed, the British were already familiar with the ports and beaches in Schleswig following their own blockade of the Elbe, the banks of which Napoleon on his part made sure were guarded by some 300 customs men in 1806 alone, a number that would only increase in the coming years.²⁶ The duchies consequently became a smuggler's haven and, at least for a time, they made a significant hole in the Continental Blockade.²⁷

This was not to King Frederick VI's liking, however, and gave all the more reason to enforce the Continental Blockade, as Napoleon was certainly not happy with the duchies virtually serving as free ports for British goods. Napoleon's annexation of the Netherlands and the Hanseatic towns during 1810 and at the beginning of 1811 showed how far he was willing to go to enforce the blockade. The Emperor did not hesitate to use this as a warning shot to the Danish-Norwegian government, clearly with the duchies in mind. When the alliance between Denmark-Norway and France was renewed on 7 March 1812, one of its main terms was that the Danish-Norwegian government must enforce the Continental Blockade even more strictly than had hitherto been the case. Frederick VI duly complied with this demand and on 23 May he decreed a prohibition against imports of virtually every conceivable product from Britain and its colonies.²⁸

The Danish-Norwegian king also ensured stricter enforcement of the blockade from 1812 by increasing the presence of customs officers at Danish-Norwegian ports and tightening up controls in coastal towns through regular searches and raids. This in turn enraged large numbers of the inhabitants who could naturally see the connection between these interventions, the alliance with Napoleon, the Continental Blockade and their own financial ruin. There were in fact outright battles between customs officers and smugglers in the town of Bergen in Norway, even though there are also many examples that show that it was not always easy – or even desirable – for the Danish-Norwegian authorities to enforce the Continental Blockade equally strictly throughout Norway, let alone in Schleswig and Holstein.

Nevertheless, tightening up the Continental Blockade was little help in making the alliance with Napoleon – let alone the Danish-Norwegian government – more popular in the eyes of the general public. By the years 1812–13, there was no longer any enthusiasm whatsoever for Napoleonic France in the duchies and southern Jutland, where economic life had rapidly deteriorated. In Norway, too, resentment toward France and the government in Copenhagen was widespread, above all as a result of the British blockade being tightened yet again after mid-1812 and from then on implemented more vigorously than ever. A brief, but very strong, economic upswing that had lasted since the autumn of 1809 made the Norwegian recession of 1812 even harder to bear and increased general anger at the government and at the alliance with Napoleon.²⁹

However, the double blockade did not leave Denmark-Norway totally isolated for the entire duration of the war, as demonstrated by the trade licenses introduced in 1809. Nor was the double blockade a result of the Danish-Norwegian government's own willing policy, even though Frederick had been the first to forbid all trade with Great Britain and had tightened up the enforcement of the Continental Blockade. In the final analysis, Frederick VI was perhaps Napoleon's most loyal ally and even the strictest enforcer of the Continental Blockade, at least in comparison with the Emperor's other continental allies, but it was not because he was in complete agreement with Napoleon's policy and supported him wholeheartedly, as his critics have claimed. With the French in control of northern Germany, with superior French troops only a few days' march from the duchies and Jutland and with barely concealed threats from Napoleon, the king had no choice, knowing full well that even the slightest confrontation with Napoleon in matters concerning the blockade could have catastrophic consequences.

In the summer of 1810 Napoleon allowed licensed trade with Great Britain, which was regularised through his Saint-Cloud decree of 3 July. Licences were also issued for exports from the empire, something that Napoleon regarded as doubly beneficial, as they helped to sell off surpluses from the empire and drained British gold reserves, which Napoleon believed was the chief means by which Britain attracted allies.³⁰ The Trianon decree of 5 October 1810 modified the Continental Blockade even more by allowing imports of certain colonial goods hitherto prohibited. In theory this even undermined the basic idea of the blockade and may as such appear quite paradoxical. This paradox derives from the combination of Napoleon's fiscal need and wish to line French coffers as well as his wish to tighten customs surveillance in the empire. Yet, while the Trianon decree allowed for certain colonial goods to be imported, the subsequent Fontainebleau decree of 18 October did in fact toughen the blockade against British manufactured goods and was followed by a significant expansion of what has been called the 'customs terror'.³¹

'France first', as Napoleon remarked in August 1810, applied to the Continental Blockade as a whole. Although primarily aimed to strike Britain, it also promoted sales of French industrial goods for the benefit of France proper and what Michael Broers has called the 'inner empire', that is, most of the areas annexed before 1807. There was a significant economic upswing in many of these areas following their annexation to the empire, in no small part as a result of their access to the French domestic market which, in accordance with Napoleon's essentially mercantilist economic policy, was all but closed to the 'outer' empire and his allies. This was why the Trianon and Fontainebleau decrees and Napoleon's annexation of most of north Germany in 1810–11 would in the end cause great problems for Denmark-Norway and the duchies.³²

Spoils from smuggling had kept the economy in Schleswig and Holstein going after the outbreak of war in 1807, a situation in many ways similar to that of the Rhineland where smuggling across the Rhine flourished until Napoleon tightened up controls of the river in 1810. Yet, despite keeping local economies going, smuggling also had its disadvantages for the Danish-Norwegian state as it deprived the government of tax revenues, while the networks of smugglers, draft dodgers and criminals hiding and operating in the marshlands of northwestern Germany, Frisia and Schleswig-Holstein also increasingly contributed to the breakdown of morale and social stability in these areas as crime rates soared.³³

The Trianon and Fontainebleau decrees and then Napoleon's annexation of most of north Germany in December 1810 and January 1811

created major problems in the duchies. First, the decrees and their enforcement gave the kiss of death to most of the smuggling networks, not least because the Fontainebleau Decree contained draconian penalties for smuggling British goods that were not covered by the provisions of the decrees, that is, British manufactured goods in particular. This was coupled with a much higher concentration of French troops and gendarmes in north Germany, who served the double function of guarding ports and beaches and enforcing Napoleon's conscription laws. French control of the North Sea coastline was thus severely tightened, and Denmark-Norway had no choice but to follow his lead. Furthermore, the British government increasingly began to make use of Swedish ports such as Gothenburg to smuggle goods into Pomerania and Prussia, which moved the pivotal point of smuggling from the North Sea to the Baltic.³⁴

From about 1810 Heligoland therefore lost its importance as a British warehouse, which sent Schleswig and Holstein spiralling into a deep economic crisis, since it put an end to the black economy that had softened the worst effects of the war and the blockade. The Trianon and Fontainebleau decrees also had another very negative effect on the duchies as they now not only found themselves outside the French empire's customs barriers but also cut off from their traditional markets in the areas annexed to France, particularly Hamburg. In this dilemma, the alliance between Denmark-Norway and France was of no help at all as it made no mention of duty-free trade between the two partners.

Relations between the cities of Altona and Hamburg can serve as an example of how the duchies were struck by the events of late 1810 and early 1811. While smuggling of British goods from Altona to Hamburg had been both lively and creative in the years after Denmark-Norway's entry into the war – and had in practice developed into its own black economic system, which also included quite a few corrupt French civil servants and military officers – the Trianon and Fontainebleau decrees brought to Hamburg a horde of French soldiers, civil servants and customs officers who proceeded to enclose the town in an iron ring. In November 1810 alone, French officials confiscated British goods valued at more than 800,000 francs in Hamburg – plenty of which had doubtlessly come via Holstein – and some of the goods were burned outside the walls of the town as a symbolic act in full view of the inhabitants of neighbouring Altona. Furthermore, peasants from Holstein who hitherto had somehow been allowed to enter the city to sell their produce at their traditional markets in Hamburg found themselves unable to bring their hard-earned cash back across the border because all exports of money from the empire were prohibited.³⁵

The 'customs terror' introduced after the Fontainebleau decree of 1810 also had a negative effect in other ways. French customs officers and gendarmes searched everyone, including women and children, who passed through the town gates of Hamburg, which was naturally experienced as deeply offensive by the inhabitants of both Hamburg and Altona. It was, therefore, not without reason that French customs officers on the border between Altona and Hamburg were regularly assaulted, something that in turn on several occasions created crises in Danish–French relations. But the customs barrier could also have unexpected effects, such as when the inhabitants of Holstein expressed a desire for a closer attachment to France – in some cases to be actually annexed to France proper – to make it easier for them to sell their products. This was more illustrative of desperation in Holstein than of any pro-French feeling, however, as Napoleon's treatment of the inhabitants of the neighbouring town of Hamburg after the annexation of 1811 could hardly have made the prospect of French rule very tempting.³⁶

Economic Crisis and State Bankruptcy

Seen as a whole, the consequences of the double blockade were predominantly negative and in many ways outright catastrophic for Denmark-Norway – even though there were periods of economic recovery during the war years of 1807–14 while some areas certainly escaped the worst ravages of the blockade. However, the state bankruptcy in January 1813 still stands as unambiguous proof of the shattering effects of the war and the blockade on economic, political and even social life in Denmark-Norway. The loss of the fleet, the general decline in foreign trade and, not least, the ruinous cost of the war itself meant that state and private enterprises in Denmark-Norway were eventually bled dry.

Frederick VI's prohibition against all trade and communications with Great Britain in October 1807 also reflected the king's embitterment after the Bombardment of Copenhagen. But although this was shared by the merchants and citizens of Copenhagen, they were still clear-sighted enough to understand what war with Great Britain would mean in the long term. A number of merchants therefore petitioned the king shortly before he issued his prohibition against any contact with Britain at least to defer the most aggressive reactions against Britain, such as confiscating British goods, ships and property and starting a privateering campaign, until it was known for certain what the British government would do in the future. But their petition was simply ignored. There were also several merchants and citizens in

Norway who were deeply sceptical about the war with Britain, even though Norwegian support for Frederick's policy in the wake of the British attack on Copenhagen should not be underestimated. Nor did patriotism and embitterment in Norway blind people to the long-term negative consequences of war. During the winter of 1808 even the peasants in a small and remote parish near the Swedish border complained about the war with Britain, because they had neither corn nor money, while the war had brought the timber trade, vital to their living, to a complete standstill. This emphasises another aspect of the British blockade of Denmark-Norway: it dealt a hard blow to a wide range of people and was in practice a kind of warfare waged against the entire population.³⁷

Both the British blockade and the Continental Blockade were major factors in the destruction of the domestic trade cycle and the joint market in Denmark-Norway, and they virtually put an end to overseas trade. One of the worst years was 1808, which saw the Continental Blockade being enforced rigidly by King Frederick VI right across the board, while the British fleet tightened its grip on the Danish-Norwegian coasts. As early as April 1808, the British consul at Helsingborg could report to London that Danish-Norwegian commerce was to all intents and purposes non-existent. Norwegians were worst effected, as their economic survival was deeply dependent on timber exports to European – and above all, British – ports. Some 59 per cent of Norwegian timber was exported to Great Britain, counting for some 80 per cent of the total value of all timber exports combined. Total Norwegian timber exports in 1808 were reduced by over 99 per cent by comparison with 1806, the last whole year of peace. It is true that 1806 represented a peak, but this only made the reduction harder to bear two years later, even more so as more timber than ever had been prepared for export in the summer of 1807 in anticipation that the lucrative times would continue. This was nothing less than an economic catastrophe of enormous proportions, not only for the major merchants and exporters but also for the vast number of workers in their service, including the lumberjacks deep in the forests, who were suddenly deprived of work and of most of their income and, in some cases, their investments.³⁸

The British blockade also had a major impact on coastal areas, where fish exports in western and northern Norway, for instance, went into a steep decline as early as the autumn of 1807 at the beginning of what should have been the export season for salted, dried cod and stock-fish. It was no light matter to send ships out to sea, since almost all of them were seized by the British. During the autumn of 1807 alone, 553

Norwegian vessels were lost in this way. Nor was the licensed trade with Britain from 1809 particularly lucrative for the Norwegian fishing industry, which was vital to economic life in many coastal areas in western and northern Norway. In peacetime most fish exports had gone to the continent and the Iberian peninsula, but, while the British did buy timber from Norway under license from 1809, the British had no intention of allowing licenses to supply Napoleon's empire with fish.

The economic consequences of the war and the blockades were exacerbated by the fact that, in the absence of banks or other suitable credit institutions, Norwegian merchants had little or no capital reserves. Broadly speaking, this meant that the flow of money went out of Norway, which led to cash shortages even in peacetime while purchases and investments were mainly done via credit. This was a major reason why Norwegian merchants, whose fortunes were mostly based on property rather than capital reserves, had argued for decades that Norway was in dire need of a bank of its own.³⁹ Indeed, after the outbreak of war, a relatively well-to-do merchant in the city of Trondheim noted with astonishment that he was all but unable to obtain cash. Moreover, many merchants who were owed substantial amounts in Great Britain discovered that their dues had been confiscated by the British government at the outbreak of war. This not only drained their cash reserves severely but also left them with reduced creditworthiness. Norwegian businessmen normally drew bills on private banks in Copenhagen, Hamburg, Amsterdam and London, but the war had made this impossible, 'because', one merchant noted, 'when nothing is exported, nothing can be withdrawn from the banks there'.⁴⁰

This created serious liquidity problems for most Norwegian merchants in addition to the lack of hard cash. Peder Anker, the most influential and richest merchant in Norway, only narrowly escaped bankruptcy in the autumn of 1808 through the king's direct intervention, which took the form of a huge loan. Many Norwegian farmers, on their part, had no money to pay their taxes in the autumn of that year, which was one of the reasons why the interim government in Norway opposed a tax increase decreed by the king in the spring.⁴¹

The war with Sweden made matters even worse for Norwegians, because it brought an end to what was usually a lively trade across the Swedish border. Ironworks in the eastern parts of Norway, for example, no longer had access to pig iron and bar iron from Sweden, which was a major problem for many of them, as their production depended on it.⁴² And the knock-on effect of the war and the blockade was dire, because it meant that many workers lost their jobs and were unable to find other

work. However, not all parts of Norway were equally hard hit financially by the war and the blockade, as is shown by the income derived from privateering in a few coastal towns as well as the economic upswing in most parts of the country in the years 1809–11. Nevertheless, the overall picture was very gloomy, especially as the areas that were hit the hardest were also the most populous.

The outbreak of war and the liquidity problems in the autumn of 1807 necessitated immediate measures to cover two specific needs in Norway: cash and loans. Neither the Government Commission nor businessmen were satisfied with the time it took for the government in Copenhagen to solve these problems, however. The Copenhagen government was certainly aware of Norway's problems and needs, but the king was reluctant to leave the Government Commission with what he considered too much autonomy over the country's finances from fear of this spilling over into desire for national independence, while his financial advisers were equally reluctant to print bank notes from fear of inflation. A small credit institution was eventually established in Norway in March 1808 financed by special credit notes printed in Altona in Holstein to compensate for the lack of cash. From a Norwegian point of view, however, these measures were inadequate. The credit institution had a very conservative lending policy and at any rate the cash reserves were too meagre to cover Norwegian needs in the longer run. Irrespective of the fact that the most acute liquidity was avoided with the help of loans and the credit notes from Altona, there was a prospect of economic and financial chaos in the long term, not least due to the inflation that would unavoidably be the result of printing bank notes at a time when incomes were low.⁴³

It says much about the lack of cash in Norway during the war years that the merchant magnate Peder Anker, to conserve his own cash reserves, went so far as to pay his workers in money he had minted himself. Anker, who experienced the problems first-hand, made no bones about what he thought of the general economic situation caused by the war. In October 1808, clearly addressing the government in Copenhagen, he fulminated that when 'Norway is now deprived of its livelihood and its trade and is abused and mistreated' it 'filled every Norwegian with resentment'.⁴⁴

The situation in some other parts of the Danish-Norwegian state was not as entirely gloomy as in Norway, however. During the war years the economy even rallied in Jutland, above all because there were still markets for the province's agricultural produce. It is true that exporting corn to Norway became extremely difficult, at times even impossible,

but there was not much difficulty in finding other markets for it, chiefly in the duchies and in northern Germany. Furthermore, while agricultural produce remained a stable commodity because price rises compensated for inflation, monetary inflation made it easier for farmers in Jutland to pay their workers, pay off their debts and pay their taxes, at least as long as there was cash to go round. The many small Danish market towns also got through the war years reasonably well as their economies were closely tied to those of the farmers, but many small artisans were hit by the lack of work and the high cost of living. Ships from provincial towns chiefly plied the coasting trade or sailed to Norway, and even though the latter ran at a loss, the losses in provincial towns were far more affordable than those experienced in the capital.⁴⁵

Copenhagen was hardest hit by war and the blockade, as it lost its position as a transit port for overseas goods and for the Baltic trade. This had been a major source of freight and customs income before the war but shrank considerably after 1807. The same was also true of the capital's merchant fleet. While the fleet had carried 35,000 shiploads in 1806, this was reduced to 16,000 shiploads eight years later – which was even a substantial increase compared with the worst crisis year of 1808.⁴⁶ In its capacity as the centre of gravity of the Danish-Norwegian state, Copenhagen would be severely affected by the war, since neither trade nor the economy in the capital would return to their former levels after it ended. In many respects the position previously occupied by Copenhagen was filled by Altona and, in particular, Hamburg. The war was an economic catastrophe for Copenhagen, and it only really recovered during the second half of the nineteenth century. Its political status as the centre of a Danish-Norwegian-German mini-empire would, however, never be re-established.

The most numerous and largest-scale bankruptcies among Danish-Norwegian merchants came after the war, although by then many business houses had been on the verge of folding for many years. During the war on the other hand it was the state itself that went bankrupt, basically because, as customs and tax income dwindled, its income fell dramatically, and its expenditure – chiefly for the military – rose correspondingly. It was, of course, no help for the Danish-Norwegian state that Napoleon never honoured the vague promises of favourable loans and subsidies made in the Fontainebleau Treaty of 1807, while Frederick VI was left to foot the entire bill for the French troops' sojourn in Denmark in 1808. The extraordinary costs incurred through the planned crossing to Scania in the winter of 1809, and not least the auxiliaries he was obliged to place at Napoleon's disposal in northern Germany in 1812

and 1813, also made considerable inroads into state finances. War was expensive and the state simply had to find a way to finance it. The solution, as so often in financial crises, was to print more bank notes and levy extraordinary taxes, duties and charges. Progressive income tax was introduced in 1810, for example, and a real estate transfer tax was introduced during the same year. Stamp duty had already been increased the year before by a massive 50 per cent. Unsurprisingly, this only contributed to widespread public displeasure. The government, however, placed most faith in customs income, which was expected to follow the licensed trade that was introduced in 1809, but here a twofold problem arose. First, the major price increases meant that customs tariffs did not keep up with the real value of goods. Second, soaring inflation meant that in reality customs tariffs contributed a pittance to the state coffers, which contributed to a major reduction of state income – and this at the same time as there was an explosive growth in state expenditure.

After more than five years of war, the state treasury was empty, state incomes had almost disappeared and monetary value was at a minimum because the amount of paper money in circulation was enormous. Even small denomination coins had gradually been replaced by bank notes. An attempt to mint so-called war coins of copper was little help. Monetary value had fallen from 145 Danish *rix-dollars* for 100 *rix-dollars* at Hamburg banco in 1807 to 1680 Danish *rix-dollars* for 100 *rix-dollars* in December 1812. The monetary value of the old *rix-dollar* at the beginning of 1813 had fallen to 7 per cent of its nominal value. In this respect Denmark-Norway shared a similar fate to that of Austria, where the constant wars with Revolutionary and Napoleonic France, the disastrous defeat of 1809 and the exorbitant reparations demanded by Napoleon emptied the treasury. The response in Austria was similar to that in Denmark-Norway – more money was printed in parallel with tax increases, which led to galloping inflation and, in 1811, to state bankruptcy.⁴⁷

Denmark-Norway went bankrupt on 5 January 1813. It may not have been a bankruptcy in a strictly technical sense, insofar as the state did not end its payments or eliminate the claims of its creditors, but, when the entire Danish-Norwegian monetary system – including the duchies' own currency – was converted and a new bank was established, it amounted to a proclamation of bankruptcy. The former so-called Kurant Bank was replaced by a new national bank for Denmark-Norway and the duchies as a whole, meaning an end to the duchies' monetary independence. The monetary unit, the Danish *rix-dollar* and the silver

coin in the duchies were replaced by the new 'national bank daler'. Six *rix-dollars* were to be exchanged for one new 'national bank daler'. The monetary conversion also meant that the paper money in circulation was devalued to about 10 per cent of its face value, which in effect reduced the state's debt by 90 per cent. The government's chief aim was to control the issue of new bank notes throughout the state in an attempt to halt the inflation that had plagued the Danish-Norwegian monetary system and, not least, to introduce a unified monetary policy. The monetary conversion can therefore also be seen as part of King Frederick's unitary state policy.

Instead of using silver, which had become almost impossible to obtain, the state secured the bank note issue with a first-priority, 6 per cent mortgage on all real property in the country, which had either to be redeemed or carry interest at the rate of 6.5 per cent. The intention of taking security in real property was to create trust in the new system. The population was also asked to make loans or voluntary donations of silver to ensure an even firmer foundation for the new national bank daler. It was to little avail, however, as the war continued to make extreme demands on the state's coffers, while revenues were minimal. After only nine months, the state had spent all its cash and the quantity of silver received from the government's request for patriotic contributions was at best minimal. In a telling report, a bailiff in the southeastern part of Norway despaired at how none of his measures could persuade the populace to part with any of their silver for the new national bank.⁴⁸

Thus the printing presses were put to work again turning out bank-notes, and the little trust there might have been in the new system abruptly evaporated. By 10 September 1813, the new national bank daler was worth 8.5 per cent of its nominal value. A catastrophe for creditors could no longer be averted, and, on 14 September 1813, the government even had to prohibit debtors from repaying what they owed unless they did so in pure silver. There was also a drastic fall in the value of wages, which took still more people to the brink of personal ruin and bankruptcy – among them civil servants. The government's goal of stabilising monetary value was therefore to all intents and purposes a complete fiasco and propelled Denmark into a state of economic chaos that would continue for decades after the war ended.⁴⁹

The state bankruptcy and monetary reform were objects of much hatred in the duchies. Unlike Norway, Holstein had its own bank in Altona as well as its own currency which, at least compared with the Danish-Norwegian currency, had been relatively unaffected by

inflation during the war years. This economic autonomy, however, disappeared in 1813 with the establishment of the new national bank and the national bank daler. This in turn threw the duchies into a monetary chaos that they had been unaccustomed to and at a time when trade had already suffered badly from the effects of the Continental Blockade. Credit in Schleswig and Holstein was all but ruined, and capital began to flow to Hamburg, while high prices, inflation and the virtual cancellation of outstanding debts sent many people and businesses spiralling into bankruptcy. Moreover, many people were now left unable to pay their taxes and increasingly so as new taxes were introduced on top of the unpopular taxes introduced earlier in the war. Those still able to pay deeply resented the new ones, such as a levy imposed on capital.⁵⁰

Ultimately, the reform and taxes left many Schleswigers and Holsteiners with a sense that they were forced to pay for what was increasingly perceived as the irresponsible foreign and economic policies of the government in Copenhagen. Danish officials, on the other hand, saw no reason why the duchies should not bear their share of the economic burdens of war and indignantly labelled Schleswig-Holstein's resistance to the government's economic policies and measures as unpatriotic. Such differences in perception and mutual dissatisfaction were political dynamite and pushed public opinion in Holstein in an increasingly anti-Danish direction. It says something about the furious reactions and the opposition in the duchies that in the summer of 1813 Frederick VI was forced to back down as far as the introduction of the new national bank daler was concerned.⁵¹

People in Denmark proper were not happy either. Anonymous letters accusing the king of misusing the treasury and swindling the country, and the author of one letter threatened to 'buy a charge of gunpowder and saltpetre to blow up the king and all his royal apparatus'.⁵² Danish creditors and wage-earners were equally hard hit by the monetary conversion as the rest of the population. The state bankruptcy was also a hard and unpopular blow for Norwegians. The Norwegian priest, Claus Pavels, a state patriot, attempted to console himself with the thought that state bankruptcy and the measures on the part of the government that ensued were 'probably necessary in order to prevent what was even worse, and if it can lead to a desirable result in the future and ward off similar misery for us and our successors, we must put up with the present-day distress'. Others were not so optimistic and without mincing words characterised the monetary decree of 5 January as an 'abomination'.⁵³

The exchange rate for Danish-Norwegian currency in relation to foreign currencies fell like a stone, which was yet another blow for Norwegian foreign trade that was already hard pressed. Furthermore, prices had risen dramatically in Norway at the same time as cash continued to flow out of the country and credit was unavailable, despite an economic upturn after 1809. The state bankruptcy and the monetary decree of 5 January 1813 were not only the causes, but they exacerbated the serious economic problems Norway already had, and, as was the case in Schleswig-Holstein, irrevocably altered public opinion, shook confidence in the government in Copenhagen and increasingly led to the view of the royal power as 'Danish' and therefore as incompatible with the interests of Schleswig-Holstein or Norway. As such it mattered little that the reforms had been implemented by the government in the belief that peace was forthcoming. While peace would probably have made the reforms of 1813 more effective, it was not to come and the reforms thus only helped worsen Denmark-Norway's economic misery. Perhaps even worse, public trust in the state's finances and its financial institutions waned, if not wholly disappeared.

Patriotic Societies

The inhabitants of Denmark-Norway did not stand passively by as the economic crisis unfolded before their eyes. Nor was it the case that the crisis alone created a deep sense of dissatisfaction with the situation in general and with the government in particular. The war and the blockades made it necessary to set aside the economic liberalism that had evolved during the years before the war and to make the economy and production more self-sufficient. After the outbreak of war this resulted in the establishment of a number of national patriotic societies in various parts of Denmark-Norway, whose common aim was to strive for autarky. The practical economic effect of their activities can be discussed, but a very important point that can easily be overlooked is that they led to a development at the economic level that was clearly connected with the idea of national autonomy and unity.

In the 1890s a Danish historian wrote that the economic development after 1807 had been a return to 'government mercantilism'. This is inaccurate, however, as the initiative for the new national economy was not taken by the government but by the middle class. It was rather a question, as a Norwegian historian recently wrote, of cameralism. Cameralism was a popular concept with elite civil servants in Europe at the time, and, among other things, its goal was to replace foreign trade

with domestic production. This involved making use of a nations' raw materials, educating its population, improving methods of production and building up industry in order to create an autonomous state *or* an autonomous national economy.⁵⁴

This was partly a question of old wine in new skins for Denmark-Norway. Patriotic societies had been established in the eighteenth century throughout Europe – including Denmark-Norway – and in the United States. They worked for the best interests of their state by describing their national geography and resources and by improving agriculture, business and industry. Contrary to the recent claim of a Danish historian, Danish and Norwegian patriotic societies were characterised by a national rhetoric and clear national polar opposite identities. In other words, in contrast to earlier in the eighteenth century, after the outbreak of the Napoleonic Wars state patriotism was not the primary motive of these societies.

The first patriotic societies were already springing up in the winter of 1807–08, their chief goals being to support domestic manufacturing and damage the enemy's economy by refusing to buy British products. In Denmark, for example, the Society for National Handicrafts was founded in the winter of 1808. Its activities and discourse centred around Denmark, and its members actively promoted Danish industry with the aim of awakening a spirit of competition and 'convincing ourselves of our national merit'.⁵⁵ These exhibitions, which were a great success to begin with, applied to Denmark and not to the state as a whole, which emphasises the existence of the idea of national autonomy and unity and points in the direction of Danish national patriotism. It is true that the practical significance and effect of the societies was at best debatable, but these initiatives bear witness to an energy bound up with an identity more as a nation than as a state.

The clearest example of this development can be found in Norway. The outbreak of war and the blockades made it necessary to attempt to establish a domestic war industry, as the Norwegian army was completely dependent on imports of equipment from Denmark. The problem initially was that by and large there were no industrial plants in Norway, but field guns and cannonballs were soon being cast at a number of ironworks. However, attempts to establish factories that could supply the army with muskets, clothing and ammunition were blocked on several occasions by the government in Copenhagen. The reason frequently given was the absence of some form of realistic plan for establishing and operating such factories. But beneath the surface

of this argument lurked the recognition that autarky in itself created uncertainty about Norway's position within the state.⁵⁶

The Danish-Norwegian state was a market in which the individual areas played different roles and had a number of direct or indirect monopolies on supplies to certain areas. The hub of this system was the joint capital, Copenhagen, which enjoyed special privileges. This made Norway – and for that matter more remote parts of Denmark proper such as Jutland – peripheral, and Norway could unquestionably be described in many ways as a kind of internal colony within the state, though not necessarily any different to other, equally peripheral parts of the state.⁵⁷

Some historians, however, particularly Norwegian historians, have viewed Danish-Norwegian relations in this respect as an expression of Danish colonialism, but it would appear to be more appropriate to view the policy of the government from a state perspective, which, it is true, was very often to the advantage of the centre in Copenhagen. But the war cut off Norway from this centre, and that enabled the Government Commission and the Norwegian middle-class elite to act more independently and promote a policy that would lead to greater independence for the nation with regard to its economy and food supplies. While there were still Norwegians and people of Danish origin in Norway who felt that there should be economic independence within the framework of the state, other Norwegians increasingly thought of economic independence in purely national terms.

This is the perspective from which the Society for the Welfare of Norway, founded at the end of 1809, should be viewed, since many of its efforts involved turning Norway into a self-sufficient economic entity based on cameralistic ideas.⁵⁸ In other words, the society was an expression of the idea of national autonomy, unity and identity, linked to a Norwegian homeland. Even though it was most strongly represented in the eastern part of southern Norway, in practice it was nationwide and was not far removed from nationalism in a political sense.

Patriotic societies emerged in the duchies of Schleswig and Holstein, too. The most well known was the *Patriotische Gesellschaft* established in Altona in 1812, which, somewhat contrary to the main currents and moods in Holstein at the time, worked to strengthen relations with Denmark proper by supporting the crown and the state rather than looking to the allies or to the idea of a united Germany.⁵⁹ In essence, it based its thinking on Enlightenment rationalism, which led to a cosmopolitan stance that was necessarily devoid of the national sentiments that increasingly began to influence other circles in the duchies, including the Society for the Welfare of Norway.

Corn to Norway and Criticism of Denmark

Few things came to cause so much dissatisfaction and open criticism in Norway during the Napoleonic Wars as the perceived failure of the government in Copenhagen to supply Norway with corn. Shortly after the news of the Bombardment of Copenhagen reached Norway, Count Herman Wedel Jarlsberg went to Denmark to help organise corn supplies from Jutland and to urge the government to act rapidly. The count went to Denmark twice during the autumn of 1807 and succeeded in buying a large quantity of corn, including a considerable amount in Gothenburg in Sweden. In November, he also obtained a seat on a special commission in Christiania, known as the Provisioning Commission, which was responsible for supervising corn supplies to Norway. Furthermore, civil servants and merchants in the southern Norwegian coastal towns were also working tirelessly to obtain corn from Denmark. These relatively large amounts of corn were bought in Denmark both at private and public expense, and were stored in Jutland to be shipped across the Skagerrak to Norway. Here, however, the problems began in earnest.⁶⁰

Although the British blockade had not been so rigidly enforced in the autumn of 1807 as it would be later on in the war, sailing across the Skagerrak was precarious enough. It therefore became necessary to establish insurance and incentive schemes to encourage Danish and Norwegian shipowners and merchants to take it upon themselves to ship corn across the Skagerrak, since the Danish-Norwegian state was unable to do so itself. The question, however, was who should defray the shipping costs. The Government Commission in Norway was unwilling to promise compensation for corn ships that might be seized or sunk, as this was a public expense that should be paid by the government in Copenhagen. The Danish government, on its part, was equally hesitant to give promises that could impose major and potentially unmanageable expenses on the state. In the winter of 1807–08 a major problem was, therefore, the inability to agree on the insurance issue, which only increased the reluctance of private players to take on large-scale, risky corn shipments.⁶¹

Many people also began to question how much effort the government was putting into organising corn shipments to Norway during the winter. Norwegians naturally felt that the government should be taking the initiative to employ vessels to transport corn to Norway at its own expense and risk. Time and again, however, it was pointed out in Denmark that the shortage of vessels was the reason why more corn was not being sent to Norway at the government's expense. Understandably

enough, this did not go down well in Norway, and the desperate situation in 1808 further reinforced the criticism, especially after the debacle surrounding the plans for an invasion of Scania. Stocks of corn in the public and military granaries were already at a dangerously low level even before the Swedish invasion, and the likelihood of receiving new supplies before the crops could be harvested in July seemed remote. It is against this background that the critical corn shortage and the growing unrest in Norway during the war years of 1808–09 must be seen.

Several Norwegian historians believe that the government in Copenhagen simply did not appreciate how serious the shortages in Norway were until the summer of 1808 at the earliest, and there is a good deal of evidence to suggest they are right. The delay in establishing permanent insurance schemes and the authorities' problems in organising corn shipments between Jutland and Norway clearly show the government's irresolution as well as a lack of knowledge of conditions in Norway. But this should not be confused or equated with plain indifference, as many Norwegians then and since have tended to do. One problem was that, given King Frederick's centralist and absolutist rule, few dared to take major initiatives without the king's explicit orders. Unfortunately it was not until July 1808 that the king ordered an officer to be sent to Jutland to manage and coordinate the corn supply so it could be taken on to Norway. This was the first meaningful step that the government had taken, but the officer did not arrive in Jutland until September and it was only then that the king issued a regular order to levy approximately 648,000 bushels of corn from Danish farmers to be sent to Norway.⁶²

Furthermore, in August 1808, Count Herman Wedel Jarlsberg undertook yet another trip from Norway to Denmark. This was initially to find out what was happening in Jutland in an attempt to speed up corn shipments to Norway, and the steps the king had just taken made the date of his arrival there timely. Wedel Jarlsberg was given a seat on a newly established commission whose purpose was to function as a link between the Government Commission in Christiania and the Exchequer in Copenhagen to ensure the best possible communication and coordination between parts of the state and thereby facilitate corn shipments. But there still appeared to be more problems than solutions. There was enough corn and a sufficient number of ships in Denmark, reported Wedel Jarlsberg, but there was a lack of seamen to crew them as most sailors were serving on gunboats. The Skagerrak was also still full of British men-of-war and the light summer nights often made it easy for them to spot their prey among Danish and Norwegian vessels.

The consequence of all this was that in spite of the more targeted measures initiated by the government, only negligible quantities of corn reached Norway during the late summer and autumn of 1808. Even the postal route across the Skagerrak was completely cut off for long periods of time. In July, Christian August urged Frederick in the strongest terms to 'keep provisioning in mind, for God's sake', and the following month the Government Commission launched harsh criticism directly at the king in a lengthy report addressed to him concerning the critical extent of the shortcomings. Some corn had been transported on private initiatives, wrote the Government Commission, but the state had been responsible for none of it, and the commission even went so far as to echo what was being said by many critical voices, namely that Denmark was not doing enough. Christian August and the Government Commission could hardly have expressed their criticism in stronger terms, which is a measure of how desperate the situation had become and how dissatisfaction was growing. This is the background against which Count Wedel Jarlsberg's mounting criticism of the regime should be seen, and which gradually prompted him and several like-minded Norwegians to question the union with Denmark as a whole.⁶³

An even greater furore was caused by the Government Commission making known to the public the criticism it had addressed to the government when it became necessary to requisition corn from farmers in eastern Norway to secure supplies for the military. The requisitions were a risky measure, given the shortages among the peasants in this war-ravaged part of the country, and the Government Commission's decision to voice what amounted to open criticism of the government reflects how serious the measure was considered to be. The message to the peasants was absolutely clear: the government in Copenhagen had not been able to obtain corn, so the Norwegians would have to fend for themselves. These were strong words coming from the body that had been appointed to represent and enforce the royal power in Norway.⁶⁴

The situation would become even worse, however. Not only did the harvest fail in most parts of Norway in the autumn of 1808, but the Skagerrak and Norwegian coastal waters froze so hard during the winter of 1808–09 that hardly any ships could make the crossing, either with corn or post. In August 1808 Prince Christian August made it clear to the king that at least 800,000 bushels of corn were needed for southern Norway alone, while by the spring of 1809 only some 406,000 bushels from Denmark had made it across the Skagerrak – no more than a quarter of which had been shipped at the expense of the crown.

The quantity of corn being shipped to Norway was simply insufficient and the blame for having brought Norway to this miserable pass and for being incapable of remedying it was heaped on the government in Copenhagen and on the union with Denmark.⁶⁵

However, corn could also be shipped to Norway via the North Cape. With the help of the Danish-Norwegian envoy in St Petersburg – and at the request of the Government Commission – Frederick VI arranged for Russian corn to be bought and shipped from Arkhangelsk to Trondheim in September 1808 on board Russian and Norwegian ships. In this instance, Denmark-Norway derived some benefit from its alliance with Russia. Most of the Russian corn was hauled laboriously across the mountains from Trondheim to eastern Norway, an operation which in itself once again emphasised the gravity of the situation. Other food supplies were also sent to eastern Norway from other, less needy parts of Norway. This can to some extent be interpreted as an expression of national solidarity, although this solidarity did not always come about of its own accord.⁶⁶

The shortage of corn in Norway was undoubtedly greatest in the spring and summer of 1809 when famine ravaged parts of the country following a year and a half of war, blockades and military mobilisation. The situation changed overnight, however, in August 1809, when licensed trade with Britain was permitted. Norwegian ships sailed from port carrying cargos of timber and returned with corn. Between 1 September 1809 and 1 September 1810, no less than 1.15 million bushels of corn were imported into Norway – both from Danish and other ports – followed by another million bushels between September 1810 and September 1812. For the time being this brought an end to the most acute corn shortages.

Still, prices were high. For example, one observer concluded in March 1810 that even though 'there is plenty of corn for sale in Norway's market towns', inflation meant that 'farmers would not sell their domestic produce at less than three or four times the normal price'. The upshot of this was that food was only available to those who were well-off enough to afford it. What was more, food was not always readily available even after the introduction of licensed trade. 'All grocery and provisions shops are empty', was the report from Christiania, which showed that consumption outstripped imports.⁶⁷

In 1811 the government in Copenhagen did introduce a system of rewards to encourage Danish and Norwegian merchants to ship corn to Norway and, not least, to depress prices. The idea was to exploit the favourable economic conditions brought about by the licensed trade in

order to ensure adequate corn supplies to Norway by stimulating these shipments instead of the more profitable business of shipping British colonial produce and industrial goods. Put simply, ships were to carry corn rather than British colonial goods, especially those that had sailed to Britain with timber and other products from Denmark-Norway.⁶⁸

In this case, too, the effect could be discussed. As the profit on the sale of colonial goods brought back from Great Britain after selling timber there during this period was broadly speaking greater than the profit from the sale of corn, it is hardly surprising that merchants and shipowners gave the former higher priority. It was therefore no accident that Norway was reputed to be awash with British colonial and industrial goods, at least until both warring parties further tightened up the blockade in 1812. The general problem was that, while immediate corn requirements were generally covered, these imports were insufficient to enable the establishment of larger stocks of corn in public and military magazines. This meant that serious deprivation was staring Norway in the face when the British yet again imposed rigorous limitations on the licensed trade from 1812, while at the same time the screw of the Continental Blockade was tightened even more by Napoleon and Frederick VI, and harvests in Norway failed catastrophically.

Famine Exploited

Conditions especially in southeastern Norway, the most populous part of the country and the main theatre of military operations in the war with Sweden, had already become extreme in the summer of 1808. In July a vicar described how 'destitution from hunger has now increased noticeably' because 'people are found lying [h]alf-dead [...] not only on roads and rocks, but also in their homes'. Even those who were generally well-off, he continued, were starving.⁶⁹ In the summer of 1809, an officer reported from a parish near the Swedish border that 'entire families are pretty much extinct'.⁷⁰

Moreover, several civil servants and vicars described how churchyards were too small for all the dead, how rotting corpses were left in view of the disgusted populace, while a vicar described how death often came as a relief to those who were starving or suffering from disease. In 1809 there were 21,391 dead in Akershus Stiftamt, the administrative entity spanning most of southeastern Norway, compared to a median of 8278 per year in the years 1803–07. In 1808 12,679 people died in Akershus Stift. The small parish of Onsøy near the city of Fredrikstad can serve as a concrete example. Here, there were 141 dead in 1809 as

opposed to 50 in 1807 and 1808, and 38 in 1810. In fact, the population in Onsøy was reduced by 6 per cent in 1809 alone. In the entire country there were 35.9 dead per 1000 in the year 1809 against a normal figure of about 20 per 1000.⁷¹

Sweden was quick to exploit the famine and misery that ravaged Norway. This, they reasoned, would force the Norwegians to surrender and to all intents and purposes place the country in the hands of Sweden. Swedish strategy towards Norway was therefore determined in no small part by the country's food shortages, although Norwegian responses did not necessarily take the forms the Swedes expected. The Swedish revolution in March 1809 was followed by renewed efforts to unite Norway with Sweden. In the late summer and autumn the Swedes made a determined effort to win and woo Norwegian hearts and minds. Peace, trade, food and constitutional rule were among the promises made to the Norwegians by Swedish propaganda, but behind them there was also a stick at hand to beat them with. The question, however, was how to use the stick.

One idea was to mercilessly starve the Norwegians and in this way virtually force them, if only from sheer desperation, to come crawling into the arms of Sweden. This would involve a very strict enforcement of the blockade in cooperation with Britain, still Sweden's ally. Another idea was to proceed in a more subtle manner, allowing trade and corn across the border only to cut it off after a while to demonstrate Norwegian dependency on Sweden and the inability of the Danish government to provide for them. At some point Sweden was to appear on the scene as angels of mercy. With this in mind corn and other commodities were stockpiled in western Swedish ports ready to be shipped to Norway.⁷²

The question of who wanted to starve Norway outright and who preferred a more lenient approach warrants some discussion. The Swedish king, for one, altogether opposed the 'system of starvation', as he came to call it, and held that military might was a far more reliable means of annexing Norway. General Gustav Mauritz Armfelt, who resumed his military command on the Norwegian border shortly after the revolution only to fall out of favour with the government in late August, argued for his part that the only workable means was to starve the Norwegians and force them to open their ports for the British and the Swedes, which he thought would inevitably separate Norway from Denmark.⁷³

Yet, in the end the major influence on Sweden's policy towards Norway in 1809 came neither from the king nor Armfelt but Georg Adlersparre – now a government minister – who, while certainly willing to make use of the stick, was all in favour of a lenient approach.

The idea of directly starving the Norwegians had little attraction for him, and he did, in fact, find himself forced to devote much energy to countering its adherents. 'In my view', he remarked, 'it would be very good if the Danish contingent in Norway began to rely on Swedish supplies, neglected other means of supply and assistance, and was later deprived of them.' Thus, when 'the inhabitants have gained a taste for it and attached some hope to it, the arrangement could be abruptly cancelled and the blame placed on Denmark', which he thought would ensure 'the greatest possible effect'. However, this was not tantamount to actually starving the Norwegians but instead would show them their dependence on Sweden and turn them against the Danes. Whilst he reluctantly agreed to a blockade of the Norwegian coast, he insisted that the Swedish border remained open. For all the unreliability of much of what Adlersparre wrote, his practical actions in this matter do reveal that he was not out to starve the Norwegians into submission.⁷⁴

Yet, there were still those in Adlersparre's closest circle that seem to have favoured a less lenient approach to the Norwegians than did Adlersparre. The historians Birger Sjøvall and Lee Sather argue that Adlersparre was less in favour of a policy of starving Norway than, for example, Count Wedel Jarlsberg, Baron Baltazar von Platen and Colonel Carl Pontus Gahn, all key figures in the conspiracies across the border in 1809. The count, Sather argues, even suggested starving Norway on his own initiative. This raises the question of whether Count Wedel Jarlsberg was, in fact, prepared to starve his countrymen for the benefit of a union with Sweden in what, at least in his eyes, would have been a patriotic act to save Norway from incompetent Danish absolutism. The count's sympathetic biographer, Yngvar Nielsen, thinks not and stresses that the count 'did not want to starve his countrymen'. Naturally, Count Wedel Jarlsberg would not have been as foolish as to leave hard evidence of such an opinion, let alone to openly display it in Norway, even more so as he was still a member of the Provisioning Commission and as such keen to avoid suspicion. Yet, when he was unexpectedly summoned to Copenhagen in February 1811 the count made sure to burn many of his private papers, which clearly shows that he had something to hide. In the light of both the king's and Adlersparre's misgivings against the 'system of starvation', it seems even more reasonable to believe that its main advocates were found elsewhere. In any event, the introduction of licensed trade with Britain in August and September soon put all thoughts of either using corn as bait or starving Norway to an end and instead forced the Swedes and Count Wedel Jarlsberg to consider other strategies and methods to unite Norway with Sweden.⁷⁵

Postwar Ruin

Essentially, the war was an economic catastrophe for Denmark-Norway, with repercussions that lasted well into the 1830s. During the years between 1816 and 1820, many Danish business houses went into liquidation. These represented a substantial proportion of Danish businesses, including most larger ones. These hard times after the war made the 'palmy days' before 1807 seem like a veritable golden age to business communities in Denmark and Norway.⁷⁶

A major contributing factor was that the business houses found it difficult to adapt to the new conditions after the war. During the war and the blockade, many of them had invested their money in goods and industry, which had flourished in what was largely a closed, protected market. After the war, however, it was impossible for industry to compete with British factories and goods, even though an attempt was made to protect the market by using customs barriers. Industry was particularly hard hit because state subsidies – which had been maintained during the war on the grounds that they were necessary to ensure supplies for the army and navy – had to be abruptly withdrawn as a consequence of the state's financial difficulties. At the same time, industry was exposed to fierce international competition. But it is worth noting that, in spite of a huge decline in what was an artificially inflated Danish industry, production was stabilised in the textile industry, for instance, at a level that was higher than before the outbreak of war in 1807. The businesses that survived were those that had invested in new machinery and rationalised production, while amateurs and speculators lost everything.⁷⁷

Landed estates proved unsaleable and were now in practice often worthless, which was a hard blow for the landowners and business houses that had invested in these properties. The international agricultural crisis also hit Denmark hard, first because the end of the war and demobilisation brought a reduction in the demand for the corn from which Jutland farmers in particular had made a good living. Second, the loss of Norway as a domestic market and the introduction of highly protectionist corn laws in Britain in 1815 preceded an even worse situation as a consequence of the international decline in prices in 1818.

The crisis in Denmark-Norway was further exacerbated as the often closely intertwined structure of Danish and Norwegian business houses led to them dragging each other down into bankruptcy. This was largely because the domestic business cycle in the Danish-Norwegian state had been broken in May 1814, when Frederick IV declared that

Norway should be regarded as a foreign country. This meant that customs duties were imposed on imports and exports between the two countries before trade was completely broken off during the war of 1814 under pressure from the great powers. When trade was resumed in the autumn, Denmark no longer had a *de facto* monopoly on corn sales to Norway, as had previously been the case despite the formal abolition of the monopoly in 1788, and it became necessary to compete on international market terms, which was a major problem. Danish corn was considered an inferior product because it was not adequately dried. The best had formerly been sold abroad, while the remainder was sent to Norway. The loss of a large share of the Norwegian market hit Danish corn merchants and farmers like a boomerang, and it was particularly hard on provincial merchants, who often had goods and money owing to them in Norway, which, as it turned out, they never saw. In this way the provinces lost a considerable share of their market, while at the same time prices fell and the number of farmers and agricultural labourers rose dramatically as demobilised soldiers gradually returned to their homes. The crisis was, if possible, even worse, then, at rural village level than it was in towns. Furthermore, corn sales to Norway had been invaluable to the Danish economy since the Norwegians paid in silver, which they had received for timber exports.⁷⁸

Silver was of decisive importance for Denmark's trade with the Orient, where it was the preferred method of payment. However, much of the overseas trade had also been lost, as the French and the Dutch had taken over many of the markets that Denmark-Norway and Great Britain had dominated during the 1790s. There was still a certain amount of trade with India, but Denmark had lost its foothold in the Chinese market. A Danish poet, who had accompanied the last Danish expedition to the Orient, described how the rich sons of Java and even Batavia's declining merchants mocked Denmark 'as a tiny, impoverished country'.

The state of affairs in the West Indies was somewhat better, at least for a while. As a well-functioning free port, the Danish colony of St Thomas became an important centre for Caribbean trade and communication after the Napoleonic Wars. In the words of one Danish historian, this had 'a certain influence on the fact that the Danish West Indies enjoyed a period with excellent financial conditions, not least because St. Thomas plied a fast growing and, as time went on, very considerable trade with Venezuela, Colombia and Panama'.⁷⁹ However, this had little knock-on effect in Copenhagen. Here, government strategy had consigned about one-third of the ships in Copenhagen to the West India trade with the intention of supplying the entire Baltic region with

colonial produce and creating an economic upturn in the capital. The strategy failed dismally, not only due to competition but because of falling sugar prices. Sugar beet had arrived in Europe, and sugar production had also begun in the East. Besides which, the Danish sugar produced in St Croix was not ideal for large-scale production. Matters were only made worse by the sugar refineries in Copenhagen being outdated technologically and unable to survive in the face of competition. Danish sugar exports fell dramatically, and soon only the domestic market was left. The number of ships sailing to the West Indies began to decline as early as 1817, and the decline continued in 1820 when the price of sugar fell to a quarter of its former levels. This resulted in bankruptcies not only among plantation owners in the Danish West Indies but also among the merchants and shipowners in Copenhagen who had invested heavily in new ships or in the West Indies trade.⁸⁰

To make matters worse, the value of money fell considerably in the wake of state bankruptcy and the peace. The decline in monetary value along with inflation had already created major problems during the war, but the problems for Denmark became more acute after 1814, when the amount of paper money in circulation, which had been calculated for the entire Danish state in 1813, was now legal tender only in the Kingdom of Denmark. As a result its value fell even further. In 1816 it corresponded to only 30 per cent of its face value, but this rose to 70 to 75 per cent a year later, while it was close to par in 1818. The discount rate also fell, and the credit market, which had been through terrible times, briefly recovered. However, the development was due to the extension of credit on foreign loans, and the consistency of the state's monetary policy meant removing as many bank notes from circulation as possible. This itself had negative consequences for the business community, but the crisis was only felt in earnest when corn prices fell in 1818, knocking out many businesses – and once again bringing down the value of paper currency – which only returned to par in 1838.

The Scope of War

While some scholars remain somehow unconvinced, most tend to agree with Clausewitz that the Revolutionary and Napoleonic Wars were 'people's wars'. David A. Bell has recently gone further, however, and referred collectively to these wars as 'the first total war'. The fusion of war and politics, Bell argues, 'drove the participants relentlessly *toward* a condition of total engagement and the abandonment of restraints'.⁸¹ Although accepted by some historians, others are less convinced by Bell's views.

Michael Broers, for example, argues that total war ‘was in the mind, and even on the drawing board, but not yet on the battlefield’.⁸²

While a definition of the concept of total war such as ‘the complete mobilization of a society’s resources to achieve the absolute destruction of an enemy, with all distinction erased between combatants and non-combatants’ is perhaps not very helpful as it is very unlikely that such an event would occur,⁸³ the distinction – or lack of it – between combatants and non-combatants is nevertheless important as far as gauging the scope and effect of war. Indeed, there can be no doubt that the distinction between combatants and non-combatants was erased in many cases during the Revolutionary and Napoleonic Wars – at least compared with what had been the case in most European wars in the latter half of the eighteenth century.

On the one hand, this was the case in parts of Spain and Italy, for example, where resistance to Napoleon took the form of guerrilla warfare and, in the eyes of French soldiers, made the entire population potential enemies. On the other hand, it also came to expression in the case of Denmark-Norway, when the British blockade made the entire population the target of warfare. Or, in other words, the entire population, and therefore the state, had to be brought to their knees and forced to break with Napoleon. This was seen at its most extreme in Norway, which was completely cut off from its foreign economic connections and, not least, from access to vital imports of food. Even though the British blockade can hardly be called a case of total war, it clearly showed how warfare could come to include non-combatants. This does not mean that the methods used by the British government to wage war on Denmark-Norway and on its overseas possessions can be regarded as completely ruthless. At the explicit wishes and orders of King George III, links and supplies to Iceland, Greenland and the Faeroes were allowed to continue during the war, albeit on the condition that all ships on route to these dependencies visited a British port to be checked and inspected.⁸⁴ The case of Norway was different, however, since it was far more closely tied to British interests – certainly as far as forcing the government in Copenhagen to surrender was concerned – so purely humanitarian considerations played a less central role in this respect. Furthermore, the famines in Norway in 1809 and 1812 could not be blamed solely on the British government. They would probably not have occurred, at least not to the same extent, had the Norwegian harvests not failed. Moreover, Great Britain permitted licensed trade with Norway at certain times during the war, which also helped to bring food supplies to Norway. There were therefore several underlying

factors that contributed to the Norwegian catastrophe, Britain's blockade policy being one of the most prominent. Yet there was one significant difference between the Norwegian blockade and the Continental Blockade: the Norwegian blockade had a direct effect on the entire population because it prevented their primary needs being met. It was a form of direct warfare against a broad segment of the population that directly countered the efforts of the Enlightenment to rationalise warfare and spare civilians as much as possible.⁸⁵

It is not surprising that resentment against Great Britain was deep and long-lasting in Denmark and Norway, but here, too, there were differences of opinion within the state. The fury against Britain in Denmark after the bombardment and the seizure of the fleet lived on, and the British were still referred to as robbers and thieves several decades after the Napoleonic Wars, the memory lasting well into the twentieth century.⁸⁶ The Norwegians, however, viewed these matters in a rather different light. Even though Norway had been hard hit by the blockade, rather paradoxically, perhaps, they did not necessarily place all the blame for their distress on the British. During the crisis years from 1812–13 there was a great deal of anger with the Swedes as contributors to the blockade, and it could even be claimed that the traditional view of Sweden as the arch-enemy was projected onto something for which the British were primarily responsible. Swedish observers also noted in 1813 and 1814 that it would be difficult to regain the friendship of the Norwegians as a consequence of their bitterness against Sweden because of the blockade. Furthermore, many Norwegian merchants had long-lasting relations with Great Britain and realised that trade with Britain was vital for their enterprises, so this could have reduced the tendency to direct their rage exclusively against the British. Instead, anger in these circles was increasingly directed against the government in Copenhagen, which was held responsible for the long war with Britain that many Norwegians felt was unnecessary and unwanted.

5

Internal Changes and External Threats, 1810–12

Respite, Discontent and Dangers

The government in Copenhagen could breathe a sigh of relief when the peace treaty between Denmark-Norway and Sweden was signed at Jönköping on 10 December 1809. Moreover, the election of Prince Christian August as the heir to the Swedish throne promised more harmonious relations between Sweden and Denmark-Norway in the future. At the same time Sweden was gravitating towards France, suggesting that the Scandinavian countries would soon find themselves on the same side of the great conflict between Napoleon and Great Britain. The licensed trade with Great Britain was also warmly welcomed by the Danish-Norwegian government, as it would help to remedy the worst effects of the war with the British. For a while, the peace with Sweden and the licensed trade provided the Danish-Norwegian state with desperately needed respite and the opportunity to heal the wounds of war as well as to breathe new life into trade and financial life across the state.

However, many problems and dangers still loomed on the horizon. The crisis in Norway in 1808–09 had sowed the seeds of discontent, which, even in times of respite such as 1810–12, was never far below the surface and could emerge again. The same was true of Schleswig and Holstein. Following the incorporation of Holstein into Denmark after the dissolution of the Holy Roman Empire in 1806, a series of reforms and changes was suggested, planned or introduced, all of which threatened or could put an end to the autonomy Holstein had previously enjoyed as a duchy bound to the Oldenburg monarchy by a union and which came on top of the economic crisis suffered as a consequence of the Continental Blockade.¹

Yet the most serious threat to Denmark-Norway was external. While Sweden's peace with France in January 1810 brought her into Napoleon's camp, Sweden was never destined to be a really faithful ally of Napoleonic France. And while Christian August's arrival in Stockholm, also in January 1810, signalled friendlier Scandinavian relations, his tenure as Crown Prince Carl (Charles) August – the name he assumed after he crossed the border – proved to be brief. He suffered a stroke and died on 28 May 1810, which caused renewed destabilisation of the political situation in Scandinavia, as his death made it necessary to settle the issue of the Swedish succession once more.

The Society for the Welfare of Norway

The Norwegians held a magnificent farewell celebration for Christian August in Christiania on 29 December 1809. The entire town was illuminated, and its prominent citizens had been invited to a dinner in the rooms of the Cathedral School in honour of the prince. On the face of it, the celebration and the dinner seemed an innocent event for an extremely popular prince who had guided Norway through two years of deep crisis and, in the eyes of many people, had saved the country from destruction. Beneath the surface of the celebration, however, there was a clear political undertone that was packed with dynamite.

Count Herman Wedel Jarlsberg's efforts earlier in the summer and autumn of 1809 to pave the way for a union of Norway and Sweden had yielded few, if any, practical results.² Wedel Jarlsberg was obliged to change his plans and strategies, but his aim remained the same: to separate Norway from Denmark and unite it with Sweden. This was the reason underlying the foundation of the Society for the Welfare of Norway as part of the farewell festivities for Christian August. All who attended the dinner received an invitation to join the society, and the response was overwhelming, some 200 prominent citizens immediately accepting it.

Once the decision had been made to set up the society at a private meeting in Christiania on 9 December 1809, Count Wedel Jarlsberg energetically opposed its official founding on 28 January, which was Frederick VI's birthday.³ Instead he wanted it to coincide with the farewell celebration for Christian August so that it would take on a completely different symbolic significance. This reflected the count's desire to link the society to a new political course for Norway under Christian August and, by implication, to a union with Sweden. Furthermore, Count Wedel Jarlsberg refused to attach the prefix 'Royal' to the name of the

society, as was the custom when establishing patriotic societies in the Danish-Norwegian state. Another departure from the usual practice was the omission of a dedication to the king in the invitation to join the society.

Wedel Jarlsberg regarded the society as a launchpad for a future national government once ties with Denmark had been severed. It comes as no surprise, then, that the outlines of liberalism and civil administration can be discerned in the way the society was organised. The society would eventually gain as many as 2652 members – or practically speaking almost the entire Norwegian political and socioeconomic elite, and the underlying idea was indeed to unite the entire country. It is no accident that the society's first task was to set to work energetically connecting Norwegian towns using new stagecoach and freight routes, in other words carrying out a national infrastructure project.

Frederick VI was far from pleased at the creation of the society. He was also warned in no uncertain terms by his brother-in-law, the Deputy Governor of Norway, Prince Frederick of Hesse, that it was a 'Jacobin' society that could 'very easily become a dangerous instrument', as it 'ignores all formality and intervenes in government department affairs'. But the king was painfully aware of the discontent rife in some circles in Norway and knew he had to tread carefully. He would run the risk of alienating virtually the entire Norwegian elite by opposing the society, something that he wished to avoid under any circumstances. Therefore, instead of banning the society outright, the king opted in the spring of 1810 to sanction and support it on condition that it be renamed the *Royal Society for the Welfare of Norway*.⁴

By then he no longer regarded it as an overly serious political threat, since communications between Denmark and Norway had been restored, the autonomy of the Government Commission had been considerably curtailed and other special Norwegian institutions established to deal with the crisis, such as a temporary Supreme Court, had been closed. Yet the Society for the Welfare of Norway was nevertheless a reminder that Norwegian loyalty to the monarch and the state could not be taken for granted. Furthermore, its cameralist belief in a self-sufficient – and therefore possibly politically independent – national economy was also a potential threat to the intricate economic system that bound the Danish-Norwegian state together.⁵

On the other hand, neither the political aspirations nor the homogeneity of the Society for the Welfare of Norway should be exaggerated. It was divided into seven branches, and while its practical dealings were not concerned mainly with politics, it is true that its central

management or *management board* could in a sense resemble a government body. Moreover, most of the 1500 or so members who had joined the society before the end of 1810 probably saw the society as little more than an all-round or state-patriotic organisation designed to promote the material interests of Norway.⁶ The real political dynamite lay where these interests were not in harmony with the wishes of the government in Copenhagen. There were two areas in particular where the interests of Norway and those of the government collided: the questions of a bank and a university. These issues generated express Norwegian national demands that the members of the Society for the Welfare of Norway generally supported.

Norwegian Demands

The failure to establish a Norwegian bank and university had been one of the prime causes of complaint among Norwegians for decades. These demands were reiterated forcefully after the outbreak of war in 1807 when Norway's isolated and desperate situation emphasised the country's helplessness. A lengthy letter from the influential merchant Jacob Aall, who held a prominent standing in Norway's elite, to Prince Christian August, dated 21 September 1809, contained an assessment of Norway's situation and a summary of the country's demands. Unsurprisingly, Norway's critical situation was a matter of discussion and Aall's letter was written at the request of Christian August. For this reason it was probably somewhat bolder than it might otherwise have been. One passage is worth quoting at length:

There are a multitude of limitations on trade, the scope of industry has been restricted in many ways, the paths of education are blocked. No bank, no free trade, no academy, few of the country's own men have been entrusted with the most important posts. Most applications arrive too late and the decisions made are often left to men with little knowledge of the country's situation. It sometimes happens that applications from the country's honourable and wealthy citizens are set aside for such a long time that the best-intentioned plans are never brought to execution.⁷

Put briefly, this was an expression of dissatisfaction with the immediate state of affairs and even with the state of the union at a more general, structural level. Aall clearly stated that something must be done and in his frustration expressed the wish that 'the Danish government [be]

more willing than it has been to listen to the complaints harboured and presented by us Norwegians'. To help remedy this, he suggested setting up a convention of 'the better part of the country's citizens' to assess the situation and present the government in Copenhagen with specific suggestions for measures to improve the situation. In essence, this was a call for some kind of a national Norwegian representative/executive body.

Aall's comments were not intended as fundamental criticism of the union *per se*. What Aall wanted first and foremost was change and reform, which he saw as preconditions for the continued existence of the union. Some Norwegian historians have called this a 'third way' between the continuation of a unionist status quo and outright secession from the union with Denmark. This third way reflected a desire for greater Norwegian autonomy, but still within the framework of a union with Denmark.⁸ Aall was not alone in his desire for autonomy and in 1809 he no doubt enjoyed the support of many of the influential merchant patriciate in eastern Norway. However, while they stopped short of demanding a separation, such complaints and demands were still unmistakable signs that all was not well within the Danish-Norwegian state, even though Wedel Jarlsberg had failed to drum up much support for his schemes in 1809.

Yet, while few were as outspoken as Count Wedel Jarlsberg, some lent their support to his views and even made them public. The priest, Peter Hount, was one of them, presenting his views in a fiery article entitled 'Norway's Just and Reasonable Wishes'.⁹ He pulled no punches in this article, which contained an explicit demand that Norway be granted a bank and a university of its own, and he also hinted that Denmark was deliberately exploiting Norway for its own purposes. Before the war and the interruption to communications between Denmark and Norway, an article such as this would have been redacted by the censor's pen. However, after 1807 something of a separate public sphere emerged in Norway and made it possible for Hount to mount his fiery criticism and to make public his demands. Nonetheless, even though the liberal Government Commission in Norway showed tolerance to public opinion during most of the war, at least compared to what was deemed acceptable in Copenhagen, Hount went far beyond what it was prepared to tolerate. However, after having considered bringing formal charges against him, the authorities backed down when they learned that Hount enjoyed widespread support.¹⁰

The demand for a university, in particular, was endorsed by the vast majority of Norway's educated elite and for this reason pursued with

much vigour by the Society for the Welfare of Norway.¹¹ However, fearful of the idea of establishing a university in Norway, the central government bodies in Copenhagen and King Frederick VI were simply not prepared to agree to it. Yet, knowing full well that the seeds of discontent had been growing in Norway and that the society had tremendous backing from the Norwegian elites, they were nonetheless cautious about openly opposing the society by rejecting its demands outright. This saved Hount from the courtroom.

In the first quarter of 1810, Frederick VI nevertheless tightened his grip on Norway and made it clear to Deputy Governor Frederick of Hesse, sent to Norway in the later summer of 1809, that Norwegian policy must to be guided by the primacy and principles of the unitary state. For this reason the king made it clear that he was not prepared to grant Norway a bank, because an independent Norwegian bank, he feared, would essentially tie itself to Britain and as such 'turn Britain into Norway's master'. A university, he suspected might become a breeding ground for separatist ideas that could fuel demands for national economic independence.¹² Yet, such ideas had already taken root in the Society for the Welfare of Norway, and the king was anxious to prevent them developing and gaining more momentum.

However, for all these reservations, the king was about to change his mind. On 28 February 1811 he suddenly ordered that preparations should be made to establish a university in Christiania, less than a year after he had rejected the idea. The ostensible reason for the king's sudden change of heart was his awareness that the demand for a university had become a national cause that was increasingly defined in terms of opposition to the government in Copenhagen. This found clear expression in 1811 when a priest, Nicolai Wergeland, wrote a prize paper on a Norwegian university in a competition mounted by the Society for the Welfare of Norway. This paper was, to say the least, a highly controversial work, as it balanced on a knife edge between extreme national patriotism and outright demands for national independence. Reactions in Denmark were anything but muted, with one reviewer fulminating against the 'morbid nationalism' of Wergeland's paper.¹³ The politically explosive nature of the demand for a Norwegian university lay, therefore, not only in the concept of national separatism that at times underlies such demands, but also in the regular conflict it could trigger between Denmark and Norway.

Public exchanges of this kind naturally made an impression on the king and the government. They also renewed King Frederick's suspicion

of Count Wedel Jarlsberg because of his overt conspiracy with the Swedes in 1809. The count found himself the object of the king's close scrutiny during the winter of 1810–11 after the turmoil generated in Sweden by the election of the new heir to the throne in the late summer of 1810. He was eventually summoned to the king's headquarters in Copenhagen in February 1811, ostensibly to be questioned about his overtures to the Swedes.¹⁴ Wedel Jarlsberg arrived in the capital only a few days later on 28 February, but was extremely surprised to learn that Frederick VI was basically appointing him to establish a university in Christiania. Nothing could have been further from the confrontation and charge of high treason he had been expecting.

A number of Danish and Norwegian historians have attributed this surprising turn of events to the fact that Wedel Jarlsberg arrived in Copenhagen so soon after he was summoned that it left the king with no time to obtain sufficient evidence against him, which forced him to use the university as a pretext for having called upon the count. While there may be something in this, there is also reason to believe that, by the time Frederick VI summoned Wedel Jarlsberg, he nevertheless had begun to sense that new crises were looming on the horizon and that measures would have to be taken to accommodate the Norwegians. And Frederick did succeed in this, at least in the short term. His decision to grant Norway a university gave cause for much celebration, and the Norwegians' gratitude was confirmed in the form of nationwide festivities following the king's decision, during which he was praised for his generosity. This reflected, and generated, strengthened loyalty and state patriotism. At the same time the university festivities had a strong national undertone and derived inspiration from revolutionary France in cultivating abstract concepts such as freedom and wisdom. The awareness that the university celebrations were nationwide created a perception of a Norwegian national community, even for some common people who attended the festivities to be fed at public expense.¹⁵ Yet, for the time being, this perception went hand in hand with loyalty to the king and the state.

However, there were also dark clouds on the horizon for the Danish-Norwegian government. Events in Sweden were among the main reasons Frederick was so anxious about Norwegian loyalty in 1811. While Frederick VI had felt it was quite certain that Charles John would further strengthen Sweden's ties with Napoleon's camp it appeared increasingly clear that the Swedish crown prince had a completely different aim which, at the beginning of 1811, would once again make Sweden the primary foreign threat to Denmark-Norway.

The First Turning Point: The Sudden Death of Crown Prince Carl August

Relations between Denmark-Norway and Sweden improved after Christian (Carl) August arrived in Stockholm on 20 January 1810 and tentatively grasped the reins of the Swedish government in the place of the ailing King Charles XIII. As the supreme authority in Norway, Christian August had showed himself to be unwilling to contribute to Adlersparre's and Wedel Jarlsberg's plans to bring about a Norwegian-Swedish union. There is also a good deal to suggest that he made it very clear to Adlersparre that he had no intention whatsoever of conducting an offensive policy towards Norway even as Swedish crown prince. This did not mean that he had given up the dreams of a Scandinavian union that had so enthused him in 1809, but as the Swedish crown prince, he wished to realise his dreams in a peaceful manner. One of the thoughts that crossed his mind was to turn over the Swedish throne to Frederick VI on his accession or to marry one of the Danish-Norwegian king's daughters. However, these hardly amounted to more than mere thoughts that he soon abandoned anyway.¹⁶

Carl August could certainly envision political change in Scandinavia in the form of the establishment of a constitutional Scandinavian union, but such change would have to be brought about through peaceful means and was hardly something he thought could be realised in the short term. At all events, none of this played a significant role. Carl August died of a stroke during a military parade in Scania on 28 May 1810, which once again created a vacuum in Swedish and Scandinavian politics, which many sought to exploit and the outcome of which would determine the course of Scandinavian politics and even history.

Carl August's death was very unexpected and at first sight even improbable. He had not yet turned 42, had a relatively healthy physical constitution and lived a simple life. As such there was no reason to expect that he would die at a young age. His untimely death caused a sensation in Sweden and Denmark-Norway alike, with the majority believing that he had been murdered as a result of the political tensions with which Sweden had come to be associated. It did not take long for rumours to emerge – albeit false ones, as subsequent investigations would prove – that the Swedish nobility was responsible for poisoning him. 'On 28 May the devilish deed was carried out, after all other attempts had failed', noted one observer in Norway in her diary, while Frederick VI dispatched a representative to Sweden to find out what had actually happened.¹⁷ Suspicions that the crown prince had been

the victim of an insidious plot concocted by aristocrats were shared by many Swedes, as was evidenced by the brutal lynching by the populace of Count Axel von Fersen – the Bourbon favourite who had joined Louis XVI on his flight to Varennes – during Carl August's funeral in Stockholm on 20 June.

The sudden and apparently mysterious death of Crown Prince Carl August soured relations between Denmark-Norway and Sweden, while the Swedes were thrown into yet another domestic political crisis. Although he had kept a low profile for most of his brief tenure as crown prince, Carl August had proved to be an acceptable and unifying figure among the various political factions in the Swedish *Riksdag*, including what was still the powerful Gustavian party that supported the hereditary rights of the deposed King Gustav IV Adolph. His death, however, triggered new conflicts about the future course of Sweden's domestic and foreign policy and, not least, about the question of succession.

The Second Turning Point: The Second Crisis of Swedish Succession

The Swedish succession crisis of 1810 – the second in only a year – marks a turning point in Scandinavian history, and its importance cannot be overestimated. Not only did it determine the course of Scandinavian politics during the years that followed right up until the twentieth century, it also provides a clear example of what is known in counterfactual history writing as decisive or open historical situations, when history could potentially have taken a completely different course.¹⁸ In the case of the issue of Swedish succession in 1810, the crisis revolved as much around those who were *not* elected as it did around the final choice, namely the French marshal Jean Baptiste Bernadotte.¹⁹ In other words, if someone other than Bernadotte had been elected – which was indeed the most likely outcome – Scandinavian history would most certainly have taken a completely different course.

It goes without saying that the question of the Swedish succession was of great interest in Denmark-Norway, both in its ramifications as regards state security and as an opportunity to exert a powerful influence on Swedish policies or even in terms of ruling the country. A key figure in these considerations was Napoleon, whose power left virtually no European government – with the exception of France's few remaining enemies – with the courage to make a decision of this importance without Napoleon's consent. While this to some extent tied Sweden's hands, it gave the Danish-Norwegian government, as Napoleon's ally, a

certain amount of influence. This made itself felt in the intense diplomatic activity, the lobbying and bribery that took place in the summer of 1810, when several candidates were proposed by Sweden, Denmark-Norway and by other elements in a battle for the acceptance of the Swedish *Riksdag* on the one hand, and Napoleon's support on the other.

Meanwhile, in Copenhagen, Frederick VI had by no means forgotten his brief candidacy to the Swedish throne during the previous year and did not hesitate to promote it once again. In Paris the Danish-Norwegian emissary was made to understand that the Emperor was not opposed to Frederick becoming a candidate. Hearing this, King Frederick began single-mindedly to promote his candidacy, using lobbying, bribery, diplomatic soundings and, finally, a personal letter to King Charles XIII to ensure he would be elected.²⁰ The problem was that the great majority of people in Sweden had no desire whatsoever to see Frederick on the throne of Sweden. Chiefly associated with despotism, reactionary stubbornness and military pedantry, Frederick was widely disliked. Napoleon's apparent endorsement of his candidacy therefore worried Swedish political circles. Consequently, the Swedish government began to look for alternatives to Frederick who would still be acceptable to Napoleon.

In the immediate aftermath of Carl August's death, one faction, which included Adlersparre and King Charles XIII, had already been considering as their preferred candidate the liberal-minded Duke Frederick Christian of Augustenburg, King Frederick's brother-in-law and a minister of the Danish-Norwegian government. The duke was the deceased Swedish Crown Prince's elder brother, and the support for his candidacy in Sweden was probably in large part due to fondness for Carl August. However, King Charles XIII was soon waxing enthusiastic about the prospect of yet another candidate, who had been suggested as a counter-move to Frederick VI's candidacy. Prince Christian Frederick, the intelligent, charming and fairly liberal-minded 24-year-old heir to the Danish-Norwegian throne, was considered by many people in Sweden – including Foreign Minister Lars von Engeström – as a preferable and more suitable candidate were Napoleon already to have reserved the Swedish throne for the Oldenburg dynasty. Frantic attempts were therefore made to convince Napoleon that Christian Frederick was a better candidate than Frederick VI, and that all arguments in favour of the Danish-Norwegian King's candidacy – dynastic and otherwise – were also applicable to his heir. Finally, a minor faction, chiefly consisting of those still in favour of the deposed dynasty, proposed Prince Gustav, the son of Gustav IV Adolph, as the rightful Swedish heir.

There is no room in this book to follow in detail the intricacies of the diplomatic intrigues that surrounded these candidates. Ultimately Napoleon – although he had minimal interest in Scandinavian affairs – favoured Duke Frederick Christian of Augustenburg, or the Prince of Denmark, as the Emperor referred to him. Frederick VI, for his part, still clung to his own candidacy, with Prince Christian Frederick as his second choice.²¹ This laid the foundation for a quarrel and, eventually, a major conflict between Duke Frederick Christian and Frederick VI, which ultimately prompted the latter to set up a naval blockade around the island of Als, where the Duke resided, to prevent him from travelling to Sweden while the *Riksdag* was convening in the town of Örebro to elect Carl August's successor. Needless to say, Duke Frederick Christian was infuriated by this, and not least because he believed that a formal offer from Sweden was, in fact, imminent. With relations between the Duke and the King already deeply soured because of the King's annexation of Holstein in 1806, their conflict over the question of the Swedish succession brought about a final breach between the two men.

However, when the Swedish *Riksdag* convened in early August, both men were left high and dry. There was a feeling in Swedish military circles that the Duke of Augustenburg's total lack of experience and interest in military matters made him unsuitable as a Swedish regent, an aspect that also appears to have been decisive in sowing doubt in the otherwise sympathetically inclined King Charles XIII. The same considerations applied to Prince Christian Frederick, who had hardly any military experience worth mentioning either. After all, many Swedes had reconquest of Finland in mind. This led a number of Swedish officers to start thinking of alternatives who were better qualified from a military point of view as successors to the Danish-Norwegian throne, and who would nevertheless be acceptable to Napoleon. One of these officers looking for alternatives was a young lieutenant, Otto Mörner, who in June had been sent as the official emissary to Paris to hear Napoleon's opinion.²²

Having arrived in Paris, the undoubtedly fearless lieutenant flagrantly exceeded his authority initially by paying a visit to Marshal Jean-Baptiste Bernadotte and then exceeded it further when he as good as offered him the Swedish throne if Bernadotte – and Napoleon – were willing. Bernadotte was given the impression that the *Riksdag* was determined to elect a French candidate regardless, which only added incentive for the marshal as he was falling out of favour with Napoleon as a military commander. So, parallel to the tug-of-war between Frederick Christian and Frederick VI, Bernadotte began working behind the

scenes to secure his own election even before the *Riksdag* in Sweden was aware of his candidacy. Napoleon, who had recently voiced his support for Frederick Christian, remained vague and non-committal, which Bernadotte exploited to give the Swedes the firm impression that he was the Emperor's preferred candidate. Bernadotte immediately launched what amounted to a PR campaign targeting Swedish *Riksdag* deputies, which included frequent references not only to his military record, but also to his vast personal fortune, which would enable him to offer generous loans to Sweden's exhausted treasury at a low rate of interest. The marshal's financial standing also allowed him to use bribes and rewards to win support for his candidacy. So, even though the young Lieutenant Mörner's activities in Paris had initially been ill received in Stockholm, particularly by the king, and actually led to his imprisonment on his return, they did also bring about Bernadotte's election as crown prince of Sweden by the *Riksdag* on 21 August.

This was, to put it mildly, a highly improbable outcome to the second Swedish succession crisis. In fact, most contemporary observers were astonished at the *Riksdag*'s choice, not least King Frederick, who could not understand how the Swedish throne had slipped out of his dynasty's hands. But Bernadotte had three main advantages over his opponents: he was *believed* to have Napoleon's endorsement, he had a proven military record and he possessed the financial means that enabled him to tip the balance in his favour. Furthermore, his revolutionary and Napoleonic background put him on an equal footing with the liberal-leaning Duke Frederick Christian and Prince Christian Frederick, and was in stark contrast to the absolutism of Frederick VI, who for all his efforts was unable to convince the Swedes that he would respect their constitution, laws, political culture and territorial integrity.

Nevertheless the key factor had been Napoleon, an indication of the influence the French emperor had even in matters that were at best of secondary importance to him and on which he exerted little direct pressure. In fact, in the case of the second Swedish succession crisis, it was basically a matter of *interpreting* the alleged wishes of the Emperor. It is no exaggeration to assume that if Napoleon had given his unambiguous, firm and explicit support to one of the candidates, that candidate would have been elected. Niels Rosenkrantz, the new Danish-Norwegian foreign minister who had assumed office during the crisis, therefore bitterly lamented that his predecessor and Frederick VI had not done more to secure Napoleon's direct support for a Danish-Norwegian candidate. Rosenkrantz's irritation was shared by the heir to the throne, Christian Frederick, who told the king exactly what he

felt about the matter, although in rather cautious terms. 'If one sits quietly in inactivity, one must give up any thought of unification of the kingdoms', he wrote on 13 August, and concluded, 'Unfortunately, the moment to win Sweden's crown peacefully by a vote of the Rigsdag appears to have been lost.'²³

The election of Bernadotte as Crown Prince Charles John of Sweden was a decisive turning point. Had Frederick VI or Christian Frederick been elected, the most likely outcome - sooner or later - would have been some sort of Scandinavian union. A Scandinavian union would have been less likely in the event of the election of Duke Frederick Christian, but it seems highly improbable that the Duke would have pursued the same political course as Charles John eventually did in abandoning the idea of reconquering Finland in favour of seizing Norway. Nevertheless, the election of Charles John put Swedish foreign policy far beyond the influence of the Danish-Norwegian government. Moreover, with the election of Charles John the proto-Scandinavianist ideas that the two succession crises had engendered were left dead in the water.

Proto-Scandinavianism

While he was still intending to invade Scania in February 1809, Frederick VI launched balloons to which proclamations hailing him as 'Nordic Frederick' were attached. These were sent drifting across the Sound into Scania with the aim of convincing the Swedes that they would benefit from a Scandinavian union under his rule. The problem was that Frederick VI regarded a Scandinavian union less as a kind of federal structure than as an annexation and incorporation of Sweden into the absolutist Danish-Norwegian state, which was hardly very attractive to the Swedes.

Notions of a Scandinavian union and what might well be called proto-Scandinavianist sentiments had, at least for some people, close ties to constitutionalism. Christian August had also thought along these lines and, after leaving Norway at the turn of 1809–10, went so far as to suggest that the way to ensure Norwegians' loyalty and to secure Norway for Denmark in the future was to give Norwegians political influence.²⁴ In the spring of 1809 he had also made it clear to Frederick VI that the key to the Swedish throne lay in promising a constitution 'for all of Scandinavia'.²⁵ Even the reactionary Frederick VI would eventually see how the land lay, which was why he went so far with his promises and guarantees to Sweden in 1810. However, he had no intention of introducing a constitution in his domains. As Lee Sather writes, the difference

between Frederick VI and Christian August was that Frederick 'did not regard a Scandinavian union as the ultimate goal of his foreign policy but rather as a means to his ultimate purpose, the acquisition of additional territory by Denmark'.²⁶ The propaganda for which Frederick VI was largely responsible – or that he at least sanctioned – both in 1809 and 1810 made active and quite novel use of terms like the Nordic countries and Scandinavia and gave them a dynastic-political content in line with the idea of a united Scandinavia under a single monarch.

For many people proto-Scandinavianism was above all committed to peace and political stability on the grounds that a unified Scandinavia would mean an end to centuries of Danish-Norwegian and Swedish rivalry and war. This was why the idea became so prominent in many influential circles during and after the calamities of the war of 1808–09. The prospect of Scandinavian peace and unity was the primary motive behind Prince Christian August's efforts to secure the Swedish throne for Frederick in the spring of 1809, and was the main reason why he ultimately came to accept it himself. On the one hand, the prince's stance stemmed from the realisation that the war of 1808–09 had been forced on the Scandinavian powers against their wishes and interests, and similar scenarios could be prevented in the future if Scandinavia were united under one crown. Such dynastic Scandinavianist tendencies were strengthened by the peace and by Christian August's election in 1809. Swedes were often described as a brave people in Danish-Norwegian publications after the peace at Jönköping in December the same year. War between the Scandinavian states was unnatural, as a number of writers pointed out. It is true that there had been such statements as early as 1808, but while in that context they should be understood as propaganda aimed at turning the Swedish people against their government, they were undoubtedly meant far more sincerely after 1809.²⁷

On the other hand a fragmented Scandinavia beset by internal hostilities could be highly vulnerable to Russian ambitions. Christian August was therefore desperate to avoid aiding Russian territorial conquests that would lead directly to threats against Danish-Norwegian borders. From that point on, he feared, it would only be a matter of time before Russia conquered all of Scandinavia. These fears also reflected a cultural perception in which Scandinavian culture as a whole was contrasted with the 'barbaric yoke' of Russia. Consequently, a perceived threat from Russia could help to further Scandinavian unity by creating a negative stereotype of Russia that could be fed into perceptions of a Scandinavian cultural and ethnic 'self'.

As a result more attention was now paid to common Scandinavian cultural features, and these features were frequently given prominence as arguments for a united Scandinavia. In 1809, for instance, Danish propaganda distributed in Scania contained expressions such as 'Scandinavia's borders', 'Scandinavian blood' and 'we Scandinavians', living in 'the united Scandinavia', while the similarity of the Scandinavian languages was a 'unifying factor for Scandinavian populations'.²⁸ Similar concepts and turns of phrase were used in Danish lobbying of Swedish politicians and the *Riksdag* in 1810, and they also anticipated many of the ideas that became current in Scandinavianist movement later in the nineteenth century.

In addition to large numbers of Danish poets, writers and journalists, this proto-Scandinavianism also attracted many of the key German-speaking figures in or near Danish-Norwegian government circles who, like Count Wedel Jarlsberg, may have been motivated by a desire for political reform and the introduction of a constitution. They included Prince Christian August and Finance Minister Ernst Schimmelmann, who even wrote a number of propaganda pamphlets. While it is true that a number of the arguments for proto-Scandinavianism, such as many of those made by Schimmelmann, were employed in promoting Frederick VI's candidacy for the Swedish throne, several influential thinkers, such as the Danish priest N.F.S. Grundtvig and not least Christian August, were genuinely and openly enthusiastic about common Scandinavian cultural features which, in their eyes, held the promise of future concord, harmony and peace.²⁹

If only in the longer term, the kind of dynastic union envisaged in both Danish-Norwegian and Swedish circles might have facilitated the formation of a common and distinct Scandinavian identity that could have proved stronger and more durable than the Scandinavianism that would, at least in political terms, fail in the second half of the nineteenth century. This is not to say that an election of Christian Frederick, for instance, as heir to the Swedish throne in 1810, or the survival of Carl August after 1810 would have automatically led to a politically and culturally united Scandinavia. But it seems probable that, had Christian Frederick been elected or had Carl August not died prematurely, Scandinavian history would have taken a completely different course. However, as matters stood, a new war was the almost certain outcome of the policies Charles John would pursue, causing intra-Scandinavian enmity to flare up once again and putting Scandinavianism on hold for another two decades.

The Annexation of Holstein

Duke Frederick Christian and King Frederick VI had been in disagreement about Schleswig and Holstein since 1806, when Holstein was annexed by Frederick. The duchy of Schleswig, which was roughly half-Danish and half-German, and the German duchy of Holstein constitute a very complex and complicated chapter of Danish-Norwegian and even European history. Lord Palmerston, the British statesman, reportedly sighed in 1864 that 'only three people [...] have ever really understood the Schleswig-Holstein business – the Prince Consort [Albert], who is dead – a German professor, who has gone mad – and I, who have forgotten all about it'.³⁰ The duchies made up an intricate territorial, ethnic and legal patchwork, and this made them a very delicate matter for the Danish government to handle, both in terms of domestic and foreign policy. While the most serious and pressing foreign policy problems concerning the duchies had been formally resolved in 1773 by a Danish-Russian settlement of various territorial and hereditary claims and conflicts, several potential domestic problems had still been left unresolved and would remain so until 1864.

Political, social, economic and legal order in the duchies at the turn of the nineteenth century was uneasily balanced between the king in Copenhagen's dual function as the monarch of parts of Schleswig and as Duke of Holstein on the one side, the Imperial Knights and the Holy Roman Empire (of which Holstein – unlike Schleswig – was a part) on another, and then a wide range of ancient rights and privileges in the duchies and a variety of concessions and compromises that had been arrived at because of them. This balance also relied upon a range of multi-layered and overlapping loyalties and identities. Loyalty to the Oldenburg dynasty and the state generally ran deep in the duchies, but there was also a deep sense of local attachment and orientation. However, as was the case in Norway, attachments and identities in the duchies – even if they were substantially more local in kind and scope – ran parallel to dynastic loyalty and state patriotism.

In so far as a greater sense of regionalism or a more abstract identity was felt, it was bound primarily *either* to Schleswig *or* to Holstein. The population in the duchies during the war years therefore rarely referred to themselves as 'Schleswig-Holsteiners', but rather as 'Danish Holsteiners' (in Schleswig) or 'Holsteiners'. To a certain extent this reflected the ethnic composition of the duchies. But, as a Danish

historian points out, while the Holsteiners were the first Germans the Danes would encounter whenever they travelled south, they were also a neighbour population and a border population, and thus a transitional population. For this reason the 'German' Holstein subjects of the Danish king were often regarded elsewhere in the Holy Roman Empire as half-Danish and half-German. Nevertheless, most Holsteiners could certainly perceive of themselves as Germans, though this did not stop them also regarding themselves as 'Dänen' in the sense of being subjects of the Oldenburg dynasty or citizens of the Danish state. Yet, as in Norway, problems were bound to arise once the idea of being a Holsteiner or a German was felt to be incompatible with owing loyalty to the Danish king. This was what increasingly happened after 1806.³¹

The annexation of Holstein in 1806 was motivated by several concerns, state-building and modernisation being two of them. These were not all new concerns to Frederick, however, and reforms were indeed nothing new in Holstein after 1806. Just a few years previously in his capacity as duke, Frederick had introduced a number of modernisation processes, among them a reform of the army and of tax legislation and the abolition of feudalism. This indicated a move towards state formation, consolidation and modernisation, and it was a process Frederick attempted to continue after 1806, with the outspoken aim of consolidating the Danish-Norwegian state by fully incorporating and integrating Holstein into it. In this respect, his endeavours differed little from the policies pursued by many other European governments at about the same time. However, if Holstein were to be incorporated into the Danish-Norwegian state the Holsteiners would have to relinquish their regional characteristics and identity and become 'Danish', as Holstein and its inhabitants would be placed on an equal footing with the rest of Denmark.

Foreign policy considerations also played a major role in his assessment of the situation. Holstein had been shielded by Denmark-Norway's policy of neutrality since the outbreak of the revolutionary wars and by the Prussian-led northern German neutrality zone established in 1795, but Napoleon's invasion of Hanover in 1803 had brought the Napoleonic wars to north Germany. The dissolution of the Holy Roman Empire and the creation of the Confederation of the Rhine the following August caused serious worries in Copenhagen that Prussia would seize Holstein to strengthen its strategic position and influence in north Germany vis-à-vis Napoleon. These worries seemed to be confirmed when in the late summer of 1806 Prussia suggested the creation of a northern German confederation to compensate for the

Confederation of the Rhine, which was virtually under Napoleon's control.³² As a consequence, the process of annexing and integrating Holstein into the Danish-Norwegian state was accelerated.

The process of incorporating Holstein was implemented in a number of ways. As soon as the annexation had come into force, the chancellery in Copenhagen responsible for affairs in the duchies was renamed 'The Schleswig-Holstein Chancellery' having shed its original name, the 'German Chancellery', on the grounds that the duchies no longer had any connection with Germany. Furthermore, the crown prince summoned the Cabinet and other advisers to draw up a charter formalising the annexation, but the wording of the charter was the subject of much controversy in government circles. Many ethnic Danes followed the king himself and had full annexation in mind. Most people of German origin in central government institutions, including most of the king's senior ministers such as Foreign Minister Christian Bernstorff, opposed the annexation of Holstein altogether. This faction, sometimes referred to as the 'German bureaucratic nobility', eventually succeeded in wording parts of the charter in such vague terms that much of it remained at least open to interpretation. This meant that the two different factions had quite different views of what had, in fact, been agreed. Yet, sufficient tension had been created in both camps to sow the seeds of mutual alienation.

The means used for annexing and integrating Holstein into the Danish-Norwegian state were increasingly interpreted – and resisted – by many Holsteiners who constituted something of a national anti-Danish faction, although this did not yet amount to German nationalism. Still, differences between Danes and Germans were central to the conflict. Most officials in Schleswig and Holstein were Germans. They included 3500 civil servants and 9000 teachers and priests, and for obvious reasons German was their native language. In fact, most of them were unable to write or speak Danish, except for some from certain parts of Schleswig. Therefore, the linguistic reforms introduced by Frederick following the annexation were not well received in these essentially German circles and, while they were varied in kind, they all pointed in the same direction. In 1807 the Schleswig-Holstein Chancellery, the General Customs House and the Commerce Department were instructed to issue all ordinances, patents and edicts in German *and* Danish. From 1809 all commissions were exclusively issued in Danish, while two years later the Schleswig-Holstein Chancellery and the royal departments were instructed to state whether candidates for official posts in Schleswig and Holstein mastered Danish and, if they did,

they were to be preferred. In January 1811 it was also decided that the Danish language should be used in schools, churches and in law courts in those parts of Schleswig where the majority of the population spoke Danish. Furthermore, a chair in Danish literature was established at the University of Kiel in 1811 to promote the Danish language in the duchies.³³

This certainly looked like a deliberate national chauvinist attempt to eradicate the German language in the duchies and simply replace it with Danish. But as far as Frederick and the government in Copenhagen were concerned, the chief intention of all of the reforms was to standardise the administration of Holstein and facilitate its full incorporation into the Danish-Norwegian state. This was made even clearer by the king, who remarked that he did not regard language as a symbol of culture and patriotism but as a means of creating standardisation and state uniformity. That he favoured Danish rather than the German language in these reforms was due to the fact that Danes (and Norwegians) were the ethnic majority, and probably also because – unlike his forefathers – German was not his first language and one he was not very comfortable speaking. All told, there was no great difference between the king's intentions in introducing linguistic reforms in Holstein and Joseph II's replacement of Latin with German as the language of administration in the Habsburg domains in the 1780s, which in Joseph's view was less a matter of nationality than of improving administrative efficiency.³⁴

Frederick and the government found support for their policy of Danicisation in Holstein among some segments of the public in Denmark. For nationalistically inclined Danish citizens, Holstein and the German-speaking population constituted the chief threat to the cohesion of the state. These views were in line with Frederick's intentions, but it was not the case that the majority of the Danish public agitated for the annexation or 'Danicisation' of Holstein because of their national chauvinist leanings. On the contrary, Holstein continued to be perceived by some as an essentially foreign territory united with Denmark only through the Oldenburg state. Even though most Danish schoolbooks of the period normally defined the fatherland in state-patriotic terms, this definition was not so clear-cut to all. In one schoolbook it was made quite clear that Holstein was part of Germany, while Schleswig was part of Denmark. A similar tendency could be detected in a highly respected Norwegian-born teacher who described Norway in 1806 as part of the fatherland while passing over Holstein in silence.³⁵ The general tendency in Denmark was to include Norwegians in a community based on language, culture, history and common myths of origin from which

the Holsteiners were excluded because they were different in most of these respects. Thus, the feeling of incompatibility in Denmark-Norway and Holstein was to some extent mutual.

Some Holsteiners viewed the reforms that were implemented or proposed after 1806 as signals that the government in Copenhagen was increasingly being moved by Danish national chauvinism and bent on de-Germanification and 'Danicisation' of Holstein by eradication of all of the duchy's peculiarities and cultural characteristics. This seemed to be confirmed not only by the sacking or resignation of most of the king's German-born- and speaking ministers in the years after 1806, but even more so by a series of ill-considered remarks made by the celebrated Danish author Frederik Høegh-Guldberg. Høegh-Guldberg was tutor to Princess Caroline (King Frederick's daughter) in Kiel during the years from 1805–10 and as such a part of the king's entourage. His remarks probably reflected Frederick's own opinions, then, although he might have gone rather further than the monarch had desired or intended. For Høegh-Guldberg language made the difference between 'us' and 'them', so, as far as he was concerned, the subjects of the Danish-Norwegian king were only foreigners in the places where Danish was not spoken.³⁶ This view made the language barrier the border of the fatherland and of the Danish community, a barrier that excluded Holsteiners and included Norwegians.

While enthusiastically encouraging the duchies to embrace Denmark and all things Danish, Høegh-Guldberg also remarked that the purpose of so doing was 'so that they might amount to something' and then predicted that the very name of the German people would sooner or later vanish. A speech he held at the University of Kiel on the king's birthday in January 1809 particularly displeased the Holsteiners, not only because it contained what they felt to be downright insults, but also because it was in Danish. His remarks, which appeared to be little more than expressions of national chauvinism, stirred up a great deal of resentment among many German speakers in Schleswig and Holstein, even more so in subsequent decades when German nationalists in Holstein set out to prove that the Danes were bent on eradicating all things German from the duchies.³⁷

The linguistic reforms were not the only cause of resentment in Schleswig and Holstein. Only a week after the annexation of Holstein in August 1806, Crown Prince Frederick made preparations to introduce an absolutist constitution in Holstein as well as in those parts of Schleswig that had not hitherto been directly under Danish-Norwegian rule. This would amount to the introduction of autocracy in Holstein,

which Frederick VI had officially ruled as an elected duke until the annexation. Under constitutional law the duchies had previously been kept separate from the rest of the state, because (in theory) the king did *not* rule autocratically there but ruled as a duke alongside and supported by the Imperial Knights. The introduction of absolutism in Holstein was, to say the least, controversial, especially among the nobility and the Imperial Knights, who enjoyed special rights and privileges, which they now quite rightly felt were seriously threatened. In step with the current measures to increase standardisation and improve efficiency, the Danish Chancellery had been agitating for some time for the introduction of a common code of laws throughout the Danish-Norwegian state in order to facilitate administration. The desire for uniform legislation in Denmark, Norway and Holstein at the Schleswig-Holstein Chancellery was motivated by the need for a unitary state policy. Undoubtedly modelled on Napoleon's Civil Code, the entire Danish-Norwegian-Holstein state was to be unified through a common legal system.³⁸

It is true that nothing came of this proposal – while the question of the extent to which it was made known to the public remains open – but it still indicated a process that was perceived in Holstein as a very serious threat. Holstein's distinctive constitution and code of laws were regarded as central characteristics of the duchy, which meant that the introduction of an absolutist constitution and other new laws that originated in Copenhagen was considered a threat to the Holstein identity. Already in 1806, many had opposed annexation and reforms on the grounds of Holstein's ancient rights and privileges, dynastic hereditary rights and indeed the traditional privileges of the Imperial Knights.

It is an axiom of research into nationalism that threats strengthen identities, and this is what happened in Holstein, although primarily on a regional level. Holsteinian identity was steadily strengthened and presented as a contrast to what was generally perceived and disliked as 'Danish', and through a process that witnessed class interests and regional independence taking on an increasingly articulate Holsteinian identity. A variety of concerns and interests in Holstein were channelled into an ethnic, regional and cultural way of thinking that, to many Holsteiners, amplified the implicit threat of the policies of the government.

The introduction of the absolutist constitution in Holstein also presented a cause of conflict in Frederick's inner circle, as it would mean that the duchies would become the sole hereditary territories of the Oldenburg

dynasty. This was intolerable to some. Duke Frederick Christian of Augustenburg also claimed a hereditary right to the duchies on behalf of his family and was not prepared to relinquish this in favour of the Oldenburgs. The fact that the King had introduced the absolutist constitution in Holstein without even consulting Frederick Christian beforehand made matters even worse and sent the outraged duke into a fury. Set alongside the second Swedish succession crisis of 1810, this was a major reason why Frederick Christian eventually turned his back on the king altogether and decided to live in what amounted to domestic exile in his residence until his death in June 1814. During this period he wrote a text explaining and justifying the Augustenburgs' claim to Schleswig-Holstein, which alongside the memory of Frederick Christian's conflict with Frederick VI came to play a central role in the attempts of his son, Duke Christian August of Augustenburg, to promote the secession of the duchies from Denmark in the 1840s.

Although the commission set up to investigate the constitutional implications of the full incorporation of Holstein into the Danish-Norwegian state was supposed to complete its work by 1 January 1808, Denmark-Norway's entry into the Napoleonic Wars in the autumn of 1807 brought the work to a standstill and postponed it indefinitely. Consequently, little came of plans to introduce new laws and the absolutist constitution in Holstein, although in practice Frederick came to rule Holstein in the war years as an absolute monarch. Danish laws were only introduced in the armed forces, where the introduction of Danish military laws also implied that the official language of command was changed from German to Danish.³⁹ Frederick also closed down the military academy at Rendsburg in Schleswig in 1811 in order to create a unitary officers' corps with similar training and backgrounds and to make sure that all officers from Holstein received their training in Copenhagen. They also had to learn Danish and familiarise themselves with Danish culture in accordance with Frederick's ambition to standardise his state apparatus.

The introduction of the national bank daler following the state bankruptcy of 1813 was also seen as part of the Danicisation of Holstein, even though the government's motives in introducing it were national-political considerations and pressing economic necessity. But the reactions of the Holsteiners did not always take account of the government's actual and stated intentions, which shows how easily resentment and distrust can be directed against what were clearly national and regional concerns by reinforcing or even creating a sense of 'us' and 'them'.

Resentment and Resistance in Holstein

It was not necessarily the case that all Holsteiners, as if by default, vehemently opposed the annexation itself or even all of the reforms planned or introduced. In 1801, the first Battle of Copenhagen had led many Holsteiners to express patriotic pride in being 'Dänen' and, moreover, there were Holsteiners of a rational bent who could well greet many of the reforms because they strengthened the state across ethnic divisions, improved its efficiency and, crucially, thus made it more capable of resistance to Napoleon and Prussia. Moreover, many members of the Holstein elite – not least those who occupied top official posts in Copenhagen – were bilingual and had no difficulty in using Danish as the official language of administration, although their everyday social language was German. The introduction of Danish as the language of administration therefore had little effect on them, while the ordinance that would have introduced Danish in all churches, schools and law courts in those parts of the duchies where Danish was already spoken by most of the populace was never put into practice at any rate.⁴⁰ Therefore, not too much should be read into the role of the annexation and the proposed linguistic reforms themselves for the development of anti-Danish sentiments.

Above all, anti-Danish reactions reflected what could be called a widespread *Landespatriotismus* in the duchies, which stopped short of German nationalism and was not incompatible with other identities and patriotisms.⁴¹ The dual notion of fatherland in the duchies, where Holstein was regarded as the natural fatherland and Denmark as the civic fatherland, survived the Napoleonic wars, even if affection for the Danish state cooled considerably.

As far as a German identity went, the people of Holstein had increasingly begun to emphasise their German origin in the latter half of the eighteenth century, which to some extent coincided with a measure of *Reichspatriotismus* (imperial patriotism associated with the Holy Roman Empire). In some ways, *Landespatriotismus* and *Reichspatriotismus* were mutually reinforcing in Holstein, much in the same way as in the Rhineland.⁴² Regional rights and the Holy Roman Empire, until its dissolution in 1806, protected the existing order in Holstein and served as guarantees against being incorporated into the absolute Oldenburg state – or for that matter any other major states. Moreover, German identity in Holstein was also tied to the German language. Many Holsteiners were indeed well aware that their language helped offer them career opportunities in other German states. As such it is little surprise that

some members of Holstein's intellectual elite from 1806 onwards increasingly began to feel a linguistic attachment to Germany as a cultural nation, no doubt heavily inspired by their reading of Fichte. However, this also led to the Danish language being perceived as a cultural threat.

Yet, none of this equated with German nationalism in any political sense. As far as statehood went, most were happy to accept and support the Danish-Norwegian state as their civic fatherland as long as the rights and privileges of their natural fatherland Holstein were respected. The permanent secretary of the foreign ministry, Joachim Bernstorff, may prove a case in point. While Bernstorff certainly felt a linguistic and cultural attachment to Germany, he regarded Holstein as his natural fatherland and Denmark as his civic fatherland. However, he wanted to limit the king's power in Holstein to preserve the duchy's traditional rights and – contrary to Frederick's expectations – he saw absolutely no reason to approve of the incorporation of Holstein into Denmark proper in 1806, which in his view marked the ruin of his Holstein fatherland.

The feeling of Holstein being ruined and Danicised was reinforced by the material grievances caused by the Napoleonic wars. The state bankruptcy of 1813 exacerbated the severe economic crisis that had beset Holstein ever since the implementation of the Trianon and Fontainebleau decrees just over two years earlier. The establishment of the National Bank and the currency conversion introduced in January 1813 were extremely unpopular, especially as this deprived the duchies of the economic independence from which they had previously benefited. What was more, these measures were even seen by some as a blatant attempt by the government to transfer its own economic problems to the duchies. In addition, some people linked the currency conversion with the policy of Danicisation after 1806, which gave the currency conversion an added impetus. However, as with the linguistic reforms that for the most part remained unimplemented, the currency conversion and National Bank nevertheless aroused much suspicion in Holstein as to the government's true intentions.

There was also much resentment in the duchies about Frederick's foreign policy. The war with Britain and Frederick's alliance with France were both very unpopular. The ruthlessness of the French customs officers and gendarmes was well known to most, not least the inhabitants of nearby Altona. As such it is not much of a surprise that some Holsteiners chose to vent their outrage in various fora. Anti-French statements made by Holsteiners left Frederick treading very carefully with regard to Napoleon, and already in 1807 he had been obliged to issue an edict forbidding Holstein's civil servants to show pleasure over any military

progress made by the enemies of France. The situation was not improved when the Duke of Augustenburg openly supported Austria in its war with Napoleon in 1809. Furthermore, civil servants in the duchies would often turn a blind eye to smuggling, if they were not actively involved in it.

As if to highlight the decline of state patriotism in the duchies as a result of the war, there was also indifference regarding Norway. This was clearly demonstrated in 1813, when the traditionally state-patriotic and loyal newspaper *Altonaer Mercur* made apathetic reference to the possibility that King Frederick could lose Norway. The king was furious and fulminated that in the Danish-Norwegian state there should be no noticeable distinction in the patriotic tone of articles, irrespective of whether they were published in Norwegian or German newspapers, and that he would not tolerate what he called 'pseudo Danes'.⁴³ As in Norway, the war also heightened the tendency towards fragmentation in the duchies and created more antagonism between the peripheral areas of the state and Copenhagen at its centre.

In spite of everything, Denmark-Norway's alliance with Napoleon meant that Schleswig and Holstein emerged from the Napoleonic Wars relatively unscathed – at least by comparison with Norway or other parts of Germany subjected to invasions and occupations – even though the duchies were obliged to endure a year of allied occupation from December 1813 onwards. Even then, there was no agitation of any serious extent, either against Frederick's government or in favour of the so-called German war of liberation against Napoleon. The chief desire in the duchies was to return to the old state of affairs, preferably with much autonomy in a personal union with Denmark, and above all through the re-establishment of their old administrative and judicial autonomy.

For most Holsteiners, the war strengthened local and regional identities and characteristics that they felt had been threatened both by the government's policy during the war *and* by German nationalist movements elsewhere in the German Confederation after the war.⁴⁴ It was only during the 1830s that the conflict with Denmark took on clear national overtones, but even then for many years it still had a decidedly regional core. Conversely, it was also only at this time that the conflict began increasingly to be seen in Denmark in national terms, as the separate 'Holstein' element gradually metamorphosed into a larger image of an enemy that was *German*. While this does not mean that there were no negative stereotypes of a peculiar 'Germanness' in many Danish circles before 1814 – stereotypes that were even occasionally attributed to Holsteiners – it took much longer for such concepts to become commonplace and take on any semblance of modern nationalism.

Renewed Threat from Sweden

Charles John's Norwegian policy took shape during the years from 1811 to 1812 and posed a new and very serious threat to Denmark-Norway. Many of the *Riksdag* members who had voted for Charles John in 1810 had done so with a view to reconquering Finland, a task for which the French marshal seemed well suited. However, this was not Charles John's goal. He held a firm view that Sweden would not stand a chance in a protracted conflict with Russia and that Finland could not be defended in the long run. Instead, he wanted to consolidate and strengthen Sweden by acquiring Norway, as that would then make it almost impossible to penetrate the Scandinavian peninsula and leave Sweden as the dominant Scandinavian power.

Far from cementing relations between Sweden and France, like many Swedish officers certainly wanted, Charles John's foreign policy distanced him from Napoleon and constituted an approach to Britain and Russia. Charles John's aim was on the one hand to tie Denmark-Norway's hands by obtaining British and Russian support and guarantees and, on the other, to continue the Swedish policy of conquering Norway from within by fomenting and exploiting anti-Danish and pro-Swedish sentiments. In this way, the Swedes once again set out to manipulate and exploit Norwegian identity and loyalties by playing up Norwegian misgivings towards Danish rule.

A Swedish propaganda campaign in Norway had been prepared as early as the spring of 1811, but it was temporarily abandoned as Charles John gave higher priority to his diplomatic efforts, while at the same time doing what he could to strengthen his army and secure his own standing in Sweden. His extension of conscription in 1811 proved to be tremendously unpopular, however, and led to a popular uprising in Scania. But he succeeded in extending it and in implementing a number of military reforms, which was obviously a source of concern for the Danish-Norwegian government and led to counter-measures in Norway. This also made it clear to Norwegians that a new Scandinavian conflict was in the offing.

Faced with the renewed threat from Sweden, Frederick attempted to appease the Norwegians to secure their loyalty. The university at Christiania was formally opened on 2 September 1811 and its first students were enrolled in 1813. Furthermore, Charles John's Norwegian ambition gave King Frederick VI another reason to stay loyal to Napoleon, although the military threat to Holstein and Jutland was still the main reason why Frederick was at pains to avoid war with the

emperor. However, Charles John's diplomatic manoeuvring during the build-up to what was increasingly seen as an unavoidable Franco-Russian war in 1812 further convinced Frederick VI that he was safest with the French Emperor, as he could not imagine French military failure in a conflict with Russia and Britain.⁴⁵

In Swedish historiography, Charles John's political manoeuvring during the years from 1811–12, which culminated in alliances with Russia and Britain, is known as the 'Policy of the Year 1812' and is seen as a watershed in Swedish history. Although its real significance lay in its execution rather than its novelty, it also marked a crucial departure in the history of Denmark and Norway, as it would eventually give the *coup de grâce* to the Danish-Norwegian union in 1814. At the time, it confronted Denmark-Norway with a renewed and forceful external threat that would do much to determine King Frederick's foreign and domestic policies during the years from 1812–14.

The Threat from Napoleon

Even though Sweden was an almost constant threat to Denmark-Norway during the Napoleonic Wars, it was not the chief threat as far as King Frederick was concerned. The war of 1808 had shown him that there were limits to what Sweden could accomplish against Norway even when allied with Britain, and the Danish-Norwegian king also regarded Sweden's alliance with Russia – perhaps on the basis of his own experiences of 1808 and 1809 – as of limited military value. He regarded the threat from Napoleon, however, as far more menacing and even came to regard the Emperor as invincible, although he was certainly not alone in this. Perhaps for good reasons, the king felt that failure to comply with Napoleon's terms and policies would terminate the alliance and expose Denmark-Norway to French military sanctions. The fact of the matter was that fear of a French invasion of the duchies and Jutland was one of the main reasons why Frederick had opted to throw in his lot with Napoleon.

The significance of this threat for the Danish-Norwegian government's foreign and domestic policies during the Napoleonic Wars can hardly be exaggerated, even though the degree to which Frederick allowed it to dominate these policies is open to discussion. The strong French military presence in northern Germany since 1806 and, more tellingly, Napoleon's annexation of the Hanseatic cities, were painful reminders to the Danish-Norwegian government that Napoleon could rapidly defeat the Danish army and flow into Danish territories

should Frederick decide to terminate the alliance or simply fail to comply with Napoleon's terms. In fact, whenever Napoleon was unhappy with the Danish-Norwegian government, as regards the holes it had left in the Continental Blockade in the duchies, for instance, he bluntly hinted to Frederick that it would be most favourable for France if the imperial borders were moved further north.⁴⁶

Such hints were a continuous source of concern for the Danish-Norwegian government, as shown in numerous dispatches sent to Denmark-Norway's envoys in Europe. A French occupation and possible annexation of the duchies and Jutland would cripple the Danish-Norwegian state and threaten the very existence of the monarchy. It would cut off the state from Jutland, which was Norway's vital granary, and from Holstein as one of the state's most important economic centres and the granary for Zealand. Frederick VI therefore dreaded and desperately sought to avoid such a nightmarish prospect at all costs. In the absence of a real alternative to the French alliance, or of military aid that could help him to defend his territory against Napoleon, Frederick felt that he had no choice but to stick with Napoleon and avoid provoking any conflict.⁴⁷

What would have happened if Frederick had decided to abandon Napoleon at some point after 1807 is, of course, pure conjecture. In the eyes of some historians an alliance with Britain at the cost of French occupation of the duchies and of Jutland – or at least of some kind of neutrality – would still have created major problems in terms of corn supplies to Norway, as these came mostly from Jutland. Therefore, neutrality or an alliance with Britain would probably have led to grain shortages and discontent among the Norwegians under any circumstances. How far Britain would have made an effort – or could have adequately managed – to aid Norway is an open question, but if Britain had failed to do so, the corn shortages in Norway could possibly have been just as severe as they became in the event, although this is certainly a disputed matter among historians.⁴⁸

Furthermore, it is likely that a deliberate break with Napoleon and a subsequent French invasion and annexation of Schleswig and Holstein would have generated a feeling in Jutland and the duchies that they had been abandoned by the king and government, perhaps much the same as many Norwegians actually came to feel as the war progressed. Since Jutland and the duchies collectively had a larger population than Norway, the potential for unrest would have been greater. Therefore, regardless of which side he had chosen, structural conditions would have made it impossible for Frederick VI to satisfy everyone in his dominions.

Faced with this choice between the devil and the deep blue sea, Frederick chose to remain by Napoleon's side on the grounds that the Emperor constituted the most serious threat to Denmark-Norway. Referring to the Norwegian desires for peace with Britain and for a break with Napoleon in 1813, the king sternly warned the country against 'satisfying the needs of the moment by putting itself in a position whereby it will never be able to obtain corn and food; for nature has determined that Denmark is its only larder'. It could be argued that such statements represented a desperate attempt by Frederick to give the Danish-Norwegian union a rationale. However, at least initially, his standpoint was supported by the Norwegian-born Foreign Minister, Niels Rosenkrantz, who feared France both as a friend and as an enemy. Rosenkrantz agreed that the Norwegians would starve if the French occupied the duchies and Jutland, but he was also concerned that Norway might then turn towards Britain. In that case he predicted that loyalty to the government in Copenhagen would disintegrate, since 'necessity has determined that dealings with England have become permissible for them'.⁴⁹

Frederick's decision to stay in Napoleon's camp, at least until early 1813, shows that the heartlands of his empire were his ultimate concern. Many contemporary and later historians – especially in Norway – considered this a lamentable, deliberate sacrifice of Norway to protect the centre of Denmark from the ravages of war that came to afflict the Norwegians. However, in the context of his concern for the state as a whole, Frederick's policies were reminiscent of the Austrian government's decision not to risk the dismemberment of the core areas of the Habsburg Monarchy – Austria, Bohemia and Hungary – in 1809 by supporting a prolonged and increasingly hopeless war in Tyrol.⁵⁰ Seen in this light, the accusation that King Frederick VI deliberately abandoned Norway is biased because it largely ignores the imperial context on which his decision was based, and it also obscures the fact that Norway was actually central to his policies and concerns in 1812 and 1813, even if the practical effects of this were not much to the Norwegians' liking.

On the other hand Frederick's continued alliance with Napoleon also revealed his reluctance to take risks, his inability to foresee possible political outcomes and, decisively, his increasing failure to listen to the advice he was given by his civilian ministers. There is no doubt that such failings originated, at least in part, from his personal character and views, but they probably owed most to the shortcomings of his absolutist methods. Becoming increasingly reactionary and autocratic

during the course of the Napoleonic Wars, Frederick alienated the abler members of his government and key ministers, surrounding himself mainly with less capable men from his close circle of military adjutants whose faulty judgement only compounded his own.

Frederick's Absolutism and the 'Red Feathers'

The Napoleonic Wars created a political and social state of emergency in Denmark-Norway, which also had consequences for the king's exercise of power. Having initially held fairly liberal views and been willing to take the advice of his senior ministers, Frederick became more authoritarian and self-willed after the death of Foreign Minister Andreas Peter Bernstorff in 1797. Conflicts arose between the king and some of his ministers, leading to the resignation of some, while others were removed or otherwise fell out of favour during the course of the war years. Gradually the king began to take power into his own hands and increasingly ignored his remaining ministers. By 1808 the Cabinet had already been seriously weakened and consisted of only three ministers: the foreign minister, the finance minister and the prime minister.⁵¹ After 1808 it ceased convening, which left the king to decide most matters on his own without taking formal advice from his ministers through meetings in the council.

The year 1810 saw a wave of resignations from Frederick's government, owing much to his foreign policy and conflicts over the incorporation of Holstein.⁵² By 1813 all the king's senior ministers – most of whom were German-born – were gone. The new ministers that came in their stead were generally middle-class Danes and Norwegians who, although they were generally capable men, were more in awe of the king and loath to openly challenge his decisions. Moreover, their influence was limited by the fact that the vacuum left by their predecessors had been filled by the king himself, as well as the circle of adjutants with whom he had increasingly come to be associated as Denmark-Norway was gradually drawn into the sphere of the Napoleonic Wars.

Frederick's corps of adjutants and advisers were known collectively as the 'Red Feathers', because of the red feather they were entitled to wear in their hats as members of the General Staff. As such the Red Feathers originated after the formal creation of the General Staff on 20 January 1808, which – perhaps symbolically in the light of subsequent events – was followed by the abandonment of the *Geheimstatsraad* on 19 March 1808. Their daily relations with the king – which included everything from military planning sessions and drills to games, hunting and

dinners – enabled the Red Feathers to exert increasing influence on him. Their standing was enhanced by the king's keen interest in military matters and by the immense enjoyment he derived from their company, which also contributed to their informal power.⁵³

The growing influence of the Red Feathers was considered a serious problem by the king's civilian ministers. Foreign Minister Niels Rosenkrantz lamented their influence on several occasions, especially with his growing frustration over being kept on the political margin of the king's cabinet. Civil servants, on their part, were furious at being instructed to take orders from the Red Feathers. Thanks to their relations with the king, the Red Feathers had a great deal of latitude, but this has also made it difficult to assess accurately how much power and influence they had over the king, and to uncover how many of his decisions could actually be attributed to their counsel. This did not mean that Frederick VI was simply a puppet in the hands of the General Staff; he remained fully capable of and determined to exercise his personal power autocratically, but it did influence the king's perceptions and opinions.

It was no secret to the contemporary Danish-Norwegian public that the Red Feathers enjoyed a special standing with the king and, as their influence was felt to have a detrimental effect on Danish-Norwegian policy, they were widely detested. There was also resentment of the economic benefits they appeared to enjoy at a time when other civil servants found their wages dwindling as a result of inflation. The role played by the Red Feathers in activities such as burning confiscated colonial goods was also a source of resentment, and their unpopularity was emphasised when posters abusing the king's adjutants and their arrogance began to appear on walls all over Copenhagen, reputedly hung up by members of the public.⁵⁴ These posters were probably also intended as criticism of the king himself. While few people would dare to openly criticise the king, they vented their anger instead on his closest circle of advisers, who allegedly kept the wise and just king in the dark about matters of state and prevented him making the right decisions. This indirect criticism of the king was also apparent in Norway, where a growing number of carefully worded complaints began to appear in the press and other publications.⁵⁵ Discontent with Frederick's absolutism and policies was spreading in Denmark, Norway and the duchies, and at a level that would have been unthinkable before the war.

Another cause of complaint about the king's increasingly authoritarian rule and the influence of the Red Feathers was the censorship of news and information. Not only were the civilian ministers deprived of

information about what was going on in the king's closest circles and what the Red Feathers were doing, they were also unable to obtain recent news of what was happening elsewhere in Europe. The king issued a series of censorship decrees, some of which were motivated by fear of public criticism of Napoleon and of the alliance with France. Concern that defamatory statements might also compromise Denmark-Norway's international reputation effectively prevented the reporting of international events and of French military setbacks.⁵⁶ As a result of the news censorship, a bubble of unreality seems to have formed around the king and the Red Feathers, which prevented them from acknowledging the extent of Napoleon's defeat in Russia in the autumn of 1812.

One Danish historian believes that Frederick 'lived in a strange and limited fantasy world, at whose centre was an almost childish trust in the Emperor Napoleon and a view that Austria would never dare to oppose Napoleon together with Prussia and Russia'. One contemporary observer thought more of the king but suspected that he was being kept in ignorance by his adjutants and was only fed selected news and reports that favoured Napoleon. The lack of news and information, even as late as December 1813, left several of Frederick's civilian ministers largely unaware of the extent of Napoleon's defeats and, by extension, of how precarious Denmark-Norway's situation had become. This, in turn, prevented them from offering the king much useful advice even when he eventually reconvened the *Geheimstatsraad* in December 1813 – the first since 1808 – to assess the gravity of the situation. Even Prince Christian Frederick, who was sent to Norway as governor in May 1813, complained to the king that he was not being informed of what was really going on in Europe.⁵⁷

While some administrative decentralisation was taking place in some parts of Denmark-Norway during the Napoleonic Wars, with extended administrative powers being granted to temporary bodies such as the Government Commission and the office of the governor in Norway, the overall political tendency was for power to become concentrated in King Frederick's hands. This meant that he came to rely on the advice of informal bodies such as the Red Feathers, rather than on the well-considered advice that he needed during the turmoil created by the Napoleonic Wars, the rapid succession of events and shifting alliances. But even when his civilian ministers bypassed his other advisers and tried to offer him their advice directly, Frederick was often reluctant or unwilling to listen to them.

Another consequence of Frederick's autocratic hold on power was that it became increasingly difficult for him to devote the necessary

attention and energy to the complexities of handling the entire civil and military leadership of the state. During the early years of the war, for instance, Christian August in Norway was irritated by the lack of instructions from Frederick, and this was not only due to the difficulty of communicating across the Skagerrak created by the British blockade. Frederick VI was also often vague in his communications with Deputy Governor Frederick of Hesse and seemingly incapable of specifying or implementing measures necessary for ensuring supplies to Norway. This was very much in evidence after the catastrophic failure of the harvest there in 1812, when the king's reactions were chiefly restricted to more or less non-committal lamentations and promises. As these vague expressions of sympathy and promises – however well-meant they might have been – only emphasised the inability of the king and his government to provide sufficient supplies of corn to Norway, or even to organise shipments of corn in general, frustration and resentment were bound to arise. One particular issue was King Frederick's inability to coordinate the bodies responsible for supplying Norway, while for their part these bodies were reluctant to take any independent initiatives for fear of somehow acting contrary to the king's orders and intentions. This resulted in a series of inconsistencies and contradictory measures that simply aggravated the problem of food supplies and created even more dissatisfaction among Norwegians.⁵⁸

Dawning Separatism in Norway

The Napoleonic Wars showed that Norway was in many respects able to fend for itself, even though Norwegians only fully appreciated this after 1814. In the first place, the country had faced and overcome tremendous challenges during the war years. In spite of the famine in various parts of the country and the economic ruin caused by the British blockade, the Norwegians not only survived the years of war and crisis, they were also able to ward off the Swedish invasion of 1808. This was crucial, because it left the Norwegians with the conviction that they had prevented an outright Swedish military conquest, and in turn created the feeling that they were quite capable of defending themselves by military means.

Second, Norwegians had also gained experience of political autonomy. Although the Government Commission, established in 1807, was intended as the king's executive body, it came to function in practice as the Norwegians' own government, and this could not be ignored. The Norwegian civil servants Marcus Gjøe Rosenkrantz and Herman

Wedel Jarlsberg were the leading figures in the commission, and it was no accident that, when Enevold de Falsen, a Danish-born, but pro-Norwegian, member of the commission, had to be replaced after his death in November 1808, Prince Christian August asked the king to appoint 'native Norwegians' to serve on the commission. 'Your Majesty is familiar with the character of the Norwegian nation', urged Christian August, 'but a principal feature of this character is a sense of honour, a certain national pride. A feature that bears excellent fruit and, in view of Norwegians' proven loyalty to the king and fatherland, should, in my very humble opinion, be encouraged as one of the cornerstones of our independence'.⁵⁹

This was a clear expression of the prince's conviction that Norwegians should be granted a greater degree of autonomy. His successor, Prince Frederick of Hesse, agreed and wrote a lengthy memorandum in which he proposed what amounted to a new model for the administration of Norway, which left all administrative institutions and decisions – except those relating to foreign policy and financial affairs – to Norwegians. The memorandum was probably not passed on to the king, but Frederick of Hesse left a copy with Prince Christian Frederick, who succeeded him as the king's chief representative in Norway in May 1813. In other words, the lamentations voiced by many members of the elite in Norway were echoed by the king's primary representatives in Norway during the war years.

Furthermore, Christian August, Frederick of Hesse and Christian Frederick went so far as to suggest that the only way to safeguard Norway for the Oldenburg monarchy was to somehow conclude a separate peace with Britain. Prince Christian August had suggested as much already on 17 February 1809, while Frederick of Hesse warned the king in September 1810 that 'the mood in Norway is such that the conclusion of peace with Britain is regarded as the only means of saving Norway'. Christian Frederick came to the same conclusion three years later, during Denmark-Norway's desperate situation in late 1813. Such a radical measure, he explained to King Frederick, could be justified as it was essentially the only way to secure 'the independence of this hereditary kingdom from the Swedish yoke'.⁶⁰

When such a conclusion had been arrived at and expressed directly by the king's own representatives in Norway – not least including the heir to his throne – it is no surprise that leading figures in the country had come to a similar conclusion.⁶¹ War with Britain, many Norwegians reasoned, would be so inimical to Norway's interests that it could completely destroy the country. There was such a vast difference between

the ability of Denmark to survive a war with Britain and that of Norway, especially if such a war should continue for any length of time, that even loyal civil servants in Norway could see no other possibility than some kind of separate Norwegian–British treaty. Nevertheless, proposals involving a separate Norwegian foreign policy represented an extremely radical step seen in the light of the king's domestic and foreign policies. Not surprisingly, the king always rejected such proposals from north of the Skagerrak as being completely out of the question.

Even if, at least before 1812–13, most influential Norwegians were primarily looking for a 'third way' to greater Norwegian autonomy within the Danish-Norwegian state, their desire for some kind of separate agreement with Britain reflected the obvious fact that Norwegian and Danish political and economic interests were not always identical, and in some situations were completely opposed. In January 1811, Foreign Minister Niels Rosenkrantz warned the king that 'the lack of bread is the greatest challenge a people can face'.⁶² His predictions came true a little over a year later. In the winter of 1812 the merchant Peder Anker wrote angrily that, 'Politics, Copenhagen politics, have not only destroyed our livelihood and brought starvation and ruin on us, they have now deprived us of the hope ever of experiencing happy times again.'⁶³ Like many Holsteiners, Anker felt that Norway was being treated no better by the king and his government than some overseas colony. Furthermore, in 1812 some peasants began to question whether Denmark was, in fact, able to function as the kind of 'larder' that King Frederick believed that nature had marked Denmark out to be for Norway.⁶⁴

Yet, the fact that few were thinking in terms of outright separatism makes it difficult to attribute Norway's independence later that year to a carefully planned and orchestrated separatist project developed during the preceding years by a united Norwegian elite. However, dominant socio-economic circles in Norway were adamant that something had to be done about the country's dire situation and were at best deeply frustrated by the handling of the war and ensuing crises by the government in Copenhagen. By mid to late 1813 many people had become deeply disillusioned with Danish rule, and they were certainly more inclined to the views of Wedel Jarlsberg than towards the 'third way' advocated by Jacob Aall in 1809. If national independence, with or without a loose union with Sweden, was not yet a feasible project, it was certainly not an inconceivable idea.

To add to the crisis in Danish-Norwegian relations, the increasing misgivings in Norway about what was perceived to be a lack of effort and interest on the part of the Danes aroused indignation in Denmark.

As a result resentment and dissatisfaction became mutual. There was a feeling among Danes that the Norwegians did not appreciate everything that they were, in fact, doing to help remedy their shortages. The famous Danish priest and poet, N.F.S. Grundtvig, published a poem celebrating the king's birthday in 1812 in which he lamented that the Norwegians did not seem to appreciate what the Danes had done for them in terms of culture and religion.⁶⁵ By 1812 Danish–Norwegian relations were becoming increasingly strained as a result of the crises, the economic decline and the sufferings brought about by the war. These strains were what Sweden set out to exploit.

6

Endgames 1812–13

Chained to Napoleon

By the end of December 1813, Crown Prince Charles John had King Frederick VI in a stranglehold and was prepared to deal him a final blow unless he opted to cede Norway voluntarily. The background to this dramatic turn of events was Napoleon's defeats and expulsion from Germany. Charles John was among the allied victors in the recent battle of Leipzig on 16–19 October, which had all but sealed Napoleon's fate as well as that of King Frederick, who by then was virtually the Emperor's last ally. Siding with Russia and Great Britain in 1812 had thus proven to be a master stroke by Charles John, while Frederick had clung on to Napoleon for too long, at the cost, as it would turn out, of his Norwegian kingdom.

Perhaps unsurprisingly, this has left an image of King Frederick as a devoted and affectionate ally of the Emperor from Denmark-Norway's entry into the Napoleonic Wars in 1807 almost up to Napoleon's defeat and abdication in April 1814. Their alliance was marked by Denmark-Norway's strict enforcement of the Continental Blockade – probably the strictest of all Napoleon's allies – and by the deep aversion to Great Britain largely shared by the Danish-Norwegian king and Napoleon. Furthermore, Frederick gave Napoleon a helping hand on several occasions, such as when Danish troops routed the Prussian rebel Major Ferdinand von Schill and his so-called free corps in Stralsund in October 1809. Indeed, as if to emphasise his personal affection for Napoleon, King Frederick remarked in March 1811 that he was flattered by a number of favourable comments he had recently received from Napoleon, and that he would never join a coalition against Napoleon.¹

For reasons such as these Napoleon made repeated references to King Frederick as his most faithful ally and even remarked during his exile on St Helena that he regretted not having done more to help such a loyal ally. The view of King Frederick as a loyal Napoleonic ally was shared by many contemporaries, some of whom could not bring themselves to believe that the Danish-Norwegian king remained loyal to the Emperor even after his crushing defeats in 1812–13. Many later historians, too, have come to regard Denmark-Norway's alliance with France as one based on the king's personal loyalty to Napoleon. In the words of Eli F. Heckscher, Frederick VI was Napoleon's 'sincere collaborator' – and eventually paid dearly for it.²

Such views, however, rather miss the point. Napoleon's praise of Frederick at St Helena, for example, should certainly not be taken at face value. Ultimately, King Frederick's loyal support of Napoleon was not due to unthinking devotion but because he had no option if he were to safeguard the territorial integrity of his state which, in the final analysis, only Napoleon could guarantee. This was the main difference between Frederick VI and several other European rulers who collaborated with Napoleon, such as Grand Duke Charles of Baden, King Maximilian I of Bavaria and King Frederick I of Württemberg. Unlike the Danish-Norwegian king, these monarchs were able to successfully switch sides in 1813 after securing allied pledges for the territorial integrity of their domains. And, in contrast to Charles, Maximilian and Frederick I of Württemberg, Frederick VI was sidelined by his opponents during the final struggle with Napoleon. Ultimately, King Frederick's personal failings and the shortcomings of his absolutist rule made it impossible for him to ensure he had the same level of diplomatic manoeuvrability as many other monarchs allied to Napoleon, a manoeuvrability that made it possible for them to turn their backs on Napoleon and secure a place at the victors' table.³

Napoleon's ever-present threat to the duchies and Jutland was underpinned by Frederick's recognition, and even admiration, of Napoleon's military ability, but this should not be confused with affection. This is an important distinction, because it helps explain why Frederick clung on to his Napoleonic alliance for so long. He did not do so because he had anything in the vein of personal loyalty to Napoleon but because he regarded the Emperor as invincible. The fact that this view was shared by the Red Feathers influenced discussions in the king's immediate circle and, not least, military planning activities at his headquarters.

This was why Napoleon's defeat in Russia was a major shock to the king, but even then he can be forgiven for having doubted the possibility

of success for the formidable coalition formed against France over the course of 1813, when Prussia and Austria joined the ranks of Russia, Great Britain and Sweden, given the failure of no less than five previous coalitions against France. Indeed, as Paul W. Schroeder has demonstrated, it was only with the Sixth Coalition that the major European powers managed to fully cooperate on grounds of a common goal, and even then there were many stumbling blocks along the way.⁴

Nevertheless, Frederick's failure to join the Sixth Coalition even when Napoleon's defeat seemed certain also shows up Frederick's inability to manoeuvre in the international political arena, itself largely due to his inability to grasp changes in political and diplomatic constellations, let alone anticipate them. Foreign policy for Frederick was quite a static entity and, in the words of one historian, 'problems were addressed when they emerged on his desk – but not before'.⁵ This made King Frederick miss the windows of opportunity that occasionally opened and that would have enabled him to terminate his alliance with France, most notably in 1812.

Still, there was no shortage of warnings to the king about the dangers to which an alliance with Napoleon could expose the state in the long term. As early as September 1810, the heir to the throne, Prince Christian Frederick, had advised him to break with Napoleon, even though it might lead to a French occupation of the duchies and Jutland, and in the following years he continued to urge the king to break with France before it was too late. His pleas fell on deaf ears, for the king kept him well away from government circles and, more importantly, had little faith in Christian Frederick's military evaluations and qualities. The king also continued to receive warnings from Foreign Minister Niels Rosenkrantz. Although too much may have been made of Rosenkrantz's allegedly intimate knowledge of Russia due to his marriage into the Russian nobility and to his earlier service as an envoy to St Petersburg, Rosenkrantz nevertheless demonstrated his deep insight into the connection between military operations and diplomacy on 19 September 1812, at the height of Napoleon's Russian campaign, when he told Frederick VI that he could not see how Napoleon could decisively defeat Russia.⁶

For these reasons, warned Rosenkrantz, Napoleon's occupation of Moscow meant little, as he would never be able to control all of Russia. He therefore advised Frederick to abandon Napoleon, especially as the campaign in Russia had weakened the French military presence in northern Germany. These words of warning made no impression on the king, however. Regarding a Napoleonic victory as imminent precisely because of the fall of Moscow, he replied firmly to Rosenkrantz on

20 September that he would 'continue with my system and remain allied with France, in accordance with which you must absolutely and unchangeably obey my instructions'.⁷

Seeing what appeared to be Napoleon's full control of continental Europe on the one hand and a new threat from Sweden on the other, Frederick VI had renewed his alliance with France on 7 March 1812. The new treaty involved mutual military obligations, and Napoleon made little attempt to conceal the fact that his primary aim was to ensure Danish-Norwegian support for his forthcoming Russian campaign.⁸ The Danish-Norwegian government managed to duck the obligation to provide troops for the campaign itself, but it had to place 10,000 fully equipped and supplied men at Napoleon's disposal to be used between Lake Zuider and the mouth of the River Oder in Germany. In return, Napoleon offered the struggling Danish-Norwegian state a commercial treaty and the promise of military support in the event of British or Swedish attacks. But these were hollow promises. The commercial treaty stipulated in the renewed alliance of 1812 was never honoured, while the military support offered by Napoleon was unwelcome, as the Danish-Norwegian government did not want to see French troops cross the Elbe into Holstein under any circumstances. 'No matter under what pretext French troops might cross the border', Rosenkrantz warned Frederick VI, 'the state will be destroyed, its independence completely crushed, and Denmark's connection with Norway dissolved'.⁹

Frederick VI renewed his alliance with Napoleon in 1812 under the impression of Napoleon's unlimited might. Relations between Denmark-Norway and France were not particularly warm, however. The Danish-Norwegian government had been saddled with the bill for the military collaboration of 1808 and received nothing in return for its participation in the war with Sweden. Nor had Napoleon provided financial help of any kind in spite of the promises of loans on favourable terms stipulated in the Fontainebleau Treaty of October 1807. Instead, Danish merchant ships had been detained by French customs officers in northern Germany in 1810 and only released two years later. The overzealousness of the French customs officers in Hamburg was also a constant source of friction as it dislocated traditional trade relations in Holstein. To this could be added Napoleon's repeated and quite overt threats to occupy the duchies to enforce the Continental Blockade and lack of outspoken support for Frederick VI's Swedish candidacy in 1810.

Yet, at least until the latter half or third of 1812, there seemed to be no alternative to the alliance with France. In March 1812 Napoleon's empire still covered most of mainland Europe and even though he had

parted company with Russia, Austria and Prussia were both still substantially under French influence. All things considered, breaking with Napoleon hardly seemed a realistic option for Frederick, perhaps even less so as it meant that Denmark-Norway – or what would be left of it after a French campaign – would be placed at the mercy of Britain. This was still not regarded as an option in Copenhagen in the light of Britain's onslaught on the city less than five years previously.

The Russo–Swedish Alliance

The Continental Blockade was destined to be as much of an economic disaster for Sweden as it would turn out to be for Denmark-Norway. Even after having made peace with France in January 1810 and declaring war on Britain the following November, the Swedes never really enforced it and ended up constituting a major hole in the blockade. The declaration of war on Britain was in fact chiefly for the sake of appearances, with both parties basically agreeing that it was one way to keep Napoleon at a distance from Sweden. This meant that Swedish harbours remained safe havens for British goods and smuggling, increasingly so after Napoleon tightened his grip on northern Europe from 1810–11. British smuggling activities therefore moved from the North Sea into the Baltic region, while the Danish-Norwegian government – fearing that Napoleon would set his sights on the Sound and the Baltic – chose to keep as quiet as possible about the extent of it. British goods were smuggled into Swedish Pomerania from ports in western and southern Sweden, particularly Gothenburg, until Napoleon decided that enough was enough and seized the province in January 1812. It had been returned to Sweden upon the conclusion of the Franco–Swedish peace in January 1810, but its reoccupation by French troops exactly two years later led to a decisive breach between Sweden and France.¹⁰

This development reflected a decisive geostrategic difference between Denmark-Norway and Sweden: as long as he did not have control of the sea, Napoleon could not pose a direct military threat to Sweden in the same way as he could with Denmark-Norway on land. At the same time, Sweden was territorially smaller and more coherent than the Danish-Norwegian Empire and could therefore not be threatened by Britain in the same way that Denmark-Norway was. This in turn gave the Swedish government substantially more room to manoeuvre with regard to its foreign policy, especially as Russia was also distancing itself from France. On 31 December 1810 Tsar Alexander had in practice lifted Russia's part of the Continental Blockade by allowing access to Russian

ports for neutral shipping and gradually began to align the country with Great Britain. This meant that war with France was also brewing and that the Russian government was extremely anxious for Sweden to stay out of Finland. The advantage for Russia and Sweden was that this allowed the interests of both to join in Charles John's desire to conquer Norway – which in turn increased the threat to Denmark-Norway.

Charles John's policy from 1811 was by no means plain sailing. The break with Napoleon came as a great surprise to most people. There were many admirers of Napoleon's military skills among Swedish officers, as there were in Denmark-Norway, while others favoured France because it was Sweden's traditional ally. Like in Denmark-Norway, most tended to regard Napoleon as invincible and therefore believed that a French alliance was Sweden's safest bet, even more so if Finland were to be reconquered. Even for those who had no truck with Napoleon or who regarded Finland as a lost cause in any event, there were major problems in accepting an alliance with the old arch-enemy, Russia. On this point Charles John's '1812 policy', as it would become known, constituted a substantial risk in terms of domestic policy, as he had still not consolidated his position in Sweden.¹¹ In other words, he was staking everything on the success of his foreign policy.

Sweden and Russia joined forces by signing the Treaty of St Petersburg on 5 April 1812. This was the realisation of a centuries-old nightmare in Copenhagen, as it emphatically showed that Russia no longer needed Denmark-Norway as a counterweight to Sweden and now regarded Denmark-Norway as expendable. Russia's main concern was that Sweden kept her hands off Finland and not threaten St Petersburg while the Russian army would be fighting Napoleon further to the south, and in return for this guaranteed support for a Swedish acquisition of Norway. There were also other matters at stake for Russia. As the Russian government was seeking a rapprochement with Britain, the alliance with Sweden was also intended as an overture to London.¹²

A meeting in the Finnish city of Åbo on 27 August 1812 not only confirmed the Treaty of St Petersburg but also strengthened the personal bond between Tsar Alexander and Crown Prince Charles John. At Åbo, Alexander and Charles John pledged mutual military support and in all probability also made plans for a joint Swedish-Russian attack on Zealand in order to wrest Norway from King Frederick's hands. Swedish military preparations commenced immediately, and by early September 1812 Sweden and Denmark-Norway were heading towards war.

With great confidence and unwilling to consider other options, Frederick VI had placed Denmark-Norway's fate in Napoleon's hands

in the autumn of 1812. Consequently, when in December the Emperor returned from Russia ahead of the pitiful remains of his 650,000 strong army, the corner into which Frederick had been pushed had become so tight that it would create serious problems for him in the following year when he did his utmost to escape from it.

Denmark-Norway and Napoleon's Defeat

If Frederick had in September found intelligence of the Russo-Swedish alliance to be exaggerated, its full extent became clear to him two months later when Charles John presented the Danish-Norwegian government directly with his demand for Norway. The Russian government soon followed suit and even offered Denmark-Norway a way out. In late November the Danish-Norwegian emissary to St Petersburg was told in no uncertain terms that Russia had guaranteed Sweden possession of Norway, but that the Russian government was prepared to offer Frederick VI territories in northern Germany and the Netherlands if he gave up Norway and joined the anti-Napoleonic coalition.¹³

Yet still, King Frederick was not too concerned, being blissfully unaware of the extent of Napoleon's defeat in Russia. Furthermore, conversations between the Danish-Norwegian emissary to St Petersburg and his British colleague seemed to suggest that the British government would not agree to the Swedish demands regarding Norway and would be prepared to support the Danish-Norwegian government. This appeared to signal that extending the hand of friendship to the British government could eventually lead to peace and to a way of joining the anti-Napoleonic coalition without ceding Norway as the price of membership. Even if Napoleon were defeated, Frederick believed there would be time for Denmark-Norway to find a way out. The longer it took for Russia and Sweden to fulfil their plans, the greater the chance that domestic pressure would force Charles John to switch his focus from Norway to Finland, which would in turn terminate the Russian alliance. Or so the king hoped in his continued underestimation of Charles John.¹⁴

This was nevertheless a faint hope, and Foreign Minister Rosenkrantz, whose anticipations regarding Napoleon's war with Russia seemed to be confirmed, had much more faith in the tentative peace feelers he had initiated with Britain with the king's blessing. An emissary was sent to London in January 1813, ostensibly to negotiate British licences for corn shipments to Norway but mainly to sound out the British government about the possibility of peace. Peace with Britain, it was hoped, would at least make neutrality possible, as Denmark-Norway was not yet at war

with any other of the allied powers. This latter fact also encouraged the hope that the Russian army could be kept out of northern Germany, as the government in Copenhagen quite rightly feared that a Russian takeover of the Hanseatic cities would be a direct threat to the duchies and as such a signal for the Swedish army to invade Norway. Rosenkrantz therefore suggested that Frederick should persuade Napoleon to let Danish-Norwegian troops occupy France's northern German possessions in the hope that this would prevent a Russian incursion as it would involve attacking an army with which it was not officially at war.¹⁵

In the meantime, Frederick had assured Napoleon that he was still loyal to their alliance. Napoleon's bulletin from Russia issued on 3 December made it perfectly clear that the Emperor intended to continue the war, which in turn meant that the threat to the duchies and Jutland remained. On 5 January 1813 the French emissary to Copenhagen asked Frederick to confirm his commitment to their alliance, which the king duly did. Furthermore, Napoleon assured Frederick in a personal letter that the extent of his defeat in Russia had been wildly exaggerated by the allied powers, adding, 'I still guarantee your majesty Norway' – a vow coupled with the promise that 'no-one in the world will be able to deprive your majesty of any part of your territory'.¹⁶

Territorial integrity was indeed the main reason why Frederick was still loyal to Napoleon in the winter of 1813. Yet, at the same time he was manoeuvring to broker a peace with the allies or at least to obtain a guarantee of neutrality. The main issue was Norway, and the only guarantee that the country would not have to be surrendered was coming from Napoleon, at least for the time being. True, Frederick had been offered Dutch and north German territories as compensation for Norway but he simply did not consider these Russo-Swedish proposals for territorial exchanges a viable option. This was mainly because of the geographical spread and territorial integrity of the Oldenburg monarchy and the Danish Empire. In spite of all Norwegian and Holstein suspicions to the contrary, for Frederick the Napoleonic Wars did not solely involve ensuring the well-being of the Danish heartlands, or what would become the Danish nation-state. His concern was the preservation of his empire and state in its entirety. This was the reason why retaining Norway became his *sine qua non*, but there were also other factors to take into account. Deeply conscious of dynastic and legitimist considerations, Frederick was painfully aware that it would be in breach of the absolutist constitution and as such a betrayal of his forefathers to cede any territory voluntarily. Frederick was adamant in his determination to retain the monarchy he had inherited from them.

The significance of such conservative and legitimist considerations on the part of the king can hardly be overestimated, and can be illustrated by the fact that the eventual cession of Norway in January 1814 brought him to the verge of a nervous breakdown.

Even if Frederick, in spite of the considerations outlined above, had agreed to the territorial exchange proposed by Russia and Sweden, it would in effect only be exchanging one problem for another. As of late 1812 and early 1813, all of the areas offered as compensation were still under French control, and it would therefore be necessary to conquer them before they could be taken over. Rosenkrantz pointed out that even if this could be done successfully, the areas promised would only weaken the Danish state financially and make it more strategically exposed and vulnerable to future continental European policies and wars. This was in fact precisely the reason why Sweden had been attempting to get rid of Pomerania and exchange it for Norway for quite a long time.¹⁷ Furthermore, exchanging Norway for northern German territories would tip the ethnic balance of the state and mean that Germans would become a majority. Previous tensions, as well as those that had flared up after the annexation of Holstein in 1806, had convinced the government in Copenhagen that this was not a good idea. In addition, both the king and his foreign minister regarded the Danish Empire as first and foremost Scandinavian and were not prepared to exchange this Scandinavian identity for a German or a continental one.

Meanwhile in the winter of 1813 pressure from Russia and Sweden was rapidly increasing, and, faced with the prospect of Russian troops marching into northern Germany, it had become imperative for the Danish-Norwegian government to ensure either that they won the support of Britain without dragging Sweden and Russia into the fray, or that Napoleon made peace with the allies in the hope that this would make Russia less enthusiastic in its support of Sweden's territorial demands. A cooling of Russo-Swedish relations was precisely what the Danish-Norwegian government hoped lay behind a surprising visit to Copenhagen in late March by an emissary from the Tsar's intimate entourage, Count Sergei Dolgoruki.

Count Dolgoruki hinted to the Danish-Norwegian government that the question of Norway could be postponed until the establishment of a general peace if Denmark-Norway terminated her Napoleonic alliance and immediately joined the allies. This made it appear as if Russia were prepared to sacrifice Sweden's interests in order to deprive Napoleon of an ally, which was exactly what the Danish-Norwegian government was hoping for. Whether sending Count Dolgoruki to Copenhagen meant

that Alexander seriously intended to open the door to the coalition for King Frederick and ignore Charles John's designs on Norway, or simply trick Frederick into abandoning Napoleon, is a matter of debate.¹⁸ Whatever his real intentions might have been, Alexander had second thoughts after Charles John's furious reaction to the Copenhagen mission. Alexander's rapid recall of Dolgoruki does indicate that he was not at all prepared to sacrifice his friendship and alliance with Sweden in favour of Denmark-Norway. In late April he therefore stated to a Danish-Norwegian emissary that for all his warm feelings towards Denmark-Norway, he still stood by the promises he had made to Sweden.

But in the meantime, Dolgoruki's mission had nevertheless raised Frederick's hopes that he could make peace and retain Norway. Therefore, in early April, he sent yet another Danish emissary to London as well as one to the Tsar's headquarters in Kalisch. His hope was that Russo-Danish rapprochement would please the British government – and that Denmark-Norway's approach to Britain would please the Russians – and bring about Denmark-Norway's entry into the anti-Napoleonic coalition by the backdoor and as such leave Charles John out in the cold. To attract Russian sympathy the emissary sent to Tsar Alexander was also instructed to point out how disastrous it would be for the Oldenburg dynasty to exchange Norway for German and Dutch territories, while this would also decisively weaken the Danish state and strengthen Sweden to the point that Sweden would be able to take control of all of Scandinavia. This, the king supposed, would surely not be in Russia's best interest.¹⁹

In April and early May, therefore, Frederick VI came very close to abandoning Napoleon. All he needed was a sign of some kind from Russia and/or Britain that the Swedish demand for Norway was negotiable, or for the Austrian government to somehow manage to mediate and negotiate a general peace. It was not to be, however, even though by late April and early May hopes were high in Copenhagen that a way out of Napoleon's grasp was just within reach that did not involve ceding Norway. This made it all the harder for Frederick when the reality of his situation hit home.

Fighting Napoleon

On 12 May 1813, Danish troops opened fire on the French in Hamburg when French troops tried to retake the city from the Russian army. For a moment it looked as though Denmark-Norway had changed sides in the thick of battle and joined the allies, like Saxony would do amidst the

battle of Leipzig five months later. Prior to this incident, Danish troops in Holstein had been instructed to maintain good relations with the Russian troops who entered Hamburg on 18 March 1813 after the French had withdrawn from the city. Denmark-Norway was still not formally at war with any of the allied powers except Britain. The general goal in the spring of 1813 was therefore to institute a Danish-Norwegian policy of neutrality in north Germany. During the next two months, relations between the Danish forces in Altona and the Russian troops in Hamburg were therefore quite cordial, with occasional close contacts between Commandant Haffner in Altona and the Russian General Tettenborn in Hamburg. Knowing that Austria was trying to mediate between Napoleon and the allies, there were hopes in Copenhagen for a general peace and, moreover, there was a firm belief that it would only be a matter of time before peace could be concluded with Britain on the understanding that Frederick would retain Norway, which would be an effective counterweight to the Russo-Swedish alliance. These were the hopes that peaked on 12 May, when Danish troops suddenly found themselves firing on the French in Hamburg.²⁰

The general background to this situation was the confusion prevailing in north Germany in the winter and spring of 1813. Allied troops were advancing rapidly towards the French army, while Denmark-Norway was frantically attempting to remain neutral in spite of its alliance with France. Things were also extremely tense, as the allies' expulsion of French troops from Hamburg in March was followed by a French counter-offensive from Hanover beginning at the end of April, which also evoked the question of Danish participation in the offensive to honour its French alliance. This left Denmark-Norway's allegiances blowing in the wind while in late April and early May Danish troops in Holstein were not necessarily aware of who was friend or foe. Indeed, in the event of peace between Denmark-Norway and Britain, which Frederick was convinced would be forthcoming, news could very well reach the French headquarters before it reached the commanding officer in Altona. This prompted King Frederick to issue standing orders to his troops in Holstein on 2 May to attack the French – who by then had pushed forward to Harburg – if they crossed the Elbe and descended on Hamburg.

Frederick's most immediate goal was to keep the French and Russian troops apart – and more specifically to keep the French forces out of Hamburg – until the allies and Napoleon had concluded a general peace, or at least until Frederick had landed peace and an alliance with Britain. This way he also hoped to prevent Danish troops in Altona

from prematurely becoming entangled in fighting with French troops. The Danish-Norwegian emissaries therefore proposed that the small islands of Peut, Veddel and Wilhelmsburg in the Elbe between Hamburg and Harburg should constitute a neutral zone. The emissary sent to the French headquarters was also instructed to make it clear to the French that they could expect resistance from the Danish army – and in practice war – if they attacked Hamburg.

None of this made any impression on the French, however, even less so as the emissary sent to their headquarters failed to deliver the message properly. On 12 May a French attack was launched against Russian positions at Wilhelmsburg, which rapidly drove off the ill-prepared Russians. In the meantime, Danish troops in Altona had made preparations for joint action with the Russians in accordance with the king's orders of 2 May, and upon the French attack two companies were immediately shipped across the Elbe to the island of Veddel where they found themselves among Russian-led allied detachments. In the chaos that followed the Russian retreat from Wilhelmsburg, the French mounted a surprise attack on Veddel, which led to an exchange of fire between Danish and French troops, while the Russian commander – keen to drive a decisive wedge between Denmark-Norway and France – persuaded the captain of a Danish gunboat to fire on a house occupied by French troops in order to 'impress them'.

On 12 May, then, it appeared that Denmark-Norway had finally abandoned Napoleon and joined the allies or at least come very close to doing so. While the Veddel incident, taken as a whole, was probably more the outcome of chance and misunderstanding in the chaos of battle than an indication of a final Danish-Norwegian change of sides, the desire to abandon Napoleon and prevent a renewed French occupation of Hamburg had taken Danish troops behind allied lines. But chaos prevailed, and the officer in command of the Danish forces on the island of Veddel, utterly confused, eventually found it necessary to send an emissary to the French headquarters to enquire whether or not Denmark-Norway and France were in fact at war. In other words, too much should not be read into the Veddel incident itself. It was hardly the case that Danish and Russian troops joined forces 'for a few weeks', as suggested by some historians, but there can be no doubt that the Danish-Norwegian government had come extremely close to a break with Napoleon at this time.²¹

Understandably, French officers who had taken part in the action at Veddel believed that such a break had indeed taken place. This placed King Frederick in an extremely difficult situation. Shortly before the

Veddel incident he had learned that Tsar Alexander intended to stand by the promises he had made to Charles John. On 13 May, the day after the incident at Veddel, he learnt that the two emissaries sent to the British government in January and April respectively had been told in no uncertain terms that Britain's Foreign Minister Lord Castlereagh was not prepared to allow Denmark-Norway to enter the anti-Napoleonic coalition at the expense of Sweden and possibly Russia, let alone to offer any guarantees that Frederick could retain Norway.²²

In the light of what had happened at Veddel, this was extremely unwelcome news. Moreover, Napoleon's victories at Lützen on 2 May, Gross-Görschen the day after and then at Bautzen in Saxony on the 20th seemed to suggest that the Emperor was about to halt the allied offensive and maintain his German hegemony, which would make it possible for him to severely punish Denmark-Norway's apparent defection. This left Frederick, who was now absolutely desperate, with the prospect of a simultaneous war with the allies *and* Napoleon – the very scenario he had dreaded after the Bombardment of Copenhagen six years previously.

With no chance of entering the anti-Napoleonic coalition without having to cede Norway – even less so as both Britain and Prussia had both formally joined the coalition and now openly and officially supported Sweden's demands – Frederick decided to try to make amends for the incident. In order to patch up his relationship with Napoleon and to explain that what had happened at Veddel had been due to a gross misunderstanding, Frederick paved the way for a renewed alliance between France and Denmark-Norway, which was eventually signed in Copenhagen on 10 July 1813. The alliance bound Frederick to Napoleon more closely than ever. First, it obliged him to support Napoleon with an auxiliary corps to be placed entirely at Marshall Davout's disposal. Second, it obliged Denmark-Norway to declare war on all of Napoleon's enemies in return for vague promises of aid for the defence of Jutland and even vaguer promises of Dutch loans.²³ Yet, as with all Frederick's previous treaties with Napoleon, the Emperor kept none of his promises.

During the latter half of 1813 all that could save Frederick VI from total disaster was a French victory or a negotiated general peace between the Emperor and the allies. At least in the latter respect there was genuine hope, if faint. In the summer of 1813 a general peace did seem to be within reach, as Austria, represented by Prince Metternich, was attempting to mediate between Napoleon and the allies. On 4 June a six-week armistice between the allies and Napoleon was agreed at Pleswitz to pave the way for a peace conference to be held in Prague.

The desperate Frederick remarked on 18 June that he expected Napoleon to attend the forthcoming peace conference and, if so, he presumed that the Emperor would 'work to ensure the best for the Danish monarchy in every respect and particularly that he would persuade the allied powers to withdraw their contention that Norway should be surrendered to Sweden'.²⁴

The allies had certainly not yet resolved to dethrone Napoleon and Metternich's efforts to arrange such a peace conference made it natural enough for Frederick VI to stick with Napoleon so that the Emperor could plead Denmark-Norway's cause. But the prospect of a peace conference with Austrian mediation also meant that Denmark-Norway was pinning its hopes on Austria. There was therefore a great deal of excitement about what Christian Bernstorff, who had returned to the foreign ministry in 1812 as a diplomat, would be able to accomplish as an emissary to Vienna, even more so as Austria appeared to be favourably inclined towards Denmark-Norway and had already indicated that Charles John's claim to Norway seemed unreasonable.

However, the renewal of the alliance with Napoleon on 10 July did a great deal to harm Denmark-Norway's cause in Austrian eyes. To compound the damage, as Napoleon was not interested in a negotiated peace, and as Austria subsequently declared war on France on 11 August, Denmark-Norway's fate was as good as sealed. By then, diplomatic relations with Sweden had already been broken off for four months, while the Russian, British and Swedish governments had all formally voiced their demands that Frederick VI immediately cede Norway in part or in whole to Sweden. Consequently, in accordance with the renewed alliance with Napoleon, Denmark-Norway declared war on all of the allies, except Austria, in the autumn of 1813 and, with the Russian and Swedish armies in control of northern Germany after the battle of Leipzig, it was only a matter of time before Denmark-Norway would be cornered by superior allied forces.

The course of Frederick's foreign policy for the last two years had been determined almost solely by the issue of Norway, whose possession only Napoleon was prepared to guarantee. By the time Frederick was prepared to abandon Napoleon, he had already been outmanoeuvred and outsmarted by Charles John. In a final desperate moral outburst, the angry Frederick instructed his foreign minister to inform the Swedes that he had not 'accepted the principle that they [the Norwegians] could be given away to strangers as one replaces furniture or exchanges one herd of cattle for another'.²⁵ It is ironic that, in the final analysis, this would be precisely what the Norwegians felt that Frederick had done.

Crisis in Norway

The period from the autumn of 1812 to the summer of 1813 was a time of crisis for Norway. The licensed trade with Britain, which had been lucrative from 1810 to 1811, practically dried up as fewer and fewer licences were issued and the threat of war became open conflict. A change in British customs regulations in 1811 also made it possible for Canada to step in and virtually take over the British timber market. However, while the financial crisis hit Norway hard, there was worse to come. In the autumn of 1812, the harvest in most areas of Norway failed due to frost, at the same time as the British tightened up the blockade and prevented corn imports. This resulted in a famine that by European standards was only paralleled by the famine that ravaged Madrid from 1811–12. However, the absence of epidemics, probably owing to the fact that the army was not quartered on the peasant population, prevented Norwegian death rates from reaching the shocking levels of 1808–09 although the famine was much more severe. Still, in some rural districts it was not uncommon to see the corpses of those who had died from exhaustion and starvation lying exposed. The deputy governor asserted in early April 1813 that if Norway ‘does not soon receive the necessary supplies, the consequences for this unfortunate country will be absolutely incalculable’, adding that a quarter of the population would probably perish if things did not improve rapidly.²⁶

The severe food shortages also caused domestic tension. In some of the wealthiest rural areas, which had escaped the worst effects of the frost, well-to-do farmers profited from the famine and soaring food prices by hoarding grain, while elsewhere their fellow farmers and countrymen starved. But starving farmers did not turn on the profiteers from their own ranks. Their rage was primarily reserved for the merchants in major ports who were accused of stockpiling imported grain and waiting for prices to rise, while the rural population starved to death. This was the reason for peasant marches on several cities in the first half of 1813, when only swift intervention by the civilian and military authorities – followed by inspections of the merchants’ largely empty warehouses – prevented serious unrest. As a rule, peasants turned *to* the government and authorities rather than *against* them in venting their anger at the merchants. ‘God knows how little [corn] will be available here for us many miserable peasants if the merchants are to be the people to trade with us’, wrote one peasant to his nearest bailiff. He went on to vent his fury at what he perceived of as sheer greed among the class of merchants.²⁷

Some Norwegian historians have made much of the unrest and protests in the spring of 1813, citing them as evidence of increasing popular political discontent with Danish rule and even growing aspirations to national independence. Such conclusions, however, attach far too much weight to the protests. Without exception, incidents of active peasant protests in Norway were highly localised and stemmed from very real suspicions and grievances. As such they were hardly very different in kind – although less violent – from peasant protests elsewhere in Napoleonic Europe, like those in the Italian province of Emilia-Romagna in 1809. Even more significantly, the protests were not primarily aimed at the authorities or the government. Only in the case of a bailiff in the parish of Toten being confronted by some 200 peasants was a concerted collective protest aimed directly at the authorities, and even then it was based on concrete and highly local grievances that had little connection with more abstract political concerns and aspirations.²⁸

Yet, even if popular protests in Norway were not motivated by anti-Danish or overt political concerns, the government in Copenhagen did not escape popular resentment and complaints. One peasant expressed his hope that ‘Our government will take measures to bring about some kind of change, and if they were aware of the state of the country they would surely be quite baffled.’ This remark had a political sting to it. By hinting that the king in Copenhagen might not be aware of the desperate situation in Norway, the implication was that the king’s advisors, they being in Denmark or Norway, were not doing enough to help remedy the shortages and were keeping the king in the dark about them. Surely the mild and well-meaning king would not let the peasants starve and the merchants ruin them if he knew what was going on? By implication, if the king did in fact know what was going on, it followed that his rule was flawed. One group of peasants in the southeastern Norwegian borderlands also pointed to this question when in 1812 they angrily complained that what little grain had been shipped across the Skagerrak from Denmark had ‘absolutely not gone to the indigent’ among the populace, who had been left to fend for themselves.²⁹ While this was far from an expression of overt national separatism, such remarks do show that the peasantry in Norway were perfectly able to understand the national-political discourse that was evolving to an increasing extent among some members of the educated middle-class elites, also owing to their experience of economic disruption and shortages.

When the effects of war, blockade, financial crisis and lack of food once again manifested themselves to the full in Norway from the

autumn of 1812, the patience of the Norwegians was soon stretched to breaking point. The government in Copenhagen was painfully aware of this. Rosenkrantz emphasised that it was 'important to pay the closest attention to Norway's needs and to the mood of its inhabitants'. He wrote this exhortation in the knowledge that Charles John would pursue his Norwegian ambitions not only by military means but also by the more subtle means of propaganda. This also placed restrictions on what the government could achieve in the diplomatic field. Even if interest in the Russo-Swedish offer of a territorial exchange were feigned for purely tactical reasons, wrote Rosenkrantz, it would enable Charles John 'to abuse it by spreading the news in Sweden and Norway in an attempt to weaken Norwegians' loyalty and devotion, as has so often been attempted before'.³⁰

Sweden's Designs on Norway

For two centuries many Scandinavian historians have argued that Charles John's aims and strategies with regard to Norway were novel. However, propaganda, diplomatic *fait accomplis* and offers for territorial exchanges had been attempted by previous Swedish governments. Put briefly, the only novelty in Charles John's policies regarding Norway after his arrival in Sweden in 1810 was the simple – but still crucial – fact that, unlike those of previous Swedish regents, they were ultimately successful.

Swedish attempts to breathe life into pro-Swedish sentiment in the eastern area of Norway in the autumn of 1809, led primarily by Georg Adlersparre, had not produced any results.³¹ Nor had Count Wedel Jarlsberg had any success worth mentioning in encouraging members of the Norwegian elite to support the idea of a union with Sweden, which all but cost him the confidence of his Swedish friends and co-conspirators. When Charles John made it clear to the Swedish government in the winter of 1811 that he regarded the acquisition of Norway as the chief goal of his foreign policy, Adlersparre wrote 'that the intervention must be made, not through Count Wedel but through the entire mass of the population, including him'. The idea was thus to create a broad popular movement in Norway in favour of Sweden by inciting anti-Danish sentiment through such means as exposing Norwegians again to the effects of the war and the blockade. This way 'the Norwegian peasant would, in the midst of peace, experience the suffering of war through transports, requisitions, etc., which should make him not only want a union but also contribute to it'. Such ideas were, in fact, not foreign to

influential Norwegians either. On a visit to Gothenburg in March 1811, Count Wedel Jarlsberg and Peder Anker, his influential father-in-law, allegedly maintained that it would be easier for Sweden to wrest Norway from Danish hands in the event of another war between the two countries, as the hardships it would bring about would probably make the Norwegians turn against the government in Copenhagen.³²

After the conclusion of the Treaty of St Petersburg in April 1812, a concerted Swedish propaganda campaign was launched in the Norwegian borderlands with the aim of convincing the population and the elites of the benefits of a union with Sweden, as well as of the shortcomings and the exploitative nature of Danish rule. The Swedish propaganda operated across a broad front, ranging from the distribution of pamphlets and proclamations in the Norwegian borderlands by agents, to efforts designed to justify Sweden's claim for possession of Norway with regard to Britain. In a series of letters, pamphlets and articles in Swedish newspapers, a union with Sweden was touted as Norway's salvation from war, financial crisis and famine and was linked with promises of loans, promises to reorganise the Norwegian financial system and, not least, promises of corn. Adlersparre's and Charles John's own propaganda went even further, promising Norway also extensive independence in a union with Sweden guaranteed by a constitution. In 1812 this propaganda had a dual aim, namely to encourage pro-Swedish sentiment among Norwegians and, perhaps equally important, to prevent them putting up resistance if Swedish troops entered Norway, which was the plan in the late summer of 1812. 'In the event of an attack on Norway', argued Adlersparre, 'it would certainly not be without significance to have slanted public opinion and to have friends and supporters everywhere'.³³

There were also disagreements in Swedish political and military circles as to how Norway was to be acquired. On the one hand, there was a faction spearheaded by Foreign Minister Lars von Engeström that wanted to wrest Norway from Danish hands either by diplomatic or military means – that is, by the threat or use of force, supported by one or more of the great powers. On the other hand, Georg Adlersparre's strategy was first and foremost to stir up popular resentment of Danish rule in Norway with the aim of inciting a popular uprising and then exploiting it to prompt Norwegians to unite with Sweden voluntarily. Ultimately, Charles John decided to combine the two strategies by seeking to woo and win hearts and minds in parallel with diplomatic efforts and at the same time being prepared to use military means if the international situation permitted.

Sweden's propaganda efforts in Norway reveal a great deal about feelings and identities prevalent in Norway, as they addressed a number of fairly widespread prejudices about and antipathies towards Sweden. These, in turn, shed some light on how the Norwegians saw themselves, including the popular classes, who were the primary targets for much of the Swedish propaganda. These antipathies and prejudices about Sweden included above all deep-rooted misgivings about the Swedish nobility, about what was perceived as a semi-feudal social structure, about conscription and about Sweden's foreign policies and taxes. Moreover, expressions of perhaps more harmless kinds – but still ones revealing that there was no love to be found for Sweden – were heard in the streets of Christiania and Copenhagen alike, such as 'to make a Swede of oneself' (meaning cowardice) and 'to Swede' (meaning fraud).

In August 1810 one Swedish observer remarked that the fear among Norwegians of 'an aristocratic subjugation' in the event of a union bordered on 'childishness'. Consequently, the primary Swedish concern was to counter such prejudices. There was hardly any nobility in Norway, and the number of wealthy landowners was relatively limited. Allodial rights meant that many Norwegians possessed their own land, which again made them all the more concerned about anything resembling what was basically and widely regarded as a Swedish manorial system of sorts or an influx into Norway of Swedish nobles. One Swedish agent remarked that although he had not yet met a Norwegian who was directly opposed to a union if concluded on certain conditions, and although the Norwegians generally seemed to think 'favourably of Sweden', they 'maintained a certain distrust of the nobility'. Swedish propaganda was therefore at pains to counter such sentiments and prejudices. Sweden would never limit Norway's liberties and privileges, as was asserted in several pamphlets, and, moreover, nobles in Sweden had 'not a single oppressive right over their subordinates that could be compared with those exercised by the Danish nobility'. According to Crown Prince Charles John, a constitution in Norway would be an 'improvement on Danish absolutism [which] should make a deep and favourable impression on the Norwegians'.³⁴

Conscription and foreign policy were two other concerns. The Swedes were still considered by many Norwegians as a people who were desperate to regain the status of a great power for their country and who therefore would be fully prepared to make war on other countries, for which general conscription would be required. This threat was used on a number of occasions and served as effective scare-mongering to the Norwegian peasantry. The introduction of Swedish conscription

laws, one observer noted, would 'turn Norway under our sceptre into an absolute wasteland'.³⁵ Although Norway was often referred to as a Nordic Sparta with an extensive conscription, there was deep aversion to fighting wars beyond Norway's borders.

As a consequence, Charles John and Adlersparre were at pains to assert that Sweden would act responsibly in international politics, that Norwegian peasants would not be sent to fight wars abroad and that Norway could retain her existing laws and privileges. Another concern was Swedish taxes, which many Norwegians believed would be beyond the means of the peasantry. A Norwegian peasant visiting the headquarters of one of Charles John's adjutants remarked that 'we peasants might well want to become Swedes', but emphasised that the 'current tax levels are quite moderate' in Norway. Other Swedish agents frequently pointed out the popular fear of increased taxes, and in 1809 Adlersparre had been careful to stress in his written propaganda that 'Sweden will not pay Norwegian taxes: Norway will not pay Swedish taxes'.³⁶

As was the case in 1809, corn supplies to Norway also played a part in the Swedish strategy. The British blockade was tightened up again in the autumn of 1812 and, when Great Britain formally became Sweden's ally in the spring of 1813, the blockade could be even more rigorously enforced. However, this time the Norwegians and the government in Copenhagen succeeded in shipping large quantities of corn across the Skagerrak before the blockade could be properly organised while the British ships kept out of Danish-Norwegian waters during the winter months. Norway was therefore reasonably well supplied with corn during the winter and spring of 1814 when it had to decide which course to follow.

The differences between the means and strategies of what could loosely be called the Adlersparre and Engeström factions mentioned above were also paralleled by their different aims. The latter faction – which, in addition to the foreign minister included a considerable number of military officers and leading statesmen who had been relatively close to Gustav III and Gustav IV Adolph – basically envisaged a wholesale incorporation of Norway into Sweden. Adlersparre and his faction saw things in a different light, however. In 1809 Adlersparre had been prepared to grant Norway a constitution and quite extensive independence if a union could be achieved, and this was also the stance taken by Charles John from 1811 onwards.

The main consequence of these different strategies and goals, however, was that Swedish propaganda and arguments became ambiguous and

self-contradictory as players from both factions were actively engaged in agitation. What might in some pamphlets appear to be tempting promises and proclamations were often undermined in other publications written in more threatening terms. In other words, Norwegians were unable to form an unequivocal impression of what they could expect from a union with Sweden, and this also developed into a question of trust. For this reason, one Norwegian author warned his countrymen in 1814 that even if Sweden respected Norway's liberties and independence, the Swedish army would probably invade Norway sooner or later and annex it, after which the Swedish nobility would follow in its wake and turn 'Norwegian farms into their estates'.³⁷

Throughout the Napoleonic wars, there was a remarkably persistent perception in leading Swedish political and military circles that the majority of the population in Norway, including the peasantry and most members of the middle class, were Norwegians, while civil servants, military officers and other individuals working for the state administration and government bodies were Danes. Although there were some Norwegians who favoured a union, one Swedish agent remarked, 'these [people] are not in majority, and they are being counteracted by the civil servants there, who are Danes'.³⁸

Assumptions such as these ignored both the level of social cohesion in Norway and the important fact that civil servants in Norway were largely self-recruiting and had close ties with leading merchants. Therefore, the elites and those serving in high-ranking administrative and government posts were not 'Danish' as opposed to 'Norwegian', but rather Danish *and* Norwegian by virtue of the parallel concepts of the civic and natural fatherland. In other words, the complex identities of the middle-class elites in Denmark-Norway were also difficult for contemporaries to disentangle. In one case, a Danish professor of linguistics, who was travelling in the Norwegian borderlands in the summer of 1812, saw a furious peasant woman who wanted to cross the border from Sweden into Norway with her dying husband. When she was denied entry back into her native country by a military officer, the professor – standing on the Norwegian side of the border – was astonished to hear her exclaim, 'I shall damned well not stay in Sweden! I am a Norwegian, and if my poor husband is to die, then he shall be laid to rest in Danish soil.' This particular woman perceived herself to be a Norwegian, but regarded the territory on which Norwegians lived as 'Danish', quite possibly linking territory to her concept of the Danish state. Furthermore, the army in Norway – even though it was manned solely by ethnic Norwegians and was completely separate from the

Danish army as an institution – was often referred to as ‘Danish’, not only by the Swedes who regarded it as an institution of the Danish state but also by Norwegian peasants. The same Danish professor also wrote of his surprise when a young peasant boy who was conducting him on a tour of the battlefields of 1808 in the Norwegian borderlands told him, ‘there stood the enemy, there *the Danes* (as he called them), there we took so and so many, there this or that person fell, etc.’.³⁹

This was also quite a mystery to the Swedes, as was the identity and ethnic composition of the elites in Norway, which the Swedes regarded as *Danish*. In the end, this influenced Swedish perceptions and expectations in the sense that the Swedes considerably exaggerated the conflict between Norwegians and Danes. However, it does not mean that they were completely mistaken. Many Norwegians nurtured genuine dissatisfaction with the government in Copenhagen and with the union with Denmark, but the implications of this were not always in line with the Swedes’ conclusions.

The Effects of Swedish Propaganda

According to Georg Adlersparre, the general mood in Norway was overtly pro-Swedish in 1811, slightly less so in 1812, and it then swung increasingly in favour of Sweden following the disastrous famine during the winter of 1812–13. Although what he wrote cannot always be trusted, Adlersparre’s assertion does at least indicate how the Swedes perceived the general mood in Norway and how this was sometimes attributed to the effects of Swedish propaganda. ‘The people in general’, a Swedish agent reported in the late summer of 1812, ‘complain bitterly about their situation and want an end to it in every conceivable way’. In October, another agent argued that because ‘the political mindset in the regular army and among the masses in the country is against the Danish government, and at least divided on the question of a union with Sweden, I think the right time to mount a serious attack on Norway is now or never’. Another optimistic report from an agent related that ‘the Norwegians generally wish for a union with Sweden’, while another wrote that although ‘the peasants here are not inclined to let themselves be convinced’ he was happy to say that ‘vicars, burghers in general and especially merchants very much want the move to be fulfilled’.⁴⁰

But Adlersparre and many of the agents were often too optimistic and frequently failed to recognise the real effects of their efforts. Even among people mostly likely to favour Swedish rule – primarily

the population of the Swedish–Norwegian borderlands and the merchant elites in eastern Norway – there was no general endorsement of a Swedish union, despite increasing criticism of the government in Copenhagen and of the war. It seems that the Swedish historian Torvald Höjer is correct, therefore, in arguing that Charles John was ultimately ‘led astray by optimistic statements from the men of 1809, that is, the men behind the *coup d’état*, particularly Adlersparre and Platen’, which led the crown prince to expect much greater acceptance of a union in Norway than ultimately proved to be the case.⁴¹ This view was shared by some contemporaries, one of whom remarked that if ‘a number or only a few people have asserted that people’s minds there [in Norway] were generally quite favourably inclined towards Sweden, these assurances must certainly have been the subject of much bargaining’.⁴²

For their part, King Frederick and the government in Copenhagen energetically countered Swedish propaganda with pamphlets, texts and proclamations of their own. Furthermore, a close watch was also kept on suspicious individuals such as Count Wedel Jarlsberg.⁴³ Yet, no arrests were made in Norway on the grounds of alleged illegal relations with Sweden, and peasants usually handed over Swedish propaganda material distributed in the borderlands to the authorities. While this shows that propaganda was certainly being circulated, it also suggests that not even the peasants in the area – who had extensive cross-border relations – were very receptive to what Sweden had to offer.

This was not only a consequence of the prejudices about and suspicions of Sweden, but also of the policies of the government in Copenhagen. In his desperation in April 1813, King Frederick feared that Norwegian faith in the government – that even the union with Denmark itself – was faltering and therefore decided to send his heir apparent, Prince Christian Frederick, to Norway as governor to boost Norwegian morale and loyalty. The king hoped that, as a prominent representative of the monarchy and of the Oldenburg dynasty, Christian Frederick would reinforce the traditionally deep-rooted dynastic loyalty in Norway and create a counterweight to the Swedish propaganda campaign. Prince Christian Frederick arrived in Norway on the morning of 21 May 1813.⁴⁴ He immediately embarked on a tour of eastern Norway to win the confidence of the middle-class elites and other notables, particularly those who had expressed pro-Swedish sentiments or criticised Danish foreign policy. His aims included winning the unanimous support of the population and organising mass resistance to any offensive Swedish moves, as well as preventing Charles John from turning the population against Danish rule.

Prince Christian Frederick's arrival in Norway was an instant success. He rode into Christiania in the afternoon of 22 May to the accompaniment of fanfares, and one observer noted in his diary the same evening, 'I now have no doubt of Norway's salvation'. The Swedes, on the other hand, were worried. Shortly after the prince's arrival, the county governor of Värmland in western Sweden, bordering on Norway, reported that the prince had 'won the love of the populace, who are under the illusion that he is just like the blessed Prince Carl [Christian] August', the hero of 1808. And Christian Frederick did manage to win the confidence and support of most of the middle-class elites and merchants, with the exception of Count Wedel Jarlsberg, who remained sceptical.⁴⁵

Prince Christian Frederick and Norway

Christian Frederick's Norwegian mission was brought about by the king's wish to place Prince Frederick of Hesse, the governor in Norway since 1809 and one of the king's most trusted military commanders, at the head of the Danish-Norwegian contingent that was to fight alongside the allies against the French, which again showed how determined King Frederick was to abandon Napoleon. It also showed that the decision to send Christian Frederick to Norway was a secondary concern on the part of the king and also that the prince was not necessarily sent there primarily to boost Norwegian morale. However, the decision was one that Christian Frederick himself and several notable Norwegians had been hankering after since 1810, in the knowledge that a royal presence in Norway would be likely to give a significant boost to dynastic loyalty. And in this they were proven right.

A vital part of the strategy of boosting Norwegian loyalty and patriotism was to stir up antipathy towards Sweden. In April the king had urged the Norwegian authorities to make sure that the Swedes would be blamed if his efforts to obtain peace failed and therefore that 'the Norwegians should be informed of the Swedes' intentions, as nothing will create a greater desire to defend themselves than this'. For this reason Norwegian priests were instructed to curse Sweden and all its works from their pulpits in order to imprint the alleged crimes and evil intentions of the Swedes on the minds of the populace. The aim was to follow up the agitation from the pulpits with a concentrated written propaganda campaign in the form of pamphlets and other texts.⁴⁶ Opposition to Sweden was not only expressed in terms of political and financial arguments, it also took the form of savage public rhetoric.

For one priest in Christiania the very concepts 'Sweden' and 'Swedish' became repulsive, while another Norwegian priest at the end of 1813 described Sweden in poetry and prose as a degenerate country peopled by oppressed dwarves who had betrayed their Nordic origin (including Norway and Denmark) and their national character, as they had thrown themselves into the arms of a tyrannical nobility, an unworthy king and a foreign crown prince. The diatribe reflected not only the fiery temperament of this particular priest but also a widespread feeling among many Norwegians across a broader cross-section of the population. Having toured the southeastern Norwegian borderlands in June 1813, where social and economic relations with Sweden were normally extensive, Christian Frederick reported that even people in these areas were full of 'disgust with the Swedes'. A Swedish agent agreed, concluding bluntly that the uneducated segments of the populace 'retain an ingrained hatred of everything that is Swedish'.⁴⁷

At the same time, King Frederick was becoming more and more desperate. Time after time during the summer and autumn of 1813 he advocated pre-emptive attacks on Sweden by peasant militias, if only to seize Swedish corn and lay waste to the Swedish borderlands.⁴⁸ When Swedish territory was invaded, wrote the king to Christian Frederick on the formal outbreak of war with Sweden in early September, 'the parties you send into the country can not only prevent the concentration of troops, they can also acquire food for you'. This also showed how intense the king felt the conflict with Sweden had become. Christian Frederick had no plans to wage such a 'total war' on Swedish territory, however. He suggested instead that they should conserve their energy until the situation became more acute and until Denmark and Norway could join forces against Sweden. Rather than launch an all-out attack on Sweden, Christian Frederick set about consolidating his own position and that of the monarchy, in preparation for what might happen in the event of a French defeat.

Napoleon's defeat at Leipzig on 19 October 1813 was a sign of things to come. In Norway, Christian Frederick learned what had happened at Leipzig in early November. It was clear that from now on the war would involve defending Norway, retaining the kingdom for the Oldenburg monarchy and preventing Charles John from taking the prize he had been promised. The reaction in Norway was to take urgent steps to prepare the country's military forces and to obtain as much corn and as many other supplies as possible. It was also necessary to do as much as possible to bring some order into Norway's ailing financial situation.

This made it imperative for Christian Frederick to secure the unanimous support of Norway's inhabitants. He even reached out to Count Wedel Jarlsberg, remarking that 'barring him from taking part in our activities only aggravates his mind's disquietude; including him in them makes it easier to keep an eye on him'.⁴⁹ Furthermore, on 15 December, Christian Frederick summoned most of Norway's leading merchants and businessmen to Christiania to establish what would in reality become Norway's first bank of its own. This was no small concession from the government, given King Frederick's previous refusal to grant Norway a bank. Yet, what became known as the 'Bank meeting' in Christiania was also important for other reasons. It appears to have been the first time that the Norwegian elite more or less openly began thinking of Norway as a kingdom in its own right, with Christian Frederick as monarch.⁵⁰ This bears witness to the position Christian Frederick had been able to achieve among Norwegians after only six months or so as governor and it also demonstrates the desperation of the situation in Norway and the gravity of the threat to the union with Denmark.

Although many Norwegians had to a great extent begun to turn against Sweden during 1813, this did not mean that faith in and loyalty to the union with Denmark was strengthened. In early April 1813, an observer in Christiania said of Frederick's continued alliance with Napoleon that it was naturally a matter of honour for a monarch to keep his word and not turn his back on his allies, but he questioned whether it was right for a monarch to sacrifice what was practically speaking an entire people in so doing.⁵¹ King Frederick was certainly aware of such sentiments and it was crucial that he convince the Norwegians that he was not continuing to make war for its own sake. It was imperative, he wrote, 'that Norwegians be informed through every possible channel that I have done everything I could to obtain peace with the Swedes, and that I never intend to begin a war unless it be absolutely necessary', and that 'every attempt I have made in Sweden and in England to turn them towards peace and reason has failed'. This was still a sore point for Frederick as late as December 1813, when he wrote that 'it would grieve me if anybody should believe that I made war for my own amusement; that has never been my intention'.⁵²

Even in Denmark royal power was being put under pressure. The situation there during the war has often been represented as far less critical for the king than it was in Norway, which is essentially a reasonable interpretation. But opposition to absolutism during this period has been underestimated, and the criticism that had been voiced in 1807 was still current. For example, a British informant reported in 1808 that the former

love of the king had been replaced by fear. The unsuccessful attempts to invade Scania in 1808–09, and the similarly abortive attempts in 1809–10 to become the heir to the Swedish throne only made matters worse and created widespread unrest in the population. This was reflected in reports from British spies from 1811 and 1812, which relate that there was strong dissatisfaction with Frederick VI in Denmark. While sources of this type should be taken with a pinch of salt, the information they provide in this case is in harmony with Danish information. The development of the war and the state bankruptcy further undermined the king's prestige to the point where Denmark's leading newspaper contained no celebratory songs nor speeches on the occasion of the king's birthday in 1813. And the situation deteriorated even more after October 1813 when Denmark-Norway found itself at war with virtually the rest of Europe, and posters and bills condemning the government and, not least, the king's adjutants, appeared all over Copenhagen. To top it all, on 10 December a poster appeared demanding the execution of the people responsible for the monetary conversion of 5 January.⁵³ In brief, towards the end of 1813, the government in Copenhagen was under great domestic pressure, while external pressure continued to intensify.

War and Defeat in Holstein

At least until the French evacuation of Hamburg in March 1813, relations between the Danish and French armies in northern Germany were cordial enough. Danish troops were called out to assist the French in restoring order following the outbreak of a popular revolt in Hamburg in late February, as French troops were preparing to leave the city. The subsequent execution of a number of rebels by the French created a crisis, however, as Danish troops appeared to have had a hand in these executions. This was the cause of a great deal of disgust among the Holsteiners. Moreover, it was also a diplomatic disaster, as the outraged Russian government was left with the impression that Frederick VI was devoted to Napoleon and willing to follow him almost blindly. Whether this played a role one way or another with respect to Russian policy regarding Denmark-Norway in the spring of 1813 is a matter of conjecture, but it certainly did not benefit the cause of the Danish-Norwegian government.⁵⁴

Despite this, the inhabitants of Hamburg and elsewhere in northern Germany were too bitter about the French to hold grudges against the Danes, or the Holsteiners for that matter, in the long run. Danish troops were not considered enemies, as was shown by the warm greeting they

received from the inhabitants of Hamburg when they entered the city in May. In their view, anything was preferable to French occupation. Later that month, when the inhabitants realised that the French would reoccupy the city, many of them fled to Holstein. Furthermore, the inhabitants of the Hanseatic cities soon found out that the Danes treated them better than the allies, who sometimes sought revenge for what they considered active collaboration with the French. Men from the Hanseatic cities serving in the Hanseatic Legion – which was incorporated into Charles John's army in 1813 – were therefore generally on friendly terms with the local inhabitants when they played their part in the allied occupation of Holstein and Schleswig in 1813–14.⁵⁵

Napoleon and the French, on the other hand, were as unpopular in the duchies as they were elsewhere in northern Germany. Denmark-Norway's alliance with Napoleon was becoming increasingly unpopular also with army officers in Holstein, who sensed that Napoleon was heading for a fall. Nor was it particularly popular with many of those who served in the Danish army in Holstein and northern Germany, most of whom hailed from the duchies. Squabbles and brawls between French and Danish troops were not uncommon in 1813. Needless to say, this infuriated both the French and Frederick VI and the hard-pressed king found it necessary to order his officers and troops not to 'politicise' or 'enter into political conversations or to give expression to such principles whereby one wishes to demonstrate one's wisdom in uttering opinions other than those we have approved, which must be those that are to the true benefit of the state'.⁵⁶

In spite of the growing discontent with the French alliance and the reluctance of the Danish auxiliary corps in northern Germany to side with the French, the end of the European ceasefire in early August left them with no choice but to join forces with the French army. This not only aroused the moral dissatisfaction of the Danish officer corps in Holstein, it was also an economic disaster for the entire state. If the French troops had cost the Danish-Norwegian government a fortune in 1808, the cost of the troops placed at Napoleon's disposal in 1812 and 1813 was even higher and was a major reason why the financial crisis in the Danish-Norwegian state only increased after the introduction of the reforms in January 1813. Nor were Danish-Norwegian finances helped by the fact that a significant capital sum, owned by the Bank of Altona but deposited in the Bank of Hamburg, was confiscated by the French and sent to Paris, leaving the Bank of Altona on the verge of bankruptcy and making it appear yet again as if Frederick was blindly supporting Napoleon by any means available.

The war in northern Germany and Holstein in the late autumn of 1813 was by and large a hopeless affair for the Danish auxiliary corps. The French had dug in at Hamburg – where they would hold out until Napoleon's abdication – while the Danish corps was forced to retreat north into Holstein from Altona. On 28 November the lines between the two allies were completely cut by Charles John, leaving the Danish army isolated. By this time, several of King Frederick's advisors, including Prince Christian Frederick, were openly encouraging him to abandon Napoleon altogether, no matter what the risk, to prevent the dismemberment of the entire Danish-Norwegian state and with it the end of the Oldenburg monarchy.

It was in this desperate situation that Frederick summoned his privy council for the first time since 1808. One outcome of the crisis in late 1813 was therefore to bring about a minor palace revolution in Copenhagen, as it marked the end of Frederick's personal absolutist rule and of the influence of the Red Feathers. The privy council could offer the desperate and bewildered king little in the way of useful advice, however, and it became increasingly clear that Denmark-Norway's destiny would be decided on the battlefield. A slender ray of hope was offered by a last-minute Austrian attempt to mediate between Denmark-Norway and the allies. On 21 November, Prince Metternich sent a young diplomat, Count L.P. de Bombelles, to Copenhagen to persuade Frederick to join the allies and threatened that if he did not, Austria – the last of the major allied powers with which Denmark-Norway was not at war – would support Sweden's demand for Norway. Although this was probably an attempt by Prince Metternich to obstruct Charles John and retain a balance of power in Scandinavia, Austria's ultimatum was that the province of Trondheim be ceded to Sweden immediately in return for compensatory territories elsewhere, and that Denmark-Norway immediately enter into the anti-Napoleonic coalition.⁵⁷

As far as King Frederick was concerned, however, any voluntary surrender of part or of the whole of Norway was completely out of the question, and any hope of a negotiated settlement vanished. In Norway, rumours of the Swedish and Austrian demand created a sensation in any case, with one observer remarking that he was happy that he did not live in Trondheim, because swearing an oath of allegiance to the Swedish king would be more than he could bear.⁵⁸

The war in Holstein was forcing the Danish-Norwegian government ever further into a corner. In the early days of December orders were given to retreat into the fortified cities of Glückstadt and Rendsburg. After fighting its way through the allied lines at Sehested on 10 December,

the Danish army eventually gained safety behind the city walls. More problems lay ahead, however. Desertion, especially from the Holsteinian regiments in the Danish army, was rife after a defeat at Bornhöved on 7 December and continued in Glückstadt to such an extent that it eventually led to the city's surrender on 5 January 1814. The Holsteiners had had enough of the war, and fighting on Napoleon's side was now considered an absolute absurdity.

Furthermore, the Danish army was becoming increasingly unpopular with the civilian population of Holstein in the autumn of 1813, as was noted by one of its generals with great frustration. Its unpopularity was mainly due to logistical demands, which, as was the case elsewhere in Napoleonic Europe, were a heavy burden on the population. But in the case of Schleswig-Holstein the burdens of the campaign in the late autumn of 1813 further increased the schism between the duchies and Denmark, as the demands of the Danish army were seen as the consequences of an unpopular war and an even more unpopular alliance with Napoleon and only compounded common grounds for dissatisfaction. This further strengthened local and regional attachments in the duchies and reinforced the anti-Danish sentiment that would come to haunt relations between the duchies and Denmark proper in later decades, when the experiences of the Napoleonic Wars were increasingly viewed from a national perspective.

By 1813 clear evidence of change could be seen since the upsurge of state patriotism in the duchies following the Bombardment of Copenhagen. As if to emphasise the erosion of state patriotic sentiment as a result of the war, affection for the duchies was decreasing in Denmark proper and giving way to a national discourse that increasingly excluded the German-speaking parts of the state. This showed that many people were increasingly beginning to think in terms of nationality rather than in terms of loyalty to the cosmopolitan dynastic state, not only in Holstein. In Copenhagen there were references to a Danish 'we' and an army of Danish brothers fighting on the banks of the Eider for the fatherland with no mention made of the occupied parts of Holstein.⁵⁹ In Norway there was even less concern about the fate of Holstein, despite the fact that the country's fate was virtually being decided on the battlefields of the duchies. In other words, the three core elements of the Danish state – Denmark proper, the duchies and Norway – were gradually moving towards separation, the move being signalled by mutual indifference and, in the case of the Holsteiners and the Norwegians, by growing resentment of Danish rule.

Charles John's invasion of Holstein soon obliged the Danish forces to retreat. But before its decisive conclusion, Denmark-Norway's war against the allies in the duchies was briefly postponed by a ceasefire signed on 15 December. Although this was primarily engineered by Austrian efforts at mediation, Charles John was also motivated to halt hostilities by the realisation that it could take him a long time to oust the troops entrenched in Glückstadt and Rendsburg. But he still hoped that his Danish-Norwegian counterpart would sense that defeat was inevitable and that he would enter into negotiations to surrender Norway. This was far from King Frederick's intention, however. Clinging to the hope that Austria would somehow come to his rescue by enabling him to defer or deflect the question of Norway, Frederick saw no reason to cede Norway voluntarily. This enraged Charles John, who was also deeply suspicious that Austria and the other allies were preparing to deprive him of his Norwegian prize and admit Denmark-Norway into the coalition. Such suspicions had been a source of friction between Charles John and the allies for quite some time. One instance was a British attempt to mediate between Denmark-Norway and the allies in October that was furiously rejected by the crown prince with the words, 'once Zealand is in my power, no force on earth will remove me from it. I will – if necessary – bombard Copenhagen and, if the king hesitates to surrender Norway, I will plough up the soil on which Denmark's royal castle once stood'. He then proceeded to threaten to dismantle the Oldenburg monarchy completely. While these outbursts were no doubt a reflection of Charles John's temperament and as such should not be taken literally, they certainly indicate that a negotiated compromise was not what he had in mind.⁶⁰

When the ceasefire expired on 29 December 1813, the question for the Danish-Norwegian government was whether or not to continue the war. A council of war was convened at Amalienborg Palace in Copenhagen on 30 December to assess the military situation. The conclusions arrived at were bleak and were to all intents and purposes a decision to surrender. In the meantime Count Bombelles and the Danish diplomat Edmund Bourke had travelled to Kiel to consult Charles John, who now occupied all of Holstein. An extension of the ceasefire until the night of 6 January was agreed, but Charles John made his terms stricter. He now wanted all of Norway immediately and then only agreed to the extension of the ceasefire if Trondheim was surrendered to him immediately along with the major fortresses in eastern Norway, while the rest was to be ceded after the conclusion of a general peace. In return he pledged to try to help Frederick VI to obtain territorial

compensation elsewhere in Germany or in Swedish Pomerania, and offered him one million Swedish *rix-dollars* in cash if all of Norway was ceded without further ado.

On learning the new terms, it was King Frederick's turn to go into a fit of rage. Count Bombelles made it clear that there was nothing more he could do, however, and that Frederick really had no choice but to cede Norway, while he reminded him of the combined military power of the allies. Foreign Minister Rosenkrantz emphasised that a rejection could well lead to the fall of the entire Oldenburg dynasty and, with it, the Danish state. In fact, detachments of Russian Cossacks under Charles John's command had already begun to appear as far north as Kolding in Jutland, an event that led to the winter of 1813–14 being remembered as the 'Cossack winter'. Faced with the prospect of a wholesale invasion of Jutland and possibly Funen, and with it total defeat, King Frederick caved in on 7 January.

Room for Manoeuvre

Charles John now had Frederick VI in a stranglehold, but there was still some time left to manoeuvre for Denmark-Norway if the Danish-Norwegian government or its representatives in Norway were prepared to make a number of radical decisions. By the Christmas and New Year of 1813, it was no longer a question of *whether* something would be done about Norway, but rather of what would be done and who would do it. The goal for Denmark-Norway's side was clear enough, at least to most people: to avoid surrendering Norway to Sweden. But their underlying motives were not necessarily the same. In some circles, solutions that would secure Norway for the Oldenburg dynasty and include a union with Denmark for the short or long term were considered, while other circles favoured something more along the lines of a permanent separation from Denmark. In the latter case, there were even a number of influential members of the eastern Norwegian elite who regarded a union with Sweden as a more attractive alternative to a continued union with Denmark.

By the Christmas of 1813, most Norwegians could agree that the government in Copenhagen had played its cards very ineptly. Extremely critical opinions of King Frederick's policy could be heard even from members of the Norwegian officer corps, who were usually not ones to criticise the king. Their primary criticism was that too little had been done for Norway in government circles, and the little that had been done had been characterised by negligence.⁶¹ There was nothing new

about such views. But in that dark December of 1813, as the crisis deepened and as the idea of Christian Frederick becoming king of an independent Norway found relatively free expression, it took on a new and greater force, which in turn created various possibilities for political developments.

Prince Christian Frederick had also let it be known that he was not averse to resorting to radical measures to prevent a union of Norway and Sweden. An idea that increasingly gained ground with the prince from the late autumn of 1813 was that an enforced union with Sweden – through a surrender based on a peace treaty, for instance – could be avoided if Norwegians raised the flag of rebellion and put up resistance. This would involve putting a spanner in the works of the practical organisation of a formal surrender of Norway to Sweden on the part of Denmark.

The idea was fleshed out by Christian Frederick in a letter to the king, known as the ‘Christmas letter’, on 25 December. His point of departure in the letter was the Swedish and Austrian ultimatum regarding the immediate surrender of the province of Trondheim, the rest of Norway to be ceded to Sweden later. However, unlike the king, Christian Frederick was not convinced that this was completely unthinkable. Ceding Trondheim, he wrote, would leave it to the inhabitants of the province to decide whether they would accept surrender or resist. He did not anticipate that they would do the former, but pointed out that ‘the circumstances under which they would do the latter could not be known’. His idea was that surrendering parts or all of Norway would not necessarily involve the country’s immediate and de facto union with Sweden, if the Norwegians themselves did not want it.

For Christian Frederick, popular resistance to a union with Sweden after a formal surrender of the country on the part of Frederick VI would be a forceful expression of the will of the people, which was something he assumed the allied powers would have to consider when the inevitable question of enforcing Sweden’s claims by military means arose. Furthermore, Sweden would be left with serious practical problems when the time came to enforce a takeover of Norway after its formal surrender. In such a case, there would be two possible options for Norway: either national independence or a (renewed) union with Denmark. Christian Frederick made no bones about the fact that he was chiefly thinking along the lines of the latter, although without excluding the former as an acceptable possibility. There can thus be no doubt that, at the end of 1813, Prince Christian Frederick had set his sights on

a means of thwarting Charles John's demands and plans while at the same time securing Norway for the Oldenburg monarchy.⁶²

The Peace of Kiel was signed on 14 January 1814. This was, in fact, two separate peace treaties, one with Great Britain and one with Sweden. In the first treaty the Danish king surrendered the island of Heligoland, which had been occupied since 1807, to Britain, while the British returned Denmark's overseas colonies. The second peace treaty obliged Frederick VI to cede all of Norway to the Swedish king in return for Swedish Pomerania, the principality of Rügen and one million *rix-dollars*. At the same time the Swedes placed Norway under an obligation to pay its share of the former Danish-Norwegian state's national debt. Finally, it was explicitly stated in the treaty that Denmark would retain the old Norwegian dependencies in the North Atlantic: Iceland, the Faeroes and Greenland, simply because Charles John was not interested in anything but 'mainland Norway'.⁶³

7

Postlude – Freedom and Suppression, 1814–15

Peace in Scandinavia?

Frederick VI had lost and Charles John had won. On 16 January the Danish king issued proclamations releasing the Norwegians from their oath of allegiance and encouraging them to accept the new regime. The trouble was that quite literally no one passed the news on to the Norwegians. Although a banner headline in a Norwegian newspaper shouted, 'Peace, peace in Scandinavia' on 25 January, there was no mention of what the peace meant for Norway. This was partly due to the fact that Christian Frederick was ignorant of the precise contents of the peace treaty, as Frederick VI initially failed to send the prince those sections of the treaty dealing with the cession of Norway and the document that released Norwegians from their oath to the king. This was simply the king playing for time. Despite the anger this caused Christian Frederick, it gave the prince some latitude. The heir to the Danish throne attempted to calm his war-weary Norwegian people and buy himself time. Rumours of the terms of the peace, however, spread rapidly and they were officially proclaimed a month later. Although many Norwegians had anticipated the separation, the news came as a shock, and matters were not improved by the fact that they had been surrendered to the Swedish arch-enemy like 'a herd of cattle' without a fight.¹

The Norwegians did not dispute Frederick VI's right to surrender his power over Norway, but they did dispute his right to give the country to the Swedish king. This view had been advanced by Christian Frederick as early as April 1813, when he wrote, 'When he [the monarch] renounces his right to the throne, *when his line up to the most distant relative has done likewise*, then the right to elect a king surely reverts to the nation.' He made his attitude even clearer at the end of

January 1814, shortly after he had received the news about the Peace of Kiel. Christian Frederick wrote to the king that the monarch had the right to release the Norwegians from their oath of allegiance, but not to deprive the royal family of its right of inheritance, protesting once again on behalf of the nation. He not only saw it as his duty but as his calling to stay at his post in order to prevent a civil war and a state of anarchy and to support the Norwegians against oppression. The prince begged the king to not yet consider Norway a Swedish province but to send corn, gunpowder and bullets. In accordance with 'natural law' Christian Frederick held that, even if the king had the right to bypass the line of succession, sovereignty could not be transferred to another monarch. It had to be given back to the nation.²

Before the Peace of Kiel, it had been clear to the prince that a Norwegian uprising might be necessary if Norway were separated from Denmark, and that this in turn could have serious personal consequences for him, among them the loss of his right to the Danish throne, of his estates and of his son. In addition he risked being branded a rebel by the great powers. As early as November 1813, the heir to the throne had written a 'letter of conveyance' in which he left all of his Danish properties to his son. He also followed this up on 22 February 1814 by asking the king to become the guardian of his son and to secure his properties in Denmark for his son as it was doubtful whether he would return. This Frederick VI agreed to do. Christian Frederick told the king several times that he should disinherit him if this could in any way help or save Denmark or Frederick VI himself.³

So Christian Frederick made himself the leader of a rebellion, and his immediate goal was to create an independent Norway with himself as autocratic king. The prince had conceived this strategy in advance. He had written to the military commanders on 17 January, before he knew of the Peace of Kiel, about the course he intended to take if the kingdoms were separated, and he repeated this to them and to the heads of the civil administration upon receiving the news of the peace on 25 January.⁴ Was this, though, the Danes playing a double game?

Danish Double-dealing?

There has been speculation among historians, as there was among contemporary observers, about whether, in the event of the cession of Norway, Frederick VI and Christian Frederick had a secret agreement that the Danish prince should raise the banner of rebellion to preserve Norway for the royal house and pave the way for a later reunification

with Denmark. The Norwegian historian Knut Mykland has made a case for this, and while a 'smoking gun' has never been found there is a good deal of circumstantial evidence to support the theory of Danish double-dealing. There is no doubt that, before the separation, Frederick VI, and several members of the government, discussed the possibility of a Norwegian rebellion if the kingdom were ceded to Sweden. These ideas were in veiled terms passed on to the heir to the throne in Norway when, during the negotiations with Bombelles regarding the surrender of Trondheim, the king wrote to Christian Frederick that 'Cession could be avoided if the inhabitants of Trondheim said "We want to stay with our king".' The prince wanted this clarified and asked Frederick VI outright whether he should act independently of Denmark in the event of a separation or whether he should abide by the terms of a peace treaty. As mentioned, the king was aware of the contents of this letter before the conclusion of negotiations in Holstein.⁵

Knut Mykland cites five pieces of circumstantial evidence of Danish double-dealing in connection with these negotiations. First, Frederick VI stipulated that the allied occupation troops should vacate the duchies immediately after the peace treaty was signed. Second, the king was given a choice between initially ceding only Trondheim, and then the rest of Norway following a general European peace, or of ceding the entire kingdom immediately in return for Swedish Pomerania and one million Swedish *rix-dollars*. According to Mykland, Frederick VI chose the second option as it put all Norwegians in the same boat. The third piece of circumstantial evidence is that Frederick offered to join the allied crusade against Napoleon so that he would be seen as one of the allies and could obtain a seat at the Congress of Vienna. Fourth, corn shipments to Norway continued at an accelerated pace. To these four pieces of 'evidence' Mykland adds the psychological desire common to all people to win back what they had lost.⁶

The question is simply whether all of these five pieces of circumstantial evidence need necessarily be construed as part of a Danish deception. The Danish government knew that the Norwegians would consider an uprising against the peace treaty, so this had to be taken into account.⁷ However, this does not mean that it was part of a plan. Furthermore, no monarch in his right mind would want to have hostile troops occupying his territories any longer than necessary, so it would make perfectly good sense for Frederick VI to get rid of the allied forces in Holstein. Likewise it made good sense to seek compensation for the loss of Norway, and was wise to become an ally of the powers that determined the fate of the Danish state. As to whether Denmark was

indirectly attempting to provoke and support a Norwegian rebellion, we know that the Danish government was divided.

On the one hand, Foreign Minister Rosenkrantz advised Frederick VI without reservation to live up to the terms of the Peace of Kiel, as the Danish state would otherwise be at risk. On the other hand, his chief of the general staff and in particular Christian Frederick's adjutant, who had delivered the prince's Christmas letter on 5 January, supported the idea of a rebellion. Frederick VI appears to have tergiversated, vacillating between the two views. He appears originally to have supported the idea of a rebellion, but his doubts and fears won out in the end. However, there can be no doubt that the king was personally sympathetic to Christian Frederick and to his policy in Norway at the beginning of 1814.⁸ On the other hand, the king tried to have the Norwegian part of the fleet sent to Denmark. If Christian Frederick had not refused, this would have left the Norwegians without a naval defence.

Christian Frederick was informed of the Peace of Kiel on 24 January by an emissary, who subsequently briefed him. According to Mykland, the prince's diary clearly shows that he was 'left [...] in no doubt about what the king was thinking', but there is nothing in the diary that appears to confirm this view. On the contrary, Christian Frederick wrote,

I can understand that the king was obliged to agree to the cession to obtain peace [...]. But that the king could believe that the Norwegian people would surrender voluntarily and that he could believe that I would be so contemptible as to desert them at this time is more than I can grasp.

It makes little sense, therefore, to use the prince's diary to argue that there was double-dealing, as it is clear from the exchange of letters and from the prince's own notes that Frederick VI ordered him not to defend Norway. However, the king's lack of support did not stop the heir to the throne, who also believed he was acting in accordance with Danish interests. United with Norway, Sweden would be more powerful than Denmark, which was obviously a danger to the Danish state.⁹

The king's actions have helped to lend weight to the theory of double-dealing. On 14 January, the same day that the Peace of Kiel was signed, the monarch ordered that corn shipments to Norway be stepped up, irrespective of the fact that the country was still being blockaded. Corn shipments were accordingly intensified during the spring on Danish ships with bogus papers. Christian Frederick gathered a group of Danes and Norwegians in Denmark who shipped the corn with the king's support.¹⁰

For all that, the king was forced to dismiss Frederick Moltke, minister and president of the General Customs House, who had helped to organise the corn shipments, after a compromising letter en route to Norway fell into Swedish hands. His dismissal did not, however, prevent huge quantities of corn reaching Norway in breach of Denmark's obligations under the treaty and to increasingly vociferous protests from Sweden.

Frederick VI was under steadily increasing political pressure from Sweden. This was bolstered by the continued military presence of the allies in the duchies. The pressure was further increased when Charles John persuaded the allies to support the Swedish demand for an immediate stop of all help to Norway. This prompted Frederick VI to issue an open letter in April to the effect that Denmark recognised the Swedish king as the sole legal authority in Norway, while in a private letter he encouraged Christian Frederick to give up his project in Norway. He told the prince in no uncertain terms that his advocacy of Norwegian independence was endangering the existence of Denmark. However, Frederick VI did nothing to stop corn shipments to Norway until the beginning of May, when it became known that a delegation from the great powers was on its way to Copenhagen to find out whether Denmark was honouring its obligations and to enforce the union between Sweden and Norway. A prohibition against all trade and communication with Norway was introduced on 11 May and tightened on 28 May. The corn that had already found its way to Norway was, however, a precondition for the bid for independence. Without Danish corn the Norwegians would have been forced to accept the Swedish demands outright. Paradoxically, it was thus the autocratic Danish king who would pave the way for a Norwegian constitution.¹¹

Christian Frederick, however, refused to bow to pressure from the king in the spring of 1814. On the contrary, he resolutely began to mobilise the resources of the Norwegian population – mental, physical and political – for a national struggle for liberty. However, a mobilisation of this sort takes time. The fact that Christian Frederick was left with time to act can be attributed to a combination of three factors. First, Charles John and the main body of his Swedish forces were on the continent; second, the Swedish government was weak; and, third, Christian Frederick was initially able to keep the Swedes in the dark.

Mental Mobilisation

Anti-Swedish propaganda in Norway the year before had fallen on fertile soil. The Peace of Kiel was unacceptable to the Norwegian middle class

and some of the farming class, who harboured prejudices and antipathies toward the Swedish state and did not wish to be subjected to what they called the 'Swedish yoke'. Few people believed the Swedish promises. In one of the countless pamphlets, the civil servant Christian Magnus Falsen pointed out that the Swedish promises were accompanied by the demand that Swedish troops should take over the Norwegian fortresses which, according to him, would pave the way for 'French' military despotism. Falsen painted a picture of cultural genocide where everything Norwegian would be abolished, Norway annexed to Sweden and Norwegians made slaves of the Swedish aristocracy, and skilfully played on the existing image of the enemy and on prejudices arising from the new situation.¹²

The general population feared that Norwegian peasants would be forced to fight in remote countries in Sweden's 'eternal' wars. Indeed, the presence of Swedish troops in Germany and France in 1813–14 only seemed to confirm these fears. They also remembered the many wars that Norwegians had fought against the Swedish arch-enemy, and were very much aware that Sweden had played a central role in the blockade. The Swedish 'policy of starvation' was a point that was emphasised time after time both within the country by Christian Frederick's well-oiled propaganda machine and internationally in diplomatic appeals to other European countries. However, evidence of animosity towards Sweden among the Norwegian peasantry should not be seen as being tantamount to a well-developed national identity, as some Norwegian historians have suggested over the years, any more than anti-French sentiment in the general German populace meant that they had been gripped by the nationalist fervour of the educated classes.¹³

The facts that the Peace of Kiel made Norway the property of the Swedish king and that the Swedes were prepared to assert their claim by force united the nation against the external threat. This led to Swedes being described as everything that Norwegians were not: aggressive, imperialistic, authoritarian and militaristic. There was a 'pro-Swedish' group associated with Count Wedel Jarlsberg, however, that attempted to neutralise the image of a Swedish enemy, play up the Swedish-Norwegian brotherhood, emphasise the 'naturalness' of a union between the two kingdoms of the Scandinavian peninsula and the political necessity of the union. Their contention was that the 'national' hatred between Swedes and Norwegians was exclusively the result of an instrumental 'Danish' policy to keep the Norwegians in check. The arguments of the Wedel group were fully in line with Swedish propaganda, but they had no effect on the majority of a middle class besotted

with nationalism,¹⁴ while Christian Frederick's men skilfully exploited the national hatred of the Swedes. Indeed, newspapers, periodicals, pamphlets, sermons, speeches, songs and poems all helped to create a uniformly negative stereotype of 'the Swede' as a foreign assailant who wished to oppress Norwegians.

The Prince's Policy

The intellectual and cultural attainments of the heir to the throne were far superior to the mediocre abilities of the king. In 1814, Christian Frederick proved to be a shrewd, sensitive politician who was able to take stock of the situation and change his course in accordance with it, a skilled negotiator and accomplished administrator, but, as supreme commander of the army, he failed miserably on the battlefield.¹⁵ Until the spring of 1813 Frederick VI, had denied him political influence and his appointment as governor of Norway threw him from the frying pan into the fire. However, thanks to hard work, his native charm and natural political talent, he succeeded in turning the tide in Norway in his favour and made himself a political and national Norwegian figurehead. The 28-year-old Christian Frederick appeared to some Norwegians to be almost infallible, but nobody would have been capable of living up to such superhuman expectations, and Christian Frederick was extremely human. His character, marked as it was by humanism and rationalism, prompted him to avoid all-out war with Sweden, but his own propaganda had set the stage for such a war and members of the elite, especially in western Norway and Trøndelag, expected it of him.

Christian Frederick bought himself time in January and at the beginning of February by travelling from Christiania to Trondheim, the seat of the medieval Norwegian kings, where he sounded out the mood of the people as regards a potential rebellion. At the same time, this deferred the date on which he would receive the message from Frederick VI that he had released the Norwegians from their oath of allegiance – a message that would oblige him to act. The question therefore was whether, if the prince placed himself at the head of a Norwegian rebellion, he should agree to be crowned king of Norway, as several of the older, more conservative civil servants wished, or whether he should take the course of becoming a constitutional monarch, as the younger, more progressive civil servants and the majority of the middle class wished.

Before leaving, the prince went to Eidsvoll Ironworks, northeast of Christiania, where he presented his policy, following the conservative line, to those civil servants closest to him, who supported it. Christian

Frederick then sent letters to a number of European princes in which he laid claim to the Norwegian throne, in accordance with the Norwegian Act of Sovereignty from 1661 and *Lex Regia* from 1665, and declared that Norway was at peace with all powers that were not its enemies. The former would later prove to be a strategic mistake, but not an irreversible one.

During the days from 11 to 14 February Christian Frederick received complete copies of the peace treaties with Sweden and Great Britain, as well the king's open letter dealing with the cession of Norway. In the original draft of the proclamation, Foreign Minister Rosenkrantz had emphasised that the cession was 'for all eternity' and that it applied not only to the king but also to his heirs. However, the cabinet in Copenhagen had this wording changed. What might appear as a mere formality was probably an attempt on the part of the Danish ministers to keep the door open for a later reunification in the hope that if the expected rebellion should break out it would succeed.¹⁶

The time to act had arrived. On 16 February, many of the leading civil servants, clergy, nobles and officers from southeastern Norway convened at Eidsvoll Ironworks for what was known as the 'Meeting of Notables'. Of the 21 people who attended the meeting, 19 advised the prince to accept the principle of the popular sovereignty in return for the Norwegian crown and executive power: an offer that Christian Frederick accepted pragmatically. He officially gave up any thoughts of absolutism and instead proclaimed himself regent, announced a general day of prayer in Norway and convened a Constituent Assembly at Eidsvoll on 10 April 1814. The new regent appointed a cabinet on 2 March, but the policy was still determined by him alone.

The Meeting of Notables lent an air of legitimacy to the Norwegian rebellion domestically and abroad, while the elections to the Constituent Assembly were linked with the general day of prayer in the country's churches on 25 February. From now on, the new regent would fight on constitutional lines, and his proclamation that he taken over power and convened a Constituent Assembly led to scenes of celebration in the new capital, Christiania.

Three days after the meeting at Eidsvoll Christian Frederick wrote to his autocratic cousin that he had made himself regent and that his goal was to 'safeguard the rights that have been returned to the people'. This remained Christian Frederick's policy throughout 1814. Paradoxically, the Danish prince who was the embodiment of autocracy came to champion the principles of popular sovereignty, while the former revolutionary general, Charles John, despite his promises of a

Norwegian constitution, came to represent an antiquated state policy that allowed princes to transfer between themselves power over a people without their say.¹⁷

When Home Is a Foreign Country

Nationality in absolutist Europe was defined by country of birth, and Denmark-Norway was no exception, as is made clear by the various government circulars written at the Danish Ministry of the Interior to civil servants in Denmark and Norway regarding the separation. All Danish-born officials and officers in Norway were recalled to the country of their birth, while their Norwegian-born counterparts serving in Denmark were obliged to state in writing within four weeks whether they wished to resign or remain in Danish service. Officers and civil servants were forced to choose between love of their native country, loyalty to Frederick VI and their best career prospects.

The problem was only aggravated by the fact that the absolutist 'objective' definition of nationality based on country of birth did not always harmonise with the individual's 'subjective' self-knowledge. One category faced with a dilemma here was the civil servants and officers born in Denmark of Norwegian parents, many of whom lived in Norway in 1814 and regarded themselves as Norwegians. One example was the Danish-born Norwegian, Captain Johan Ræder, who was preparing to obey the king's order and move to Denmark in the spring of 1814 to avoid a dishonourable discharge but was persuaded to stay by Christian Frederick, who reminded him of his duty to Norway.¹⁸

The fluid transition between Danish and Norwegian was nowhere better exemplified than in the case of the author Christiane Birgitte Koren, who was unable to differentiate between the interests of Denmark and Norway, and who could speak seamlessly of 'we Danes' and 'we Norwegians', without this involving any contradiction for her. After the separation and defeat by Sweden, the Danish-born Norwegian priest Frederick Schmidt remained divided between his two fatherlands because, as he wrote, he was neither Danish nor Norwegian, but either Danish-Norwegian or Norwegian-Danish. The separation remained an open wound for him as well as for Koren, and their feelings were shared to a greater or lesser degree by many Danes and Norwegians.¹⁹

Even in those cases where country of birth and subjective nationality coincided, however, what people chose was far from a foregone conclusion. Many Norwegian naval officers in Norway initially only wished to enter Norwegian service after they had either been granted an

honourable discharge or received permission to enter 'foreign' service. Few of them were prepared to swear allegiance to Norway, however, until they could be certain that they would be released from Danish service. Most of the officers in the Norwegian army, which, unlike the navy, had been an independent Norwegian force, did not feel bound to the same extent, but many of them still found it necessary to write to Frederick VI to explain their actions and to obtain an honourable discharge. By far the majority of Danish-born army officers, naval officers and civil servants in Norway chose to stay in Norway, which must chiefly be ascribed to career opportunities, to family allegiance and, for some younger officers, to the idea that they could best serve their fatherland by fighting against Sweden.²⁰

Norwegian civil servants in Copenhagen founded the Norwegian Association with the aim of enabling Norwegians in the city to help, encourage and advise each other. The association issued a declaration that Norwegians should regard Norway as their true fatherland, but that those who were still Danish citizens had a duty to Danish society and the Danish king. Frederick VI, out of fear for Sweden, had the association dissolved. However, he allowed a new and more discreet association to be founded. The 900 Norwegian seamen in the capital applied to the Swedish ambassador for passports that would enable them to go to Norway, but when he demanded that they must first swear an oath of allegiance to the Swedish king, they collectively refused to comply, after which a collection was made in Copenhagen to pay for their board and lodging in the city.²¹

During the Constituent Assembly at Eidsvoll young Norwegian lawyers from Copenhagen regularly arrived in Norway in the hope of obtaining an appointment in the as yet 'unborn state'. While what motivated these young people to return home was often their love of the fatherland, the importance of career opportunities should not be underestimated. The statistics provide a clear picture and show that it was the younger Norwegian civil servants and officers who returned home, while those in good positions who owned property, were married and had families chose to remain where they were.²²

On the Brink of Revolution?

In spite of extreme war-weariness, it was still possible to inflame hearts in Copenhagen. The students offered to go to Jutland to fight for the fatherland and the union with Norway was rejected in friendly but firm terms by the king shortly before the cession of Norway. The immediate

reactions to the Peace of Kiel in Denmark were feelings of indignation, disgrace and sorrow, combined with deep dissatisfaction with the king. A caricature of the Danish army on the stock exchange depicted the generals headless, the officers with sheep heads, while the soldiers had the heads of lions. According to a Norwegian observer everybody in Copenhagen turned against the king, while an army general stated that Frederick VI had lost the respect and trust of his subjects. Dissatisfaction spanned both social and geographical boundaries and went right up to high government and military circles. Such damage had been inflicted on Frederick's reputation that a story emerged that he had been obliged to sneak back into Copenhagen in disguise following the Peace of Kiel. According to a high-ranking civil servant, the hereditary loyalty to the king was disappearing.²³

Therefore, when the Norwegians rose under the leadership of the Danish successor, even the most conservative civil servants were gripped by enthusiasm for the rebellion. Every positive rumour from Norway was received as gospel truth, with Christian Frederick playing the part of the saviour. In spite of the fact that citizens did not have the right of free assembly in Denmark and the country was obliged by the terms of the treaty to support the Swedish claim for Norway, arrangements were made for the benefit of the Norwegians and associations for their support were founded, while people at gatherings toasted Christian Frederick and old Norway and sang the forbidden Norwegian 'national anthem'. The enthusiasm and support were not only due to love of Norway and hatred of Sweden, but also to the hope of a reunification of the twin kingdoms.²⁴

A well-known philologist continued to refer to the Norwegians as his countrymen and the highly influential priest, N.F.S. Grundtvig, called the 'twin kingdoms of the North' his true fatherland. A Danish count wrote, 'For me, Norway is part of Denmark – just as I regard Denmark as part of Norway.' A Danish professor wrote to a Norwegian friend that Norwegians should not judge Danes on the basis of the government's vacillating, feeble policy. His political creed consisted of Norway's independence, reunification and a Scandinavian union. In 1814, with people's hopes centred on the person of Christian Frederick, he was not alone.²⁵

Denmark broke its connection with Norway under international pressure, but the king refused to agree to the Swedish demand that he disinherit Christian Frederick as the successor to the throne. This could have been due to family feeling, but the king must also have feared the consequences of such a move, which according to some sources would have resulted in an immediate rebellion in Copenhagen, where people

already were talking privately about deposing the king in favour of his successor. The king wrote that disinheriting the prince would turn him into a martyr, while he would lose the love of the people.²⁶

Letters from Denmark to Christian Frederick predicted that the king would be deposed within four weeks, while the Swedish ambassador in Copenhagen reported that there were pamphlets demanding a constitution akin to the Norwegian model – a demand that, according to the ambassador, found favour in many circles. Furthermore, three Danes wrote a draft Norwegian constitution, which was sent to the Norwegian Constituent Assembly. One of the authors, Count Holstein-Holsteinborg, had described what a Danish constitution should contain as early as January 1814. In his treatise, *A Dane's Wishes for his Fatherland*, the count emphasised that in a situation in which the Danish kingdom was shaken to its very core and the state's finances were in ruins, all citizens should come forward and give expression to their thoughts about a constitution. It was necessary for the royal father of the country to meet the people half-way so that they could approach him with respect and freely tell him where they felt the best interests of the country lie. Count Holstein-Holsteinborg envisioned a combination of a heritable kingdom with a king who possessed executive power and a parliament in Copenhagen that possessed legislative power. Electoral eligibility and the franchise would be conferred on citizens without a criminal record who were over 25 years of age and owned property.²⁷

The desire for greater freedom of the press was expressed in a newspaper exactly as it had been in 1807, while a well-known poet wrote a series of articles pouring out his pent-up rage against the former ally of the state, Napoleon, comparing him to the emperor Nero. The poet had, however, miscalculated. He had underestimated the government's will to accept anything that could conceivably be interpreted as a criticism of the king's foreign policy since 1807. The matter resulted not only in the suppression of the newspaper in which the articles had been published but also in a further tightening of the legislation governing freedom of the press.²⁸

There is much to suggest a concept of kingship that was subordinate to the welfare of the nation, and a conviction that a monarch who broke his contract with the people could be deposed. The alternative to absolutism seems to have been popular sovereignty and a constitutional monarchy. Such thinking was common in Europe, Prussia being a good example. The Prussian Major Schill tried to spark off a rebellion against Napoleon in Germany in 1809 in the name of the nation and against the wishes of the Prussian king, while General Yorck signed a peace

treaty with Russia in 1813 without the acceptance of Frederick Wilhelm in order to save Prussia. For Schill and Yorck, therefore, the nation and the state weighed more heavily than loyalty to the monarch.²⁹

A House Divided

In Norway the national mood was fundamentally different in the spring of 1814, and the people were gripped by a national enthusiasm. The public became politicised to an unheard-of extent, and a host of civil servants in particular threw themselves into the task of drafting a free Norwegian constitution.

However, the 'new' Norwegian nation was a conflict zone, and this was clearly in evidence in the internal disunity in the Constituent Assembly. The Independence Party had its main bases in the western and central parts of Norway. The party was often described by the 'pro-Swedish' faction as 'pro-Danish' as its opponents believed that it would strive for a reunification with Denmark. In fact, the Independence Party obtained support from a number of partially opposed tendencies – traditional loyalty to the government and the king, hopes of a reunification with Denmark, fear of the Swedes, anti-Danish sentiments, Norwegian separatism and patriotism. All of these threads were skilfully gathered up by Christian Frederick in a national movement³⁰ that included prominent figures from the civil service and the clergy. The party's undisputed leader at Eidsvoll was Christian Magnus Falsen. Together with Christian Frederick's secretary, the Dane Johan Gunder Adler, he had written a draft constitution – read and approved by the prince – that constituted the basis of the negotiations of the constitutional committee at Eidsvoll. Falsen's close relations with the regent and their ongoing discussions during the Constituent Assembly made it possible for Christian Frederick to indirectly exercise influence over the wording of the constitution and the political debate.

The Union Party, which wanted a union with Sweden, was called 'pro-Swedish' by its opponents. The party had its main base in south-eastern Norway, where there had traditionally been closer relations with Sweden, and on the south coast of Norway. Its support came chiefly from the business community, but a number of civil servants in these areas also supported the party's line. Its undisputed leader was Count Wedel Jarlsberg. Several 'pro-Swedish' members wanted independence, but their policy was characterised by a mixture of pragmatism, level-headed considerations of practical policy and an anti-Danish attitude. Other 'pro-Swedish' members, including Wedel Jarlsberg, believed that

Norway was too weak economically and too culturally backward to become independent and should therefore enter into a union.³¹ Exactly the same view could be found among some of the 'pro-Danish' members of the Independence Party. The difference between the two parties lie in whom a union should be with.

The pro-Swedish party was united in a belief that independence was impossible in reality because the great powers would not permit it. In so far as they had a choice, the Swedish sympathisers saw only two options: a union with Denmark or a union with Sweden. Personal experience and their aversion to absolutism and Denmark would play a part here, and some became pro-Swedish because they feared reunification.³² The pro-Swedish party wanted to establish a Norwegian government that would draw up a constitution and negotiate a limited union with Sweden. If this proved impossible, they were prepared to fight to the death. Initially, the pro-Swedish party presented their plans openly, but as hatred of them flared, they held their own council and, after Eidsvoll, withdrew, resigning themselves to awaiting developments.

The group around Christian Frederick did what they could to portray the count and his followers as men who did not have the courage to fight for independence. In the spring of 1814, they were referred to as the lily-livered, half-witted or jittery party. Count Wedel's open contact with Sweden made him appear even more suspicious and *un-Norwegian*, and the count and his party were watched carefully at Eidsvoll. The pro-Swedish party was accused of treason time after time at the Constituent Assembly. Some were so intimidated by the atmosphere that they dare not voice their opinion. The simple fact that the Independence Party and the Union Party called each other 'pro-Danish' and 'pro-Swedish' respectively showed how important it was for them to question their opponents' Norwegian sympathies.³³

The support shown by elements of the merchant class for a union with Sweden prompted Christian Frederick to word the election rules in such a way as to ensure that civil servants, officers and farmers would be more strongly represented than merchants. Furthermore, an oath, which Christian Frederick had dictated that Norwegians must swear on the extraordinary day of prayer in the country's churches, bound the population as a whole and the representatives of the coming National Assembly in particular to the prince's person and to the policy of independence. The normal procedure was to swear allegiance to the new king on his succession, but the Danish heir to the throne was not yet even king of Norway. Many people did probably feel that the oath expressed traditional loyalty to the king. In principle, though, the

roles had been reversed. People did not swear an oath of loyalty to the king but to the fatherland and its independence. By making use of the church ceremonies, Christian Frederick deliberately linked religion, love of the fatherland and politics. After the ceremonies the priests and local civil servants were instructed to confirm in writing that they and their parishioners had sworn the oath with appropriate devotion to the fatherland.³⁴

Very few people had any advance knowledge of the oath. Until the moment when it was to be sworn, it had been kept secret, coming even as a surprise to many civil servants. This left people with very little time to reflect over what they were pledging, while its significance may very well have been lost on many. Yet, the common day of prayer bound the nation together in an imagined community, at least in the minds of the educated elite, who were conscious that their countrymen in other regions were swearing the same oath on the same day.

In one way, then, the event could be described as a political coup on the part of Christian Frederick. Yet, even though the full scope of the political implications may not have been clear, the day was generally characterised by great solemnity and joy. In Bergen people were recorded as having sworn the oath 'with a heart that burned for the fatherland' and with joy over their fatherland's independence. In Christiania all the church bells in the town were rung, and the event as a whole left many people deeply moved. The priest at Leirdal Church in western Norway told his congregation that the day was decisive for whether Norwegians were to be a free, independent people or slaves.

An oath to the fatherland in God's house was not to be taken lightly, and the adherents of a union did not wish to swear to uphold a policy of independence that they regarded as contrary to the country's true interests. But they felt forced to do so by Christian Frederick, as they felt that they could not refuse without being branded traitors. At the Constitutional Assembly, the priest, Nicolai Wergeland, demanded that the oath be cancelled, as the nation's representatives would otherwise be robbed of the authority given to them by the people, and Count Wedel Jarlsberg later argued that the Constituent Assembly at Eidsvoll was above the oath. Others simply did not take it seriously. A pro-Swedish priest asserted that what he saw as an irrational oath could be broken without fear, 'and heaven will not be angry!'³⁵

Christian Frederick had been in full control of Norwegian foreign policy and had a firm grip on executive power in the country. The Wedel group, however, challenged the regent's power in relation to foreign policy. The instrument for this would be a committee set up by the

Constituent Assembly with the aim of investigating Norway's relations with other countries. The Independence Party immediately contested the assembly's right to do so on the grounds that it had been elected for the sole purpose of writing a constitution. The pro-Swedish faction undermined this argument pointing out that the assembly had already set up a finance committee and a legislative committee. They added that the people had placed their sovereignty in the hands of the assembly through elections. Although the Union Party was in the minority, their apparently incontestable defence won them many adherents to their views. The Independence Party immediately fought back, however.

In his speech at the opening of the assembly on 11 April, Christian Frederick had made it clear that the oath sworn at the election simply entitled the assembly to write a constitution and elect a king. This argument was also repeated in newspapers, possibly influenced by the regent, who also made use of his allies among the deputies of the Constitutional Assembly. The vote between the opposing sides tied at 55 to 55, which meant that the final decision was made by the president of the assembly, who had been assigned a double vote. These he cast in favour of the Independence Party. This meant that Christian Frederick retained his unlimited control of foreign policy and could prevent information from abroad undermining the course of his policy.³⁶

The Ghost of Reunification

The question of a reunification of Norway and Denmark was constantly waiting in the wings of the political stage. Conservative Norwegians, such as ironworks-owner Jacob Aall, regarded the 'divorce' as a catastrophe that should make every Norwegian heart bleed.³⁷ His sorrow was in glaring contrast to the delight felt by others now that Danish fetters had been cast off, but the most widespread feelings were bewilderment, anger and disappointment that the Danes had not even fought to retain Norway. Even though many people differentiated between the Danish people and the despised Danish government, Danes were objects of hatred. A Danish-born civil servant in Norway wrote in April 1814 that the people

in this country heap abuse on Danish civil servants and would like to see the back of the lot of them, as anybody who has not been rocked in his cradle on Norwegian soil is now considered a foreigner and should as such be excluded from everything.³⁸

This attitude was chiefly due to the fear felt by many Norwegians that the Danish-born inhabitants were working behind the scenes to bring about a reunification.

The struggle over one of the most burning issues of the day took place at Eidsvoll: should Norway be reunited with Denmark? Historians have disagreed as to the extent of any Norwegian desire for such a reunion in the spring of 1814. That prominent 'pro-Danish' men wanted a reunification is indisputable, but they wanted it on completely different and equal terms. Others hoped for a Scandinavian union under Christian Frederick. On the other hand, it was clear that many of the patriots in the Independence Party did not want a new union with Denmark. Several pro-Swedish figures, such as the priest Wergeland, openly fought the independence movement because it was led by a Danish prince surrounded by Danish civil servants, and they feared that the 'independence' policy would bring the country back under Danish rule.³⁹

It is impossible to provide a definitive answer, but there is no getting away from the fact that the election of the heir to the Danish throne as the king of Norway as well as the wording of the constitution of 1814 itself made reunification not only possible but probable in the long term. The pro-Danish contingent argued that even though the union with Denmark had had its drawbacks, a new union in the future would be both useful and necessary. This can be understood to mean that the choice was between Sweden and Denmark and that the latter was the lesser of two evils, but it is not improbable that another circumstance played a role in the deliberations over reunification. There were rumours circulating at Eidsvoll of a forthcoming revolution and a new constitution for Denmark, and these were lent credence by the fact that the Danes had sent a draft Norwegian constitution across the Skagerrak. There was, therefore, an expectation that any new union would be fundamentally different to the old one. Even though most adherents of reunification envisioned an equal, constitutional union, then, a large minority at Eidsvoll was still opposed to a new union with Denmark in any form.⁴⁰

The Struggle over Citizenship

The thorny issue of Norwegian–Danish relations also came to the forefront in the debate on citizenship at the National Assembly. Nationality was not seen *simply* as a question of a subjective feeling or of objective criteria. It was also a practical question of the individual's status under constitutional law. Differences lie between a civil and an ethnic view of nationality.

It was quite clear that the dispute was very much a question of whether Danes would be entitled to obtain official posts in Norway, and the discussion about citizenship can be found in many of the draft constitutions and addresses to the National Assembly, where several people questioned the patriotism of Danes *and* foreigners.⁴¹ The distinction made here shows that Danes were at one and the same time inside and outside.

The point of departure for one of the most heated debates at Eidsvoll was the law on citizenship of 1776. The National Assembly's constitutional committee proposed that anyone who had sworn to uphold the constitution, was over 18 years of age, spoke the country's language and who either had Norwegian parents or had lived in the kingdom for five years was a Norwegian citizen. Any foreigner who had already sworn to uphold the constitution and who resided in the country should, like the many Danish-born civil servants, be regarded as Norwegian citizens. This liberal proposal divided the assembly. Cultural nationalists argued that only native Norwegians could occupy state posts. Native Norwegians were understood as (1) those born within the borders of the Norwegian state of parents who were subjects of the state; (2) those who had been born of Norwegian parents who were travelling abroad; and (3) the non-native civil servants who had already sworn an oath of loyalty. The proposal meant that the Storting could not naturalise Danes or foreigners, the fear being that they would remain loyal to their country of birth.⁴²

The arguments were countered by pro-Danish voices who claimed that there was a serious lack of civil servants in the state, which it was only logical to remedy by employing Danes, a 'people who had language and customs in common with us'.⁴³ The result was a compromise between voluntarism, country of birth and language. State posts were reserved for Norwegian citizens who subscribed to the evangelical Lutheran faith, had sworn loyalty to the constitution and the king, spoke the country's language and lived up to one of four criteria: (1) that they had been born in the country; (2) that they had been born abroad of Norwegian parents; (3) that they had had permanent residence in the country before the separation and had not refused to swear the oath on Norway's independence; or (4) that they have lived in the country for ten years. Teachers at institutes of higher education and doctors, however, were exempted from these conditions. Furthermore, the Storting would have the power to naturalise foreigners. This power had been deliberately withheld from the new king as it was feared he would use it to employ Danes in state posts and undermine their newly won autonomy.

While Danes could now obtain Norwegian citizenship, there were other groups that could not. The Constitutional Act stated that Lutheranism was the state religion. This was emphasised by the fact that only Lutherans could be appointed to civil service posts in Norway, and was underpinned by a prohibition against Jesuits, monastic orders and Jews settling in Norway. This should be set in the context of the dislike felt for merchants by many Norwegian patriots, of quite widespread European anti-Semitism and of the need to create a statutory example. Paradoxically, the same year the autocratic Frederick VI granted Danish Jews (almost) full citizenship in spite of some public opposition. Progressive forces in Norway abolished the 'Jewish clause' of the constitution in 1851, but Jesuits had to wait until 1956 before they would be welcome in Norway.

The Norwegian Constitutional Act and the National Monarchy

The National Assembly created the most liberal constitution in Europe, but to call it democratic would be an anachronism. The constitution was based on the idea of a monarchy and devoid of references to republics and democracies. The concept of democracy was popularly connected with radicalism and Robespierre's reign of terror. The men at Eidsvoll were liberals in a nineteenth-century sense. They believed in the tripartite separation of powers between a legislative, an executive and a judicial power, which in the case of Norway consisted of the parliament, the king and the courts of law, alongside an assurance of the basic rights of citizens. It envisaged strong royal power, which had similarities with the theory of 'of absolutism governed by public opinion', with the monarch as an independent instance who had no private interests and served the people. Christian Frederick took on in large measure the functions and authority of an absolutist king. A district recorder held that one would live and die with Christian Frederick, and the notion that he would rule the country like a father 'and treat us all as the country's children' was characteristic of this thinking.⁴⁴

The number of people who were entitled to vote in Norway was greater than in most other liberal states between 1814 and 1848. The status of the farmer with an allodial title as a national symbol meant that the franchise became widespread. Prominent figures such as Christian Magnus Falsen were deeply enamoured of the farming class, while others were afraid that enfranchising farmers would lead to a mob rule dominated by ignorance. To understand the events of the

spring it is important to remember the situation Norway was in. For the independence project of the elite to succeed, it had to be supported by the population as a whole. The hope was that, by giving the people responsibility, their support for the nationalist concept would be won. All Norwegian men aged 25 and over who either were civil servants, owned registered land or owned property worth 300 national bank dalers in silver were entitled to vote in elections. This corresponded to c. 40 per cent of the male population, so war and nationalism would appear to have had a democratising effect. Elections, however, were indirect, which helped to give civil servants a monopoly of power. They had ruled in the name of the king before 1814; now they ruled in the name of the nation.⁴⁵

Norwegians swore allegiance to the new king of Norway, Christian Frederick, and the new Constitutional Act was read out at public assemblies throughout the country and to soldiers in the army. Norway was now an independent kingdom with its own constitution. It is debatable, however, whether ordinary Norwegians understood the situation. A young officer wrote later that 'we were very pleased that we would not become Swedish subjects; I believe we thought we had enough freedom because we did not have the faintest idea what a so-called constitution meant'.⁴⁶ If this young, well-educated officer hardly knew what a constitution was, it is unlikely that many peasants would have known.

This changed as time went on and as the Constitutional Act, which is celebrated each year on 17 May, became the foundation of a Norwegian sense of self. What was central in 1814 was the election of the king, a Danish prince paradoxically becoming the symbol of a resurrected Norway. That the focus later switched from the king to the constitution is largely due to the fact that the national kingdom established at Eidsvoll was forcibly replaced by a Swedish-French monarchy that was initially regarded as foreign. Christian Frederick was compared to the ancient Norwegian hero kings from the time before the union with Denmark, and in Christiania Cathedral people sang, 'Each time we voice our fatherland, our heart is praising Christian'.⁴⁷

Christian Frederick's supporters each saw in him what they wished to see, so he was regarded in various guises as the embodiment of liberalism, of nationalism and of traditional Danish-Norwegian royal power. According to one of the deputies of the National Assembly, Christian Frederick was perceived in the spring of 1814 as an earthly messiah, which underlined the quasi-religious adoration of the prince. He was made an infallible national symbol who was at one with the nation while at the same time standing, paradoxically, for hopes of reunification.

Conscription and the Will to Defend the Country

The exploitation of historical examples and nationalist rhetoric in the war propaganda fell on fruitful soil. One author claimed that Charles John and his dastardly army would be annihilated in the same way as the Scottish colonel George Sinclair and his 300 mercenaries had been slaughtered by Norwegian peasants in Gudbrandsdalen in 1612. Another woman went even further in a notice in a newspaper when she offered to organise and lead a female army corps 'like some Amazon or shield-maiden'.⁴⁸

There was military conscription in Norway and had been, in various guises, since 1628. But it was not a matter of general conscription as there were still plenty of exemptions as well as a right to buy substitutes. Proposals for general conscription emerged as early as 1807, with references to ancient Sparta and contemporary France as well as to the idea that every citizen had a duty to defend his country. However, the idea only took on a political dimension in 1814. The Constitutional Assembly saw a clash between the interests and ideals of the elite. The main question was whether young students should be exempted or whether conscription should be the personal duty of every citizen regardless of social rank and occupation. Arguments for general conscription rested not only on middle-class ideals of equality, civic duty and self-sacrifice, but also on nationalist ideas that conscription would awaken the spirit of the people and strengthen the national character.⁴⁹

Opponents, on the other hand, emphasised the fear that general conscription would threaten the freedom of individuals (i.e. of the elite), their refinement and their performance of civic functions. The question was to what extent the traditional class society should be broken down for the sake of the universal rights and duties of all inhabitants of the country. A particular element in the Norwegian debate on conscription was the inspiration derived from the historian Laurits Engelstoft's work on national upbringing and, through that, from the French Revolution. The chief spokesman for general conscription wanted all boys from the age of 13 to perform military exercises and attend lectures on the Constitutional Act, history and geography.⁵⁰

The peculiar situation in the spring of 1814 initially secured victory for the radical point of view, but disagreement among the elite meant that there would have to be a debate at the first assembly of the Storting to decide whether the provision should be circumscribed in practice. Furthermore, there was no immediate attempt to realise the plan for national upbringing on practical and ideological grounds. The question

of general conscription created a heated public debate in 1815 with both parties arguing in the name of the nation. Opponents of conscription asserted that a large army was no longer affordable or necessary, and that true love of the fatherland was not created on the drill ground but in the schoolroom.⁵¹ This opinion won the day, as a majority in the Storting had begun to take a less radical line after the defeat of 1814. The Conscription Act retained the principle of general conscription as a personal duty but introduced a whole range of exceptions that were carefully tailored to the interests of the civil servant class.⁵²

Contributions on the Altar of the Fatherland

Norwegians had been bled dry after seven years of war, starvation and blockade, but the prospect of national independence and resistance to the feared 'Swedish yoke' created not only widespread euphoria in the spring but also enabled one last financial effort to be made. The people donated large sums as well in gold, silver, copper and food to the 'reborn' fatherland, while women gave their jewellery to make a crown for Christian Frederick. However, donations were not always voluntary. Merchants in Trondheim were summoned to the council hall on the orders of the prince to state how much corn they would donate. Those who refused were written up in the register as 'wicked men in the community', while those who did donate corn could count on finding favour with the regent. There can hardly be any doubt that the authorities used nationalism instrumentally and that this sometimes amounted to coercion, serving the interests of the elite and of social control. But, as the entire public domain, including people's letters and diaries, was saturated with references to nationalism in 1814, this cannot be seen solely as an identity imposed on people. The actions performed by members of the elite were based on existing national or patriotic ideas and not solely on Christian Frederick's policy.⁵³

A Free Norway or a United Scandinavia

Although Christian Frederick built his policy supported by the patriotic idealism and nationalistic enthusiasm of the Independence Party, he had no illusions either as regent or as king. On the contrary, he shared the view of the pro-Swedish party that an independent Norway would never survive without international recognition. In hindsight it may appear obvious that the Norwegian project was doomed to failure because the great powers supported the Swedish demand, but one should not leap to over-hasty conclusions.

The self-proclaimed Norwegian regent was obliged to act on the basis of scant and inaccurate information filtered through Charles John's headquarters or from the British Foreign Minister, Lord Castlereagh, who was on the continent. He could not trust Swedish information, while the British information did not initially cause him concern. Furthermore, Christian Frederick placed considerable weight on political developments in Great Britain, where he hoped he would be able to influence the prevailing mood.⁵⁴ To this must be added the general awareness that the Napoleonic era was characterised by abrupt political reversals and new alliances, during which ancient thrones and royal houses fell, states were swallowed up and new states arose. Christian Frederick therefore attempted to exploit the opportunities that might crop up. In this situation it was sensible to play for time, try to drive a wedge between the great powers and win the support of Britain, while at the same time uniting the nation and creating a new constitutional monarchy so that he could present the international community with a *fait accompli* that was an expression of the Norwegian people's will. In this connection, the Constitutional Act was probably more of an instrument to this end than a goal in itself for Christian Frederick. The prince, who was extremely well informed about conditions in Europe, probably knew that the government of Bavaria in 1808 had passed constitutional acts in order to keep Napoleon at bay, as such constitutional acts prohibited outside interference.

In March, Christian Frederick sent his old friend and loyal supporter, ironworks owner and civil servant Carsten Anker, to Great Britain in order to gain the support of British politicians and public opinion for a free, independent Norway. In London, Anker succeeded in gaining the support of the public, some members of the royal family and the liberal opposition in parliament for Norwegian views, but the government remained unshakeably committed to Britain's treaty obligations. The official explanation was that the government would not go back on its promise to Sweden, and emphasis was placed on Christian Frederick's title of heir to the Danish throne. The British government would also have been reluctant to challenge Sweden's Russian ally, who wholeheartedly supported the Swedish demand in general and Charles John in particular. Support for the Swedish acquisition of Norway was the price Russia gladly paid to avoid a future Swedish revanchism in relation to Finland. The British attitude was a death sentence for an independent Norway.

Christian Frederick, however, was betting on two horses. He repeatedly told the many Swedish emissaries that Norwegians were not opposed to

an equal union with Sweden in principle but did fear a merger with Sweden that might lead to their being ruled by a foreign prince such as Charles John, who had no understanding of the country's practices, customs or language. In other words, Christian Frederick regarded the French-born crown prince as the primary obstacle to a peaceful union of the two kingdoms. The solution for the Danish-Norwegian prince was naturally to try to remove Charles John from the running and to take his place, which in the longer term would pave the way for a federal Scandinavian union ruled by Christian Frederick. This might suggest that the prince had miscalculated by underestimating the opposition he would meet in Stockholm and the difficulty of getting rid of Charles John. The question is perhaps rather whether Christian Frederick was attempting to consider any solution whatsoever.

Paradoxically, Charles John was indirectly assisting Christian Frederick in his plans, as the Swedish crown prince was energetically attempting to exchange his title as heir to the Swedish throne for the French crown at the expense of the Bourbon dynasty. If this scheme had been successful, it would not only have left Sweden without a crown prince but also without a leader. In that situation the election of Christian Frederick would peacefully bring Norway into a union with Sweden, exactly as Swedish politicians had hoped with Christian August in 1809. Charles John's person and his actions in the campaign against Napoleon had, however, brought him an increasing number of enemies among the allies. Therefore, by the time Charles John reached Paris in April, his chance of winning the French throne had already been lost. The prospect of gaining a Polish-Saxon throne had also been of interest to Charles John for a while, something that shows how he used his status as Swedish crown prince to help him pursue his personal interests.⁵⁵

Christian Frederick was very much aware that a settling of accounts with the Napoleonic era was in the air. With the help of Anker in London and by writing letters to the heads of all of the European great powers, he attempted to gain their support for the idea that Charles John and the 'Napoleonites' should be deposed as part of a general European restoration. He hoped that arguments of this type would be more palatable now that Napoleon had fallen, an event that had taken place, it should be noted, without Charles John's help, since he had set his own ambitions in Scandinavia before the allies' war with the French emperor. Christian Frederick attempted to win over the Russians in support of his plan to gain the 'Scandinavian throne' by offering to marry the Tsar's sister.⁵⁶ This idea was not conjured out of thin air, for

the legitimist party at the Congress of Vienna would later sweep Napoleon's former Marshal Murat off the throne of Naples.

Christian Frederick placed his trust in the Prussian Foreign Minister Hardenberg, to whom the Norwegian regent passed a letter via the minister's own son, Baron C.H.A. Hardenberg-Reventlow, a Danish landowner and friend of Christian Frederick. In this instance the young Hardenberg-Reventlow acted as an emissary both of the Norwegian regent and of the Danish government, which was attempting to arrange a peace treaty with Prussia at the time. The Danish–Prussian peace treaty was signed on 2 July, but the attempt to win Prussian support for Norwegian independence was unsuccessful. On the other hand, it appears that Hardenberg-Reventlow did succeed in creating a more favourable Prussian attitude to the Norwegian cause, and this was significant for the delegation from the great powers sent to Norway.⁵⁷

Christian Frederick also tried winning the Swedish king for the plan of a Scandinavian union at the expense of the Swedish crown prince. Christian Frederick argued that in the event of Charles John's death or relinquishment of his Swedish title to obtain another throne, the king should adopt the Danish prince. This attempt was unsuccessful, and in the eyes of posterity it may appear to have been a desperate measure, but the situation Christian Frederick and Norway found themselves in was desperate and this meant that no stone was to be left unturned. Christian Frederick's approach to Charles XIII was not really as strange as it might appear, however. It should be remembered that Christian Frederick had been among the candidates in the election of a Swedish crown prince in 1810, in which he was supported by Charles XIII. Furthermore, it could well have been clear to the Swedish government in the spring of 1814 that Charles John was prepared to set aside Swedish interests for the benefit of his French project. On the other hand, the situation in Sweden in 1814 was fundamentally different to what it had been in 1810, and it can hardly have been of much interest to anyone in Stockholm to replace Charles John with the heir to the Danish throne when the old Swedish dream of acquiring Norway was on the verge of being realised.

Christian Frederick was not the only person in Norway to dream of a Scandinavian union. The leader of the Independence Party, Christian Magnus Falsen, shared the prince's ideas but he was probably not aware of how unstable the foundation of this policy was. As regent, Christian Frederick deliberately attempted to prevent Norwegians from learning the truth about the difficulties besetting his foreign policy. Long before Napoleon's final defeat in the spring of 1814, Christian Frederick had

been aware that Norway's fate was in the hands of Great Britain and Russia. Even *before* the Constitutional Assembly had been convened, he had written to Frederick VI and Niels Rosenkrantz and also noted in his diary that, if the Norwegian independence project proved to be hopeless, he would not hesitate to do his utmost to ensure that Norway obtained the best possible terms in a union with Sweden, and that he would not allow his own personal interests to obstruct this. This union needed to be based on the constitution that the Norwegians were about to create, as it would ensure the country's independence. The regent hoped that British mediation would prompt the Swedes to accept a constitution adopted by Norwegians themselves as the basis of a union. If they refused, Norway would oppose the union by force.⁵⁸

Swedish Policy

On 8 February, King Charles XIII sent a letter to the Norwegian people. In ceremonious terms, the real author of the letter, Charles John, promised them freedom, brotherhood and a constitution. This appeared attractive on the face of it, but the Swedish crown prince also made it clear that he did not approve of any thoughts of popular sovereignty and that the future constitution would have to meet with his approval. At the same time Charles John demanded that the Norwegians should receive the troops of the Swedish occupation with open arms. With the latter in mind, it is not surprising that many Norwegians took a sceptical view of their traditional arch-enemy.

Initially, the Swedes were not sure what was happening in Norway. It was only at the beginning of March that it became clear to the Swedes that they had been made fools of, but even then they hesitated to resort to the use of brute force. This can be partly explained by their fear of appearing to be the aggressor but equally by the simple fact that the Swedish field army was then in continental Europe. At about the same time as the news of what was going on in Norway reached the Swedish government at home, it also reached the Swedish crown prince, who angrily issued a new proclamation threatening death and destruction to all Norwegians.⁵⁹

Charles John applied to the allies for help in enforcing the Swedish demands in Norway. His diplomatic efforts were given extra impetus as it increasingly became clear to him that the French crown was beyond his grasp. This diplomatic pressure was not only applied to Norway but also to Denmark in the suspicion that the Danes might have a hidden agenda. However, the tirades of abuse and bombastic proclamations

that Charles John spat out at Danish, Swedish and allied statesmen should no more be taken at face value than his threats to bombard Copenhagen and raze the Danish royal castle to the ground. In London Charles John's broadsides were referred to as 'gasconades' in scarcely veiled reference to the Swedish crown prince's choleric temperament and origins.⁶⁰

However, Charles John's impetuous statements should also not simply be written off as imaginary plans conjured out of thin air. His threats should be seen to reflect not only his desire to force through a union between Sweden and Norway but also his attempts to erase Denmark from the map. The German romantic poet August Wilhelm Schlegel, who acted as Charles John's secretary, was instructed to draw up a pamphlet entitled *Praeterea censeo, Daniam esse delendam* (*Moreover, I Believe that Denmark Must Be Destroyed*). This pamphlet presented what Schlegel saw as decidedly Danish faithlessness. His central criticism was connected with Germany: he disapproved of the fact that, after the dissolution of the Holy Roman Empire in 1806, Denmark had made Holstein an integral part of the Danish state and prevented the region taking part in the national struggle for liberation against the French. Schlegel saw Denmark as a country that, like Carthage, deserved destruction, and he assigned the role of Rome to Britain.

Charles John enjoyed the support of the tsar. The close relations between Sweden and Russia since 1812, Charles John's well-publicised threats and the Russian army of occupation in Holstein, which amounted to 60,000 men, gave Frederick VI good grounds to fear for the future of his state. Charles John had shown a warm interest in Zealand in particular, which he wanted to annex to Sweden, but his dreams in this respect collided with the problem that ever since 1658 the great powers had opposed any state attempting to control both sides of the Sound – and thereby the entrance to the Baltic. However, this did not prevent the crown prince pestering the great powers with a steady stream of plans as to precisely how Denmark could be carved up between Sweden and various powers, including Great Britain, Prussia, numerous German duchies and Russia (which could have northern Norway).⁶¹ Among Charles John's more imaginative plans was the establishment of a Cimbric kingdom in the Jutland peninsula, a reference to the ancient people who had lived there before Christ.

In the spring of 1814, however, the allied powers had other things on their mind than sending troops to a rebellious Norway or dismantling Denmark. The blockade of Norway was, however, maintained, while a commission comprising representatives from Russia, Austria, Prussia

and Britain headed first for Denmark and then for Norway to enforce the Swedish demands. Christian Frederick received news of this on 18 May, the day after he had been elected king of Norway, and he began to doubt whether he should accept the Norwegian throne at all. In the event, however, he decided to use his election and the new constitution to create the best possible bargaining position for Norway. Christian Frederick made it clear from the beginning of the negotiations with the international commission that he was prepared to relinquish his crown but that he was bound by the Constitutional Act not to pass it on to others. According to the Act, the power to do this lay exclusively with the Storting. The constitution and the national enthusiasm that the rhetoric and policy of Christian Frederick and the Independence Party had created among the population permitted first the king and then the Norwegian politicians to refer to what the Norwegian people would accept before they could enter into a peaceful union with Sweden. Charles John and the Swedish negotiators were susceptible to arguments of this type, precisely because they feared that if they attempted to establish a union by force and annex Norway, the country could turn into what Spain had been for Napoleon or what Tyrol had been for Bavaria.⁶²

This argument also became central to determining which Swedish policy would prevail in deciding how the union between Norway and Sweden should be implemented. Traditional Gustavian policy towards Norway had involved annexing the country fully to Sweden or turning Norway into a Swedish dependency. On the face of it, to judge from the Peace of Kiel, this was the policy that had prevailed.⁶³ Charles John, however, had other plans for Norway that were far more in line with Norwegian wishes than those expressed by the old aristocrats in Stockholm. This had already become apparent in the peace treaty where, in accordance with his wishes, article four made it plain that Norway was not to be annexed to Sweden, but to be united with it under the Swedish king.

Some contemporaries, considering Charles John's revolutionary background, ascribed to him a liberal frame of reference, but the crown prince's attitude might better be interpreted as out-and-out pragmatism with a good splash of opportunism. First, support for the Swedish crown prince in Norway was based on the promises of Norwegian autonomy and a Norwegian constitution that he had given to pro-Swedish parties. Second, as long as Charles John still nursed the hope that he could gain the French throne, he would pursue a cautious policy in order to win the support of liberal circles associated with Benjamin Constant and

Madame de Staël. He could hardly argue for the right of the French to elect their own constitutional king while denying Norwegians' right to do the same. Third, Charles John feared a Gustavian restoration in Sweden. If that happened, it would be an advantage to have an additional kingdom at hand, but this naturally required a cautious approach in Norway. He also feared that any brutal suppression of the Norwegians could lead to interference on the part of the great powers, especially Great Britain. Charles John had promised the British in 1813 that he would secure the freedom and happiness of the Norwegian people.⁶⁴

Charles John later delighted in depicting himself as the person who had given Norwegians real freedom with the Peace of Kiel. In some respects this is true, as the peace treaty in Holstein was the decisive factor in creating the basis for Norwegian independence and the Norwegian constitution. Norwegians could also thank Charles John for the restrained policy that eventually helped to create a union between Sweden and Norway on reasonable terms. But Charles John acted as he did for his own sake and not to benefit the Norwegians. As a Swedish and Norwegian king he not only strove to create a far closer union between the two kingdoms than Norwegians wanted, he also attempted to strengthen his power at the expense of the Storting, the Constitutional Act and freedom of speech. Many of the liberal concessions he had given to the Norwegians as crown prince in 1814 he attempted to withdraw as king – but without success.

Targeting the Common People

As had been the case in previous years, the common people in Norway were a main target for the Swedes in 1814. There was a firm belief in Swedish political and military circles that, while the peasants – especially in the borderlands – may not have been terribly keen on Swedish rule they were inclined at least to accept a union in 1814 and thus turn their backs on Christian Frederick and those among the elite who opposed it.

Some historians have made much of hints of a Norwegian constitution in Swedish proclamations, but they also contained many less abstract promises primarily targeting ordinary people in the rural borderlands. One proclamation provided an account of what had happened at Kiel and went on to inform the people that as 'a consequence, Swedish troops will cross your borders. Receive them with calmness and trust. They will come as brothers, as soldiers of a natural, common nation' and 'bring you rights and liberty'. Furthermore, it emphasised that the Swedes 'have done everything possible to hasten grain supplies

for you. Your renewed, enlivened trade and your ports that are now open will help us in our efforts and will pave the way for the prosperity that you have lacked for so long'.⁶⁵

These promises fell on deaf ears, however, and Swedish hopes were dashed. Their response was to tighten the Swedish-British blockade of Norway from March 1814 onwards, the aim being to turn the populace against Christian Frederick and the government by claiming they were to blame for the renewal of the blockade and consequent misery in Norway. A wide assortment of propaganda to this effect was distributed across the border.⁶⁶

There is little to suggest that there was much in the way of heartfelt sympathy for Swedish rule or other pro-Swedish sentiment in the borderlands and the Norwegian authorities seem to have had far more faith in the loyalty of the people in 1814 than had been the case six years previously. But the prospect of yet another invasion was instrumental in tempering and cooling the general enthusiasm towards the policy of national independence pursued by Christian Frederick and many members of the elite.

A People's War as a Political Instrument

Even if, as some have argued, Christian Frederick did not expect war, he had to consider it a possibility and make preparations for it. He therefore issued a proclamation on 9 June that called for all able-bodied Norwegian men to take up arms. This has been construed by many historians as an appeal for voluntary enlistment. Christian Frederick, however, knew perfectly well that the proclamation called rather for the organisation and training of the traditional peasant militia based on mandatory service.

This is an important, and new, point. Christian Frederick's intention was for the peasant militia to act as a deterrent, and in this sense the general mobilisation in Norway in 1814 was chiefly for the sake of appearances. By making it appear as though the militias were voluntary rather than conscripted, he was trying to create an impression of national unity and unanimous support for the constitution and national independence. This, in turn, could possibly persuade the allies and Sweden to opt for a negotiated solution rather than war. It was no coincidence that the proclamation of 9 June was issued immediately after informal negotiations with an unofficial English emissary had broken down, thereby creating the impression that Norwegians could constitute a formidable obstacle to Sweden in the event of a war.

Attempts to impress the Swedes with a daunting vision of what they could expect of a war in Norway had, in fact, begun several months previously when Swedes had been warned that the Norwegians would not 'be subjugated' and 'that if their opponents allowed the situation to go to extremes, they would do so at their peril'. Furthermore, allied mediators who had been sent to Christiania in July warned Charles John that in the event of an invasion and war, the Swedes could expect to find 'a courageous people' who would defend themselves in rugged terrain, and create great difficulties for the Swedish army. In his detailed instructions to military commanders on how to deploy the peasant militiamen, Christian Frederick went so far as to suggest they should wage guerrilla war, word of which he obviously hoped would reach the Swedes and deter them.⁶⁷

Christian Frederick was well aware of what had occurred elsewhere in Europe in previous years and made remarks about the unwinnable 'national' wars in Germany and Spain. If Charles John drew a similar conclusion, it was possible that the prospect of such a war in Norway would help bring about a negotiated solution and increase the chances of Norwegian autonomy. So, if popular mobilisation could be called 'a pet project' for Christian Frederick, as one historian has it, it was due to its potential as a political instrument, not because Christian Frederick seriously intended to wage a savage guerrilla war.⁶⁸

The extent to which arming the Norwegian population in the summer of 1814 was a source of concern for the Swedes is debatable, although several historians have argued that there was considerable concern that an invasion of Norway would meet fierce resistance.⁶⁹ A lieutenant wrote in his memoirs that, when he and his troops took part in the invasion, they had braced themselves for 'the second act of the Franco-Spanish war because the Norwegians threatened to put up desperate resistance, and the hatred of the Swedes in Norway was well known to us'. Many expressed similar views and compared the situation to the Vendée and Calabria. One observer remarked on the eve of the invasion that 'Hatred in Norway is greater than anyone can believe, even among women and children.'⁷⁰

For this reason, Foreign Minister Lars von Engeström was warned in February 1814 that 'if Norwegian blood is to be spilled by Swedish weapons, enmity between both nations will be eternal. Upholding peace and calm in Norway will require great sacrifices and expenditure for a long time.' Shortly before the invasion commenced, a Swedish county governor reminded a Swedish field marshal about Norway's 'mountains and cliffs' from which 'logs and similar missiles' could be 'hurled down

on advancing troops', which was what had happened to Bavarian and French troops in Tyrol in 1809.⁷¹

Anxiety about what might happen in a war with Norway, however, was not universal – and was not shared by Charles John himself. He was certainly bent on avoiding a prolonged and costly war, but he does not seem to have been seriously concerned that the invasion would turn into a desperate guerrilla war. Rather, ferocious resistance in Norway was seen as one of several possibilities, but nonetheless one that could be dealt with pragmatically.⁷²

The Diplomatic Endgame

Before the international commission arrived in Norway, the British government had sent the diplomat John Philip Morier to the country. Morier, who soon developed a sympathy both for the Norwegian cause and for Christian Frederick, made it clear to the newly elected Norwegian king that the British government insisted on a union between Norway and Sweden. Christian Frederick accepted the inevitable but demanded that the union should be personal in which Norway would be ruled by a common king independently of Sweden. At the same time, it appears that he had not yet quite given up his Scandinavian dream, since he suggested that, in order to reduce national hatred, there should be a 'dynastic' agreement under which the union of the two kingdoms would be deferred until one of the two dynasties in either Norway or Sweden died out, whereupon a representative of the surviving dynasty would take over the thrones of both countries. A scheme of this kind was completely unrealistic at the time, though Morier actually appears to have been amenable to it. However, it was not a view shared by either Charles Karl XIII or Sweden's real leader, Charles John, and that was the decisive factor.

More importantly, Christian Frederick had asked for British mediation and declared that he was willing in principle to agree to Morier's demand that he should convene the Storting in accordance with the Constitutional Act in order to settle the question of Norway's future. The king initially convened a meeting of the cabinet, who supported the idea of an extraordinary session of the Storting at which a union with Sweden could be discussed, and voting arrangements were immediately set in motion. While Christian Frederick had dreamt of the reunification of Denmark and Norway and of preserving the Oldenburg dynasty, it is clear from his letters and diaries that the factor determining his policy was his concern for the well-being of the Norwegian people.

The international commission did not arrive in Christiania until 30 June. The reasons for the delay were twofold. On the one hand the Russian, Austrian and Prussian emissaries had been obliged to wait before they were joined by the British diplomat, August John Foster, and on the other, the British – influenced by the reports from Morier in Norway – surprisingly began to reverse their policy. Foster attempted to prevent the mission, and allegedly expressed the opinion that an independent Norway could not harm anyone. However, the commission arrived in Norway and began negotiations with Christian Frederick, with whom they were able to reach a reasonable measure of agreement. The Norwegian king would accept a union if it involved a certain degree of Norwegian independence and a strong viceroy in the country (a role that Christian Frederick was willing to assume). This was under the condition, however, that there was a truce while an election was held to the Storting that would approve the agreement, which, in principle, would be based on acceptance of the Eidsvoll constitution. The four emissaries were in full agreement here, but as a condition for the truce they demanded that the Norwegian army should withdraw from the area east of the River Glomma and surrender the border fortresses of Fredrikstad, Frederiksten and Kongsvinger to the Swedes. It was this demand that in the final analysis led to the breakdown of negotiations, as the Norwegian minister claimed – correctly – that it would be a violation of the Constitutional Act and that the Norwegians would not accept it.

On 22 July the representatives of the great powers presented a draft settlement to Charles John, who was now encamped on the Norwegian border with a Swedish army that had returned from its European campaign. The meeting soon began to teeter on the brink of a breakdown, because the draft document presented by four emissaries was almost identical to the Norwegian proposal, but a compromise was arrived at. Christian Frederick would abdicate, the blockade of Norway would be lifted and the Swedes would occupy Fredrikstad and Frederiksten, but not Kongsvinger. In return, the Norwegians would be entitled to have their own parliament. The demand for Christian Frederick's immediate abdication must be ascribed to Charles John's fear of a Norwegian delaying tactic and a winter war in Norway. The Norwegian king and his minister, however, refused to accept these terms, as Christian Frederick's abdication without the approval of the Storting would be a breach of the Constitutional Act, which would undermine all their efforts to retain it before the unavoidable union with Sweden. As far as the border area and the fortresses were concerned, the Norwegians

were willing to vacate them but would not agree to the Swedes occupying them. Christian Frederick had the exchange of memos published to inform the Norwegian people of the situation in an attempt to prepare them for what they could expect. He made it clear that he was prepared to abdicate in principle, if this would ensure that the Eidsvoll constitution could be retained.⁷³ The lines of battle had been drawn up, the diplomats had spoken, and now it was the turn of the canons.

‘The War of Cats’

The Swedish and the Norwegian armies were very poorly matched. The Norwegian field army comprised about 30,000 men, who could not measure up to the 45,000 Swedish troops with regard to equipment, training or leadership. True, there were in Norway militias, so-called free battalions, which had been created during the years 1811–12, and territorial reserves, so that, in total, the Norwegian army comprised what was on paper a formidable force of approximately 115,000 men.⁷⁴ In reality it was a paper tiger, however. The army may have constituted in theory a total mobilisation, as it amounted to some 13 per cent of the total population, but the majority of soldiers did not take part in exercises in peacetime and most were in fact not mobilised at all in 1814. The free battalions, the territorial reserves and the militias were only to be called up in the case of an invasion and would in principle only operate within their local areas, but in the chaos that ensued the invasion these units proved in most cases impossible to form.

The fact was that Norway was without allies, was cut off from the outside world by a Swedish-British blockade and could not, in the longer term, feed its population or its army. Moreover, the Swedish field army was superior and could also count on the support of the Swedish navy. Furthermore, Russia and Prussia had also promised assistance for Charles John should this prove necessary. In this situation, the Norwegians’ only faint hope as far as military means went appeared to lie in waging guerrilla warfare. There were those within the Norwegian army and elite who argued along these lines. Christian Frederick, however, had only wanted to threaten Sweden with a people’s war, but not to unleash it. There was, therefore, no mass military mobilisation in Norway. Some historians, however, have nevertheless exaggerated the extent of *voluntary* participation and even the scope of military mobilisation in 1814, making it appear as if a Norwegian people in arms stood poised to throw itself at the Swedish army. This was a far remove from the reality. It was rather a short and, at least seen through Norwegian eyes,

inglorious war, lasting no more than three weeks from the outbreak of hostilities on 26 July until a final truce was signed on 14 August.⁷⁵

The armies of both countries exercised such moderation that fighting in Norway in the summer of 1814 resembled some of the largely bloodless wars of manoeuvre of the eighteenth century rather than Napoleon's all-out combat. The extreme caution exercised by both sides and the absence of large-scale pitched battles was the reason why some contemporary observers referred to the war as a War of Cats, in the sense that it was mainly about the two opposing armies manoeuvring in competition for strategic positions whilst hissing at each other. One of the reasons for Swedish moderation was that a brutal war of conquest could trigger a Norwegian guerrilla war. Such a situation would create so much mutual enmity that it would jeopardise any union between Norway and Sweden and possibly even alienate Sweden's allies. What was more, Charles John was painfully aware that Sweden's finances did not allow for a prolonged war and he therefore sought to bring it to a rapid and negotiated end.

The Norwegian army chose a distinctly defensive strategy, which was based on the expectation that the Swedes would repeat their plan of 1808 by advancing over a broad front in southern Norway and concentrating on the area around Kongsvinger. To the Norwegians' surprise, however, Charles John set up a more concentrated attack in the south-easternmost Norwegian borderlands where the Swedish army's advance could be supported by the navy in the Christiania fjord (Oslo fjord). This forced the Norwegians to retreat, the only resistance in the southern border areas coming from the Fredriksten fortress at Frederikshald (Halden). Christian Frederick prepared for a decisive battle at Rakkestad but – to the dissatisfaction of the soldiers – decided instead at the last moment to retreat and continue negotiations which had already begun. There were, therefore, no pitched battles during the war but only a few skirmishes in some of which the Norwegians emerged victorious, such as at Lier, Matrand and Skotterud. However, the Swedish army forced its counterpart into a continuous retreat in the direction of Christiania. By 10 August it only seemed to be a matter of time before the Norwegian army would be forced to its knees. In this situation Christian Frederick found it necessary to negotiate a truce and peace rather than spilling blood in what he perceived as a hopeless war, although some Norwegians were still spoiling for a fight. Moreover, a major Norwegian defeat would have worsened the country's bargaining position.

Christian Frederick's defensive strategy, his depressed state of mind and his unwillingness to engage in major, decisive battles was seen by

contemporaries in some Norwegian circles as proof that he had simply been fighting for a reunification with Denmark and that now it was no longer possible – he had thrown in the towel. This interpretation was reiterated as a permanent mantra in older national Norwegian historiography and one that conveniently relieved the Norwegian nation of any responsibility, and it is still to be found in recent academic and popular views.⁷⁶ As has been pointed out, it is highly probable that Christian Frederick's ideal solution was reunification, as it was for a number of leading Norwegians, but it seems meaningless to attempt to find an explanation for the king's strategy on these grounds. Christian Frederick was under continuous mental pressure, but his strategy was neither 'Danish' nor irrational. He always acted so as to provide maximum protection for Norwegians and to obtain the best possible agreement by continuing the war until Charles John was prepared to accept Eidsvoll as a basis for a union, and he succeeded on both counts. The parties agreed on a truce at the Convention of Moss, and the Storting was convened in order to amend the Constitutional Act and make a union with Sweden possible. The condition for this, however, was that Christian Frederick had to agree to two secret articles stipulating that he must promise to abdicate as soon as the extraordinary session of the Storting opened and to leave the country immediately after transferring power to the cabinet.

Charles John's policies were crucial in ensuring that Norway was allowed to retain its constitution in 1814. Equally important, however, was the fact that these policies were also crucial in determining the popular response and reaction to the war and to the occupation in 1814. The Swedes did little in Norway that made much difference to the way in which Norwegians got on with their everyday lives. While this did not necessarily generate the kind of popular support for Swedish rule that some historians have ascribed to the inhabitants of the borderlands, it did ensure minimum resistance and made it far easier to accept the union.⁷⁷

This does not mean that Charles John intended to invade Norway and dethrone Christian Frederick, and then simply leave the Norwegians to do as they pleased. Three county governors accompanied the Swedish army with instructions to take charge of the civilian administration of the occupied areas, and Field Marshal Hans Henric von Essen had been appointed governor general of Norway prior to the invasion. As Norway had been formally ceded to the king of Sweden, it was lawful to demand that the people living in the occupied areas should swear an oath of allegiance. However, in order to indicate that the full incorporation of

Norway into Sweden was not his intention, Charles John repeatedly promised self-rule and respect for the constitution if Norwegians would simply accept the terms of the Peace of Kiel.

The war in the summer could have changed everything, however. Some Swedes were furious that the Norwegians had rejected the Peace of Kiel and made it necessary for Sweden to embark on a costly war to enforce a lawful treaty. Therefore, when Christian Frederick opted to negotiate and a ceasefire was agreed on 10 August, some Swedes regarded it as a military victory and expected Charles John to adopt Gustav III's policy of annexing Norway and amalgamating the two nations, if only to punish the Norwegians for their obstinacy. Their perplexity and outrage became even more intense when Charles John signed a final convention agreed at Moss on 14 August, which tacitly recognised the Storting and with it Norwegian autonomy.⁷⁸

Charles John approved the lenient terms for reasons of practical politics. Continued hostilities would not only involve considerable losses and expenditure, but could at worst lead to the feared guerrilla war. The confused situation was also a problem in relation to the Congress of Vienna, which was about to begin. The sensible thing to do was to take possession of Norway and avoid an unsettled situation that could lead to the reversal of those agreements that had been reached. Furthermore, by being cooperative, Charles John could facilitate his future control of Norway and ensure that his dynasty would have a separate kingdom in the event of losing power in Sweden. The French-born Bernadotte demonstrated in this way that he was capable of a certain moderation that his former colleague, Napoleon, had often lacked.

Any possibility of reunification with Denmark died with the Convention of Moss on 14 August. For many Norwegians the desire for a return to such a union had gone, but there were exceptions, such as the venerable Carsten Anker, who was prepared to attend the Congress of Vienna in order to argue the Danish-Norwegian cause. Yet, for those Norwegians who still harboured such hopes, the only realistic possibility was a Scandinavian union.⁷⁹

Deserters

Most Norwegian troops were demobilised after the Convention of Moss on 14 August. Some sections of the army of the line, which were supposed to remain mobilised during the peace negotiations, almost disintegrated as soldiers deserted in their hundreds. These mass desertions have often been explained as being caused by dissatisfaction at what the soldiers regarded

as appeasement and cowardice on the part of Christian Frederick and some of the military leaders. This could give the impression that the soldiers felt an ideological bond with the fatherland and that those who deserted did so in protest against Christian Frederick and the army commanders, who they felt had not done enough to defend Norway's independence.⁸⁰

However, what is striking is that the deserters were almost invariably men whose homes were in the areas occupied by the Swedes. The prime motive for desertion may have been that these soldiers wanted to protect their homes and families against the Swedish army – and not that they were ideologically motivated or wished to protest against Christian Frederick and the military leadership. Any desire they had to protest may have been due to their sense that their home grounds had been left in enemy hands, rather than because they felt that Norwegian independence had not been defended energetically enough. Conversely, the fact there was no irregular resistance in the areas the deserters belonged to suggests that the Swedish army behaved well and that no one was prepared to defend Norway's independence to the last man. The most important thing for these peasants from the borderlands was the safety of their native grounds and their families.⁸¹

Autumn in Norway

The truce came as a shock to many Norwegians. Particularly in south-eastern Norway, closest to the front line, the mood was despondent. The period from the end of August to the beginning of September has been called the 'time of the turncoats', when many of the former proponents of independence came out in the union's favour. For all that, there were people in many towns who wanted to continue fighting to avoid becoming *Swedish*. Even though the mood in the capital, Christiania in south-eastern Norway, was dejected, the hungry inhabitants refused to accept Swedish corn supplies and attempted instead to lynch the Norwegian generals, Haxthausen and Staffeldt, who had been responsible for supplying the army, as well as General Magnus Björnstjerna from the Swedish delegation. Every morning, the town's inhabitants woke to find new posters that encouraged people to fight with renewed courage for independence. The people of the city of Tønsberg apparently held the pro-Swedish Count Wedel Jarlsberg responsible for the Convention of Moss and were prepared to stone him and burn down his residence. The plan was never realised, however, as the count was not at his Jarlsberg estate.⁸²

Feelings ran even higher in western Norway and the province of Trøndelag in the middle part of the country. A civil servant described

the mood in the diocese of Bergen as that of a lion that had been bated; even old men were ready to face death with weapons in their hands rather than submit to Sweden.⁸³ The statement reflected the atmosphere of the city. The underlying motive force of this ultra-patriotism was the ancient bishop, Johan Nordahl Brun, who burned with an all-consuming patriotic flame. He wrote to the chaplain in Christiania,

Peasants and soldiers are the nation here; they stand on as yet unde-filed Norwegian ground waiting for a sign to go to war. Norway is still Norway, and Christian is Norway's king, and it should cost [the lives of] 20,000 Norwegian men before this changes.

Those citizens and civil servants in southeastern Norway who were of a different opinion were, according to Brun, 'rascals' who the king should 'dismiss, degrade or shoot, according to the circumstances'. A priest, Niels Hertzberg from Hardanger, also in the diocese of Bergen, suggested executing any commander who surrendered his fortress and who was not prepared to burn down a neighbouring village and to execute every citizen and peasant who refused to set fire to his own house when the area was occupied by Swedes. All who were taken prisoner by the enemy without being unfit for combat should also, in Hertzberg's own words, 'dangle at the end of a rope'.⁸⁴

It was not only members of the clergy who were capable of coming up with such doomsday pronouncements. Such ravings could also be found among the military. One senior commander advocated not only laying waste to most of the territory east of the River Glomma, but also making incursions into western Sweden and destroying everything there. His intention was to create an uninhabitable desert between Norway and Sweden, by which means the borderland would not require the same level of costly attention and would make it almost impossible to carry out military operations there.⁸⁵

However, the desire to continue the war was voiced chiefly by members of the educated elite. Ultimately it only amounted to empty rhetoric that had little influence, especially on the common people. This led one officer to remark laconically that the eagerness for war was 'as usual greatest with the gentlemen sitting comfortably in their living rooms by the fire in the winter, and the bravest of them were in Bergen'.⁸⁶ Above all, the inhabitants of the borderlands wanted an end to the war.

While the war of 1814 had thrown most of the middle class into a state of despair, the pro-Swedish priest Nicolai Wergeland was almost triumphant when, without permission, he gave a political speech to

his congregation from his pulpit in Christiansand. His theme was national unity, which he illustrated by telling the people who their real friends were. He stressed that what was needed was a united national front that would openly and honestly negotiate with the Swedes on the basis of *true* Norwegian interests, and that people should not hate the Swedish people because Christianity forbade national hatred.⁸⁷

Wergeland was later suspected of having been in the pay of the Swedes, but the truth was that he had no Swedish acquaintances at all. His speech was based on his own convictions, genuine love of his fatherland and an unquenchable hatred of Denmark, and he used the occasion to lay the blame for the war of 1814 on those with Danish sympathies and on the idea of reunification. Wergeland's speech reflected the views of the Wedel circle, but the count and his sympathisers found it unnecessarily smug and politically unwise at a time when the witch-hunt for them was still in progress. The open expression of Swedish sympathies in places such as Trondheim led to written, legal and physical conflict, especially during the election process for the extraordinary session of the Storting in the autumn of 1814. The election resulted in a landslide victory for the Independence Party. Thus the majority of the electorate still seemed to be gripped by the nationalistic principle of a free Norwegian national state.⁸⁸

The division of opinion among the country's various factions created widespread concern at the extraordinary session of the Storting. The delegates from Bergen had been given a mandate forbidding them to vote for a union with Sweden, while it was feared that no delegates would be sent from Trondheim and the country's northern areas, which could result in the Convention of Moss and the extraordinary convening of the Storting being invalidated. Christian Frederick had expressed the same fear in his declaration on the Convention of Moss, while others – both Norwegians and Swedes – were afraid that the war would be resumed if the inhabitants of western and northern Norway opposed peace and the union with Sweden. The continuing recalcitrance of the delegates came under fire, however, when they arrived at the Storting in Christiania in October, when they could sense a change of mood in the city. One officer remarked that the tone here was completely different from the rest of the country, as people were talking about the necessity of a union with Sweden and the impossibility of defending Norway. The word now was that there was a difference between becoming Swedes and having a Swedish king. The mood influenced the delegates, who grudgingly changed their attitudes in order to save the nation and ensure the greatest possible autonomy in the union.⁸⁹

In the autumn of 1814, Hans Nansen, who later became an opposition politician, spoke about how pitiful and unnatural the hatred between the two nations was and mentioned the possibility that Norwegians could in time learn to love the Swedes as brothers, as they had previously done with the Danes. In figurative language strongly inspired by the union with Denmark, he spoke of the common origins of Norwegians and Swedes, of how they were surrounded by similar landscapes, had similar cultures and spoke almost the same language. Nansen was attempting to sell the union to the nation by showing that the Swedes were *almost* like Norwegians. He therefore felt that the two nations were like offspring of one father and could live in complete equality, agreement and brotherly love.⁹⁰

As had been the case with the Danish–Norwegian union, the demand for equality would come to haunt the Swedish–Norwegian union and lead to its dissolution in 1905. Charles XIII was elected king of Norway to a claim that the two ancient kingdoms of the Scandinavian peninsula, which had always been united by the hand of nature, were now united in an indissoluble bond, and that happy times would follow when Norwegians and Swedes embraced each other like brothers. However, there was clear political recognition of the fact that elaborate panegyrics would not wash away the prejudices of generations. There was, it is true, a constrained reconciliation at the Storting in the autumn of 1814, but politically and symbolically the deputies created as many barriers between the two nations as they possibly could.

Developments, had, however, now given the pro-Swedish parties a more acceptable face. The moderation that Wedel Jarlsberg and his circle had previously demonstrated gave way to attacks on the independent parties, Danes and the defeated Christian Frederick who, in prolonging the nation's agony, had been instrumental in condemning it to conflict. However, even if circumstances had changed, the die-hard patriots and pro-Danish Norwegians neither forgave nor forgot. Those pro-Swedish parties who had formerly acclaimed the Oldenburgs were now condemned as hypocrites and poetic mercenaries, while many people still regarded the pro-Swedish Count Wedel Jarlsberg as a traitor.

The count was far from alone in being accused in this way, for this was a disillusioned Norway in which a mythology of backstabbing had arisen that ascribed defeat variously to treachery, bribery and inept leadership. Even after the union with Sweden had become a reality, several leading officers were impeached. Many contemporary patriotic poets expressed their deep sense of frustration in poems that mocked the Norwegians for their lack of courage, ability and will. They were

often compared to the Norwegians of antiquity who had possessed all of the virtues that had now been found lacking.⁹¹

With the Convention of Moss and the later union with Sweden, the winds of change also began to cool relations to the formerly adored Christian Frederick, who now became an object of hatred as he had proved to be more earthly than messianic. The young king's refusal to sacrifice lives in a hopeless war led those very people whom nationalism had stirred to turn their backs on him in disappointment at his human frailty. This led to personal attacks on the king for cowardice and frivolity, with fingers being pointed at the war and at the monarch's ability literally to seduce. Some people refused to believe what had happened, while others felt they had been made fools of and resigned from their posts in protest. It was symptomatic of some of the criticism that it was based on national feeling. While Christian Frederick's character was attributed to his Danishness, his lack of will to take part in the struggle was linked to his lack of love of the fatherland, as he was not, like a Norwegian, connected to the country by family ties, origin or property. The springtime hero had become the scapegoat of autumn, while the Independence Party refused to accept any responsibility and lacked the will or ability to understand what had been possible and what had been achieved.⁹²

It has correctly been pointed out that this was almost inevitable, as Christian Frederick's national rhetoric had helped to promote the idea of total mobilisation and a fight to the death. Christian Frederick's necessary outward idealism in the spring made it impossible to accept his realism in the autumn. The king still had his supporters, but they were chiefly Danish-born officers and recent appointments to the civil service whose jobs depended on Christian Frederick's person. He was still a national symbol for those who wanted to continue fighting, and the greater the distance from Christiania and the war, the stronger was the image of the king. Love for Christian Frederick was still palpable at the extraordinary session of the Storting, where there were proposals for a commission to vindicate the monarch, for a memorial in his honour and for the continuation of his annuity after his abdication. The proposals were all withdrawn under Swedish pressure, though the king was allowed to receive an address in expression of the people's gratitude.⁹³

After Christian Frederick had left the country on 10 October 1814, his role as the scapegoat for the collective shame became permanent. The tendency was most pronounced among military personnel. There was criticism across party lines, but it was linked by the pro-Swedish parties to the theory that Christian Frederick had been motivated by Danish

interests. This one-sided criticism occasionally led to a backlash, which was the case with a prominent editor who wrote that it had been the heir to the throne who had made a free constitution possible in 1814, and that Norwegians should be eternally grateful to him. The view of the chronically suspicious Swedish civil servants was that the 'Danish prince' still lived on in many Norwegian hearts, and that, although the Norwegian uniforms were now blue (like those of the Swedes), Norwegians' blood was still red (like the Danish uniforms).⁹⁴

The New Norway

For the Norwegian middle class, 1814 was a watershed as regards their identity, their loyalty and their conceptual basis, as other institutions were placed on an equal footing with or actually given precedence over the king in a national and political hierarchy that included the Storting and the Constitutional Act. While these were new constructions in Norway, they were ascribed historical and political legitimacy and a symbolic value that had formerly been associated with the monarch. The Storting with its two chambers, the *Odelsting* and the *Lagting*, whose names referred back to the ancient Norse and proto-democratic institution of the '*thing*' or moot, reflected the desire to link the 'old' and the 'new' Norway. This is a clear example of what Eric Hobsbawm called 'invented traditions', that is, new traditions that are invented as a reaction to a new situation in order to promote a given set of values, for which legitimacy is sought by referring to a recent or remote past.⁹⁵

The political and national legitimacy and symbolic role of the Storting become clear in the perception of the institution as a national assembly and of its members as the people's representatives and interpreters who, without considering special interests, worked for the common good. For the opposition the Storting was associated with ideas of the nation's dignity, autonomy and liberty, while membership of the Storting was accounted a sacred duty exercised out of love of the fatherland. For 'patriots', the Storting also constituted the nation's bulwark in an ongoing struggle against being merged with Sweden. However, the Storting did not always enjoy the respect of the people, as it was too divisive and the atmosphere too toxic for this to be the case. For those who supported the idea of representative government, however, the Storting was a precondition for the lasting happiness of the people. Lack of political experience came to weaken the very public spirit that such parliamentarians were attempting to strengthen. Endless negotiations, nit-picking and internal division detracted from these lofty expectations and undermined many people's faith in the new system. Paradoxically, the status

of the Storting as a national symbol that was beyond challenge only emerged when Charles John challenged its power.⁹⁶

This applied equally to the Constitutional Act, which was based on the liberal thinking of the Enlightenment and had derived considerable inspiration from the experience of the United States, Britain and France. Contemporaries were aware of this, but it was still the feigned connection with Norwegian history that was emphasised. The civil servant and politician Christian Magnus Falsen maintained that ancient Norway had been a constitutional monarchy based on popular sovereignty, and that the Constitutional Act was therefore simply a return to the constitution of their Norwegian forefathers. This attempt to create historical, political and national continuity, authenticity and legitimacy was the rule rather than the exception in the 'new' Norway, and represented an attempt to anchor the changes in a bygone golden age of the nation, the Viking era and the Middle Ages. The Constitutional Act was seen as the very symbol of an independent Norwegian nation across most party lines. Furthermore, it not only gave Norwegians grounds for pride, it also raised them above their neighbours in that free and equal Norwegians were set alongside Danish subjects and Swedish noblemen.⁹⁷

In the atmosphere of political nationalism that found expression in Norway, the Constitutional Act was described as a sacred text and a civic catechism, an expression of the people's will that all were obliged to recognise. The opposition in particular associated the constitution with nationality and considered it a tool that would shape the nation's character. Cultivation of the Constitutional Act, which was closely connected with the concept of the nation, underlines the perception of nationalism as a kind of secular religion, and this in itself shows that at least some members of the Norwegian elite had taken a decisive step away from old-fashioned sovereign-centred patriotism and embraced a national identity. The events of 1814 permanently changed Norway, and the year saw the beginning of a nation-building process that lasted through the nineteenth century with the creation of national symbols such as a Norwegian flag, a Norwegian national anthem and a national landscape, followed by the birth of a national literature and a change of the written language in a 'Norwegian' direction. The aim was to show that Norway was an independent nation in its own right, and that Norwegians were not simply 'pseudo-Danes'.

The Immediate Consequences of Separation

Norway's union with Sweden brought the flow of people travelling from Denmark to Norway to a halt. Those Norwegians who left for

Norway after the union were now regarded with the greatest indignation as 'Swedes'. The conservative reaction to the ideas of the French Revolution that flowed throughout Europe, including Denmark, created animosity against Norwegians in Denmark in some circles, as it was feared that they harboured liberal tendencies. The atmosphere in Norway, however, was no better. A small number of officers refused to swear the oath of allegiance to Charles XIII. There were considerable numbers of people who considered emigrating – to Denmark in particular – after 1814, especially Norwegian civil servants, but few of them actually did so, while others were prevented by Frederick VI's fear of employing 'revolutionary' Norwegians.⁹⁸

For centuries Denmark as a whole and Copenhagen in particular had been influenced by the thousands of Norwegians who lived in the country and the city. In Copenhagen, there were Norwegian students, seamen and soldiers who served in the Royal Life Guards. But the capital was far from the only place in Denmark with links to Norway. Jutland, especially northern Jutland, had close ties with the south coast of Norway through the exchange of goods and people. As many as 40,000 Norwegians were said to live in Denmark in 1770.⁹⁹ That corresponded to approximately 5 per cent of the population, but as the great majority of them lived in towns, the concentration of Norwegians there was far higher.

This all changed after the separation in 1814. Although the ties between the two countries remained close during the nineteenth century, there were no longer any Norwegian soldiers in the Royal Life Guards, no more Norwegian seamen, and the flood of Norwegian students who lived in Copenhagen dwindled to almost nothing. In a similar manner the separation broke off contacts between Danish towns and Norway. Much trade between Denmark and Norway ceased in 1814, and problems in settling the national debt meant that there was no Danish-Norwegian commercial treaty until 1826. This was a hard blow, especially for northern Jutland, as this was where shipments of corn had traditionally left for Norway. The separation of 1814 meant that many of the close material, financial and human ties were cut.

Denmark and the Congress of Vienna

The Peace of Kiel did not end hostilities for Denmark, as the country was still at war with Russia, Prussia and Spain as well as with France. Denmark had been obliged to declare war on the latter by the terms of the peace treaty with Britain. The Danish government had never got

around to sending the troops against Napoleon that it was obliged to, and the French regarded hostilities between the two states as having been concluded with the Treaty of Paris. A peace treaty with Russia was signed at Hanover on 8 February, but this could not be ratified before the Norwegian rebellion raised the question of whether the Danish government was double-dealing. The situation in Norway not only prevented the conclusion of a Danish peace treaty with Prussia and Spain and the ratification of the peace treaties with Britain and Russia, it also led the Swedes to refuse to live up to their obligations in spite of the ratified peace treaty, as Charles John claimed that the Norwegian rebellion was a violation of the treaty. This meant that Sweden refused to hand over Swedish Pomerania and the duchy of Rügen, to pay Denmark the one million *rix-dollars* and Norway's share of the national debt. On the contrary, the Swedes used the Russian army of 60,000 men as a threat to Denmark's existence itself.

Denmark's situation improved slightly when the international commission rejected the charge of double-dealing on the part of Denmark, but the rest of the Danish *composite state* was still in danger. The ratification of the Danish–British peace treaty on 7 April was an important step on the path to normalisation, while peace treaties were signed with Spain on 14 August and with Prussia on 25 August. The peace between Denmark and Prussia involved handing over Swedish Pomerania and Rügen to Prussia when Denmark took possession of them, in return for territorial compensation in northern Germany close to the border with Holstein. The problem remained for Frederick VI, however, that Sweden and Russia were preventing the normalisation of relations.

This is the context in which the Danish king's participation in the Congress of Vienna should be seen. Frederick VI had not been officially invited to the congress, but, encouraged by Austria, the king decided to go to Vienna. Austria was alone among the allied powers with which Denmark had not been at war, and Austrian diplomats had been instructed by Count Metternich during the war's endgame to do their best to prevent the annihilation of the Danish state. Danish participation in the congress had four partly connected aims.

The first goal for the Danes was ratification of the peace treaty with Russia and of Russian withdrawal from Holstein. The second goal was to obtain the help of the great powers to put pressure on Sweden to meet its obligations under the Peace of Kiel, which was a precondition for Prussia's takeover of Swedish Pomerania and Rügen. The third goal was to prevent the Danish state, or parts of it, being allotted to other states by the great powers as territorial compensation. The fact that

Frederick VI had stuck by Napoleon so long had created considerable dislike of the Danish monarch in many places, which could easily come to cost the state even more. The kingdom of Saxony was a good example of the fact that this was no irrational fear. As Danish diplomats were painfully aware, the example of Saxony, together with the presence of the Russian army in Holstein and Charles John's constant attempts to divide Denmark, were what Frederick VI feared most. The best thing for Denmark would be for all to forget the past, so that the country could once again become part of 'Europe's great family'. The fourth and final goal for Denmark was to safeguard the state's interests in a reorganisation of Germany, which would almost inevitably involve Holstein.

The first goal would prove to be the most difficult. At the congress itself the Danish king was treated as a tragic figure who, like his country, had undergone immense suffering. There was therefore a certain goodwill towards the Danish monarch. There were also hopes that the king's personal presence at the congress could reconcile him with the tsar, but this proved to be more difficult than expected. In spite of countless promises, the Danish monarch was obliged to wait until 14 November before the tsar finally decided to ratify the peace treaty of 8 February and ordered his troops to begin their withdrawal from Holstein. This only happened after the British Foreign Minister Castlereagh had intervened on Denmark's behalf, as he wanted to prevent Russia growing even stronger. This put a definitive end to the war and the threat to Denmark's existence.

It took even longer to achieve the remaining goals. Danish attempts to obtain more compensation for the loss of Norway were unsuccessful, and Sweden still refused to abide by its obligations under the Peace of Kiel. For their part, the Swedes attempted to bypass Denmark and reach an agreement with Prussia in relation to Swedish Pomerania and Rügen. The issue was only resolved after pressure was applied by the Russians in the form of a piece of horse-trading in June 1815, after which Prussia received the areas in question from Sweden, while Denmark received the Hanoverian duchy of Lauenburg, after Prussia had surrendered the bishopric of Hildesheim, among other territories, to Hanover. The Danish polity could then be redrawn on the map of Europe.

The composite state of which Frederick VI was monarch in 1815, however, was fundamentally different to the state he had ruled before 1807. The government in the bombed-out city of Copenhagen was geographically – if not demographically – the biggest loser of the Napoleonic Wars, as the Kingdom of Norway, with an area of 385,252 km², almost a million inhabitants and major natural resources had been

exchanged for the 1200 km² duchy of Lauenburg with 40,000 inhabitants and a feudal landowner structure. Seen through military eyes, the navy, for centuries considered the very key to the state's existence, had been irretrievably lost. Geographical, demographic and military losses, together with a ruined economy meant that the state's former political status had also been lost. It was therefore asserted in the 1820s that official Danish foreign policy was that the state had no foreign policy.

The Napoleonic Wars had also changed the Danish state in one other decisive way. Before 1814 Danish speakers (i.e. Danes and Norwegians) had comprised 75 per cent of the population of Denmark-Norway, while German speakers comprised 25 per cent. This had now changed to 60/40. This displacement was not insignificant for the residual development of the Danish polity, where German speakers in the duchies and Danish speakers in the kingdom had become increasingly conscious of nationality during the Napoleonic Wars.

The Congress of Vienna left Denmark with another inheritance that foreshadowed later political turmoil in the nineteenth century. Among the final issues negotiated in the Austrian capital was the German Confederation, which would replace the former Holy Roman Empire that had been dissolved in 1806. Holstein had been formally annexed to the Danish state for nine years, but in the spirit of restoration in Vienna the government in Copenhagen found it wisest to submit to the demand that Holstein be part of the German Confederation.

This had a decisive effect on the subsequent course of history in two senses. In a positive sense it meant that Frederick VI was in principle obliged to give Holstein a constitution and a national assembly in accordance with the text of the Confederation. Even though the conservative monarch would not initially grant the people of Holstein a constitution, he felt obliged to do so in the wake of the French Revolution of 1830. An advisory national assembly was granted not only to Holstein but also to Schleswig and the Kingdom of Denmark, as it was found politically impossible to differentiate between the state's various population groups. The German Confederation was partly responsible, then, for a liberal development in Denmark that culminated in the Danish Constitutional Act of 1849.

Holstein's connection with the Confederation, however, also gave the German states, including Prussia and Austria, both a right and a duty to interfere in the domestic political affairs of the Danish state, which gradually came to a head as the nationalist movements increased in strength among Danes and among the inhabitants of Schleswig and Holstein. Schleswig, whose cultural, political and identity-related

position was ambiguous, became the bone of contention in a showdown between 'Danish' and 'German' in the Danish composite state. When it came to the crunch, Holstein's position under constitutional law as part of the German Confederation was decisive, as, with Prussia and Austria at its head, the confederation intervened in the two Schleswig Wars of 1848–51 and of 1864. While the first war had resulted in an untenable status quo, the war of 1864 deprived the Danish state of both Holstein and Schleswig. This was a process that had begun in earnest with Denmark-Norway's involvement in the Napoleonic Wars that reached a form of conclusion 50 years later when Denmark definitively became a nation-state.

8

Denmark and Norway after Denmark-Norway

War and Separation

During the last two decades there has been a growing tendency among international scholars to paint a more variegated picture of the national, political and social upheavals and of developments that can be traced back to the Revolutionary and Napoleonic Wars. The historian Michael Broers speaks of a 'New Napoleonic History' in which Napoleon's Empire is the focal point of scholarly attention that has provided new insights not only into the nature and effects of Napoleon's imperialism but also into how Europeans reacted to the empire. This has constituted a fundamental challenge to a wide range of traditional historical interpretations and has exploded a number of myths. For example, neither Germany's Wars of Liberation against France in 1813–15 nor the hostilities in areas such as Spain and Italy are any longer considered broad national uprisings.¹

When it comes to the population at large, the 'New Napoleonic History' has thus shouldered a substantial degree of revisionism in which Norway and Denmark should now be included. Neither in 1808 nor in 1814 had the Norwegian population fought or been willing to fight a people's war, any more than had Danish peasants during the British attack on Zealand and Copenhagen in 1807. In other words, the conceptual world of the peasantry was still solidly and conservatively rooted in traditionalism. However, the picture is somewhat different if the spotlight is turned on the elites of the Danish-Norwegian state. What becomes visible here is not only a highly developed ideology of state patriotism, but also clearly articulated and distinct ideas of national patriotism that border on modern nationalism. In the case of Norway, the transition from the former to the latter took place in 1814 in one of the most striking turning points in Scandinavian history.

Before the outbreak of war in 1807 Denmark-Norway had enjoyed the fruits of peace since 1720. The policy of neutrality had created economic progress, a liberalisation of the economy and, particularly in the Danish and German regions of the state, the government had enacted comprehensive reforms in keeping with the spirit of the times. Denmark-Norway had constituted a medium-sized polity with major national and merchant fleets and, despite its close ties with Russia, the country enjoyed a certain latitude in international affairs. During the years between 1807 and 1814 this polity was destroyed in upheavals that led to financial ruin and domestic division.

Danish and particularly Norwegian historians have traditionally judged Frederick VI harshly, while he has been portrayed by several international historians as blindly loyal to Napoleon. In the final analysis he has shouldered the blame for Denmark-Norway having ended up on the losing side in the Napoleonic Wars, and not without good grounds. The Danish-Norwegian king was neither a political nor a military genius, and during the course of the war he exhibited a growing tendency to refuse to recognise his own limitations. This had consequences for his political decisions and for the ability of his administration to act as best it could. On the other hand, it is inaccurate to describe Frederick VI, as several historians have done, as irrational or feeble-minded. Frederick's policy should be understood with reference to the freedom of action available to him. Although the king was stubborn and self-righteous, it appears unreasonable to chide him for not accepting the British ultimatum in 1807, as it was a fundamental threat to the state's independence and cohesion and would have led to a French occupation of large areas of the country. Furthermore, it was scarcely irrational to side with Napoleon and his army of 500,000 men when the Emperor invaded Russia in 1812, even though with the benefit of hindsight it can be seen as the wrong choice. However, there is more justification for the charge that he failed to take Norway's interests sufficiently into consideration during the war. Frederick's choice should be seen in the light of his role as regent of a composite polity and of his well-founded fear of a French occupation of the duchies, Jutland and Funen, if he fulfilled the wishes of the Norwegians. In other words, the price he would have paid for alleviating the large-scale Norwegian sufferings would have been an increase in the burdens of the Danish and German inhabitants of the state. It would also have completely stopped corn shipments from Denmark to Norway, making it necessary for the Norwegians to obtain these vital supplies elsewhere, which clearly would have been more easily said than done.

That things turned out as they did was no foregone conclusion, however, as witnessed by the sudden death of Crown Prince Carl August of Sweden and the subsequent election of Crown Prince Charles John in 1810 and Frederick VI's decision to stick with Napoleon in 1812 and 1813. History could easily have taken a different turn in each of these cases, and it is only the eyes of posterity that erroneously perceive the course of events to have been preordained. The outcome, however, in large part laid the foundation for the Scandinavia with which we are familiar today. As far as Norway is concerned, 1814 marks the fall of absolutism, the introduction of a free constitution and national independence. The outcome of the eventful years in Norway must be ascribed to a coincidence of the acts of the Norwegian elite and the policies of Christian Frederick, Charles John and the great powers respectively. Charles John had already promised the Norwegians a free constitution, but it is doubtful whether the terms of a union between Sweden and Norway would have been equally favourable without the Norwegian rebellion under the leadership of the Danish prince. Furthermore, 1814 was also the year when after centuries of war the Scandinavian countries buried the hatchet. The borders between the three countries have remained almost unchanged since 1814, with the notable exception of the duchies of Schleswig and Holstein. The changes that came about were also political and national. Sweden and Norway gained constitutions, while absolutism in Denmark fell into discredit. For Norway this was the foundation for present-day democracy.

In Norway national patriotism and state patriotism were now replaced by a political nationalism among the country's elite that gradually spread to the broader population, where it was supplemented over time by a well-developed cultural nationalism. Things in Denmark were different. State patriotism continued to live on there, as the Kingdom of Denmark constituted the centre of a mini-empire. It was weakened, however, by the war and the separation from the Norwegians, who were closely connected culturally and linguistically with the Danes, and a Danish cultural nationalism based on a combination of the cultivation of a common, ancient Nordic past and a separate Danish golden age in the Middle Ages grew in strength.

The situation was not improved by the fact that separation from Norway created a decidedly small-state mentality and an existential anxiety in Denmark. The war had also left the state's German citizens in the duchies with bitter memories of 'Danification', with the idea of German unity subsequently surfacing among a few professors at the University of Kiel. Furthermore, the struggle for the Swedish throne and

Frederick VI's policies had created animosity between the king and the Duke of Augustenburg, and the balance of power between the various nations within the state shifted decisively with the loss of Norway. This antagonism and these changes, together with budding nationalism, would have catastrophic consequences in the long term.

Proto-Scandinavianism, which had arisen with the Nordic renaissance at the end of the eighteenth century and had gained strength during the period leading up to the election of the Swedish crown prince, did not disappear. The gradual increase in strength that began at the end of the 1820s was borne along by the new peaceful conditions in Scandinavia and the common goal of somehow returning to a period of antiquity when Swedes, Norwegians and Danes ostensibly spoke a common language and had a common culture. The Scandinavianism that bloomed during the 1830s and 1840s was initially cultural, but the idea of a political union also grew stronger in some academic and political circles. This was particularly the case in Denmark, where for many people Scandinavianism became an integral aspect of Danish nationalism, which partly reflects national tensions arising between Germans and Danes as the state developed. Political Scandinavianism in Sweden, on the other hand, was seen against the threat from Russia, while it had a less firm footing in Norway, since many people were more interested in cultivating what was characteristically Norwegian and were apprehensive about anything that could be seen as a surrender of national sovereignty.

Scandinavianism should be seen as part of contemporary national liberalism in Europe. Liberals of the day believed that a state must be a certain size in order to survive, and that Europe should ideally consist of no more than eleven states in all, one of which would be Scandinavia.² Nationalism in the mid-nineteenth century went hand-in-hand with a threshold principle, which was based on the idea that those nations considered too small to constitute states in their own right should join forces with nations they were related to by culture, language and history and form states in this way. This was the background for what could be called the 'pan' movements of the day, among them pan-Scandinavianism and pan-Slavism. Furthermore, it could be argued that German unification and especially Italian unification were also movements of this kind. Swedes and Danes certainly had no less in common than did Italians from Turin and Italians from Sicily. Only a minority of Italians, consisting of liberals and radicals, wanted unification, and people in many areas were explicitly and even violently opposed to it.

For these 'pan movements' to succeed they had to combine some measure of popular sovereignty with the *idea* of a nation based on a

common language, culture, history and descent. Forming such an idea of nationhood would naturally be a selective process, nation-building being as much about forgetting as about remembering. This was just as true of Scandinavia as of Italy in that it could be argued that both geographical areas shared language, history and descent. According to this analysis, Scandinavianism seems to have been a more realistic project than the constitutional Danish-German composite state that was unsuccessfully tried out in the 1850s in Denmark, since the former combined the ideas of nationalism and popular sovereignty. However, in the end, political Scandinavianism came to nothing when the military aid that was promised by the Swedish-Norwegian king did not materialise in the Danish-German war of 1864 (despite *very* serious efforts to promote it, including high treason, plans for rebellion and government as well as royal offers to create a federal Scandinavian state). Cultural Scandinavianism on the other hand survived, and still has an effect on Scandinavian society and on the identity of Danes, Norwegians and Swedes.

Scandinavianism is, then, an important part of the legacy of the Scandinavia that was created in 1814. However, when writing on Scandinavianism in general and political Scandinavianism in particular, historians often focus on the relationship between Denmark and Sweden, leaving Norway to some extent as the odd one out. Moreover, there is a rich literature dealing with the union between Sweden and Norway, 1814–1905. In other words, until quite recently few cared about the how the upheaval of 1814 affected the relationship between Denmark and Norway. This is something of a paradox, since the effects of the separation of the two countries can hardly be underestimated when trying to understand politics and nation-building in Norway and Denmark in the nineteenth century. To try to balance the books, so to speak, the remainder of this epilogue is therefore dedicated to an analysis of Denmark, Norway and especially Danish-Norwegian relations in the aftermath of the Napoleonic Wars.

A Norwegian Model

Influenced by the memoirs of the prominent national-liberal politician, Orla Lehmann, Danish historians have branded the years between 1814 and 1830 as a period of hysterical love of the king, and the dilettantish and bungled attempt to overthrow the autocratic system of government in 1820 has been regarded as an isolated occurrence. This interpretation is well supported by the fact that the inflamed atmosphere in Denmark

had cooled by the time Frederick VI returned to the country after the Congress of Vienna in 1815. The adulation with which the king was received has normally been ascribed to his being seen as the saviour of the country, since, in the eyes of the people, his presence at the congress had saved the state from certain destruction. This interpretation is backed by many contemporary statements and must be taken seriously. On the other hand, there are other factors that may also have played a role in the wildly enthusiastic reception of the king.³

A closer look at the Danish sources, the European context and relations with the duchies reveals a more variegated picture. Sweden was given a constitution in 1809 and the Norwegian elite, educated in Denmark, created a liberal constitution in 1814. Germany was awash with national-liberal movements and revolts had broken out in Naples, Spain and Greece. Liberal literary societies and student organisations were established in Copenhagen, while the king considerably strengthened the police force in general and the secret police in particular. Danish civil servants who had been trained in the 1790s were still influenced by ideas spawned during the French Revolution. Traces can be seen not only in the Danish draft of a Norwegian constitution and the treatise on a constitutional monarchy in Denmark but also in the requests for a Danish constitution alongside extant drafts and preparatory work published or written between 1815 and 1818. In addition there are the posters, flyers and proclamations printed during the persecution of the Jews from 1819 to 1820 demanding liberty, equality and the abolition of absolutism. As mentioned in the previous chapter, Frederick VI had also accepted the obligation imposed by the Congress of Vienna to grant the German duchy of Holstein a constitution, which would hardly have gone unnoticed by educated Copenhageners. The king's obligation to the people of Holstein led to a constitutional movement not only in Holstein but also in the Danish duchy of Schleswig, with which it was connected.⁴

This is the light in which the Prussian emissary's report to Berlin concerning Frederick VI's return to Denmark in 1815 should be seen. He wrote that the Danes had expected the king to return with a constitution for his subjects, not an unreasonable expectation given his promise to the people of Holstein in Vienna. When it became known that he refused to do so, the result was, according to the emissary, widespread dissatisfaction. With this in mind, the enthusiastic reception of the king might have been generated by political expectations among Danes for a constitution in accordance with the Norwegian model. The restrictions on freedom of expression at the time and subsequent lack

of research make it very difficult to determine how widespread these attitudes were, but we do know that constitutional ideas were discussed in a club by the name of Clio, and that men such as Professor Laurits Engelstoft were perfectly willing to voice their liberal opinions in private. The police, however, had been keeping an eye on the association ever since it had been founded in 1816, as its many Norwegian-born members made it in their eyes a potential breeding ground for revolutionary ideas.⁵

Odense, the largest city on the island of Funen, is not alone in demonstrating that these ideas were not restricted to the capital. Having been received as a hero on his return from Norway, Christian Frederick now became a central figure for the opposition, and for this reason was exiled to Funen as governor, a superfluous post that had never existed before. A number of citizens in Odense founded a literary society on 17 May 1815 and elected the new governor – formerly the constitutional king of Norway – as its president. It was the first anniversary for the Norwegian constitution, and their choice of date must be seen as a clear indication of their liberal attitudes and as a protest directed against the absolutist regime.⁶

The Norwegian constitution and the free political life enjoyed by Norwegians became an ideal for all liberal forces in Denmark. Christian Frederick was working on a Danish constitution at this time but he was unable to solve the problem of the duchies. In this he was not alone. As previously mentioned, the mixed population of Schleswig and the complex issues involving constitutional law and the right of inheritance in both Holstein and Schleswig led to two civil wars later in the century. In Christian Frederick's view the majority of Danes (the peasants) still supported absolutism but the 'educated segment of the people' (the middle class) wanted a constitutional kingdom modelled on Norway and Great Britain.⁷

The (almost) free Norwegian press allowed Danes to read, in their own language, texts mercilessly attacking absolutism and defending a free constitution. Frederick VI and his henchmen saw such input from Norway as a threat, which was one reason why the postal service to Norway was discontinued during most of 1814 and was later systematically monitored. At the request of the Swedes, a major survey was carried out in Jutland in 1821 to examine a rumour that the population sympathised with the defence of the constitution by the Storting against Charles John. The conclusion of the secret internal Danish study was that there was no 'Norwegian party' on the peninsula, which was exactly what the Danish government had expected. A similar study

had been carried out during the previous year on the government's initiative at Odsherred in Zealand where it was feared that there was Norwegian influence.⁸

Such a fear was not irrational. Norwegians were still travelling to Copenhagen, correspondence between the two countries was busy, not least on the part of the younger liberal generation, and the Norwegian press supported Danish liberalism, as can be seen in the publication of proclamations dealing with a Danish constitution in Norway in 1819 and in anonymous Danish contributions to Norwegian newspapers. Many articles cautiously arguing for greater liberty, indirectly criticising the government and expressing the idea of an opposition-controlled absolutism were published in Denmark. This must be regarded as the limit of what it was possible to print at the time. The proposal for a monument to honour the reformist policies of the mentally ill Christian VII at the end of the eighteenth century could similarly be seen as a demand for new measures, rather than as a tribute to an 'enlightened' autocratic monarch.⁹

The attempted Danish insurrection initiated by the philologist Jacob Jacobsen Dampe in 1820 has not unreasonably been described in history books as harmless. On the other hand, it is important to emphasise that the authorities did take Dampe's activities seriously, and that they have to be seen as one expression of the unrest widespread in the capital and in other Danish towns from 1819 to 1820. Recent research has shown that the authorities connected Dampe's activities with what became known as the 'physical persecution of the Jews' that prevailed in Copenhagen and other parts of Denmark during this period and which was far more widespread than has hitherto been assumed. The persecution of the Jews was triggered by similar outrages in Germany and by the state of the economy, but it is important to emphasise that the populace blamed not only the Jews for the economic crisis but also the government and the king. The crisis, which began in earnest in 1818, could be traced back to the war and the state bankruptcy of 1813, as was made explicit in posters, flyers and proclamations that also contained demands for the abolition of autocracy and the introduction of a constitution. The government as a whole was panic-stricken, and Minister for Justice Frederik Julius Kaas was afraid that this was the 'Introduction to the Final Act' – the revolution. His concern should be seen in the light of contemporary insurrections in Naples and Spain and the unrest closer to home in Germany, which resulted in the Carlsbad Decrees in 1819 limiting the freedom of the press, for example, in several German states, including Holstein.¹⁰

According to a Danish emissary in Germany, Christian Frederick, who was on his way back to Denmark after a prolonged trip abroad, was redirected by the government to Italy as the dissatisfied inhabitants of Copenhagen were said to have expressed the hope that the prince would reverse the government's policies. By chance, the former Norwegian king and rebel-leader was visiting Naples just as the revolution broke out in Southern Italy in 1821. Christian Frederick's activities in Norway had made him the logical focus for hopes of a liberal revolution. A Danish diplomat in Germany wrote in a letter the year after Dampe's 'rebellion' that, given its purposeless opposition to a constitution, only the government could be blamed for such a turn of events. The letter also contained the following view: 'In my opinion, this will mark the death throes of the aristocracy, and all European states will have free constitutions within a few decades.'¹¹

There can be no doubt that the public sphere in Denmark during the 1820s was controlled by conservative and moderate forces, and that the period was characterised by a fear of revolution and a lack of dynamism. Prominent cultural personalities defended absolutism against liberalism in lofty panegyrics. This clearly supports posterity's view of the period as royalist but should not overshadow the fact that collections were made for the Greeks' struggle for liberty and that there were examples of moderate men working for a free press and informed public opinion. By the end of the 1820s, this had resulted in more freedom for periodicals, while the members of the Athenæum literary society discussed politics and read foreign newspapers and written constitutions. The elite generation that had grown up in the 1820s was in no doubt that absolutism as a system was on its last legs. Their thinking went hand-in-hand with the desire for a constitution and the sovereignty of the people, and this in itself carried the seeds of political nationalism.¹²

Norwegian influence on conditions for the Danish monarchy could be clearly seen when the revolutionary wave reached the banks of the Elbe in 1830. The landmark publication by the Holstein civil servant, Uwe Jens Lornsen, entitled *Über das Verfassungswerk in Schleswig-Holstein*, was doubly inspired by conditions in Norway. Lornsen not only envisaged a constitution along the lines of the Norwegian model but also wanted to see the relationship between Schleswig-Holstein and Denmark changed to a personal union in accordance with the Swedish-Norwegian example. Lornsen's efforts were unsuccessful, but assemblies of the States of the Realm were instituted throughout the Danish state on 28 May 1831, and in liberal circles there were celebrations on this date in subsequent years. This makes it natural to believe that they had derived inspiration

from the Norwegian celebration of 17 May, which was at the time an element in the struggle against Charles John's absolutist inclinations.

The liberal hope was that absolutism would die out when Frederick VI gave up the ghost and that the former constitutional Norwegian king, Christian Frederick, would grant the country a constitution as the new Danish monarch. Therefore, when the old king finally died in 1839, students wasted no time in drafting an appeal to the 'famous creator of the Norwegian constitution'.¹³ To their great disappointment, however, they were snubbed by a remark from their former liberal hero to the effect that he did not find the Norwegian constitution particularly worthy of imitation. This statement, which is contrary to what the king himself had written previously, can be explained by the fact that Christian VIII – Christian Frederick's royal Danish title – had become more conservative over the years, that he feared Russian interference if there should be a liberal revolution, or that he was afraid that a constitution in the current situation would dissolve the union between the kingdom and the duchies. During the last years of his life, the king attempted to solve the state's problems with the help of a common constitution for the Danish *composite state*, but instead his sudden death in January 1848, the February Revolution in France and national conflicts propelled the country into a state of civil war. In 1849 Danes were finally given a constitution inspired by the constitutions of Norway (1814) and Belgium (1831).

The Settlement of the Danish-Norwegian Estate

As mentioned above Danish-Norwegian relations were influenced by the different systems of government in the two countries. However, this was far from the only thing putting a strain upon the relationship between Danes and Norwegians. Relations were affected, for example, by the problems relating to the settlement of the estate after the union between Denmark and Norway had been dissolved. One of the issues in question was the small fleet of warships that the Norwegians had built up during the war, which the Danes demanded as state property, a demand that the Norwegians compared to the British seizure of the Danish-Norwegian fleet in 1807. Not unreasonably, the Norwegians considered this to be in bad faith, as Denmark, already in possession of most of the common property, was demanding one of the few assets left in Norwegian possession. In the end, the Norwegians were forced to pay for their own ships, which fed the fuel of hatred against Denmark. At the same time the negotiations had paradoxically underlined the

closeness of Norwegian–Danish ties, as the Norwegian negotiators were either Danish-born, related to the Danish negotiators or had lived in Denmark most of their lives.

In the Peace of Kiel, the Swedes had promised on behalf of Norway that the Norwegians would pay a share of the common national debt, an issue that plagued relations between Norway and Denmark until 1821 to such a degree that there were those on both sides who considered going to war over it. The fear of such a conflict was exaggerated, but this did not change the feelings it created. Some Norwegians, such as the first Norwegian to negotiate the debt, Jørgen Herman Vogt, felt that the Danish demands were reasonable, but he was well aware that most Norwegians felt otherwise. In the autumn of 1814 the Storting recognised the need to settle the debt with Denmark but felt that the agreement should be based not on the Peace of Kiel but on a total statement of the state's assets and liabilities. The Norwegians demanded the return of their former tributary countries, Greenland, the Faeroes and Iceland (which Denmark had kept after the peace of 1814), compensation for the Orkney and Shetland islands (pledged to Scotland in 1468), compensation for the Norwegian money that had helped to pay for the construction of Danish palaces and all other state-owned institutions located in Denmark. The fleet seized by the British in 1807 and the Sound Dues were later added to this. A Norwegian newspaper went even further and demanded a Norwegian share of the common colonies in the East and West Indies. All in all, the Storting was of the opinion that it was Denmark that owed Norway money.¹⁴

The dispute dragged on and was beset by deliberate Norwegian and Swedish obstruction, but it was unrealistic to believe that the debt would be waived, as the great powers were on the side of Denmark, and the Norwegians would therefore have been faced with the threat of war if they refused to cooperate. Norway ended up paying a considerably smaller sum than that agreed between Denmark and Sweden, but this still failed to appease public opinion in Norway. Some people felt that Sweden or the king should pay for the promise that they had made to the Danes in Kiel in 1814, others were prepared to go to war with Denmark, the great powers and Sweden, while a majority felt that there was no alternative but to pay. Their argument was based on the idea of autonomy, as they believed that to let the king or the Swedes pay would undermine Norway's independence. The result was that the Storting, pressured by troop manoeuvres ordered by Charles John outside the capital that seemed to hint at a *coup d'état* should the parliament not cave in to his demands, recognised under protest the convention agreed

upon. But the whole issue strengthened the opposition and heaped fuel on people's dislike of Denmark, Sweden and the king.¹⁵

The Norwegian View of Denmark in the Wake of the Separation

Ernst Renan and Joop Leerssen have emphasised how feelings of oppression, defeat and injustice can help to strengthen a sense of fellowship, as was the case with the Irish, while Chris Lorenz has pointed out that traumatic events can cause a nation to reshape elements of its past into their antithesis. Both factors are clearly present in Norwegian nation-building, where, in distancing themselves from Denmark and from what was seen as uncritical Norwegian accommodation before the separation, many people strengthened their national identity. In so doing, they imposed on the past a nationalist interpretation as a time when Norwegians had failed to live up to the demands for national dignity and autonomy that now made themselves felt. Pointing up the contrast between a Norwegian rebirth in 1814 and the preceding 'Danish night', as the union also has become known in Norway, became increasingly common. However, Norwegians were and still are to some extent divided as regards the past. As late as 1830 there remained divisions between those who spoke of the separation with delight and those who harked back to the brotherly union.¹⁶

Behind such divisions lay different interpretations of the past and of the political events of 1814, which had created deep splits in society. Many patriots at Eidsvoll nursed a cordial loathing for Denmark and wanted full independence, but as a general rule negative attitudes towards Danes were connected with a positive or a pragmatic view of the union with Sweden. The divisions created at Eidsvoll suffused the bitter debates of the years that followed. The frequent literary attacks on Denmark and the Danes in this period therefore had less to do with Denmark and the Danes than they had with the settlement of the political accounts amongst different political fractions in Norway dating back to the Constitutional Assembly.

Other factors, such as age and careers, were also significant in determining attitudes towards Denmark. On the one hand, there was the younger generation who could not remember the time before 1807 and therefore judged the union harshly, and on the other those of the older generation who had had strong ties with Denmark and had prospered were more lenient in their judgement of the union. Pro-Danish and pro-Swedish Norwegians created two different stereotypes of 'the Dane', based on a feeling of (high) cultural Norwegian inferiority. The former

had and maintained a positive view of Danish culture, which they saw as common ballast from the days of the union. Copenhagen was the 'Scandinavian Athens' and the gateway to a world that was open to Norwegians by a cultural union. The heritage of the union and the continuing inspiration from the old capital could and should be used to build up the new Norway and to continue the struggle against Swedish influence. Views such as these provoked the pro-Swedish Norwegians and cultural nationalists, who felt that political emancipation from Denmark should be followed by cultural emancipation.

Some members of the Norwegian elite still feared Danish influence, believing it had a corrupting effect on Norwegians and kept them in chains.¹⁷ In some places, this attitude led to poor treatment of 'Jutlanders' (as the Danes were disparagingly called). The priest Nicolai Wergeland and his ilk spent the years after the separation wallowing in the deprivations that Norwegians had suffered during the union, as they could now give their pent-up anger free rein and whip up a mood of ever-mounting hatred. It should be remembered here that, while it was now acceptable to criticise Denmark and absolutism, people had to be more careful about criticising Sweden and the new royal house. Attacks on the past could serve as thinly veiled warnings directed at the union with Sweden and at a king with absolutist ambitions.

In 1814 Nicolai Wergeland invented the terms 'Danomania', 'Danomaniac' and 'Danish-minded' to denote what in his eyes was the unnatural predilection felt by many Norwegians for Denmark. He attempted to set this to rights in his book *A Truthful Account of Denmark's Political Crimes against the Kingdom of Norway from 955 to 1814* (1816). It was characterised by a form of 'political archaeology' that involved using anything in history that could fit in with a nationalist interpretation while everything else was 'forgotten' or explained away as treachery. The past, Wergeland argued, was not only a mirror in which the nation could see itself. It was also a battlefield and a weapon in Norway's settling of scores with Denmark, and the work, in Wergeland's own words, was a catalogue of sins that was just as long as Scandinavian history. For Wergeland the book was a project designed to open Norwegians' eyes, and the second edition stressed that it was intended as evidence that would expose Danish crimes to the rest of Europe and make Norwegians realise that, prior to the deplorable Kalmar Union (the formal unification of Denmark, Norway and Sweden in 1397), Norway had been a proud nation. For him it represented a national battle for political truth, waged between genuine Norwegians and those who loved Denmark more than their own fatherland.¹⁸

Wergeland's history was not allowed to go uncontested. On the contrary, it sparked the first true literary feud in Norway. A whole range of pro-Danish Norwegians launched vehement attacks against him, while others defended Wergeland and wanted his book translated into the principal languages so that people in other countries could learn about the Norwegians' sufferings and the Norwegian nation's autonomy. In the short term Wergeland lost the public battle, but many people sided with him in subsequent years, and such support must be seen as part of a national development that placed the nation's dignity at its centre. In other words, history in Norway became a battlefield in a national zone of conflict in which each adversary saw the other as the enemy within.

Pro-Danish Norwegians were not blind to the disadvantages of the former union and their judgement of the time before 1660 was harsh, but they emphasised the advantages of a lenient Danish government, civic liberty and the long period of peace. In their eyes the union had been beneficial for Norway, but only a small number of them wished to see it resuscitated after 1814. The professors at the university, who were either pro-Danish or Danish-born, were severely affected by the separation. Whatever their individual views of the former royal power, they differentiated between the Danish people and the previous government, the latter being the only instance they felt could be reproached for anything. These Norwegians had been shaped by their lives in Denmark and they loved the country, the people and the culture, which they were part of themselves.

According to one Norwegian professor, Denmark was a nation worthy of respect, one to which Norwegians had an emotional bond. Danes and Norwegians had a shared language and shared memories, and their peoples were still connected by ties of friendship, family and affection. Furthermore, there were many Danes still living in Norway. The separation and the union with Sweden neither could nor should change any of this. The two nations were connected so closely and their families so tightly knit that what affected one people also affected the other.¹⁹

Pro-Danish Norwegians reacted instinctively to statements about Denmark they regarded as unreasonable and vindictive. A Norwegian professor wrote to a Danish colleague that every bitter word between Danes and Norwegians pained him more than any personal affront. And an observer wrote in a Norwegian newspaper that he felt it was his duty to protest against foul and foolish talk of Norwegians' power and their 'shameful clamour against Denmark, as though it were the source of all our ills'. In the same vein one professor argued that the anti-Danish attitudes that hid behind the mask of national feeling were expressions

of arrogance and egoism, and he more than hinted that, after the disappointment of 1814, Norwegians were attempting to put the blame for their own mistakes on the Danes.²⁰ The middle-class Norwegian perception of Denmark says far more about domestic divisions and nation-building in Norway than about their former Danish 'brothers'.²¹

Danish Relations with Norwegians Shortly after the Separation

After the separation Danes still wanted to maintain close cultural ties between the two countries, but it would have to be on Danish terms. As late as 1819 a Danish historian could speak of a Danish-Norwegian people that was still one with regard to faith and culture, while the Danish translations and publication of Icelander Snorre Sturluson's Norwegian kings' sagas *Heimskringla* (c. 1220–35) and Saxo Grammaticus's *Gesta danorum* (c. 1200) by the great priest and poet N.F.S. Grundtvig were an attempt to remind the two peoples of their spiritual union by which, according to the poet-priest, they were still bound.²²

The severing of the political link in itself resulted in widespread and intense distress. It comes as no surprise, therefore, that the hope of reunification was expressed in poetry, prose and letters during the years immediately after 1814. The poem *Dannemark* (1816) emphasises how the love between the two 'sisters', Denmark and Norway, was so strong that the poet feels there must be a reunification. This hope changed over the years, turning into Scandinavianism and/or the view that separation had been necessary as an expression of popular sovereignty. From a purely political point of view, the idea of reunification was completely unrealistic. This was due not only to opposition from Sweden, the great powers and Norway, but also to the two different systems of government. Norway constituted a model for younger liberals in Denmark but was anathema to Frederick VI. Like most other European countries, Denmark was caught up in the conservative reaction that followed 1815, which resulted in suspicion being cast on Norwegians, almost by definition, as potential revolutionaries. Set alongside the issue of settling their debt, this created bad blood between the 'sisters'.

There were two other decisive factors that were instrumental in distancing Danes from Norwegians: anger and denial. The separation had been a humiliation for Denmark and Danish self-understanding and was exacerbated when Norway settled accounts with a common past, a common culture and a common language. Danes were conscious of the Norwegians' complaints that they had been ignored and had not been

treated equally during the years before the separation, and many sympathised with them. At the same time many Danes felt that these complaints were sometimes exaggerated or were due to misunderstandings. The disparity between Danish and Norwegian memories of their common past can be compared to Peter Burke's observations of British–Irish relations, which show in both cases that the 'stronger' party remembers the good times and forgets the bad times, while the reverse is true of the 'weaker' party. This 'social amnesia', to use Burke's phrase, may reflect the different needs of the two nations in their nation-building but creates bitterness in the opposite party.²³

Wergeland's work made him the incarnation of everything that Danes hated about the 'new' Norway. There are many sarcastic remarks in periodicals and letters about Wergeland's publication but, with a single exception, there were no 'replies' to his charges from the Danes. There is no doubt that several of the academic 'gladiators' in Denmark wished to take Wergeland to task. The reason why this did not happen can be found in Frederick VI's dislike of discussing politics in general and in the traumatic effect of the loss of Norway in particular.

Official Danish policy was that Norway should be 'forgotten' and memories of the former union repressed, which was made all the easier by the Norwegian provocations. The king had attempted to influence public opinion as early as 1814 by publishing pseudonymous pamphlets. These commissioned works argued that the 'loss of Norway' was really a blessing in disguise, as the country had been a financial burden for Denmark, which was a downright lie as the loss of the Norwegian market was a considerable problem for the Danish economy.²⁴

An Independent Language by Name or by Nature

The dissolution of the Danish-Norwegian state had immediate consequences for language in Norway. In February 1814 an observer noted in his diary a tendency for people to talk about the Norwegian language instead of the Danish language. He called this ridiculous, as Danish and Norwegian were one and the same language, but in his diary entries later in year he himself began to refer to the spoken language as Norwegian. On the other hand, he continued to maintain that the written language and the language used in schools was Danish, underlining his wish – and the wish of many educated Norwegians – to maintain close cultural ties between the two countries.²⁵

The tendency to call the language Norwegian became official policy. The majority of the Norwegian elite regarded any merging with

Sweden with foreboding, as was evident from the Constitutional Act of November 1814, in which Sections 47 and 81 emphasised and secured the name and status of the Norwegian language. The Storting received academic backing for this 'language coup', as it later became known, in a statement from the University of Christiania, which concluded that the written language had been jointly developed and was therefore as Norwegian as it was Danish. Later in the century powerful movements advocated the creation of a 'truly Norwegian' written language. However, in the years immediately after 1814 few people went any further than demanding that the written language of Norway be called Norwegian despite the fact that it was identical with Danish. Nevertheless, the language coup must be seen as an expression of the emphasis placed on the link between the nation and the language. As the nation had not yet achieved full political independence, Norway needed to position itself symbolically and conceptually in relation to both Sweden and Denmark. In other words, there was a need for external recognition and a national sense of self alongside the right to the greatest possible national autonomy and self-expression.²⁶

The official status conferred on the 'Norwegian' language in the Constitutional Act did not, however, decide the matter once and for all. Danes wanted to maintain a linguistic and literary fellowship not only in nature but also in name, and the language coup was a blow to Danes' self-perception, which had already suffered a serious blow.²⁷ For Danes the Norwegian language was and remained throughout the period up to the 1830s either a dialect, the language of Norwegian peasants, or the name of a language spoken in Norway in the Middle Ages. A prominent Danish linguist spoke scornfully of 'the royal Norwegian tongue' and made it clear that, if Norwegians really wished to cultivate their rustic dialect, that language must be called Norwegian, but there was no mistaking his view that it was a mad idea. In Danish eyes, this was all an attempt by some Norwegians to undermine the spiritual fellowship that Danes and Norwegians had been building up for centuries and that was symbolised and guaranteed by their common language. In other words, Norway's cultural secession was instrumental in breaking down an integral aspect of people's sense of self south of the Skagerrak.²⁸

The numerous Danish objections led to an intense debate about language in Norway. Immediately after separation there was no consensus about the name of the language in the country, but people gradually began to use the term 'mother tongue', as a kind of compromise. However, the controversy lingered on. For Norwegian nationalists the heart of the matter was national independence. For the language of the

nation to have its own name emphasised the fact that Norwegians were a people separate from the Danes, even though the written language might be identical, while calling the language Danish emphasised Danish ascendancy over Norway.

By about 1830, however, the term 'Norwegian' as a language appears to have found favour with the public, while the language taught at the university was called Danish up to the 1820s, and several Norwegian grammar schools only changed the name of the subject they taught from Danish to Norwegian in the 1830s or 1840s. This initial victory for the 'Norwegian' language went no deeper than the name and had little to do with content. In other words, the written language to all intents and purposes remained Danish. This can be explained by the deep-rooted middle-class fear of the severance of cultural ties with Denmark. However, the Norwegians' struggle with the language continued. Some measure of pragmatic 'Norwegianisation' was used by the elite to pepper their written language without really breaking with Danish. But for some this was far from enough. In the spirit of national romanticism they wanted to return to the past and the true 'essence' of the nation. They did this by constructing an artificial Norwegian language based on dialects collected in West Norway, which allegedly reflected the original, genuine Norwegian language – before it had been polluted by Danish. Norwegians dubbed the new language *landsmål* (language of the country), but this was later changed to *nynorsk* (new Norwegian), while the Danish-influenced language was called *rigsmål/riksmål* (language of the realm) at the time, which today, in its 'Norwegianised' version, is called *bokmål* (book language).

The Fellowship Continued

The close and time-honoured connections across the Skagerrak, together with the affection of the 'Danomaniacs' for Denmark in general and for Copenhagen in particular meant that the cultural union lived on somewhere in the region of a hundred years after the political union had been dissolved. This was in no small part due to the Danish capital being able to maintain its position as a centre of culture for Norwegians. Norway's new capital, Christiania, was not as yet considered an undisputed centre for Norwegians. The town was only half the size of Bergen, and even though the first Norwegian university had been founded there in 1813, it contained few other cultural institutions. Compared to Copenhagen, Christiania could still only be considered a provincial town. The Danish capital was not only ten times larger than its Norwegian counterpart, it was also the home of institutions such as the

Royal Theatre, the Royal Library, the Academy of Fine Arts and a host of publishing houses, in addition to the large number of poets, artists and scientists who lived there. Norway did not as yet have a well-developed literary or cultural infrastructure, and Norwegians were therefore still obliged to make use of the Danish facilities, even after the separation.²⁹

While Frederick VI suppressed political activities, art and culture flourished in what posterity has called the Danish 'golden age'. This meant that Norwegian painters, sculptors and musicians, whose opportunities for developing their talent at home were extremely limited, quite naturally flocked to Denmark and, after it opened in 1829, the Polytechnic College acted as a magnet for Norwegian students until 1900.

The leading Norwegian national romantic painters and sculptors received their training at the Academy of Fine Arts in Copenhagen, while the foremost Norwegian national romantic composer, Edvard Grieg, was strongly influenced by the Danish composer Niels W. Gade and wrote several of his greatest works in Denmark. As for the theatre, Norway had to make do with amateur theatricals and travelling (Danish) theatre troupes until 1827. This was the year when a Swede founded Christiania Theatre hoping to use Norwegian-born actors, but the project was soon abandoned, and Danish actors continued to be imported until the second half of the nineteenth century. The same applied to plays, which were for a long time Danish or Danish translations of German plays.

For many decades after the separation Norwegian schoolchildren read Danish schoolbooks or Norwegian schoolbooks primarily containing Danish texts. The explanation for this was that no independent Norwegian literature was yet available. Until about 1850 cultural links went only one way between the two countries, and what was known as 'the national breakthrough', with the collection of Norwegian folktales and the creation and introduction of new Norwegian, does not alter the fact that the major Norwegian authors from the second half of the nineteenth century derived their primary cultural inspiration from Danish golden-age art, just as the breakthrough of modernism in Danish literature was also very important for Norwegian artists. Furthermore, Henrik Ibsen, Knut Hamsun and about 90 of Norway's major authors all published their works in Copenhagen. This was because Norwegian authors received more professional treatment from Danish publishers and because they had far more readers in Denmark. There was, therefore, a common Danish-Norwegian market for books until the beginning of the twentieth century.

The talent and the popularity of the Norwegian authors in Denmark, however, changed the relative strengths of Danish and Norwegian

literature. As a Danish author correctly pointed out at the end of the nineteenth century, it was now Norwegians who dominated the common culture. Norway and Norwegians became fashionable in Copenhagen, and it was said in all seriousness in Danish circles that Norwegian was quite simply a better language for lyrical expression. However, it must be pointed out that Norwegian and Danish were still extremely close to each other (the language used by Ibsen is closer to that of present-day Danish than present-day Norwegian). Although there were doubtless Norwegian artists and intellectuals who had an ambivalent and sometimes hostile attitude to Denmark and the days of the union, most of the great Norwegian authors regarded the continued connection with Danes as a benefit. Henrik Ibsen wrote that he desired to be as closely connected to Denmark as possible, while a Norwegian author who felt she was misunderstood in the more puritanical Norway, had the following words engraved on her tombstone: 'Danish citizen, Danish subject and Danish author'.³⁰

The victory of parliamentarism in Norway in 1884 may have given impetus to the Danish Left (the liberal farmers' party in Denmark), but the cultural policy of the Norwegian Left (the liberal farmers' party in Norway) was a tremendous disappointment for progressive Norwegian authors who had formerly supported the party, and this proved to be a nail in the coffin of Danish–Norwegian cultural fellowship. The Norwegian farmers who now came to power conducted a consistently national and pietistic policy that curbed authors' freedom of expression and placed new Norwegian on an equal footing with 'book language'. The prominent author, Bjørnstjerne Bjørnson, who had criticised the close ties with Denmark earlier in his career, defended the closest linguistic links between the countries as he grew older and wrote, 'we must not sever our connection with Denmark. Danes are the world's most enlightened people and are therefore the most skilful'.³¹ While this is a statement that begs discussion, there can be no doubt that Bjørnson and his like-minded compatriots saw Denmark as a gateway to the world. Their national feeling gave way to a cosmopolitan view, while the agrarian nationalism of the Norwegian Left was introverted and saw democracy almost as a Norwegian phenomenon that could be traced back to the Viking era. Parliamentarism therefore brought to prominence a domestic Norwegian division between town and country, which can still be seen today.

1905 – The Waterloo for the Common Culture

The national line pursued by the Norwegian Left undermined the Swedish–Norwegian union and paved the way for full Norwegian

independence and the dissolution of the union in 1905. Danes were completely in support of Norwegians in their national struggle, which in the years that followed turned the Swedes first against Norway and then against Denmark. This did nothing, however, to strengthen Danish-Norwegian relations. Political emancipation and national enthusiasm prompted many Norwegians to demand a cultural settlement of accounts with the *Danish period* and with the continued links with Denmark. Just as in former colonies, attempts were made to erase those traces of history that did not conform to the national self-image. Among other things, this took the form of changing the names of towns, particularly those towns that had been named after 'Danish' kings. Christiania became Oslo, Frederikshald was changed to Halden and Trondhjem became Nidaros, which was changed again to Trondheim as a compromise in response to protests.

In 1907 the first in a long series of spelling reforms began that distanced Norwegian from Danish, but without it being possible to amalgamate 'new Norwegian' and 'book language'. National rearmament led, among other things, to new demands that included the return of Norwegian documents from the National Archives in Copenhagen, the repurchasing of the rights to the works of Norwegian authors by Norwegian publishers, and the struggle for (eastern) Greenland, which Norwegians felt had been stolen from them in 1814. Norway went so far as to occupy parts of eastern Greenland, at which point Denmark successfully took the matter to the International Court in the Hague in 1933. The issue whipped up popular resentment and seriously damaged Danish-Norwegian relations. The Norwegian government had recognised the ruling, but the situation changed again with the outbreak of the Second World War.

Both countries were occupied on 9 April 1940, but while the Norwegian government went into exile, the Danish government chose to collaborate with the German occupiers in order to protect the civilian population. This made Denmark's status ambivalent in relation to the Axis Powers and the Allies. That Denmark ended up on 'the right side of history' was due both to the breakdown of the policy of collaboration in 1943, the resistance movement and skilful diplomacy on the part of the Danish ambassador in the United States, who acted independently of the government in occupied Denmark. The foreign minister of the Norwegian government in exile, however, went to great lengths to thwart him in an attempt to regain Greenland for Norway. But the diplomatic Norwegian offensive came to nothing, as it contravened the Monroe Doctrine and the agreements the United States had made with the Danish ambassador to build US bases in Greenland.³² At the same

time, the Nazi Party, which had assumed power in Norway, attempted to gain Hitler's support to acquire parts of Greenland, but it was beyond the power – and probably the interest – of the Führer to return the Norwegians' lost dependency, while the allies refused to hand it over to the democratically elected Norwegian government after the war.

However, all of this was kept secret at the time, and the Second World War dramatically improved Danish–Norwegian relations. While Danes got through the occupation fairly lightly, the Norwegians suffered greatly. In Copenhagen, the old capital of Norway, people began to send emergency supplies to children north of the Skagerrak during the war. This turned into the single greatest relief effort in Danish history. In return, after the war, Norwegians took the initiative to establish the Danish–Norwegian Cooperation Fund, which still works to maintain close ties between the two countries. This fraternisation and the Nordic cooperation that took place after 1945, however, was weakened when Denmark and Norway chose different directions in 1972 as regards the European Union. The ties that linked Denmark and Norway, once so close, are slowly being forgotten. Some Danes today are not even aware that Denmark and Norway were united for more than 400 years, and neither north nor south of the Skagerrak are there many people who know anything about the period of cultural fellowship that flowered after the separation. None of this changes the fact that the histories of Denmark and Norway are inextricably intertwined and have a common story to which their 'two' languages can bear witness.

Notes

1 Denmark-Norway and the Ideology of Patriotism

1. Barton 1986. Cf. Barton 1982; Sather 2004; Feldbæk 1997a; Barton 2009; Jørgensen 2004; Munch-Petersen 2007b; Sather 1975; Tønnesson 1966; Dwyer 2003: 111–12; Esdaile 1993: 427; 2005: 1.
2. Olufsen 1839: 146; *Trondhiems borgerlige Skoles*, 19 November 1811.
3. Storsveen 1997: 10, 19.
4. Feldbæk 1984: 281.
5. Nielsen 1877: 259–70; Feldbæk 1994a; 1998: 300–7; Collett 2008: 137.
6. Feldbæk 1998: 170–1; Dyrvik 1999: 196, 264.
7. Storsveen 1997: 26–7; Feldbæk 1998: 289–90.
8. Winsnes 1807; Platou 1813: i; Rian 1997: 170; Rask 1941: 131.
9. Fjeldstad 1990: 151–2; Engelhardt 2004: 385–7; Treschow 1810–11: 169.
10. Heiberg 1884: 179.
11. Nyerup 1799: 352–3.
12. Japsen 1979–81; Colley 1992; Kryger 1991: 291.
13. Schlegel 1805 [1798], vol. II: 172; Seip 1958: 16–17, 21.
14. Clark 2006: 256–82.
15. Wessel 1862: 222–6.
16. Ottosen 2012b; Mentz 2004b.
17. Hemstad 2004: 202–4.
18. Møller 2007: 8; Bourgois 2007: 45.
19. Feldbæk 1997b: 7; Bjørn 2003 [1990]: 67, 102–4.
20. Ottosen 2012b: 232–41.
21. Brøndsted 1847: 87.
22. Ørsted 1951: 82–3, 331; Bülow 1966 [1906]: 45; *Danske Tilskuer*, no. 89, 1801; *Danske Tilskuer*, nos 16–17, 1802.
23. Bjørn 2003 [1990]: 102.

2 The Bombardment of Copenhagen in 1807

1. Bourgois 2007: 49–50; 2005.
2. Saxtorph 2007: 54; Glete 1993.
3. Munch-Petersen 2007a: 107.
4. Henningsen 2007a: 18.
5. Mentz 2007b: 89–90.
6. Bourgois 2007: 48.
7. Munch-Petersen 2007a; 2007b.
8. Quoted in Munch-Petersen 2007a: 106.
9. Manchester 1969: 148–83.
10. Feldbæk 2002: 495.
11. Harvey 1992: 87.

12. Holm 1912: 295.
13. Generalstaben 1888, vol. III: 12–13.
14. Munch-Petersen 2007b: 206.
15. Ræder 1845, vol. I: 107–13.
16. Hedegaard 1970: 34, 120; Henningsen 2007b; Hammond 1899–1902: 294–5.
17. Ebbesen 1941.
18. Henningsen 2007b; Ræder 1845, vol. I: 129ff.; Rowe 1998: 153.
19. Holm 1912, vol. I: 327; Ræder 1845, vol. I: 9798; Frantzen and Jespersen 2010: 422.
20. Saxtorph 1990; Hedegaard 1970: 30; Ræder 1845, vol. I: 93–6.
21. Rubin 1970 [1892]: 145–6, 447; Hatting 1988: 72–3; Hedegaard 1975, vol. I: 164.
22. Hedegaard 1970: 38; Johansen 1948: 52–86.
23. Generalstaben 1888, vol. III: 96–7, 50–1.
24. Mynster 1884: 174.
25. Generalstaben 1888, vol. III: 105; Hedegaard 1970: 114.
26. Ottosen 2009a; Esdaile 2004: 88–92; Colley 1992: ch. 7; Frost 2008.
27. Hillingsø 2007: 142–4; Hedegaard 1970: 116, 120.
28. Langen 2007.
29. Paludan 1807: 10. Cf. Glenthøj 2007: 84–9.
30. Peymann 1807: 106; Harvey 1992: 100–1.
31. *Efterretninger og Opmuntringer*, nos 15–16, 1807.
32. Hansen 2007: 282.
33. Esdaile 2007: 312; Munch-Petersen 2007b: 199; Krogaard 2007; Scheen 2007; Callisen 1807: 629; Hillingsø 2007: 181.
34. Balle 1807: 5–6; 17–19.
35. Collins 2012.
36. Dahlerup 1908: 32–3.
37. Engelhardt 2001: 37–8; Engelstoft 1867–68: 147, 168.
38. Overskou 1961: 24; Petersen 2007.
39. Engelstoft 1867–68: 152.
40. Schmidt 1966: 142; Werlauff 1873–74: 300; Engelstoft 1867–68: 107.
41. *Det norske Nationalblad*, vol. 12, 1818: 88.
42. *Nyeste Skilderie af Kjøbenhavn*, 7 Nov. 1807.
43. Glenthøj 2007: 95–103.
44. Rubin 1970 [1892]: 474; Hansen 2007: 286ff.
45. *Nyeste Skilderie af Kjøbenhavn*, 25 Feb. 1809.
46. *Tiden* 1808–10, vols V–VI: 46; Glenthøj and Rasmussen 2007b.
47. Quoted in Glenthøj 2007: 155ff.
48. Røepstorff 1808: 25; Manthey 1807: 9, 10, 15, 108; Treschow 1810–11: 85–7; Boye 1809: 21–6.
49. Quoted in Rubin 1970 [1892]: 457.
50. Münter 1807: 92–3; MacDonald 1809: 68, 119.
51. Ræder 1845, vol. I: 308–9, 345.
52. Hellfried 1808: 76; Werlauff 1873–74: 311–12; Seerup 2007; Hillingsø 2007: 187.
53. Cf. Sevaldsen 2007.
54. Goiske 1808; Henningsen 2007a: 43ff.; 2007b.
55. Høegh-Guldberg 1815: 191.
56. Debes 1808: 5; Ewald 1809; Laqueur 1975: 343–6.
57. Bruun 1807: 11; Holst 1807: 18; 1811: 3; Paludan 1807: 14.

58. Engelstoft 1808: 148, 165, 178–9, 180, 182–97.
59. Røepstorff 1808: 23–4; Hellfried 1808: 135.
60. Hellfried 1808: 5–7.
61. *Ny Minerva*, II, 1807.
62. Hansen 1807a: 11; Bech 1807; Bugge 1807; Sørensen 1807.
63. Bugge 1807: 3; Hansen 1807b: 6.
64. Hansen 1807a: 66; Boisen 1811: 6; Bugge 1807: 2–4; Paludan 1808: 39.
65. Paludan 1808: 8–10, 20, 22.

3 Scandinavian War, 1808–09

1. Clason 1912: 8–16; Jörgensen 2004: 106–9; Ottosen 2012b: 238–41; 2012a: 15–18.
2. Pedersen 2007: 204–5.
3. Jörgensen 2006; Olsen 2009.
4. Clason 1909, 1912, 1913; Muir 1996: 26–9; Ottosen 2012a: 15–16; Ottosen 2012b: 240–2.
5. Ottosen 2012a: 14–15; Clason 1913: 52–95; Mentz 2007a: 60; Holm 1912: 38; Bourgois 2006: 21–2.
6. Bourgois 2006 and 2009.
7. Ottosen 2012a: 16–18; 2012b: 241–3; KRA. Krigshandlingar 1808–09. Vol. 22. Tibell to Gustav IV 6 March 1808.
8. Bourgois 2006: 33–4.
9. KRA. Krigshandlingar 1808–09. Vol. 22. 'General Majorn af Tibells underdåniga Embets Berättelse...', 19 March 1809; Ottosen 2012b: 222–5, 241–3; Friis 1897–99: 243.
10. Ottosen 2012b: 241–4; 2012a: 17; Clason 1912; GKA, vol. 6: 123–64.
11. Platou and Lange (eds) 1859: 7–15, 174; Generalstaben 1888, vol. III: 270–2.
12. Worm-Müller 1918: 91; Platou and Lange (eds) 1859: 179.
13. KRA. Krigshandlingar 1808–09. Vol. 158, '*Plan till Västra Armeens inbrott i Norrige*', 5 April 1808, cf. vol. 32: Armfelt to Gustav IV 21 March and 8 1808; vol. 295. Armfelt to Gustav IV 8 April 1808 and Gustav IV to Armfelt 11 April 1808; vol. 153. Armfelt to Th. Cederström 13 April 1808; vol. 158. Armfelt to Leijonstedt 14 April 1808; Barton 1986: 281.
14. KRA. Krigshandlingar 1808–09. Vol. 295. Armfelt to Gustav IV 30 April, 12 and 13 May 1808, cf. Gustav IV to Armfelt 25 April and 8 May 1808; vol. 153. Armfelt to Vegesack 1 and 10 May 1808, and to Gustav IV 10 [May] 1808.
15. KRA. Krigshandlingar 1808–09. Vol. 295. Armfelt to Gustav IV 13, 21 and 24 May 1808; Clason 1912.
16. Clason 1912; Muir 1996: 26; Esdaile 1995: 231–4; Ottosen 2012a: 20; Sather 2004.
17. Glenthøj 2010: 77; Wersel 1808.
18. Ottosen 2012a: 15; Koht 1926: 133–44; Rian 1997: 172, 180; Pugh 1980: 131; Sather 1975: 131.
19. See RAO. RAA. SGK. Ea. L0001. de Seue to Christian August 16 April 1808.
20. Generalstaben 1888, vol. III: 415–16; RAO. RAA. SGK. Da. L0048: Hesselberg to Christian August 24 May 1808; Aall 1859: 135.
21. Holm 1903: 619; *Budstikken*, Copenhagen 1808: 99.

22. Pedersen 2008: 273–5; Morgenstjerne 1808: 47 (note); Wergeland 1811: 32; Nygaard 1960: 29.
23. Generalstaben 1888, vol. 3: 415–16; Aall 1859: 99; Daae 1891: 319; KRA. Krigshandlingar 1808–09. Vol. 32. Armfelt to Gustav IV 17 April 1808, cf. vol. 295. Armfelt to Gustav IV 17 April 1808. See also Feilitzen 1955: 36; RAO. PA-0135. 'Ludvig' Rynning to 'Lilla' Rynning 29 April 1808 and Wollebæk 1926: 259.
24. Worm-Müller 1918: 246; Hauge 1960: 55; Holm 1903: 613–14.
25. Feldbæk 1998: 322; Sørensen 1903: 109; Generalstaben 1888, vol. III: 437–8.
26. Ottosen 2012b: 236–8.
27. Svandal 2012, cf. KRA. Krigshandlingar 1808–09. Vol. 32. Promemoria by 'J.A.D.' 13 March 1808; Vegesack to Gustav IV 21 March 1808. See also RAS. Kabinettet/UD 1681–1952. FIA: vol. 8. Rosen to Ehrenheim 28 February 1808 and Carpelan to Gustav IV 5 March 1808; see also KRA. Krigshandlingar 1808–09. Vol. 32. Carpelan to Gustav IV 26 March 1808 and 'J.A.D.' to Gustav IV 7 March 1808; vol. 161. Dahlmann to Armfelt 4 May 1808; vol. 180. B. Sparre to Th. Cederström 4 May 1808.
28. KRA. Krigshandlingar 1808–09. Vol. 32. Armfelt to Gustav IV 28 March 1808 and vol. 295. Armfelt to Gustav IV 3 April 1808.
29. KRA. Krigshandlingar 1808–09. Vol. 32. Armfelt to Gustav IV 28 March 1808 and vol. 295. Armfelt to Gustav IV 3 April 1808; vol. 153. Armfelt to Th. Cederström 13 April 1808 and vol. 179. '*Extra Brigad Ordre af d. 14 April 1808*', cf. vol. 180. Armfelt to Th. Cederström 22 April 1808; Ottosen 2012d: 122; cf. Davis 2006: 133 (quote).
30. KRA. Krigshandlingar 1808–09. Vol. 295. Armfelt to Gustav IV 20 April 1808; Ottosen 2012c: 169; 2012d: 109.
31. Ottosen 2009a and 2009b; cf. 2012d: 29; Mykland 1978: 64; Rian 1997: 180; Dyrvik 1999: 214–15.
32. Aall 1859: 142–3; Nielsen 1888: 163–5. Cf. RA. Genst. kra. XVI. L0086. Juul to Christian August 19 and 26 October 1807; RAO. RAA. SGK. E. L0011a, No. 16. Lund to Christian August 1 May 1808, cf. Ohme to Christian August (undated, probably 2 May 1808) with attachments (three reports from Wedel Jarlsberg to Ohme 1 May 1808 and Friis to Ohme 30 April 1808); RAO. RAA. SGK. Ea – vol. L0011a. No. 16. Ohme to Christian August 27 and 28 May 1808, cf. RAO. RAA. SGK. Bb. L0017. Christian August to Ohme 25 May, 28 May and 5 June 1808, and to *Akershus Stift* 25 May 1808; RAO. Genst. kra. XVI. L0386. Moltke to Christian August 18 April 1808.
33. Snøfugl 1986: 411; [Kolltveit] 1946: 101; RAO. Manuskriptsamlingen. L0066. Thord Johannsen to Peder Johannessen Hagestuen 27 May 1808.
34. Frost 2008. Cf. Damsholt 2002 and 2000: 314–20.
35. Vasbotn 1982: 25; Snøfugl 1987: 409; Austigard 1982: 151; Colley 1992; Cookson 2009; Barstad 1908, vol. I: 48.
36. Glensthøj 2010: 75; Ræder 1852, vol. III: 55–7; Ødegaard 1980: 70; Midthaug 1923 and Olafsen 1913; RAO. GKK. KNK. D. L0092. Bech to *Det Kongelige Norske Kommissariats Kollegium* 25 August 1808; RAO. Manuskriptsamlingen. L0066. Thord Johannessen to Peder Johannessen Hagestuen 10 January 1808 [1809].
37. Broers 2010a: 54.
38. Ottosen 2012d: 225–45 and 2009a.

39. HHS. Carsten Tanks Arkiv. A. 1. Box 3. 1808–12. 1808. Halvor Johannessen Trosterud to Carsten Tank 26 March 1808; SAH. FH. Df. L0686/vol. 15. 1808. Hornseth to Lind 21 May 1808.
40. SAH. FH. L0042/vol. 1. 1807–11 (1817–19). C. Bendeke to J. Rasmussen 22 April 1808; *Trondhiems borgerlige Skoles* 29 March 1808; Ottosen 2009a.
41. KRA. Krigshandlingar 1808–09. Vol. 32. Armfelt to Gustav IV 17 April 1808; vol. 161. Lagerbring to Armfelt 14 April 1808.
42. Ottosen 2012d: 239–40; Rothenberg 1994: 94; Forrest 2005: 40–1; Bell 2007; Blanning 2002: 127–31.
43. Esdaile 2004: 174–5; Scotti-Douglas 2005: 54–5; Rian 1997: 169; Snøfugl 1985: 408 and 1987: 599.
44. SAH. FO. DI. L0515. Schultz to Sommerfelt 25 January and 22 February 1808; cf. Thorald 2011: 197.
45. Tranberg 2012; SAH. FH. Brev fra forskjellige. L0083/vol. 5. 1808–09. Petition to Bendeke from Halsteen Olsen Ous among others 7 November 1808.
46. Tidemand 1881: 194.
47. Smith 1999 [1986]: 192–6.
48. Christensen 1998: 61–9; Sørensen 2001: 28.
49. Ottosen 2010a.
50. Platou and Lange (eds) 1859: 184; Laache 1941: 203; Ottosen 2012d: 70.
51. Blanning 1983.
52. Persson 1986; Hårdstedt 2012.
53. Ottosen 2012d: 93–135; 2010a.
54. KRA. Krigshandlingar 1808–09. Vol. 158. Proclamation issued 8 June 1808.
55. RAO. RAA. SGK. Ea. L0002. Staffeldt to Christian August 1 June 1808.
56. Ottosen 2012b: 234–5; Tegnér 1905: 157; Ridderstad 1847: 27; KRA. Krigshandlingar 1808–09. Vol. 32. Armfelt to Gustav IV 29 May 1808; Ottosen 2012d: 128–9.
57. Ottosen 2012c.
58. Bourgois 2009: 77–8; Sørensen 1903: 115; Ræder 1847, vol. II: 177; Jensen 2009: 88.
59. Floris 2009: 17–25; Høj 2009: 144.
60. Platou and Lange (eds) 1859: 184.
61. Petersen 2009: 116.
62. RAS. SL. Värmlands Län. Vol. 8: 1808–09. Rosen to Gustav IV 18 February 1809.
63. Worm-Müller 1918: 160–3; SAH. FH. L0634/vol. 13. Høegh to Bendeke 3 March and 6 August 1809; L0042/vol. 1. 1807–11 (1817–19). Bendeke to *Akershus Stift* 9 May 1809.
64. Barstad 1908, vol. I: 154–5, cf. 158–9 and 1908, vol. II: 128–9; Carl 2009; Planert 2006.
65. Martensen-Larsen 1987.
66. Aall 1859: 141.
67. James 2012: 229–33; Ottosen 2012d: 263–9; Worm-Müller 1918: 153; Platou and Lange (eds) 1859: 216–19; Cf. RAO. RAA. SGK. Da. L0046. Krogh to Christian August 11 February 1809.
68. Hårdstedt 2006: 209–15, 246–51.
69. Quoted in Bregnsbo forthcoming.

70. Hedegaard 1975, vol. II: 400; Vaupell 1876: 317–19; Hedegaard 1975, vol. I: 166–74; Ræder 1852, vol. III: 258–9.
71. Platou and Lange (eds) 1859: 125–8, 218–22; Sørensen (ed.) 1889: 18–21; RAO. RAA. SGK. Da. L0046. Krogh to Christian August 20 January and 7 February 1809.
72. Sørensen (ed.) 1889: 218. Cf. Sather 1975: 317–18, 329–30.
73. Sather 1975: 313, 345; quoted in Ræder 1847, vol. II: 477.
74. Sather 1975: 344–7, 392–3; Feldbæk 2002: 500; Ræder 1852, vol. III: 561–7.
75. Barton 1982: 146; Nielsen 1888: 130–90.
76. Sather 1975: 296–305.
77. RAO. Genst. kra. XVI. L0386. Wedel Jarlsberg to Christian August 21 September 1807, 23 January 1808 and 8 March 1808. Cf. Nielsen 1888: 163–5.
78. Sather 1975: 296–305.
79. Nielsen 1888: 200.
80. Dørum 2009: 110–13.

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1. Glenthøj 2010: 77; Garde 1835: 419–22; Ræder 1847, vol. II: 8.
2. KRA. Krigshandlingar 1808–09. Vol. 32. Lagerbjelke to Gustav IV 24 August 1808.
3. Bjerg 2012.
4. RAO. RAA. SGK. Da. L0046. Klerck to Krogh 28 July 1809, attached to Krogh to Christian August 30 September 1809.
5. Ræder 1847, vol. II: 555–6; Feldbæk 1998: 328.
6. Ræder 1847, vol. II: 544–70.
7. Barton 1986: 294; Mykland 1978: 224; Vaupell 1876: 346–57; Holm 1912: 302–3; Ottosen 2012c: 183.
8. Lyngby 2004; Pavels 1864: 88; Schrøder 1924: 33.
9. Petersen 2007; Ræder 1847, vol. II: 247.
10. Ræder 1847, vol. II: 251.
11. Seerup 2007; Rian 2002: 31; Petersen 2007: 278.
12. Holm 1912: 369–70; Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 87, 182–7; Elgvin 2003: 91; Weibull 1957: 45–9.
13. Tønnessen 1950: 87; Dam 1810.
14. Teige 2012; Tønnessen 1955: 22–3; Larsen 1915; Frydenlund 2009a: 165–6.
15. Worm-Müller 1918: 129; Larsen 1915: 19; Tønnessen 1955: 23, 105–6.
16. Feldbæk 2002: 505; KRA. Krigshandlingar 1808–09. Vol. 308. Krogh to Hesselberg 13 June 1808.
17. Tønnessen 1955: 105–6; Ræder 1847, vol. II: 558.
18. Larsen 1915: 21–22; Feldbæk 2002: 105; Tønnessen 1955: 108; Pedersen 2011; Frydenlund 2009a: 164–6.
19. Glenthøj 2010: 89; GKA 1919: 232; Feldbæk 1998: 296–300.
20. Tønnessen 1955: 224; Holm 1912: 292–3; Ræder 1845, vol. I: 436.
21. Nielsen 1888: 354; Worm-Müller 1918: 126; Ruppenthal 1943: 21; Ræder 1847, vol. II: 537.
22. Tønnessen 1955: 411; Mykland 1978: 201.
23. Hedegaard 1975, vol. II: 289–94.

24. Ellis 1991: 94–7; Schroeder 1994: 310; Heckscher 1922: 88–94.
25. Ottosen 2010b; Rubin 1970 [1892]: 356–7.
26. Forrest 2012: 192.
27. Forrest 2012: 192; Aaslestad 2005: 229–30.
28. Heckscher 1922: 151–3; Ruppenthal 1943: 13–14; Mykland 1978: 234.
29. Aaslestad 2010: 393; Mykland 1978: 250.
30. Ellis 1991: 97, 104.
31. Heckscher 1922: 205–24; Ellis 1991: 104–5; Ostenfeld 1909: 6–7; Aaslestad 2007: 122–3.
32. Ellis 1991: 98–102; Crouzet 1964: 574–7, 580–1.
33. Cf. Aaslestad 2007: 124–5.
34. Aaslestad 2007: 124–5; Heckscher 1922: 153, 179–80, 182–3, 202–3.
35. Heckscher 1922: 188–97; Aaslestad 2005: 119–25; 2009: 124.
36. Ruppenthal 1943: 21; Aaslestad 2009: 129; Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 107; Hedegaard 1975, vol. II: 246; Ostenfeld 1909: 6–7; Aaslestad 2005: 245–69.
37. Rubin 1970 [1892]: 325–6; SAH. FH. Df. L0758: 1807–08. Weidemann to Bendeke 12 March 1808, cf. Bd. L0042 – vol. 1. 1817–19 [1807–11]. Bendeke to Weidemann 17 March 1808.
38. Ruppenthal 1943: 10–11; Mentz 2004a; Worm-Müller 1918: 34–6; Mykland 1978: 202; Tveite 2008: 49.
39. Worm-Müller 1918: 43–5.
40. Mykland 1978: 160–2.
41. Frydenlund 2009a: 163; Ottosen 2012d: 273–5.
42. Kirkeby 1966: 353–6; Worm-Müller 1918: 35–6.
43. Worm-Müller 1918: 42–81.
44. Frydenlund 2009a: 194–203; quote from Hauge 1960: 55.
45. Feldbæk 1993: 171–2, 176–7.
46. Møller 1998: 11.
47. Hedegaard 1975, vol. II: 232; Mykland 1978: 235–9; Rubow 1918: 10; Schroeder 1994: 406–7; Ellis 1991: 70; Røider 1989.
48. Rubow 1918: 12–15, 38–40; SAH. FH.– Df. L0692 – vol. 21 – 1814–15. Lind to Bendeke 1 June 1813.
49. Rubow 1918: 12–13, 18–21.
50. Hedegaard 1975, vol. I: 161; Frandsen 2008: 101; Carr 1963: 40.
51. Ostenfeld 1909: 11; Holm 1903: 687; Carr 1963: 40; Skovgaard-Petersen 1985: 84–5.
52. Quoted in Hedegaard 1975, vol. II: 254.
53. Pavels 1864: 49, 63.
54. Rubin 1970 [1892]: 434–5; Bjerke 2008 and Collett and Bjerke (eds) 2009; Cronenberg 1990; Esdaile 1995: 93–4.
55. Quoted from Nyrop 1873: 139–40.
56. Frydenlund 2009b: 180–4; Worm-Müller 1918: 137; Nielsen 1888: 189.
57. Bjerke 2008: 36; Frandsen 1996.
58. Collett and Frydenlund 2009; Frydenlund 2009b, 2009c.
59. Ostenfeld 1909: 6–10, cf. Frandsen 2008: 47.
60. Martensen-Larsen 1987; Worm-Müller 1918: 93–104.
61. Worm-Müller 1918: 93, 104–6, 158–9, 166–7; Nielsen 1888: 158–9.
62. Worm-Müller 1918: 93–106, 164–77, cf. 93–6; Nielsen 1888: 172; Generalstaben 1888, vol. III: 530–1; cf. Martensen-Larsen 1987.

63. Platou and Lange (eds) 1859: 55–6; 78–87; cf. Holm 1903: 619–10; Nielsen 1888. Cf. Sather 1975: 296–305.
64. Ottosen 2012d: 176–82; Worm-Müller 1918: 179–80.
65. Platou and Lange (eds) 1859: 77; Rubin 1970 [1892]: 361.
66. Worm-Müller 1918: 188–96; Ottosen 2012d: 262–9.
67. RAK.Kongehuset.Frederik6.Vol.75.1784–1839.Brevefrforskellige.Haxthausen to Frederick VI 31 March 1810. See also Haxthausen to Frederick VI 7 May 1810.
68. Platou and Lange (eds) 1859: 78.
69. SAH. FH. Df. L0758: 1807–08. H. Tulle to Bendeke 17 July 1808.
70. Barstad 1908, vol. I: 154–5, cf. 158–9 and 1908, II: 128–9.
71. SAO. Akershus Amt. Dd. L0035 Pind to *Akershus Amt* 21 June 1809. SAH. FH. Df, L0634 – vol. 13. Høegh to Bendeke 7 May 1809; Mykland 1978: 179; Øy 1991: 19; Sather 1975: 386.
72. Nielsen 1888: 359–60; Sather 1975: 416.
73. LUB. HS. GA. Vol. 3. II: 1. King Charles XIII to Adlersparre 8 October 1809; Nielsen 1888: 359–60.
74. LUB. HS. GA. Vol. 4. II: 4. Adlersparre to Platen 4 September 1809; Sjövall 1917: 296.
75. Sather 1975: 416; Sjövall 1917: 295–6. See Frydenlund 2009a: 212 for a different view.
76. Feldbæk 1997a: 63–130.
77. Feldbæk 1993: 185.
78. Feldbæk 1997a: 14–27; Møller 1998: 20–3.
79. Gøbel 2000b.
80. Møller 1998: 13–17.
81. Esdaile 2001a: 67–92; Palmer 1986; Förster and Nagler 1997: 4–11; Clausewitz 1997: 308–15; Bell 2007: 8.
82. Thorald 2011: 38, 209; Forrest, Hagemann and Rendal 2009: 2; Hagemann 2009b: 159 and 2009a: 191–2; Chickering 2010, cf. 1999; Broers 2008: 268.
83. Bell 2007: 7–8.
84. Bregnsbo and Jensen 2004: 169–70.
85. Best 1982: 31–74; Bell 2007: 44–51.
86. Glenthøj and Rasmussen 2007a.

5 Internal Changes and External Threats, 1810–12

1. Frandsen 2008: 15–18, 73–120; Carr 1963: 35–42.
2. Ottosen 2013; Sjövall 1917: 292–310; Weibull 1957: 8–44; Nielsen 1888: 207–409; Clason 1908 and 1909.
3. Nielsen 1888: 309, 400; Ræder 1852, vol. III: 690; Elgvin 2003: 105–10.
4. Bjerke 2008: 101; 2009a: 44; Feldbæk 1998: 338–40; Nielsen 1888: 309, 400–9; Glenthøj 2010: 95.
5. Nielsen 1888: 403–6; Bjerke 2009a: 49–50; 2009b: 65–71; cf. 2009c.
6. Dyrvik 1999: 222–3; Bjerke 2009a: 45.
7. Hyvik 2003: 141. Cf. Collett 2009: 29.
8. Frydenlund 2009a: 180; Collett and Frydenlund 2009: 144–7.
9. *Tiden* no. 34, 9 December 1809.

10. Ringvej 2009; Feldbæk 1998: 338.
11. Collett and Frydenlund 2009: 152–7; Frydenlund 2009c: 184–8.
12. Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 3–6; Nielsen 1888: 406–7; Elgvin 2003: 113.
13. Wergeland 1811: 59–60; *Dansk Litteratur-Tidende*, no. 38–43, 1811: 596.
14. Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 18, 28–31, 56, 59; Elgvin 2003: 131–2.
15. Aarnes 1994: 14; Platou 1812.
16. Sather 1975: 411–15, 424, 430–1, 455–6.
17. Sather 1975: 482–8; Koren 1915, vol. I: 191; Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 6–7.
18. Sørensen 2013; Demandt 1993: 11–12; Østergård 1999: 45.
19. Höjer 1943: 1–40; Friis 1897–99; Barton 1970.
20. Clausen 1896: 120–40.
21. Friis 1897–99: 279–81, 291–300; Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 7–8, 50–3; Clausen 1896: 120–40.
22. Alin (ed.) 1899; Friis 1897–99: 284–5; Mørner 2000.
23. Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 50–3; Friis 1897–99: 287–8, 299–300.
24. Mentz 2007a 64; GKA, vol. 7: 421–3; Nielsen 1888: 226–44; Sather 1975: 420.
25. Sather 1975: 256–8, 260; Nielsen 1888: 244–6; Ræder 1852, vol. III: 423–4.
26. Sather 1975: 313; Friis 1897–99: 299–307.
27. Hemstad 2005; Glenthøj 2010: 242; *PH*, 1808: 321, 326–7; *Tiden*, no. 20, 1808: 153.
28. Hemstad 2013a.
29. Barton 1986: 312; Sather 1975: 244–8, 256–60; Friis 1897–99: 246, 261, 289–91, 309–22.
30. Strachey 1921.
31. Frandsen 2008: 9; Hemstad 1996.
32. Dwyer 1994: 370–1; 1993, 1997; Schroeder 1994: 280–5; Frandsen 2008: 73.
33. Frandsen 2008: 75–84; Carr 1963: 36–7.
34. Carr 1963: 36; Anderson 2006: 84.
35. Olufsen 1839: 148, 160–1; Engelstoft 1862: 352–3; Thornboe 1809b: 14; Munthe 1806; Soldin 1806.
36. Frandsen 2008: 82; Høegh-Guldberg 1809: 19.
37. Winge 1991: 147; Conrad 1991: 399; Rubin 1970 [1892]: 410–11.
38. Frandsen 2008: 80; Carr 1963: 36; Engberg 2009: 322; Jørgensen 1930–31: 196–7; Rasmussen 2006.
39. Frandsen 2008: 73–86.
40. Frandsen 2008: 34, 85–9; Glenthøj 2010: 48; Fabricius 1937: 60–2; Hemstad 1996: 84.
41. Cf. Rowe 2003: 69–82; 2005: 70 and 2006: 615–17; Simms 1998: 96; Hemstad 1996.
42. Cf. Simms 1998: 96–7; Aaslestad 2005: 6–30; Rowe 2005: 70; 2006: 617.
43. Frandsen 2008: 91–2, cf. 78.
44. Hansen 2005: 103–10; Frandsen 2008: 44–5.
45. Cf. Holm 1903: 636–7; Mentz 2007a: 67.
46. Ruppenthal 1943: 12–13.
47. Rasmussen 1977: 67–8; Bregnsbo forthcoming.
48. Feldbæk 1998: 334; Worm-Müller 1918: 82–3; Mentz 2007a: 66.
49. Generalstaben 1894, vol. VI: 10–12, 78; Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 97.
50. Eyck 1986: 101–6 and 149–53; Schroeder 1994: 366.

51. Feldbæk 1998: 192 and 2002: 250.
52. Feldbæk 1997a: 483; Hedegaard 1975, vol. II: 299.
53. Hedegaard 1975, vols I and II; especially vol. I: 124, 221; Engberg 2009.
54. Hedegaard 1975, vol. I: 181–92, 220–1, 291.
55. Viken 2011.
56. Hedegaard 1975, vol. I: 165, 206–7.
57. Generalstaben 1894, vol. VI: 441.
58. Sather 1975: 103; Ottosen 2012d: 276–7.
59. Platou and Lange (eds) 1859: 112–13.
60. Sørensen (ed.) 1889: 18; Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 53; Generalstaben 1896, vol. VII: 449.
61. Aall 1859: 190–1.
62. Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 87; Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 97, 101.
63. Quoted from Hauge 1960: 59; cf. 55.
64. Ottosen 2012d: 276–7.
65. Feldbæk 1998: 343.

6 Endgames 1812–13

1. Feldbæk 2002: 503; Ræder 1852, vol. III: 436–59; Grab 2003: 102–3; Rink 2010: 23–4; Rowe 2001: 215–16; Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 24–7.
2. Heckscher 1922: 154; Hedegaard 1975, vol. II: 237, 342; Feldbæk 1999: 135–6; Engberg 2009; Mentz 2009.
3. Dwyer 2001: 1; Forrest 2012; Broers 1996: 273–4; Grab 2003: 109; Planert 2006: 677.
4. Schroeder 1994: 445–516.
5. Rasmussen 1977: 70–1.
6. Steen 1951: 12–13, 35; Feldbæk 2002: 501.
7. Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 251, 353; Holm 1912: 339–41.
8. Hedegaard 1975, vol. II: 236–7; Feldbæk 1997a: 487 and 2002: 501.
9. Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 97.
10. Zetterberg 2012: 69; Heckscher 1922: 160–1, 178–83, 236–7; Bregnsbo forthcoming.
11. Wolke 2007: 87–8; Höjer 1943: 106–61; Schinkel and Bergman 1855, vol. VI: 159–60.
12. Schroeder 1994: 429–31. Cf. Esdaile 2007: 480.
13. Rasmussen 1977: 72; Feldbæk 1997a: 488; Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 351
14. Hedegaard 1975, vol. II: 243–9; Rasmussen 1977: 72; Feldbæk 2002: 506; Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 373–4 and 1894, vol. VI: 74–6; Wolke 2007: 88–9.
15. Rasmussen 1977: 72–4; Generalstaben 1894, vol. VI: 17–20, 63–4.
16. Hedegaard 1975, vol. II: 248.
17. Holm 1912: 347; Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 276–7; Ottosen 2012b: 226–32.
18. Höjer 1943: 153–4.
19. Holm 1912: 374–7; Sørensen 1871, vol I: 130–45.
20. Vaupell 1876: 363; Hedegaard 1975, vol. II: 263–70; Rasmussen 1977: 81–3; Holm 1912: 384–5; Feldbæk 1997a: 489; 1999: 139; 2002: 507.
21. Hedegaard 1975, vol. II: 269–70; Feldbæk 1999: 139; cf. 2002: 507; Rasmussen 1977: 81–2; Aaslestad 2005: 295–6; Sørensen 1871, vol. I: 122–33.

22. Rasmussen 1977: 74–5; Holm 1912: 386–9.
23. Feldbæk 2002: 509; Rasmussen 1977: 83.
24. Bregnsbo forthcoming; Schroeder 1994: 461–3; Esdaile 2007: 503–10.
25. Feldbæk 1998: 347 and 2002: 508–9; Weibull 1957: 90; Holm 1912: 391.
26. Frydenlund 2009c: 186; Esdaile 1995: 111; Worm-Müller 1918: 163. Quoted in Generalstaben 1894, vol. VI: 298.
27. Ottosen 2012d: 263–7; SAO. Akershus Amt. Dd. L0037. J. Gulbrandsen to Borchsenius 23 December 1812.
28. Sars 1891, vol. IV; Lunden 1992; Koht 1926; Grab 1995a, 1995b; Broers 1996: 171–2; 2010b: 198–200, 211–15; Sande 2012. See Pedersen 2012 and Pedersen and Munch-Møller 2012 for a slightly different perspective, however.
29. Ottosen 2012d: 276–7.
30. Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 98, 101, 276–8.
31. Ottosen 2012b and 2013.
32. Schinkel and Bergman 1855, vol. VI: 324–7; Frydenlund 2009a: 204–5.
33. Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 101; Ottosen 2012d: 328–43; Hemstad 2013b; Weibull 1957: 43 and 68 (quote); Höjer 1943: 62–3.
34. Weibull 1957: 62–3, 112; Ahnfelt (ed.) 1886: 11.
35. Ottosen 2012d: 209–10 and 238–43; Ridderstad 1847: 26.
36. RAS. LSLs. Afd. XVI (nos 1–12). Ang reservarmén på norska gränsen 1811, 1812. E4575. Lefrén to Essen 3 October 1812; BAS. Norvège 1812–15. I–III. XI: Unknown agent to Adlersparre 19 June 1812, attached to Adlersparre to Charles John 16 July 1812; LUB. HS. GA. Vol. 4. II: 4. *En gamal Bondes Testamente till sina barn och Grannar* by Georg Adlersparre (possibly a draft).
37. Falsen 1814: 13–17.
38. RAS. SHH. XIV: vol. 47. Hasenkamm to Engeström 21 June 1813.
39. Rask 1941, vol. 1: 131.
40. Weibull 1957: 69–73, 101–2 and 152–4; RAS. LS. Afd. XVI (nos 1–12). Ang reservarmén på norska gränsen 1811, 1812. E4575. Lefrén to Essen 3 October 1812; BAS. Norvège 1812–15. I–III. XI: unknown and anonymous agent to Adlersparre 19 June 1812, attached to Adlersparre to Charles John 16 July 1812.
41. Höjer 1943: 62–3; Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 327–9; Bagge and Mykland 1987: 299–300.
42. RAS. SHH. XIV: vol. 47. Hasenkamm to Engeström 21 June 1813.
43. Generalstaben 1892, vol. V: 312.
44. Generalstaben 1894, vol. VI: 325.
45. Pavels 1864: 72–3; RAS. SHH. XIV: vol. 47. Echstedt to Engeström 22 June 1813; Holm 1912: 463–7.
46. Generalstaben 1894, vol. VI: 70; Mykland 1978: 255.
47. Morgenstjerne 1813; Bonnevie 1813; Hjort 1867: 14–16; Generalstaben 1894, vol. VI: 429; Weibull 1957: 152–4; Wollebæk 1926: 74; Pugh 1980: 129; Bas. Norvège 1812–15. I–III. XI. Letter from unknown agent to Adlersparre 9 July 1812, attached to Adlersparre to Charles John 16 July 1812.
48. Generalstaben 1894, vol. VI: 312–13, 314–16, 421–5, 452.
49. Generalstaben 1896, vol. VII: 426, 429–33; Generalstaben 1902, vol. IX: 133.
50. Feldbæk 1998: 347–8; Aall 1859: 319–21; Pavels 1864: 80–1.
51. Pavels 1864: 62–3.
52. Pavels 1864: 62–3; Generalstaben 1894, vol. VI: 78, 83; Generalstaben 1896, vol. VII: 135.

53. Mentz 2007b: 100; Hedegaard 1975, vol. I: 116, 172–3, 206–7 and vol. II: 291 and 317; SRO, Ipswich, HA/93/6/1/2031. FO 22/62 – Charles Fenwick 1811–13; Blüdnikow 1986: 31; Rubin 1970 [1892]: 289–91, 5668.
54. Hedegaard 1975, vol. II: 262–6; Aaslestad 2005: 266–8; Hagemann 2009c: 34–6.
55. Aaslestad 2005: 267, 295–6, 302; Ostensfeld 1909: 21.
56. Hedegaard 1975, vol. II: 270–1; 278–313.
57. Holm 1912: 434–4; Hedegaard 1975, vol. II: 307–17; Feldbæk 1997a: 490–1 and 2002: 509–10.
58. Pavels 1864: 119; Generalstaben 1902, vol. IX: 140.
59. *Dagen*, 1 Jan. 1814.
60. Vaupell 1876: 367–83; Höjer 1943: 201–34; Hedegaard 1975, vol. II: 293 (quoted).
61. Pavels 1864: 120.
62. Linvald 1965: 40; Generalstaben 1902, vol. IX: 137–40.
63. Feldbæk 1995.

7 Postlude – Freedom and Suppression, 1814–15

1. Linvald 1965: 30–1; Platou 1872: 6–7.
2. Linvald 1965: 40; Christian VIII 2011: 292–3.
3. Linvald 1965: 12; Christian VIII 2011, 1: 292–5, 298–9, 301, 306, 308.
4. Seip 1974: 23.
5. Mykland 1967; Bagge and Mykland 1987: 303ff.; Mykland 1978: 288ff.; Moltke 1870–72: 63ff.
6. Mykland 1967.
7. Linvald 1965: 29–30.
8. Linvald 1965: 134–8; Linvald 1953–56.
9. Bagge and Mykland 1987: 304; Christian VIII 1914: 143–4, 166; Christian VIII 2011: 295; Linvald 1965: 194.
10. Linvald 1965: 186ff.
11. Bagge and Mykland 1987: 312–13.
12. Ottosen 2012d; Blom 1860 [1823]: 135; Falsen 1814.
13. Nielsen 1904: 230; Wollebæk 1926: 173–6; Linvald 1965: 328; Sars 1891, vol. IV: 336; Lunden 1993: 141; cf. Esdaile 2001b: 152; Connor 1994: 162–3; Rowe 2001: 222; Breuilly 2009: 269–70; Schroeder 1994: 451–4.
14. Essen 1867, s. 25.
15. Linvald 1965: 14–15.
16. Linvald 1965: 102, 145–6.
17. Christian VIII 2011: 294; Linvald 1965: 19.
18. Gøbel 2000a: 46–7; Ræder 1916: 35–8.
19. Koren 1915, vol. I: 8; Nygaard 1960: 284–6; Winsnes 1924: 427.
20. Larsen 1881: 5–6, 13; Christian VIII 1914: 176; Generalstaben 1902, vol. IX: 162–5.
21. Tidemand 1881: 132; *Vedtægter...* 1814: 3–5; Winsnes 1924: 458; Linvald 1965: 189–90.
22. Aall 1859: 420; Wergeland 1830: 61; Gøbel 2000a: 47–51; Ræder 1968: 114–15; Reske-Nielsen 1950–52: 117–18.

23. Grundtvig 1814, vol. IV: 4; Wergeland 1843, III: 160; Ræder 1968: 109–10; Hedegaard 1975, II: 342, 352; Dreyer 1993, vol. I: 409–10; Ræder 1968: 111; Clausen 1877: 6; Engberg 2009: 392.
24. Schmidt 1966: 344–5; Jørgensen 1903: 11; Christian VIII 1914: 202; Nathan-David 1814; *Athene*, July 1814: 67; Lyngby 2004: 184; Grundtvig 1814: I–II.
25. *Athene*, 1814, vol. I: 322; Grundtvig 1924: 224–6; Linvald 1965: 191; Daae 1876: 217–18.
26. Bonderup 2007: 21–2; Christian VIII 1914: 206; Generalstaben 1902, vol. IX: 187–8; Hedegaard 1975: 342.
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